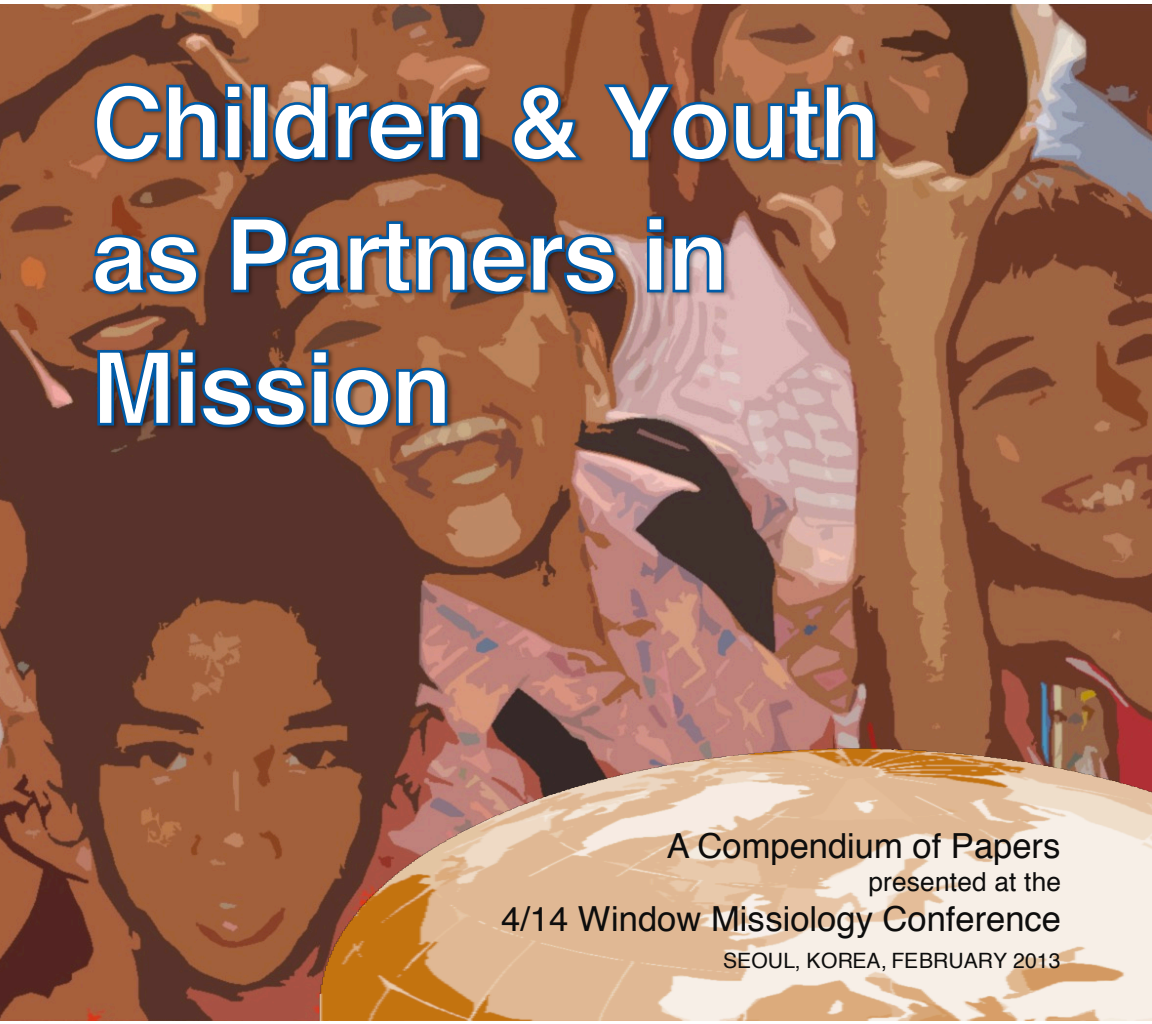
4/14 Movement

Raising Up Christ Followers from
4/14 Window to Transform the World



Children & Youth as Partners in Mission

A Compendium of Papers
presented at the
4/14 Window Missiology Conference
SEOUL, KOREA, FEBRUARY 2013

Edited by
Dan Brewster
John Baxter-Brown

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Contents

Acknowledgements 1

Introduction to the 4/14 Window Missiology Process 4
By Dan Brewster

PART 1: THE PURPOSES OF GOD 11

A MEDITATION ON PSALM 8 VERSE 2 13

DEVOTIONAL 1
A Meditation on Psalm 8:2 15
By Keith White

THEME 1: CHILDREN AND YOUTH AS PARTNERS IN MISSION 27

PAPER 1
Children and Youth as Partners in Missions 29
By Bambang Budijanto

THEME 2: A CRITICAL REVIEW OF MODERN MISSIONS MOVEMENT 47

PAPER 2
A Critical Review of Modern Missions Movement 49
By Mark Oxbrow

THEME 3: TOWARDS A NEW MISSIOLOGY: RENEWING OUR ENGAGEMENT IN GOD'S MISSION 73

PAPER 3
Towards a New Missiology: Renewing Our Engagement in God's Mission 75
By Gustavo Crocker

GROUP DISCUSSION NOTES 86

PART 2: THE PROMPTING OF THE SPIRIT 89

DELIVERANCE OF A SLAVE GIRL ACTS 16:16-38 93

DEVOTIONAL 2
Deliverance of a Slave Girl Acts 16:16-38 95
By Genevieve James

THEME 4: DISCERNING THE WORK OF THE HOLY SPIRIT IN MISSION TODAY 103

PAPER 4
Discerning the Work of The Holy Spirit in Mission Today 105
By Richard Howell

RESPONSE 1
Discerning the Work of the Holy Spirit in Global Mission Today 123
By Gwendolin De Rozario

RESPONSE 2
The Ethiopian Experience in Holistic Ministry to and with Children 128
By Shiferaw W. Michael

GROUP DISCUSSION NOTES 133

THEME 5: THE MISSIOLOGICAL PRESUPPOSITIONS, MOTIVES, STRUCTURES AND METHODS SPECIFIC TO THE 4/14 WINDOW 135

PAPER 5
The Missiological Presuppositions, Motives, Structures and Methods Specific to the 4/14 Window 137
By Siga Arles, John Baxter-Brown, Genevieve James, Glicerio (Jojo) Manzano, Jr., Nativity Petallar, Augustin Sokolovski

GROUP DISCUSSION NOTES 156

THEME 6: RAISING SAMUEL 159

PAPER 6
Raising Samuel: Releasing Children to Discover God's Purpose 161
By Susan Greener

RESPONSE 1 182
Children and Youth as Agents of Transformation and Mission: Child Participation 182
By Enrique Pinedo

RESPONSE 2
Children as Agents of Transformation 189
By C. Rosalee Velloso Ewell

QUESTIONS SPECIFIC TO THEME 6 191

GROUP DISCUSSION NOTES 193

PART 3: THE POSITION OF JESUS 195

JESUS, CHILDREN, CHURCH AND MISSION 197

DEVOTIONAL 3
Jesus, Children, Church and Mission 199
By Las G. Newman

THEME 7: SPACE AND COMMUNITY, ENGAGEMENT AND EMPOWERMENT: MISSIOLOGICAL EQUIPPING FOR A NEW MISSION ERA 210

PAPER 7
Space and Community, Engagement and Empowerment: Missiological Equipping for a New Mission Era 213
By Perry W.H. Shaw and Corneliu Constantineanu

RESPONSE 1
Response from the Perspective of the Family 239
By Amanda J. Sanchez

RESPONSE 2
"Children and Ministry" – An Integral Part of Theological Education 245
By Manfred W. Kohl

RESPONSE 3
Response from the African Perspective 249
By Victor Nakah

QUESTIONS SPECIFIC TO THEME 7 258

GROUP DISCUSSION NOTES 260

THEME 8: CHILDREN AND YOUTH AS AGENTS OF TRANSFORMATION AND MISSION 265

PAPER 8
Children and Youth as Agents of Transformation and Mission 267
By Vinay Samuel

THEME 9: REDEEMED ADULT/CHILD DYAD AND THE *MISSIO DEI*: SPEAKING BACK TO MISSIOLOGY 279

PAPER 9
The Redeemed Adult/Child Dyad and the *Missio Dei*: Speaking Back to Missiology 281
By Dave H. Scott

AFTER WORD 303

SCRIPTURE INDEX 309

APPENDICES
About the Sponsoring Organisations 313
About the Participants 315
About the Contributors 319
Appendix: "Where have we come from, where we are and where are we going?" 331
By Luis Bush

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I had the privilege of chairing the Program Committee, and was especially aided by the delightful Dr. Rosalee Velloso Ewell, Executive Director of the WEA Theological Commission, who served as our **Discussion Coordinator**. Rosalee recruited the affable Mr. John Baxter-Brown, Evangelist and Theologian, who helped much in the formulation of the discussion questions and, together with Rosalee, did constant monitoring and fine-tuning of the process. Particular thanks go to John who is also the general editor of this Compendium. John did most of the work in compiling and shaping this present Compendium including envisioning the re-organization of the Major Papers, resulting in the overall shape of this Compendium. It was John who did the introduction to each of the papers herein, and pulled together the notes from the group interactions.

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key highlights from the small group sessions which followed the presentation of each Major paper. Dave then also provided the overall conference summaries which are included here in. His team consisted of Joshua Daniel, Alexandra Marcano Rivas, Shin-Ock George and Young-Mi (Irene) Lee. Dave also presented a key response which had such substance that we included here as one of the Major papers.

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Of course the life blood of both the 4/14 Window Missiology conference and this Compendium of the proceedings were the scholarly papers presented and the official responses to those papers. Their work is prominent throughout this book. I won't list them again here, but you will enjoy and learn from their wisdom and insights on every page that follows. I especially thank the Lead Authors, and each of the team members whom they brought together. Together they have helped provide careful scholarship, grounding, guidance, accountability and credibility, not only to the 4/14 Movement, but other similar initiatives as well.

Compassion International was a key sponsor, providing the bulk of the funding for the conference. Mrs. Menchit Wong, International Advocacy Director for Compassion, headed up the management and funding support for the conference. Most people know where Compassion is coming from. We are neither academics nor theologians nor missiologists. But we have ventured into those spaces to further and enrich our unwavering commitment to helping the Church care and capture more effectively the energy and potential of

the ‘next’ generation. As you read and study these papers, and as you seek to share and incorporate them into your church and mission conversations, our hope and prayer is that you will be more motivated to join hands with us in that lofty endeavour.

Dan Brewster
Penang, August 2013

Introduction to the 4/14 Window Missiology Process

BY DAN BREWSTER

It was a pleasure for me to chair the 4/14 Window Missiology conference in Seoul, S. Korea in February, 2013. The task gave me the privilege and opportunity to engage with countless missiologists, theologians, church and mission leaders, and practitioners of all stripes who care passionately about the next generation.

Since the last quarter of the 20th century, children have gained increasing significance in the Kingdom of God. The Church is being made aware of God's heart for children. It is awakening to the significant role children played in the building up of the Kingdom of God throughout the 20th century and beyond.

In 1996 I wrote a paper called "The 4/14 Window: Child Ministries and Mission Strategy." It was published as one of the chapters in the book *Children in Crisis: A New Commitment,* one of the fine books in a series on meeting children's needs by Dr. Phyllis Kilbourn. As a Missiologist, I was building of course on the powerful concept of the '10/40 Window', which did so much to change the focus of missions over the past 2 decades. In that article, I noted and developed the central premise of the '4/14 Window' – that most people who will ever come to Christ, will do so between the ages of 4 and 14 – and developed the early evidence.

In the intervening years, much evidence has accumulated. Nearly every time I have spoken to a group of believers, large or small, on 6 continents, and in every class I have taught for the past 12 years, I have asked the question "How many of you made your first decision to follow Christ before you were 18 years of age?" [1] I can count on the

[1] Just as the '10/40 Window was 'flexible,' so I have 'flexed' the 4/14 Window, following the UNICEF definition of childhood as persons under the age of 18.

fingers of one hand the times when the response has been less than 50%. Generally it has been in the 60 – 80% range. Sometimes (interestingly particularly amongst Christians in leadership roles) the percentage has often been closer to 90%.

It has become clear that the 4/14 Window is not just a catchy phrase, but a true 'window' of receptivity – an established fact. People *do* tend to come to Christ while they are young, while the 'cement' in their lives is still soft and impressionable. Wait until the child is a young adult and it will take a chisel; wait until adult hood and it takes a wrecking ball to make an impact. Indeed, in the US, there is only a 6 percent chance that the decision will be made after the age of nineteen.[2]

Moreover, it is not just as *objects of* mission where children and youth are now being considered, but also as *agents for* mission. Indeed, many new initiatives and strategies are understanding children and youth as one of the most important resources for mission in the coming decades. Mission leaders, some of them contributing to this volume, are recognizing the promise and the possibilities of engaging children and youth as 'strong partners in Mission.'

While that 'window of receptivity,' for mission *to* children, and the energy and potential of children and youth *for* mission has always been there, they have not featured prominently in most church ministries. And they have been conspicuously absent in most mission strategies. Missiologists focus on people groups and strategies for reaching out to Muslims, Hindus and others, but children and youth have tended to be ignored.

Fortunately that is changing. Many key Christian leaders in all aspects of ministry are now acknowledging this historical lacuna in their plans and strategies. And the number and quality of the missiologists and mission thinkers who contributed in one way or another to the 4/14 Window Missiology Conference which this

[2] George Barna, *Transforming Children into Spiritual Champions* (Ventura, CA: Regal Books, 2003), 34.

Compendium documents is an indication that children and youth are at least in the conversation as they plan and strategize effective approaches for the 21st century. Global leaders of the Church and Mission are now 'lifting up their eyes and looking around' (Isaiah 49:18) regarding potential and possibilities of children and youth, and seeking to challenge, encourage and equip them to use their gifts and energy as agents in transforming the world.

The 4/14 Window Missiology Conference is an example and manifestation of the attention now being given to this important age group.[3]

The Conference Antecedents

It must first be said that this conference was a follow on to the *Now and Next Theological Conference on Children* which was held in Nairobi, Kenya in 2011. In his fine introduction to the Compendium from that conference,[4] Dr. Keith White observed that

> despite [a long tradition of] reflection on, and activity for children and young people, mainstream theology, and mainstream church have commonly continued as if children were marginal or even invisible. It is possible therefore to study major works of Christian systematic theology, only to find children absent from the content and index. It is equally possible (some would say probable) that Christian pastors can complete their training without any contact with, or reflection on, children and their place in church and mission.

Moreover he added,

[3] It is important to note that the '4/14 Window' is a concept – not exclusive boundaries. Children at risk care-givers and Christian nurturers are, of course, very concerned about those under the age of 4. And any consideration of 'mission strategy' amongst 'children' is of course giving primary attention to those in the 15 – 18 age group. Just as the '10/40 Window' draws our attention to the particular area of the world, the purpose is to draw attention to, and provoke reflective, strategic thinking about all

[4] See *Now and Next,* eds. Siga Arles, Dan Brewster, Kok Chik Bu, Rosalind Tan, Keith J. White (Compassion International, 2011).

> … Christian organizations concerned with doing good for children, are often so consumed by the urgency and scale of the need, that theological reflection tends to take a back seat, or even to be overlooked. It is only in the 21st century that many such organizations are realizing how theologically thin their thinking is; how rudimentary their store of theological knowledge and insight.

The *Now and Next* conference began to address that apparent oversight. Insights and themes that emerged from that time of reflection included further clarity on the definition of *Child Theology;* keen attention to children as 'signs of the Kingdom' and the challenges and practicalities of what that means in churches; a constant 'conversion' to the logic and '*upside-downness' of God's Kingdom;* and a quiet recognition that *humility* is a fundamental challenge to the existing ethos and hierarchies of church and Christian organizations. *Now and Next* also gave significant attention to the role and functioning of Christian seminaries, and the qualities of leadership modelled by most leaders, and the ethos of those institutions. Our Korea 4/14 Window Missiology both benefited from and built upon the reflections and insights in the *Now and Next* conference.

Another event both challenged and enriched the process in our Korea conference. A strong but helpful letter from Dr. Doug Birdsall, then Director of the Lausanne Movement, to many prominent global Christian leaders, reminded us of the need for exceptionally careful exegesis in our Scriptural exploration. Moreover, because the letter was copied to an august group of theologians and scholars, it had the effect of drawing in many others who may have been on the side-lines of the discussion. Whereas before it might have been mostly activists and those already engaged with children and youth in some way who were part of the conversation, now the matter was on the lips of many, many others – others who could and did make significant contributions to our reflections and insights.

We also wanted to be particularly vigilant regarding matters of protecting children from manipulation of any kind, especially that which comes in the name of God and ministry. We were committed

to learn from different parts of the body of Christ globally, especially faithful and great mission theologians, in order to build a sound theological framework and to understand what role children and young people play or are supposed to play in the Kingdom of God today. We asked ourselves, "What should we as adults to do (and not do) to help children and youth fulfil their roles?" The hope, prayer and expectation was that children and youth would be recognized, equipped and released to be increasingly significant players in fulfilling the Great Commission.

Our Conference Starting Points

As noted in the Conference Prospectus, current data indicates that children and youth are not only the most receptive of 'people groups' to the Gospel, but they also have been, and will increasingly become, a primary energy for mission in the 21st century. The Conference sought to begin to establish a solid missiological foundation and framework to inspire and engage Christ followers to give priority mission focus to children. To accomplish this, we began by asking ourselves things like:

1. What do biblical insights from the Old and New Testaments suggest regarding the roles and functions of children and youth in building and expressing the Kingdom of God today?
2. What does the Bible suggest might be the scope and roles of children in fulfilling the Great Commission?
3. What may be the theological and missiological issues of holistic mission with children – particularly with respect to children living in extreme poverty – who are among the neediest, often outside the church and often marginalized and neglected by the global Body of Christ?
4. What should be the presuppositions, motives, structures, methods, and patterns of cooperation and leadership for the 4/14 Window missiological construct?

With these as our starting points, the objectives of the conference were to:

5. Provide Biblical Insights and Principles to enable church and ministry leaders at all levels of influence to shape a mission-oriented response to holistic ministry to and with children.
6. Establish a missiological framework for the 4/14 Window Global Movement.
7. Review and challenge modern missionary methods, concepts, vocabularies and practice in light of biblical insights on the roles of children and youth.
8. Increase the passion and commitment of theologians and missiologists with respect to raising up a generation of Christ followers and leaders from the 4/14 Window.

The Conference Process

The approach taken in developing the shape of the conference was to invite topics and writers interested in those topics. Lead Authors were appointed, and they were asked to form a team of 3 to 5 people with whom to work to develop the assigned paper. Freedom was given to the Lead Authors to do the paper as a group effort, or to have the other members of the team either write on sub-topics or provide responses to the main paper. All approaches were used by the Lead Authors, thus the variety of styles and approaches seen in this Compendium. The writing teams were also invited (but not required) to suggest some discussion questions which would lead the small groups reflections.

For the presentations, the Lead Authors ad their contributing team members were asked to share their work in a 45 minute time-frame. Then, and additional 45 minutes was allotted for small group discussions. The Documentation Team headed by Dr. Dave Scott, worked during the discussion times to facilitate, capture, compile and summarize key points.

The general (though not consistent) overall flow of the Major Papers was to be from historical missions, through present to future, and from broad reflections on Missions to more specific exploration of mission to and with the '4/14ers.' We elected however to organize this Compendium around the three outstanding devotional

reflections, done by Drs. Keith White, Genevieve James, and Las Newman.

For this Compendium, we in the editorial group have done considerable editing and made numerous corrections to the papers and responses which were presented for the conference. But we have not sought to correct everything, nor standardize styles, footnoting, or punctuation, or even to do full reconciliation of British and American (and other!) English.

So what you see here will reflect not only the very cogent, innovative, and often very powerful and convicting thinking some of the writers, but also some of the rough edges of the present state of thinking on this topic. This is not a formal, precise, 'correct' presentation of the missiological issues surrounding children and youth. But I hope as you read it openly and carefully, you will find some very remarkable truths about the role and place of children and youth as strong partners in Mission.

For the children and the churches in the 4/14 Window,

Dr. Dan Brewster
Chair of the Program Committee
Penang, Malaysia

August, 2013

Part 1:
The Purposes of God

INTRODUCTION TO PART I

God moves in a mysterious way,
His wonders to perform.

So wrote William Cowper in the 18th century. They still resonate with many Christians for there remains a mystery about God: ultimately He is beyond human understanding. Yet, we can and do know something of God through inspired Scripture, human experience, the action of the Holy Spirit in the world, reflection and prayer and mainly through Jesus, His Son. It is possible to build up a picture of God's involvement in His creation and to begin to understand His It's essentially the gospel story, but with a bit more content. purposes for His people and His creation.

Part 1 of this Compendium explores three perspectives on God's purpose specifically relating to two areas: mission to and with children and young people today. A reflection on Psalm 8 opens the Section, as it did the 4-14 Movement's missiology conference Seoul in February 2013, reminding those attending that "The Psalm as a whole puts everything in its proper perspective: the truth is that all things owe their existence to God, and are designed to praise and serve Him."

There follows three papers. The first is an address by Dr. Bambang Budijanto which sets the stage for considering children and youth as potential partners in mission. He first suggests reasons why children and youth have not typically

been considered as resources in mission strategizing, and suggests how our 'schema' -- mental frameworks can cause us to exclude pertinent information and focus only on those things that confirm our pre-existing beliefs and groups ("prejudice"), produce selective perception ("bias"), and underestimate differences within groups and ideas. This, he suggests, may be part of the reason mission thinkers have overlooked children and youth as potential resources in mission. The second paper, by Dr. Mark Oxbrow, explores six models of mission, pointing out that the most prominent one in the last two hundred years (that of the professional missionary) is not the only historically valid model, nor the most appropriate model today. The final paper in Part 1 by Gustavo Crocker also includes a plea for a new model of mission which must include children and young people.

These four perspectives take a "big picture" approach, setting the backdrop for the rest of the Compendium. Important themes are introduced which are explored further in Parts II and III.

A Meditation on Psalm 8 verse 2

EDITOR'S INTRODUCTION

In this opening devotion Keith White draws upon Psalm 8, delving deep into the psalmist's soul. White develops his thinking, noting that the psalmist "puts everything in its proper perspective." This includes the power of the cry of the unweaned child such that the cry can silence "the foe and the avenger", God's enemies. White explores this by referring to worship and the 'mission Dei.' When babies cry, "they are joining in the hymn of praise of all creation to its Creator, from the tiniest of insects to the greatest of whirling galaxies." "Mission is to discover, receive, experience, and then proclaim the mystery, majesty, holiness, mercy, grace and love of God. … How then can the cry of suckling infants play any significant part in it?" White asks. And part of his answer: "The new birth and the cry of the child is a sign of the New Creation. Every child born, seen in this context, is therefore a herald of God's reign."

White is mindful of the atrocities that can be heaped upon children. He acknowledges the painful reality of human existence. "Imagine if you will that you are on the side of the foe and the avenger for a moment: you are a representative of Satan … You devote all your energy, your very being to trying to destroy all that God has created … Your final aim is the thick black silent darkness of death throughout the cosmos. … You watch broadcasts on television with glee: wars, famines, abuse and suffering on a grand scale. … And then you hear what is to you and the enemies of God that most terrible and feared of sounds: a newborn baby crying! Is there nothing you can do to stop the creator God?"

“The grace of God is revealed in the birth of new children, despite all the ravages of human and institutional sin. Their cries, reminders of our own inadequate babbling, are a sign that the light has not been, is not, and will not be extinguished.”

DEVOTIONAL 1

A Meditation on Psalm 8:2

BY KEITH WHITE

Introduction

Let us read this Psalm together in our own languages.

What a hymn of praise that is! Hallelujah! Praise the Lord!

Let it be known that we began our first day with the words: "O Lord, our Lord, how excellent is thy Name in all the earth!" Tell it from the rooftops! Shout it from the paddy fields! This was where we started. This is our compass bearing. This is our foundation.

Why are we beginning our conference with this? There are two reasons:

1. The Psalm as a whole puts everything in its proper perspective: the truth is that all things owe their existence to God, and are designed to praise and serve Him. "All things come from You, O God, and of Thine own have we given Thee." Genuine Christian mission, likewise, necessarily begins and ends with God. He is the author, He is the sustainer, and He is the completer. We are invited to be partners in His Mission.
2. Jesus draws our attention to verse two, with its unique reference to suckling babes and unweaned infants. That should be a good enough reason for His followers to take good note of it! What's more, He pointed to this verse to silence his foes and avengers for a few days before giving His life as the Lamb of God, slain that through Him we might know forgiveness, reconciliation, peace, adoption into His family, and be called to serve Him as Lord. He was, you will

recall, in his Father's House as teenagers called out, "Hosanna to the Son of David!" (Matthew 21:15-16).

We will not here do any justice to this exquisite piece of poetry, its beauty, form and message as a whole. For now we are going to zoom in on verse two. Versions differ because the Hebrew text is difficult, but I believe that the essential meaning is as clear as it is startling:

> "God has ordained such a bulwark of powerful praise through and from the lips of suckling babies and unweaned infants, that His enemies, the foe and the avenger, are silenced".

Putting Verse Two in Context

Before we start to get enthused, even amazed, at the ordination of little babies, and rejoice that they are chosen partners in God's mission, let's remind ourselves that God is God. He is the subject of everything. This Psalm is a hymn in praise of the Creator, and the majesty of His name, not of anything he has created. We are not here to admire little babies, (or each other, or our organizations, for that matter). You might find it helpful to think of creation in this Psalm as a great orchestra, with God as the composer and conductor. Some will recall that Calvin called creation: "the theatre of God's glory".

You have realized that the first phrase is repeated at the end: like twin towers. These book-ends leave us in no doubt that this psalm is a description of God's doing, from beginning to end: His activity, not ours:

"you have set your glory above the heavens" (verse 1)
"…you have ordained praise" (verse 2)
"the work of your fingers" (verse 3)
"which you have set in place" (verse 3)
"You made him a little lower than the heavenly beings" (verse 5)
"You made him ruler" (verse 6)
"you put everything under his feet" (verse 6).

The psalm may have different effects on us as readers, but the one that is identified in the psalm itself is an overwhelming awareness of how miniscule human beings (that means adults, as well as little children) are when set in the context of the heavens and all the works of God's fingers. When we are conscious of being in the very presence of God, and we are, all the time, for the moon and stars always surround us whether we see them or not, then we are humbled: "Who or what am I, that you the Creator God should take the least bit of notice of me?"

So we are reminded whenever we set out to build something however laudable, whether a cathedral, a piece of music, an orphanage, or a global movement in the Name of Christ, we go off track the moment we fail to see that apart from God, and what and who he ordains, we are nothing. God appoints humans to be partners in His creative and redemptive work, but we are always junior partners: subalterns.

We are partners *by grace*. We are surprising partners who do not fit the job description. We cannot and do not do what is required: we fall short of the glory of God. That is one reason why the baby is such an illuminating representative of human being.

But by grace *we are partners*: God is content to work with human being in its honest littleness. When we do great works, we are still little, but probably not able to be honest about our littleness. As for babies, they cannot but be little: they have no choice!

When we are engaged in any activity in the holy, holy, holy Name of the Lord, it is not enough to acknowledge that we are nothing without God. We can even we say it in prayer, but the besetting risk is that we still go on building, broadcasting and basking in our doing the work. It is only genuinely honest when our being little is truly built into the building, just as vulnerability to earthquakes is built into modern tall buildings. What is required is a confession of vulnerability not in words of detached though fervent prayer alongside the building, but in its very structure.

We must build in measures to prevent disaster, and that express our humility and littleness in face of the threat of earthquake. What

does a movement of mission or church like when it has this built in humility and honesty? Sadly there are all too few examples that come to mind. May 4/14 be one of them!

Now Psalm 8 doesn't have anything direct to say about this because it is not considering building movements. But in this conference it would be remiss, even dishonest, not to consider it. And it is timely to do so at the very outset of this gathering.

Verse Two

With all this in mind (always in mind), we come to verse two. In the light of this whole context, and the witness of the rest of the Bible, what might God by His Spirit reveal to us through this exceptional verse? Here are three reflections, and a coda:

1. The true calling of children is to praise God, their Creator

The very fact of our birth means that as babies we are related to our Creator, and this relationship is at the very heart, the core of who we are. To discover that babies are hard-wired for a relationship with God is a step the right direction! Note that babies are not set here under parents, within families, in Sunday Schools, sponsored, or protected by the state. They have a direct relationship with their Creator quite distinct and apart from the appropriate mediation of parents, families, teachers and churches.

And this relationship with God is, for those adults who engage in serious missiological reflection, something which we can and must try to formulate in words, knowing that we will never succeed. God is working in, with and through them. Anything that comes between children and this divinely appointed relationship and calling is a serious distortion and disruption of God's whole creation.

The text here is very clear on one point: the Psalmist is talking of *suckling babes* and *unweaned infants*. They are human beings who are at a stage of life when they have no ability to speak any human language. I am always interested to hear adults try to mimic the sound

of babies crying in their own cultures. Could we have a go now, all together?

When babies make a sound something like that, they are joining in the hymn of praise of all creation to its Creator, from the tiniest of insects to the greatest of whirling galaxies. (In case you haven't heard of it, let me commend to you the Salvation Army programme, Babysong, and its CD, *Boom Chicka Boom!* They have listened very carefully to what comes from the lips of babies and toddlers.

Please let us be very clear about this now, and throughout out conference: there is no way in which babies are conscious of this, and it has nothing to do with human training or development. It has nothing to do with adults, whether parents or teachers. *Simply by being what they were created to be,* they praise their Creator. It is, to use a word of the Apostle Paul in Romans 12, their *logical* service. This is the species-being of humans from the Creator's perspective. This is what He intended them to be and to do.

While on the subject of age, we take careful note that in Matthew 21 it is teenagers who praise Jesus as the Son of David in the Temple (His Father's House), when Jesus points his critics to Psalm 8 verse 2. We will pay attention during the conference, to the ages (as well as the gender and cultures) of the children of whom we speak. But we must never get carried away into thinking that as they form words and sentences, and when they learn to sing, that any true praise or service of God can originate anywhere except through the work of God in Christ, by His Spirit. Or that Kendrick, Hillsong or even Bach's Matthew Passion, is more pleasing to God than the cries of babies.

We must be properly and scrupulously sceptical of human methods, with their tendency to assume we can discern cause and effect in the Kingdom of God. (For example, "We did this and they were converted" etc.) This verse is a bulwark that should silence any such thinking.

By the way, have you ever wondered what might have been the motivation of these teenagers in the Temple? Perhaps they were simply being teenagers, and this was verbal graffiti, or a forerunner of Rap! Let us not impute motives where we cannot know. Humans

praise God by being who He appointed them to be, and doing what He ordains them to do.

2. Silencing the foe and the avenger

Why should enemies, the foe and avenger, be mentioned at all? At first sight it seems a strange intrusion into such a paean of praise. They disturb the equilibrium of this hymn of praise like the infamous drum-roll of Neilsen's *Inestinguishable Symphony*. But once we begin to get over this unexpected shock, we are left with the question: how can it be that little babies, who can't walk, speak or fend for themselves, silence God's foes? Put in words that resonate with the focus of our gathering: how do they sign, let alone contribute to, authentic Christian mission?

Missio Dei is the presence and dynamic of God the Trinity with, in and for human beings in every part of our daily lives and experience. Mission is to discover, receive, experience, and then proclaim the mystery, majesty, holiness, mercy, grace and love of God. It is to challenge anything that sets itself up apart from or against His Name. How then can the cry of suckling infants play any significant part in it? Especially so, when we know that the process involves the *creation* of the world described so majestically in this Psalm (verses 5-8), and its *re-creation* in Christ (Hebrews 2), the passage in this letter where Jesus is identified as the One who is crowned with glory and honour.

The core of Missio Dei is God's creating and calling humanity to reflect and live God's image God in the earth, in a dominion that is like God's kingdom, where God has His way. Babies are, by their very existence, part of it.

The Psalms often refer to the disruption of God's world. They are not sentimental or unreal. So, if God's glory is throughout the created world, how can that be when there are such real despoilers and enemies? That is precisely when and how God chooses to show another dimension of His glory! He chooses some of the most fragile creatures of His creation to silence the forces of darkness. In this His glory is revealed to be remarkable. Is there anything that He cannot do? Is size or scale of any significance to Him?

This needs to be tested out alongside the rest of the teaching of the Bible. Does God typically choose children, and the weak things of His world to confound the strong and the wise? Did God choose Israel because it was a great or righteous nation? Not at all: read Deuteronomy 9! Does Christ through His Spirit choose the strong and intelligent for His purposes? Not at all: read I Corinthians 1!

God is God, and once He has chosen or ordained, that is enough: there is no more to be said on the matter. Just one stone: against all the armour and military experience of Goliath? Yes, indeed!

But lest we take the single achievement of the boy David as a general missiological principle that guides our reading of the Bible, we do well to note that the world of human history, and the world we live in, is one in which the falsely wise are not confounded: the enemy is not silenced. Just over a century ago there was a famous missionary conference in Edinburgh; since then there have been many organizations and movements devoted to local, national, regional and world mission.

No sane and informed observer could possibly claim that the enemy has been silenced, not when children die of hunger, thirst, war, disease and oppression and their cries go unheard. We must examine the facts and our souls if we are to avoid grandiose claims and objectives as we pray that God's Kingdom may come. Otherwise our legacy may well be conferences, books, slogans which somehow convince us, or ameliorate our souls and consciences, while burying our heads in the sand about the real truth of the matter.

The writer to the Hebrews, is perfectly clear and honest about this: "…we do not see everything subject to [God's rule]. But we see Jesus"! (Hebrews 2:8, 9)

3. So how does God do this through Little Children?

We find it hard to take this on trust. Despite the fact that we may swallow the responsibility given to little human beings as somehow credible (verses 5-7) we strain at this particular exercise of power! It shows how little faith we have, and how easily adults get things out of proportion, not least our own importance in God's scheme of things!

We who have flown to Seoul have travelled over high mountains and small, but from a great height we could tell little difference. So why do we have any difficulty with seeing that to God we are all babies and little children when compared to the scale of the challenges we face, and our adequacy for the task?

It is not something that babies do in and of themselves: they do not silence the foe and the avenger by the power of human cries. God alone does that. But their cries are signs that the foe and the avenger can read, when many of us cannot. And when we reflect in some small way the image of God in our lives and groups, our little chattering, like their babbling praise, discloses something of the true worth and wonder of what God puts in place.

There is a hidden dialogue or counterpoint running through this Psalm that seems to go something like this. The Psalmist looks at the macro-cosmos, the moon and stars as the established order of God, the heavenly powers and rulers (cf. Psalm 2:4; Psalm 82): they might be commissioned by God to silence the foe and the avenger, but they are far away, and in themselves they are incomplete. What is lacking is *a face*, the uniqueness of what is given in human being, as a whole, male and female old and young.

When I look at the stars, and think something more is called for, then I think what else is there? I say the missionary prayer of Isaiah, "Here I am, send me." But that makes me ask the crippling question, "Who am I?" (This is human being, represented by an individual speaker.) And the answer would be, "Nothing like enough to do the job with." And then God says, or reminds the Psalmist so that he can say, "Thou hast made man a little lower than God." This is a formulation hinting towards humility, accepting the lower place. The crowning has nothing to do with us and our valuation: like the Resurrection of Jesus Christ, and the new creation: it is all of God.

This is the way God silences the enemy. But note that it is not pure God, not God acting apart from humanity, as pure creator. For it is God who gives human being the job of imaging God in reality in the creation of God. And it is babies as representatives of the whole of humanity who best reveal who we really are.

They make the point that humanity is little, that their part in Missio Dei is by grace, that they serve it by being what they are, and that reminds us all our participation in God's mission is not only or primarily some particular things we do, but our whole being in the whole of life. (This is surely what holistic means!)

By their being, babies chant the praise of God, which can only meaningfully be shared by people as they grow up if they get on living the whole image of the glory of God in Christ. What babies can do without words, because they do not have them yet, grown ups do with words because they are a significant part of their real whole being. And the words of adults are not vehicles for detached ideas, but can be integrated in the whole life of being human.

4. A Coda

The birth of a baby is a miracle that we may underestimate because it has happened so often. The first cry of the newborn child is a sign of hope and a prayer of God's Creation over the forces of darkness. It has not been possible for the forces of death to extinguish the light of life. Moltman puts it like this:

> With every beginning of a new life, the hope for the reign of peace and justice is given a new chance…Every new life is also a new beginning of hope for a homeland in this unredeemed world…children are not only metaphors of our hopes…but of God's hope for us: God wants us, expects us, and welcomes us…God is "waiting" for the human person in every child, is "waiting" for God's echo, resonance and rainbow.[1]

The new birth and the cry of the child is a sign of the New Creation. Every child born, seen in this context, is therefore a herald of God's reign. If we point out that many millions of babies have been abused and tortured, that many who are being born as we gather here will suffer, thousands will not reach adulthood before they die, that demonstrates the awfulness of sin. But the grace of God is revealed in the birth of new children, despite all the ravages of human and

[1] *Theology Today,* January 2000: 603.

institutional sin. Their cries, reminders of our own inadequate babbling, are a sign that the light has not been, is not, and will not be extinguished. God's kingdom will come; His will be done in earth as in heaven.

We must go back to the source of life and these cries, and we must in faith look to Jesus, to God in Christ. May we be purged of any thought that God silences evil through human endeavour or institutions! We see Jesus, and him crucified. How is the Cross testimony to the power of God to silence evil? God takes a way in the world, in Jesus, which lives the weakness of God and invites us to go with God where he goes, and to start on the way by thinking and talking the weakness. Whatever else we do, may God preserve us from boasting save in the Cross of Christ!

Some of you will know a very popular song, I Believe. It includes the lyrics:

I believe for every drop of rain that falls, a flower grows;
I believe that somewhere in the darkest night a candle glows…
I believe above the storm the smallest voice can still be heard;
I believe that Someone in the great somewhere hears every word…[2]

It was only after studying Psalm 8 that I realized the significance of one of its lines:

"Every time I hear a newborn baby cry, then I know why I believe!"

Imagine if you will that you are on the side of the foe and the avenger for a moment: you are a representative of Satan and all his vicious forces of evil. (Those of you who have read C. S. Lewis' Screwtape Letters have an advantage here.) You devote all your energy, your very being to trying to destroy all that God has created: to bring chaos, lies, disease, war, distrust, and to extinguish the light that

[2] Writers: Al Stillman, Ervin Drake, Shirl Jimmy, Irvin Graham (Lyrics © Universal Music Publishing Group, EMI Music Publishing, Warner/Chappell Music, Inc., Sony/ATV Music Publishing LLC, The Songwriters Guild Of America, T.R.O. Inc., Memory Lane Music Group).

shines in the darkness. Your final aim is the thick black silent darkness of death throughout the cosmos.

At this moment of time on earth, things are going really well for you. Are these the last days, you wonder?! You watch broadcasts on television with glee: wars, famines, abuse and suffering on a grand scale. Surely triumph is not far away. And then you hear what is to you and the enemies of God that most terrible and feared of sounds: a newborn baby crying! Is there nothing you can do to stop the creator God? You immediately target the baby, and you create havoc in her life, perhaps you manage to kill her before puberty. But then there is another, and another.

This is the most demoralizing sound you can imagine. And the Psalmist like the song-writer sees into the great truth that this cry is a signal that the Lord's name was, is and always will be excellent in all the earth. And in His way and His time, every knee will bow and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord.

"O Lord, our Lord how majestic is your name in all the earth!" When we uttered these words at the beginning of the Psalm, we had not been on the stunning journey on which the Psalmist invited us to embark. At the close we say it with hearts, minds, eyes and hearts that have been touched, stirred and humbled.

And in that spirit of humility, aware that the best that we can offer is little better than baby-talk, we continue to seek to reflect God's image in every part of this conference, and in every part of every day of our lives.

Theme 1:

Children and Youth as Partners in Mission

EDITOR'S INTRODUCTION

This first paper was the first key note address at the conference. It gives a back drop for all that follows in this Compendium. Bambang Budijanto frames the paper by referring to "the elephant in the room" (by which he means the role of children and young people in mission today) and highlights two variables. These are the "schema" or cognitive frameworks through which we interpret the world, and "the age and stage of a child's cognitive and socio-psychological development" when we talk about child engagement in mission. He believes that these three factors must be taken seriously as we reflect on mission early in the twenty first century.

Budijanto is realistic about the different perspectives that exist among Christian leaders regarding the involvement of children and youth in mission. He notes four common reasons that people use for not engaging them in mission (Caring for children vs. Scoreboard of evangelistic efforts; children are easily manipulated; children are immature; and Calling the exception the norm). He then explores his two variables in more depth. The latter half of his paper explores two verses from Peter's sermon on the Day of Pentecost – Acts 2:17-19. These verses are taken from Joel's prophecy in the Old Testament that Peter applies to the birth of the Ecclesia, the Christian church. In his careful exploration of the text, Budijanto

makes several vital points about mission, crucial amongst them that children and young people have a key part to play in fulfilling Joel's prophecy. He closes with a warning:

"Today we stand in the way of Jesus blessing and using children simply because they are not part of "our" version of missions, church and the Great Commission".

Take heed!

PAPER 1

Children and Youth as Partners in Missions

BY BAMBANG BUDIJANTO

> In the last days, God says, I will pour out my Spirit on all people.
> Your sons and daughters will prophesy, your young men will see visions, your old men will dream dreams.
> —Acts 2:17

Introduction

In the past year, God has allowed me to dialog with leaders of differing perspectives on the issue of children and youth and their involvement with missions. I have met leaders who passionately and intentionally create space for children to play significant roles in the public square such as preaching, leading worship and praying corporately. Adversely, I have encountered leaders who caution me about encouraging and mobilizing children and youth to play a leadership role in missions because it is irresponsible and borders upon child exploitation. I've also engaged with leaders who believe that God has utilized children and youth in the ministry of the Gospel in the ancient past and will continue to do so in the future. And finally, some leaders maintain that "serious ministry is carried out by adults and not by children." They believe that we are to care for children during their formative years so when the time of service arrives (adulthood), they will be fully prepared.

Recently, a highly respected Christian leader voiced her concerns, which raised some legitimate questions. She suspects that people focus on reaching children because they are easy targets and easily manipulated. She's also concerned about "numbers" becoming the focus of mission and using children and youth to increase the "scoreboard" for God. She asks, "When a church intentionally enrols

children in discipleship because of their receptiveness to the Gospel and humility, is it for the purpose of "manipulation" or "strategy"? Where do we draw the line?"

All of these leaders' convictions are motivated by good and noble intentions. As I reflect upon their passions, concerns and questions around the issue of utilizing children in missions, my attention is drawn into several variables. First, how does a person's "schema" (cognitive framework or concept that helps organize and interpret information)[1] shape the conversation? Second, are we distinguishing the age and stage of a child's cognitive and socio-psychological development when we converse about children and youth's involvement in missions?

As we acknowledge the "elephant in the room" and these two variables, let's allow them to shape our conversations and deliberations at this conference.

Reasons for Not Engaging Children in Missions

Here are some of the reasons why church leaders choose not to engage children in missions:

1. **Caring for Children vs. Scoreboard of Evangelistic Efforts.** There has been a concern that focusing missions on and with children could be done for the sake of adding "numbers" to the evangelistic "scoreboard." Do ministries utilize children and youth in evangelism to get higher numbers on the scoreboard?
2. **Children are Easily Manipulated.** Do children accept Christ and play different roles in the ministry of the church with wrong motives (to gain acceptance or approval for example)? (The fact that the majority of Christians made their decision

[1] Theorist Jean Piaget introduced the term "schema," and its use was popularized through his work on theory of Cognitive Development. By Kendra Cherry, About.com Guide – Psychology, http://psychology.about.com/od/sindex/g/def_schema.htm.

to follow Christ before the age of 18 would mean that many of us have been successfully manipulated.)

3. **Children are Immature.** Children and youth do not possess adequate biblical and theological understanding (cognitive). They are immature and unwise (mentally). There is a concern that engaging children in missions could be harmful for the children themselves, as well as hurting other people and ministries.
4. **Calling the Exception the Norm.** There are leaders who argue that God "normally" utilizes adults to fulfill His purpose, however Scripture indicates that He did utilize some children—Samuel, David, Esther, Naaman's slave girl, Josiah, Jeremiah, and the young boy who offered the fish and bread to Jesus—but these are exceptions. To call these exceptions as the "norm" is heresy.

Schema, Stereotype, Prejudice, and Human Nature

"Psychologists once believed that only bigoted people used stereotypes. Now the study of unconscious bias is revealing the unsettling truth: We all use stereotypes, all the time, without knowing it. We have met the enemy of equality, and the enemy is us."[2]

Schema is both a blessing and a curse. It allows us to take shortcuts in processing new information and retrieving our memories. However, these mental frameworks can also cause us to exclude pertinent information and focus only on those things that confirm our pre-existing beliefs and groups ("prejudice"), produce selective perception ("bias"), and underestimate differences within groups/ideas. "Stereotype" is the cognitive schema of a group. These collective schemas tend to exaggerate differences between

[2] Annie Murphy Paul, "Where Bias Begins: The Truth about Stereotypes" in *Psychology Today*, May 1, 1998.

In most cases, the use of schemas to learn occurs automatically—that is how our brain works. Unfortunately, an existing schema can actually hinder the learning of new information. Prejudice is one example of schema that prevents people from seeing the world as it really is and inhibits them from taking in new information. By holding certain beliefs about a particular group of people (ethnic, nationality, gender, age), the existing schema may cause people to interpret situations incorrectly.

In the Gospel narrative, Jesus used parables and stories to draw the attention of people into the richness of the truth and go outside their narrow stereotypes and schemas. The story of the Good Samaritan, the God-fearing centurion, the Samaritan woman, and the Canaanite woman—even the Sermon on the Mount—was presented to challenge people's schema.

Similar to schema, stereotypes in our modern world have also changed over time. The perspective on women in the U.S. has significantly changed in the past 150 years. The debate over a woman's right to vote resulted in the 19th Amendment to the U.S. Constitution and took more than 40 years (1878-1920) to ratify. A couple decades ago, it was unthinkable for the U.S. to elect a black president. Members of Congress who fought against a woman's right to vote did it in the name of God; so did those who fought against the abolition of slavery. The early stereotypes of women and black citizens denied them the right to exercise their potential and maximize their contribution toward society and the Kingdom of God.

The stereotype that our community/society[3] places on children may be the primary cause why children in certain contexts have not been able to fully exercise their potential and significantly contribute to the Kingdom of God. In many developing world countries, a teenager works to support his family and takes care of his siblings; this may be viewed as child abuse in the U.S. In some cultures, children are stereotyped (by adults) as powerless, deficient,

[3] I assume different communities/societies/cultures may develop different stereotypes for children.

manipulative and irresponsible, and we (adults) may see ourselves as better than children. We (adults) extend more grace to ourselves than to children. It is often tolerable for us to make mistakes, but we want to ensure that our children so not make the same mistakes.

Our schema has significantly influenced how discipleship, missions and the Great Commission are defined and have unintentionally left children "out of the picture." The terms mission, missions and missionary are defined for us (adults) as "full members" of the society and are often associated with:

- The crossing of cultural or linguistic barriers
- A relocation away from a person's familiar surroundings
- Proclaiming the Gospel and making disciples

In this schema regarding missions, children are not only left out of the picture but they often pay a significant price when adults take part in missions. Author Montagu G. Baker, in his critical study of William and Dorothy Carey, called for mission boards and mission leaders to re-examine the cost of missions on spouses and children.[4]

In 2008, I surveyed 900 pastors in Asia, Africa and Latin America and found that less than 30 percent of them considered their churches as disciple-making churches. I have visited many of those churches and observed that most of them include only adults in their discipleship programs. In my conversations with the pastors of those churches, I have inquired why children are not part of the disciple-making process. They are often surprised by the question and indicate that it never occurred to them that the Great Commission to make disciples of all people (*ta ethne*) included children. Their schema defined "all people" as adults only.

My 16-year-old son, Arvad, achieved the rank of Eagle Scout on August 21st, 2012—the highest rank in the Boy Scouts of America. Possibly you are aware of how demanding the requirements are to

[4] Montigu G. Baker, "Madness: The Cost of Missions? A Study of William and Dorothy Carey" in *Leadership and Mission*, Chapter 6, ed. Mark TB Laing (CMS/ISPCK, 2004), 110-111. Also C. Barnabas, "Problems of Missionary Families: Historical Examples" in *Indian Journal of Missiology,* 3/1 (1998): 25-32.

reach this rank. When Arvad was 11 years old, he was selected as a Deputy Patrol Leader, was sent to leadership training and began his leadership journey in Scouting. Over the past five years, he has been entrusted with different leadership roles in the Boy Scout networks and at school. As a father, I am proud of the leader he's become.

We do not have a problem with a young boy to be a leader in their troop, in their school, and in their community. Perhaps this is because our schema of the Boy Scouts is associated with children (adolescence). In contrast, however, I know many people who resent the idea of the same 11-year-old boy engaging in discipleship or serious ministry within their local church. Why? Because our schema defines the church as not belonging to children—it belongs to adults. It's an adult arena and not the place for children and youth to exercise any level of leadership.[5]

Cultural differences influence schema. When my friends in Colorado Springs hear the word "family," they refer to the nuclear family (husband, wife, children). When my friends from Indonesia hear the word "family," they refer to the entire family (husband, wife, children, grandparents, uncles, aunts, nieces, nephews, cousins). When I am in conversation with my friends in the U.S. about our children's developmental stages, there is a different schema as well. In America, parents prepare their children to leave the home when they reach 18 years old—parents and children alike see this as a significant milestone. However, in many developing world countries, it is not uncommon to see offspring in their twenties still living with their parents. Cultural schemas define maturity and life stages differently. This may influence our thinking about youth in mission as well.

[5] There are certain leadership positions in the church which require spiritual and mental maturity, e.g., 1 Timothy 3:2-10 and 1 Titus 1:6-9. What the church often misses is providing an opportunity for children and youth to grow in leadership capacity through exercising and practicing appropriate levels of leadership through apprenticeships in fulfilling God's missions in their communities.

Children's Developmental Stages: Cognitive and Socio-Psychological

Another important variable related to the agency of children for missions is our failure to align conversations to the specific age group and developmental stage of children (cognitive and socio-psychological development). When we encourage children to engage in the Great Commission of making disciples of all people (Matthew 28), are we referring to a two-year-old toddler, a 12-year-old adolescent or a 17-year-old teenager?

Erikson's theory of psychological development postulates a significant shift in development when one reaches adolescence (12-18 years old). Preceding adolescence, development depends on what is done to a person; at adolescence, development depends primarily upon what a person does. At this stage too, adolescents begin to develop strong affiliation and devotion to ideals, causes and friends.[6]

Recent Barna Group research on "Reasons Why Young Christians Leave Church" focused on those who were regular church goers during their early teens and explored their reasons for disconnection from church life after age 15. The research revealed that the number one reason our youth leave church is because "churches seem overprotective."[7]

At the 4/14 Global Summit in New York in 2010, Reverend C.B. Samuel of India indicated that our Christian teens are in need of ideals—a cause worth living for and dying for—but the church is giving them more and more entertainment instead. Churches thought that teens left the church because of the X-Box and the varied entertainment available to them, so to compete we invested more resources on entertainment, only to discover that the exodus continued. What children and youth need is a personal connection

[6] E.H. Erikson, *Identity: Youth and Crisis* (New York, NY: Norton, 1968).

[7] David Kinnaman, *You Lost Me: Why Young Christians are Leaving Church and Rethinking Church* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2011).

with high ideals, causes and worthy challenges; to be a force they believe can change the world.

Just recently, Catholic Marawi Bishop Edwin De La Peña of San Juan, Philippines, urged children and youth to actively participate in the missionary endeavors of the church.

> "You young people and children have the energy, enthusiasm, courage and the ability to take the risk to step forward and say, *we want to be in that boat also, we want to be with Jesus and respond to the challenge of mission*," said De la Peña, who is also chairman of the Episcopal Commission on Mission of the Catholic Bishops Conference of the Philippines. The prelate also told the youth that as the future of the nation, this is the right time for them to take the opportunity to engage actively in the mission of the Church. (CBCP News, Monday, February 11, 2013)8

Stewardship

Dr. Bryant Myers' statement that nearly 85 percent of people who make a decision for Christ in the U.S. do so between the ages of 4 and 14[9] has largely been validated by George Barna's book "Transforming Children into Spiritual Champions."[10] While global research concerning this trend is not available, Dan Brewster has been able to confirm similar trends in other parts of the world.[11]

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[8] Forces outside the church often recognized the needs and potentials of teenagers and youth more than the church. Nazi established Hitler Youth in 1922 with 1,000 memberships in year one. It grew to 5,000 in year 3, and reached 2.3 million in 1933. Scott C. Todd, *Fast Living: How the Church will End Extreme Poverty* (Colorado Springs: Compassion International, 2011), 210.

[9] Bryant Myers, "The State of the World's Children: A Cultural Challenge to the Christian Mission in the 1990's," Paper presented at the EFMA Executive Retreat, 1992.

[10] George Barna, *Transforming Children into Spiritual Champions* (Ventura, CA: Regal, 2003).

[11] Dan Brewster, "The 4/14 Window: Child Ministries and Mission Strategy," 1996.

In the 1990's, a survey was conducted with hundreds of varying groups of Christians who came from non-Christian backgrounds. At least 70 percent of those surveyed indicated that Christian friends or peers were the most 'significant others' who introduced them to Christianity.[12] If both the level of receptivity to the Christian faith of children, as claimed by Myers (affirmed by the Barna Group and Brewster), as well as the significant role of peers or friends in introducing Christ to the non-Christians, are globally true then children and adolescents (the 4/14ers) are the most significant source for missions in the past many decades.

Singlehurst claims that the first few months and years of our Christian journey are the most productive years for mission. When we first convert, we have non-Christian friends and significant opportunity to share the Gospel with them. However, after a few short years, we are drawn into the Christian subculture and have fewer and fewer non-Christian friends. Conversions occur at the rate of 85 percent between the ages of 4 and 14, and if newly converted children are not encouraged to share their faith with their friends until they reach adulthood (18 years or older)—a time when they have fewer non-Christian friends[13]–then the church has unintentionally wasted years of evangelistic productivity.

Interpreting Acts 2:17-19

The Context

On the Day of Pentecost, 120 of Christ's followers were together in the upper room in Jerusalem waiting for the promise of the Holy Spirit, which Jesus had spoken about 10 days earlier. When the Holy Spirit came, they heard the sound like a violent wind, saw what

[12] The remaining 30 percent came to know the Lord through reading literature, listening to radio broadcast, evangelistic sermons, dreams or visions of Jesus and others. See Laurence Singlehurst, *Sowing, Reaping, Keeping,* 2nd ed. (Nottingham: Inter-Varsity Press, 2006), 39.

[13] *Ibid*., 40.

seemed to be tongues of fire upon them, and spoke words they did not understand. To add to the excitement, visitors from Arabia, Asia, Rome, Mede, Parthia and others heard these people speak in their own languages declaring the wonders of God. In response to those making fun of the event, Peter stood up and referred to the "incident unfolding on their watch" as the fulfillment of Joel's prophecy spoken 800 years earlier. Students of the Bible will recognize the slight difference between the text in Joel 2:28 and Acts 2:17.

Joel 2:28-32	Acts 2:17-21
And afterward,	'In the last days, God says,
I will pour out my Spirit on all people.	I will pour out my Spirit on all people.
Your sons and daughters will prophesy,	Your sons and daughters will prophesy,
your old men will dream dreams,	your young men will see visions,
your young men will see visions.	your old men will dream dreams.
[29] Even on my servants, both men and women,	[18] Even on my servants, both men and women,
I will pour out my Spirit in those days.	I will pour out my Spirit in those days,
	and they will prophesy.
[30] I will show wonders in the heavens	[19] I will show wonders in the heavens above
and on the earth,	and signs on the earth below,
blood and fire and billows of smoke.	blood and fire and billows of smoke.
[31] The sun will be turned to darkness	[20] The sun will be turned to darkness
and the moon to blood	and the moon to blood
before the coming of the great and dreadful day of the Lord.	before the coming of the great and glorious day of the Lord.
[32] And everyone who calls	[21] And everyone who calls
on the name of the Lord will be saved	on the name of the Lord will be saved

Most scholars maintain that Luke's slight change of the text of Joel was deliberate; it should not be viewed as either his or Peter's ignorance of the correct text.[14] In fact, what Peter did was a common practice in rabbinical tradition, where "*Midrash*" was "to make yesterday's text (which is the Word of God for all time) meaningful and nourishing for today."[15] In this case, the change of the opening phrase, from "and afterward" to "in the last days" served the purpose of declaring the beginning of a new epoch, the Messianic Era, with a strong message of hope (restoration and salvation) and an added sense of urgency.

The Last Days and the Outpouring of The Holy Spirit

Peter's "last days" points to the period between the first and second coming of the Messiah. There is ample evidence that the earliest disciples did not expect a long interval between the first and second coming of Jesus. Peter appears to believe that, as the prophecy is being fulfilled, it will be followed by a quick repentance and restoration (see Acts 3:19-21). This view was not unique to Peter—the early Christians seemed to hope and anticipate that Christ would come very soon.[16] They seemed to believe that the last days belong to their generation (1 Corinthians 10:11; 1 Peter 1:20; James 5:3).

Some scholars suspect that first-century Christians struggled over the Second Coming 'delay'.[17] Later Scripture references also seem to point to the last days as occurring at a time in the future (1 Timothy 4:1; 2 Timothy 3:1; John 6:39). Just like any other Old Testament prophecies, Joel's prophecy has multiple fulfillments.[18] Today, 2,000

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[14] Leander Keck, *The New Interpreter's Bible*, Vol. 10 (Nashville, TX: Abingdon Press, 1973), 874-5.

[15] Addison G. Wright, *Midrash* (New York, NY: Alba House, 1967), 133-4.

[16] C.H. Dodd, *Apostolic Preaching and Its Developments* (London: Hodder & Stoughton, 1936), 33.

[17] Oscar Cullmann, *Christ and Time* (SCM, 1971), 156; Homer A. Kent Jr., *Jerusalem to Rome: Studies in the Book of Acts* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 1974), 33.

[18] The Hebrew idea of prophecy is a pattern that is repeated, multiple fulfillments with one ultimate fulfillment. Each of the multiple fulfillments is both

years later, while no one knows the time when the prophecy of Joel will arrive at its final fulfillment, it is certainly much closer as compared to Peter's days.

Throughout the 20th century, the church witnessed the Acts 2 outpouring of the Holy Spirit in different parts of the world with ever-increasing volume and intensity. It started with the Welsh Revival in 1904-1905, followed by the Azusa Street Revival in 1906, and the Pyongyang Revival in 1907-1910. Ghana experienced the outpouring of the Holy Spirit in 1914-1915; Shanghai was visited in 1924-1925; Nagaland in 1956; Timor-Indonesia in 1961; Asbury College in Wilmore, Kentucky in 1970; the China underground church in the 1980s; Argentina in 1992-1994; Shillong, North-East India witnessed a unique outpouring of the Holy Spirit among children in 2008, and many others. Signs and Wonders and a sense of urgency accompanied each of these awakenings—Jesus is coming soon.

In the midst of the heightened intensity of missions and awakenings in the global South, the past decade has seen a significant awareness of the biblical and strategic importance and potential of children and youth as both objects of and agents for missions. A wealth of new initiatives and publications has raised further awareness of the needs, as well as the promise and possibilities represented by this large, needy and receptive 'people group.' Christian literature is welcoming the emergence of this new discourse with enthusiasm. Churches are being challenged to engage with children both inside and outside the walls of the church, especially those who live in poverty, oppression, abuse and exploitation. Increasing numbers of books and other resources offer new and profound insights into the topics of children and childhood in the Bible, child theology, children and mission, and children and leadership.

Toward the last part of the 1990's and early 2000's, the church witnessed the birth of several major initiatives, commitments and movements for and on behalf of children—especially those who are at

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a type of, and a lesson on, the ultimate fulfillment (http://www.inplainsite.org/html/old_testament_prophecy.html).

high risk. Among them are Viva Networks for Children at Risk and their cutting-edge conferences; the Oxford Statement of Children at Risk in 1997; the Godly Play Initiative (1997); the Holistic Child Development Program in Penang, Malaysia begun in 2001; the Child Theology Movement (also born in Penang, Malaysia in 2002) and followed by numerous child theology consultations in many areas of the world; the Children's Church Movement; Children's Prayer Movements; Children's Spirituality Conference in June 2009; the 4-14 Window Global Initiative launched in New York in September 2009; and more.

If Peter would visit us today and witness the outpouring of the Holy Spirit with its signs and wonders, just like his experience in Acts chapter 2, he would observe how God has used the children and youth of today's church to spread the Good News and proclaim peace, justice and healing among children, youth and families in their communities. I wonder if he would even more passionately associate today's church with the fulfillments of Joel's last day's prophecy?

Your Sons and Daughters Will Prophesy

The word "*ben*" (meaning: son) is one of most common Hebrew words used in the Bible. It appears 4,850 times in the Old Testament and refers to "son begotten by,"—heir, inhabitant, successor, offspring and "to establish family line" (TDOT 2:145).

The phrase, "your sons and daughters" does not refer to a specific age group. It does, however, point to the 'next generation' of people to whom the prophecy was spoken. The promise covers both genders. Female and male of the next generation will become God's mouthpieces and declare His wonders.

Your Young Men Will See Visions, Your Old Men Will Dream Dreams

The "*bahurekem"* (from the root *"naar"* meaning "young") in this prophecy was contrasted with "*ziqnekem"* (meaning "old men"). In the last days, God will work through both young and old. The young will see visions and the old will dream dreams (cf. Numbers 12:6). But

something critical to our understanding is—what is the age range covered by this prophecy?

The word *naar* appears 239 times in the Old Testament; one-third of them in the books of First and Second Samuel. The Biblical usage of the Hebrew word *naar* covers 3-month-old babies (Exodus 2:6, cf. 1 Samuel 4:21), a very young boy/toddler (1 Samuel 1:22; Isaiah 8:4), probably a teenager (Jeremiah 1:6), and young men of 20 years old (Exodus 30:14; Numbers 1:3).

In most cases, our schema would lead us to focus on the higher range of the age spectrum (those twenty years and older)—it seems to make more sense that young people who are 20 years old and older would engage in missions, see visions and declare the Word of God. The way we read the Scriptures often leaves children and teens out of the picture. When it does not make sense to me and when it does not fit my schema and my stereotype, then it must be wrong.

Is Acts 2:17-21 a Missional Text?

Most scholars recognize Luke's intent of Joel's quotation in Acts 2:17-21 as programmatic for Acts in the same way that Isaiah's quotation is in Luke 4:18-19 (Isaiah 61:1-2).[19] As the arrival of Jesus the Messiah was the fulfillment of the Isaiah's prophecy, "*Today this Scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing*" (Luke 4:21). The birth of the *Ecclesia* in Acts chapter 2 was the fulfillment of Joel's prophecy, "*For these men are not drunk, as you suppose, for it is only the third hour of the day; but this is what was spoken of through the prophet Joel*" (Acts 2:15-16). As Jesus used Isaiah 61:1-2 prophecy to describe His mission,

The Spirit of the Lord is on me, because he has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor. He has sent me to proclaim freedom for the prisoners and recovery of sight for the blind, to set the oppressed free, to proclaim the year of the Lord's favour.

[19] Leander Keck, *The New Interpreter's Bible,* Vol. 10 (Nashville, TX: Abingdon Press, 1973), 870.

Peter used Joel chapter 2 to describe the mission of the "*Ecclesia*,"—"*And everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved*" (Acts 2:21).

In Luke's framework, Luke 4:19-21 and Acts 2:17-21 represent significant milestones in God's missions. In a sense, the fulfillment of Joel's prophecy in Acts chapter 2 was a democratization of the Spirit of God and thus the missions of God. In both narratives, the protagonist of God's missions is the same, namely the Holy Spirit. In Luke 4, the mandate was on Jesus, while in Acts chapter 2, the mandate to carry out God's missions is now on all people, "I will pour out my Spirit upon all flesh" (Acts 2:17), of all genders and ages.

The outpouring of the Holy Spirit in Acts chapter 2 itself was a fulfillment of a promise Jesus made to the disciples 10 days earlier, when he spoke of what the disciples would need to fulfill the Great Commission, "*But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit comes on you; and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the ends of the earth*" (Acts 1:8).

While Luke 4:19-21 provides the holistic nature of God's missions, Acts 2:17-21 promotes an intergenerational and inclusive (gender, social strata) missional approach. One describes the "what" and the other describes the "who" (and "how") to do God's missions.

Close

The disciples of 2,000 years ago hindered children from drawing closer to Christ because of their ignorance to the significance of children in the Kingdom of God. Today we stand in the way of Jesus blessing and using children simply because they are not part of "our" version of missions, church and the Great Commission.

As we engage in this conversation—listening to God and one another—may the Holy Spirit continue to help us recognize that the enemy of equality and inclusiveness is our own "unconscious bias" against children and youth. May God lead us from self-deception to

self-awareness. "*Suffer the children, and forbid them not, to come unto me, for of such is the reign of the heavens.*"[20]

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Theme 2:

A Critical Review of Modern Missions Movement

EDITOR'S INTRODUCTION

This was the first commissioned paper delivered at the 4/14 Missiology Conference in Seoul in February 2013. It explores six models of mission, pointing out that the most prominent one in the last two hundred years (that of the professional missionary) is not the only historically valid model, nor the most appropriate model today. It is also the model that is least accessible to children. Rather the Church needs to develop "appropriate contemporary models" for mission which must include children and young people, and a "multiple-model strategy for mission." Mark Oxbrow builds his argument by considering children in the Bible and a theology of childhood and human development, including an examination of the text from Joel 2:18-32 which Peter draws on for his sermon on the Day of Pentecost. What interests Oxbrow is that "the outpouring of God's spirit is manifested in different ways amongst different groups in society and in ways which fit so beautifully with our experience of generational differences… Whilst the elders dream the young people are full of visions."

As he develops his thinking about models for mission for children, Mark's first plea is that we listen, both to children and to God. He then offers three keys: the prime importance of relationships over programmes; the value of story, and the need for passion controlled by love.

Oxbrow starts and finished his paper with stories. This narrative approach in part defines his position: his understanding is that missiology needs to be rooted in lived human experience as well as within the Scriptures.

Oxbrow's paper deals with 'big picture' themes.

PAPER 2

A Critical Review of Modern Missions Movement

BY MARK OXBROW

Introduction

Abbe is a 17 year old Ethiopian from a poor family. She is highly vulnerable, working for a wealthy businessman in Rhiad, Saudi Arabia, where she cleans the house and looks after the children. She has noticed the way her employer and his friends look at her, and she is not comfortable in their presence. She has heard stories from other girls about the 'favours' they have to give to the men at night. She keeps a cupboard pushed against the door of her tiny room each night. When the men are at work life is very different. There are three wives in the house and they all have great fun together with the children. Abbe came to faith in Jesus when she was ten years old. A school friend told her about Jesus and took her to see the Jesus film at a church near their school. She has an Arabic version of the Jesus film (which she doesn't understand). Her pastor gave it to her when she got this job. Yesterday afternoon she showed the film to the wives and children in her house. At first they were chatting but gradually they stopped and at the end of the film Abbe noticed that one of the wives was crying. Today that wife has been asking her questions all day. She was surprised how well she answered some of them but there are a couple she will need to write to her pastor about.

Is Abbe a missionary?

In my role with Faith2Share I have the privilege of working with hundreds of mission leaders around the world, many of them leading new and emerging mission movements. One of the saddest aspects of this work for me is to see one after another struggling to fit their

mission vision into the models of mission they have received and been taught from the past, and largely from the West. It is rather like a zoo keeper reading a book on poultry farming and then trying to run his zoo like a chicken farm. The chickens will do well and the rats will survive but the elephants will go rather hungry and the lions may decide to eat the keeper!

In a sense we are suffering today from the great success of the last two hundred years of Protestant missionary movements and their development of a highly effective model – the deployment of well-trained full-time cross-cultural missionaries. But this success has blinded us to the fact that throughout the Christian era God has called his people into mission in very many different ways. In this paper I will hope to show that children can be very effective missionaries but that the model we most readily adopt, the professional missionary, is one of the least appropriate for their participation in the mission of God. Children can cross cultures in mission far more readily as migrants, refugees, students and electronically than they can as professional missionaries. And like adults, children need to be helped to see that mission is as much about how we witness to Christ's life within us where we are now as it is about going somewhere else.

Six Models of Mission

1. Refugee Evangelists

Some of the very first cross-cultural missionaries were refugees. Luke tells us that during the persecution that broke out in Jerusalem after the death of Stephen "those who were scattered [throughout the region of Judea and Samaria] went about preaching the word."[1] Of course children were amongst those refugees and in their new contexts no doubt shared their faith-story with their new peers within the host community. This story has been repeated throughout history with refugees from war, famine, and natural disaster taking the gospel

[1] Acts 8:4

with them to new communities and founding new churches. In 1988 thousands of Christians from the Bahr al Ghazal region of southern Sudan fleeing a violent civil war, crossed the swamps, many dying in the process, into the Gambella region of Ethiopia where some continue to live in refugee camps even today.[2] As they became settled local animist Ethiopians began to take an interest in the Christian faith which they brought and now many churches are being established amongst local Ethiopian tribes people.[3] In his book *Children of War and Hope,* Joseph Ayok-Loewenberg, a Sudanese child of the Dinka tribe, tells his own story and that of many other children who were killed, abused and exploited during the civil war and yet hung on to their hope in God and witnessed to His sustaining love.[4]

Living in a decade which has seen more forced migration and people displacement than almost any before, it is not surprising that we continue to see the Christian faith spread by African refugees in Eastern Europe, Tamils in the Middle East and Iraqi Christians in London. In what is today a much more 'connected' world, formal refugees are now joined by those who migrate for employment, education or family reasons and these groups also can become very significant in terms of Christian mission. The influence of Chinese students who have found a faith in Christ whilst studying in Singapore, the USA or UK and then return to senior positions in China is recognised as having been significant in recent years for the growth of Christianity amongst the Chinese middle class.[5]

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[2] See R. Werner, W. Anderson & A. Wheeler, *Day of Devastation Day of Contentment: The History of the Sudanese Church across 2000 years* (Paulines Publications Africa, 2000), 525.

[3] This work is now being supported by the Anglican diocese of Egypt through its ministry in Ethiopia and more information about current developments is available from Bishop Andrew Proud in Addis Ababa.

[4] J. Ayok-Lowenberg, *Children of War and Hope* (CMS: London, 1995).

[5] See for example F. Yang, "Chinese conversion to evangelical Christianity: The importance of social and cultural contexts" in *Sociology of Religion* 59(3) (1998): 237-257.

We need to ask ourselves how we equip children and young people (as well as adults) who travel to new cultures as refugees, migrants, or temporary residents, to witness effectively to Christ. For example, if a Christian schoolchild is involved in a student exchange and lives with a Buddhist or Hindu family for some weeks have we considered equipping them with appropriate ways of sharing the story of Jesus? In 2010 28,142 high school children from around the world studied for a term or more in the US. Many of these will not have been Christian. Were their US classmates ready to share the gospel with these visiting students and equip them to take the good news of Jesus back to their families and home countries?

2. Witnessing Traders and Entrepreneurs

The contemporary exploration and discussion of Business as Mission (BAM)[6] is nothing new. It is simply a new expression of a missional process that saw witnessing traders and entrepreneurs bringing the hope of the gospel to many along the Silk Routes of the Middle Ages and later the great trading companies of the nineteenth century – right through to the Christian entrepreneurs of more recent times. With the Nestorian churches of Iraq, and elsewhere in the Middle East, under severe pressure today we tend to forget that the Nestorian Church was "the 'missionary' church par excellence in the overall context of medieval Christianity."[7] "Three dimensions of Nestorianism – monasticism, theology, and mission," David Bosch reminds us, "were mutually interdependent"[8] resulting in a mission which travelled rapidly along the trade routes of Asia as far as China, businessmen winning trading partners as fellow disciples of Christ.

In the twenty-first century a significant number of Chinese intellectuals and entrepreneurs have been encouraged to explore Christian faith because of its perceived positive influence on Western

[6] See for example S. Rundle and T. Steffen, *Great Commission Companies: The Emerging Role of Business in Missions*, (InterVarsity Press, 2003).

[7] W. Hage, "Der Weg nach Asien: Die ostsyrische Missionskirke" in *Schaferdeik* (1978): 360.

[8] D. Bosch, *Transforming Mission* (Orbis Books, 1991), 204.

economic growth during the past three centuries.[9] Christian business is understood to be good for social and economic advancement. At the core of 'Business as Mission' lies the conviction that the holistic mission of God includes the creation of opportunities for women and men to be creative, to contribute to society and to create wealth for themselves and others. Business is an integral part of the holistic gospel, ministering to communities as well as to individuals.[10]

Today more Christians travel on business than ever before and the opportunities for them to engage formally, corporately and individually in mission expand daily. In some parts of the world those engaged in business gain access to 'closed' communities decades before more intentional missionaries arrive. The questions facing mission agencies are: What contact do you have with the business community? Do you know where Christians are travelling on business? What support, preparation and training are you offering to these men and women so enable them to be effective gospel carriers?

3. Wandering, Gospeling Monks and Nuns

From the fifth and sixth centuries onwards the monastic communities of the Eastern Churches, spreading across North Africa and eventually up into the Celtic European fringes, and then the great Roman Catholic missionary orders provide a model for 'mission in community' which is being embraced afresh by the 'New Monasticism'[11] and other similar movements.

In an age when we run the double risk of focusing too much on the conversion of individuals and driving a wedge between evangelism and worship (as alternative activities competing for time and resources) it is good to recall a day when communities focusing first and foremost on the worship of God daily proclaimed the gospel of the living Christ to those outside the church. Children were (and in

[9] R. Moll, "Great Leap Forward" in *Christianity Today* (May 2008).

[10] C. N. Johnson, *Business as Mission: A Comprehensive Guide to Theory and Practice* (IVP Academic, 2010).

[11] See for example J. Wilson-Hartgrove, *New Monasticism: What it Has to Say to Today's Church* (Brazos Press, 2008).

many of the Eastern Churches still are) given significant roles to play within these worshipping-witnessing communities. Not as mini-adults but as children, the young people of Orthodox Romania can still be found taking significant roles in the daily or weekly liturgy and even more so on the great high feasts of Easter, Transfiguration or Pentecost.

Following the pattern of God's mission through His people Israel[12], monastic communities in Ethiopia[13] and Egypt[14] and then across North Africa found that their worship and life together drew people from near and far to discover just what these communities had to offer. But not only did these communities share the gospel with those who came to them, they also went out and onto the oceans in flimsy coracles, to carry the gospel to scattered villages and hamlets from Spain to Ireland, the Volga River to the Baltic Sea. The key point to note here is that these early monastic communities were not intentionally established for mission, their primary focus was the worship of God and their communal life of discipleship. Mission was more of an outcome than an objective. Children often found a more natural place within these 'communities in mission' than they might in a mission agency today.

These early mission communities were followed in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries by the formation of major missionary communities within the Roman Catholic Church. The Jesuits, for example, formed in 1538 by St. Ignatius of Loyola, became one of the world's most successful missionary movements. Ignatius said of this new movement that it was "founded chiefly for this purpose: to strive especially for the defense and propagation of the faith and for the progress of souls in Christian life and doctrine." Not only were individuals 'won for Christ' and churches established in numerous

[12] C.J.H. Wright, *The Mission of God* (IVP Press, 2006), chapter 3.

[13] See for example S. Kaplan, *The Monastic Holy Man and the Christianization of Early Solomonic Ethiopia* (Wiesbaden 1984).

[14] See for example O. Meinardus, *Ethiopian Monks in Egypt in Christian Egypt: Faith and Life* (Cairo, 1970), 427-35.

countries but, especially in Latin America, whole nations were shaped by their, often controversial, missionary methods.[15]

The Jesuits, of course, were also noted for their work with children, putting huge resources into Christian education and the spiritual formation of young people. The abuse and exploitation which have marred Catholic (and other Christian) child care in recent decades should not blind us to the very positive role that these Catholic orders have had in the recognition of children as equal citizens of the Kingdom of God and as young disciples of Jesus with their own distinctive witness to His gospel.

Examples of contemporary monastic communities with far reaching missional impact would be the Taize Community[16] in France (which has been largely a movement of young people), the Iona Community[17] in Scotland, the Sojourners Community[18] in the USA, and the Order of Mission[19] which began in Sheffield, UK in 2000 but has now become international. These and the many other contemporary experiments in residential and dispersed community life are providing 'ways into faith in Jesus' that often cannot be provided by more traditional churches or mission agencies. As communities of families they naturally include children within their lives of discipleship and witness.

4. Imperial Philanthropists

Empires (from Egyptian, Chinese and Roman to Ottoman and British) have always had their tyrants and their extortionists but they have also had their 'imperial philanthropists.' The story of Paul's mission in Acts includes reference to imperial officials who supported

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[15] In Brazil, for example both the cities of Sao Paulo and Rio de Janiero were founded by the Jesuits.

[16] For a description of Taize and its history see J.L.G. Balado*, The Story of Taize Mowbray* (London, 1980).

[17] For a description of the Iona community and its history see R. Ferguson, *Chasing the Wild Goose: Story of the Iona Community* (Collins, 1988).

[18] See http://www.sojo.net

[19] See http://www.missionorder.org

his mission[20], and many civil servants in the Indian Raj were active in mission amongst Hindus and Muslims, whilst their colleagues in China and Japan planted the name of Jesus in less fertile soil. European industrialists turned explorers in 'darkest' Africa or the more exotic East often adopted the tri-polar objectives of bringing civilization, commerce and Christian faith to the native peoples they encountered – a programme famously espoused by the London Missionary Society's David Livingstone. Today those blessed with more than adequate financial resources continue to travel and to become aware of the needs of others including engaging in specifically missional activity.

Of more significance for the purpose of this paper are the less well known Christian philanthropists who often combine their financial support with an active involvement in mission, giving their time and using their contacts to resource mission work. Many mission agencies benefit from supporters who have the resources necessary to engage in philanthropy for mission. Sadly these people are rarely recognised as part of the missionary task force although they are the backbone of much evangelism, discipleship, care and support amongst children around the world.

5. Cyber Surfing Disciples of Jesus

Almost 50 years ago I was introduced to Jesus as my personal Saviour by a 16 year-old Ethiopian school boy whom I had never met. I had been his 'pen friend' for two years and when he himself came to faith in Jesus he very naturally wrote to share his experience and began to pray for me. His witness was so natural – one child to another – that I felt under no pressure at all and soon found myself on the road to full Christian discipleship.

Since those months back in 1964 the world has changed. In those days it was quite unusual for me, a British child, to have an Ethiopian pen friend, and our letters took several weeks to travel from home to

[20] See for example Philippians 4:22 and Acts 19:31.

home. Today almost every child I meet has someone amongst their Facebook friends who lives in a different country.

As elders we are concerned about children being 'groomed' on-line and how we limit their access to pornography and violence, but are we also aware of the very real opportunities that exist for on-line witness and faith-sharing – not just for adults, but also for children? Children are naturally creative and naturally communicative and the internet can facilitate both of these to an amazing degree. Fifteen years ago, after helping to run a Youth Alpha course in Malaysia, I found myself doing a weekly on-line Bible study with a 14-year old boy in Malaysia. That Bible study was done by email but today it could just as easily happen by Skype or instant messaging on Facebook (taking due regard to the issues of protecting vulnerable people on-line) .

My question for church leaders is about how we are resourcing our children and young people to use the technology that is more at their fingertips than ours for effective gospel ministry. Short videos created by a group of Christian children can be an immensely powerful witness on YouTube; and how about a mobile app. which allows children to share their thoughts (their thoughts, not adult thoughts) on a different Bible verse each day?

6. Professional Missionaries

It seems strange today to realise that up until the 1780s it was almost unheard of for a lay man or woman to find a career (long or short term) as a missionary. In fact one of the founding documents of the Society for Missions to Africa and the East (later to become CMS), drafted in 1799, had to argue the case for those not episcopally ordained to be sent overseas as ministers of the gospel.[21] William Carey and John Thomas of the Baptist Missionary Society, who set out for India in 1793 are credited as the forerunners of the hundreds of thousands of men and women from numerous nations, but

[21] Unpublished archive document of CMS Account of a Society for Missions to Africa and the East Instituted by Members of the Established Church, 1799.

particularly Europe and North America, who have served as professional missionaries over the past two centuries. Initially service was expected to be lifelong (although at least in West Africa that typically meant two or three years before disease brought death or permanent disability).

The distinguishing characteristics of those I here describe as professional missionaries are the vocation to a life exclusively focused on mission; the ownership of this call and subsequent sending by the church; training for and in mission service; the provision of a salary/stipend/allowance either by the missionary agency, church or a group of friends/supporters; the provision of other support structures such as education for children, prayer support, medical care, etc.; and normally the guidance, direction or management of the missionary by an agency or church.

During the whole of the nineteenth century and the first half of the twentieth century almost all wives who went into the mission field were regarded as 'homemakers' and mothers, although history reveals that many had as great, if not greater, impact on the faith of local communities as their husbands. Today most women are regarded, and trained, as full missionaries in their own right. This is good but it leads us to the question of children. Are the children of 'professional missionaries' simply children who must be cared for, or are the children of a missionary family also missionaries in their own right? If so how are they prepared, equipped and supported in this role?

Although this paper is encouraging a diversification of missionary modalities it should in no way be seen as underestimating the amazing contribution that these thousands of dedicated professional missionaries have made, and continue to make, to the growth in Christian discipleship globally.

The Biblical View of the Child

During our time together this week others will deal more fully with the Biblical view of the child but in order to advance my review of contemporary mission praxis I need briefly to put down a few

markers which will help us to correctly appreciate the place, responsibilities and gifting of children in contemporary mission contexts.

The primary model for understanding the role of children in mission is the relationship between God and his people. The Old Testament, in particular, is full of language in which God adopts a father-daughter, mother-son, relationship with his people. Through the prophet Isaiah God promises, "As a mother comforts her child, so will I comfort you"[22], and through the prophet Nathan God speaks of Solomon saying, "I will be his father, and he will be my son. When he does wrong, I will punish him with a rod wielded by men, with floggings inflicted by human hands. But my love will never be taken away from him."[23] The model then for our relationship with children within, and outside, the church is clearly the relationship God establishes with his children. This relationship is characterised by love, respect, discipline, honour and joy. Most importantly there is never any hint in scripture that God regards children as inferior to adults, or as 'potential adults.' Just as men and women are different but equally honoured and valued by God so children, teenagers, adults and the elderly are all of significance to God in their own right.

Also, very significantly, for our discussion here, God who is omnipotent and has no actual need of collaborators in His mission, invites the participation of His children, men and women, in mission to the whole creation. God delights to share His mission with us, despite our frailty and the many mistakes we make. He gives each of us different gifts and different opportunities for mission and this is not restricted to adults. God loves to be inclusive. If we are to follow this divine pattern then we see that every child of God, has a role in mission and has been given, by God, the gifts needed to fulfil that role. Children are not excluded from participation in the mission of God. To God the slave girl who brings Naaman to bathe in the river is just as important as Solomon, the wisest of kings. He does not expect

[22] Isaiah 66:13

[23] 2 Samuel 7:14

a slave girl to rule nations or a king to encourage the leprous Naaman, but He does expect each to contribute to His great work of salvation.

As we look at contemporary patterns of mission there are a number of questions we must face in the light of our biblical understanding of childhood. I will deal with these more fully later but they will include such issues as:

- Whether churches regard children as full members of the Body of Christ and agents of God's mission
- Whether we expect children to engage in mission as 'little adults' or as children, exploring the particular gifting and calling that God has given to each child.
- Whether our churches allocate resources to children to facilitate their development, equipping, participation in, and initiating of, mission in their own contexts.

Children in the Bible

Despite its origin in cultures which largely regarded children as the 'possessions' of their elders and 'future promise', the Bible relates many stories where children play a key role in the fulfilment of God's purposes. Both Bambang Budijanto[24] and Dan Brewster[25] have retold their stories in print. All I need do here is mention a few names to remind us of the key roles these children play.

- Moses – whose early years in Pharaoh's courts were such an important preparation for his leadership of God's people.
- Samuel – responding to God's call as a young child
- Naaman's slave girl – faith strong enough to bend the stubborn will of a fighter
- Josiah – the boy king and great reformer
- David – with courage to defeat Goliath

[24] Bambang Budijanto, "Children: New energy for mission" in *Emerging Missions Movements*, ed. Bambang Budijanto, (Compassion/AEA, 2010).

[25] Dan Brewster, *Future Impact: Connecting Child, Church and Mission* (Compassion, 2010), 21ff.

- Jonathan – putting his own life at risk out of loyalty to a friend, David
- A boy with five loaves and two fishes – shares his small resource with 5,000 people
- Mark – the young lad who followed Jesus into Gethsemane and became an evangelist[26]

It would not be a misuse of terminology to attribute to the ministries of these children the terms 'leader', 'prophet', 'evangelist', 'pastor', and 'minister' but in doing so we need to free ourselves from our adult interpretations of these terms and see how beautifully God creates child evangelists, etc.

There were of course many other children who participated in the central acts of salvation history but whose story was never recorded in scripture. How many of the shepherds who came to worship the child Jesus were, I wonder, children, just as many children today tend the family flocks? The Children's version of the Jesus Film[27] is an interesting and imaginative attempt to bring to life the response of first century Palestinian children to the birth and life of Jesus.

A Theology of Childhood and Human Development

The psychologist Carl Rogers[28] has pointed out that it is a common failing of insecure human beings to regard all those who are different from themselves as inferior, but with potential to become like us and therefore better. The African tribesman is regarded as a 'savage' who can be 'civilised', and, given time, find his place amongst the superior members of society – like us. Women have the potential to become good leaders in industry once they learn how to behave like men. The same, says Rogers, is true of children. Threatened by their difference,

[26] Mark 14:51

[27] http://jesusfilmmedia.org/video/1_529-cl-0-0/english/the-story-of-jesus-for-children

[28] Carl Rogers, *On Becoming a Person: A Therapist's View of Psychotherapy* (London: Constable, 1961).

their energy, and even their innate morality, adults only see in their children the potential for them to become adults, to become like them. We too easily regard childhood as an inferior stage of life, a preparatory stage during which we are prepared for real life as an adult.

A biblical passage which is really helpful here is God's promise of redemption in Joel 2:18-32 and specifically verses 28 and 29. Here, at the point of salvation, God promises an outpouring of His Spirit on the nation. (Although originally addressed to Israel, in the light of Christ's work on the cross, we would today interpret this as a promise to all nations.) The promise comes first as a promise of the Spirit for all people and then it is repeated as a four-fold promise.

1. Both men and women will prophesy (the sons and daughters of the nation – v.28)
2. Elders will dream dreams (there is no gender in the Hebrew, it is men and women – v28)
3. Young people will see visions (again no gender, so girls, boys and teenagers – v28)
4. Even servants (male and female) will receive the Spirit (the Hebrew word used here only occurs three times in the Bible but appears to mean more than 'servants' – something like 'the more lowly members of your society' so here it deals with class or caste divides - v29)

What interests me here is that the outpouring of God's spirit is manifested in different ways amongst different groups in society and in ways which fit so beautifully with our experience of generational differences. While adults are seen to be prophesying (a gift more closely related to the actual activity of daily life – the planning and acting of the adult world), the elders are pictured as dreaming. Dreams make sense of the complexities of life that elders more readily understand. Whilst the elders dream the young people are full of visions. Visions are about clarity of sight and are often couched in very black and white language, the language of young people, for whom the distinction between good and evil is so clear. (The reason why there is no specific manifestation attributed to the outpouring of

the Spirit on the lowly members of society must await another occasion.)

This passage illustrates for me the great importance of allowing children to receive and give witness to the Spirit of God in ways that are appropriate for children, in childish ways. I am aware that by using the term "childish ways" I immediately run the risk of belittling the witness of children but that is unbiblical thinking! In God's eyes "childish ways" and "adult ways" (as indeed the "ways of the elders") are different but of equal worth. In fact when Jesus wanted to show adults how to behave, what did he do? He brought a child and placed the child in their midst saying, "unless you change and become like little children, you will never enter the Kingdom of Heaven"[29]

Preserving the Integrity of Childhood and the Integrity of Mission

The French feminist, Simone de Beauvoir wrote, "I made up my mind that when I was older I would never forget that a five-year-old is a complete individual, a character in his own right. But this is precisely what adults refused to admit and when they treated me with condescension I at once took offence."[30] In his more political work, the socialist, Peter Fuller suggests that maintaining the integrity of childhood as a state of being as valuable to society as adulthood is essential for the very future of human existence, as humanity.[31] If we turn children into mini-adults we destroy an essential part of the 'community of persons' which we know as the human race. (The same, he maintains, would apply to the destruction of elders through euthanasia).

[29] Matthew 18:2-4

[30] Simone de Beauvoir, *The Second Sex* (1949), trans. H M Parshley, (Penguin, 1972).

[31] Peter Fuller, "Uncovering Childhood" in *Changing Childhood*, ed. Martin Hoyles (Staples, Rochester, 1979).

Childhood is a gift from God, as is every stage of life and death, and we make a sad mistake if we consider it inferior to adulthood and something from which a child should be 'set free' as soon as possible. But it is a gift not only to the child. As Fuller has suggested all humanity is impoverished when childhood is diminished. So what do we make of this theologically and missionally?

In Penang, Malaysia, ten years ago a group of theologians came together to form what is now known as the 'Child Theology Movement.' Through a series of consultations they have, since 2002, begun to raise awareness within the Christian community, of the importance of doing child focused theology. Speaking out of that new movement Professor Haddon Willmer alludes to Matthew 18:2-4 saying,

> "The child was a converting corrective to these disciples partly because they did not expect the child to have anything to teach them, or anything to do with their concerns. Theology requires us to take note of much that we overlook or ignore – first it calls us to attend to God, who is so easily missed, mistaken and despised and then to see the world in God's light, and God's glory in the entire world. God creates all things in love and treasures the beauty of all his creation: the sparrows have value in his eyes, like the angels who always behold his face. Theology is not a narrow teaching about God, isolated from the world, for that cannot be true to God who creates the world."[32]

He goes on to show how Jesus' interruption of the theologizing of the disciples opened their eyes to a new understanding of greatness which they would never have grasped without the child's eruption into the middle of their adult, power-seeking, theology. As long as the child is absent our theology is not only incomplete but in danger of being fatally flawed.

The same is true of mission. When only adults (or children encouraged to act as mini-adults) are engaged in mission then the mission of God is fatally flawed.

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[32] Haddon Willmer, "Introducing Child Theology Paper," given at 5th CCCF Forum, 13 April 2005.

Within the Old Testament the child has a stronger role. When Isaiah saw a vision of the promised salvation of God he wrote, "The wolf will live with the lamb, the leopard will lie down with the goat, the calf and the lion and the yearling together; and a little child will lead them."[33] At the Passover feast it is a child who asks the questions (a very childlike thing to do!) that provide the prompt for the elder to relate the story of God's salvation. Isaiah's "little child" is not only a prophetic reference to the child Jesus but also a theological contestation of the power-theology of adults, and on Passover night we see this beautiful demonstration of the complementary nature of the child's questioning theology and the elder's reminiscing theology which together provide a functional theology for all who eat together at the table of God's salvation.

Little is recorded of the role of Nestorian children or the children of the Celtic communities who took the gospel across Western Europe but we do know of St. Nina of Georgia, the slave girl from Cappadocia who in the fourth century was taken to Georgia and there performed miracles, leading the queen and her people to faith in God. In more recent times thousands of children have migrated to new cultures with their missionary parents and there have shared their faith with new friends and neighbours, but sadly these stories are seldom told. Certainly few mission archives, or mission histories, give any place to the role of children in the spread of the gospel during the past two centuries. What must we now do to ensure that we preserve the integrity of mission by insisting that the mission of children is both given place and recognized in all we do as a missionary church? This is the question to which we must now turn.

Appropriate Contemporary Models of Mission for Children

We must begin by listening. With a child in our midst (either literally or figuratively) we must listen to God and listen to children. As adults we need to give children space (and permission) to tell us how they

[33] Isaiah 11:6

wish to respond to God's love. Children are natural evangelists – for the latest video game, for hunting snakes by the river, and for God. If God is real to them they will naturally talk about Him with their peers. 47 years ago my pen-friend in Ethiopia did not seek the permission of his parents or pastor to share the gospel with me; he used a pen and some paper, and more importantly his 'childish' words, to share across 5,900 kilometres what was on his heart – child to child. In fact if we could listen to children telling us what they think mission is then we might be able, finally, to escape from some of the entrapments that keep us from engaging every moment of our lives in the mission of God. So listening and asking the right (open) questions is very important.

Having said we need to listen I am now rather nervous about what I, as a speaking adult, am about to say, but perhaps I should say something about how we might see children engaging in mission in childish ways.

The key is relationships not structures or events. Children are relational and passionate about such things as trust, betrayal, loyalty, love and friendship. So, their mission will be relational and in our modern world relationships are no longer geographically constrained.

The second key is story. Children love story, they live story. Sadly many adults have become blind to the power of story thinking of stories only as a leisure time escape from reality. But God loves story. Sit a child in your midst, look hard at the scriptures with fresh eyes and you will see story after story, so many stories in fact that they come together as one all embracing story, God's story, His-tory.

If we can let children loose with God's story, the myths, the family stories, the great stories of good and evil, the stories of betrayal and trust, the story of salvation, we might be surprised by the results.

The third key is passion controlled by love. Children are passionate. The broken toy signals the end of the world, the late arrival at school is an event of cataclysmic proportion, a new friend found is the entry into the highest heaven. Adults sometimes find such unbridled passion frightening but when passion is controlled by love (not force) amazing things happen. God is passionate, so

passionate that he does quite stupid things, like giving away his Son to evil men. What will happen in mission if we can love our children enough to allow them their passions?

I have spoken here of three keys, and of course there are others. The temptation now is to build these into structures, a new strategy for children in mission. Before we know it we will have an international board, a budget of millions and a raft of strategies for deploying passionate, relational, story-telling child evangelists. Immediately adults are taking control again. But what about children, what do they need? Perhaps all they need is space, permission, unconditional love, and respect. Before we do any more planning we need to do a lot more being and listening. Can we create space so that children can take the initiative, do their own planning and discover themselves what resources they need to be effective in mission?

Releasing Resources for Child-led Mission

Now comes the challenging part. Todd Johnson tells us in his annual review of global mission[34] that globally churches receive US$ 237 billion of which they spend US$ 33 billion on cross-cultural mission; that there are 640 million computers in use in Christian ministry and 7.7 million books about Christianity in print. We also know that 26% of all Christians are currently under the age of 15.[35] So what proportion of these church-controlled resources are readily available to that 26% of the Body of Christ? I don't know the answer but I can make a fairly good guess, as I am sure you can. Are we even aware what resources the children in our churches need to be effective in mission? When I see a church I know well (my own church!) allocating 0.7% of its annual budget for "children's work" alarm bells ring. But it is not primarily about money. It is about time, about prayer, about creativity, about emotional energy, and relational space,

[34] Report prepared by Todd M. Johnson and Peter F. Crossing at the Center for the Study of Global Christianity, Gordon-Conwell Theological Seminary, published in *IBMR* Jan 2013: 33.

[35] Pew Report 2010.

and about so much more that could truly resource and release our children into effective child-shaped mission.

Perhaps the first resource we need to allocate is the time and relational commitment it will take to come alongside our children, to be received into their circle, to listen, to reflect and then to respond in the ways that they will find most helpful.

I do not want what I have just said to be misinterpreted as suggesting that we 'put children in the driving seat' of the church. Rather what I am suggesting is that as adults and children we need to enter into a new partnership of mutual respect and collaboration in mission.

A Multiple-Model Strategy for Mission in the 21st Century

So what of the future? I began this paper with a review of six different models of mission. I went on to suggest that some of these models are more accessible to children than others and that the model of the professional missionary is one of the least accessible to children. We explored something of the nature of child(ish) faith and mission and suggested that the mission of God is incomplete unless space is made for the genuine contribution of children. My (childish) story is one of a fatally flawed mission which had undervalued the contribution not only of children but also of business people, refugees and internet surfers, and a central (adultish) proposition is that we need to urgently rebuild a collaborative model of mission which allows to each human person their true place in the mission of God.

For too long academically trained missiologists (whom of course we need and value) have controlled the theology of mission and adult mission strategists (whom again we need) have controlled the missional activity of the church. I do not deny the great results we have seen, whole continents brought closer to the Kingdom of God, but I dream (as an elder) of so much more. I dream of a missiology which is rich in the story telling of children, the analytical and propositional work of adults and the reflective, mystical, thoughtfulness of our elders. I dream too of the Church's mission

enriched by the skills of the business entrepreneur, the relational passion of children, the vulnerability and humility of refugees, the emotional intelligence of women, and the clear thinking of alpha males. I dream that one day every human person will find their true place in the Mission of God, not modelled by others, but shaped by the empowering of the indwelling Spirit. I dream.

Becoming "like the least of one of these"

> "Jesus called a little child to him, and placed the child among them. And he said: "Truly I tell you, unless you change and become like little children, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven. Therefore, whoever takes the lowly position of this child is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven."[36]

Postscript

With eyes wide open and pride in his heart Joel watched his father preach every Sunday morning. He was especially pleased when men and women came forward at the end of the service and knelt down just in front of where he was sitting. He saw their tears and then heard his father gently praying with each one in turn. At night in the privacy of his bedroom Joel solemnly put on his long dressing gown, stood on the end of his bed, and with his toy bear, his sister's doll and Actionman sitting quietly on the floor, he began ... "Brothers and sisters, the Lord has laid in on my heart tonight to share with you the most terrifying words of St. Paul ...." The words, he had practiced many times, but he was still unsure of his voice. Was it grave enough? Did he sound as convincing as his father? Night after night he practiced and then the day came, the day when he was to become God's true servant. It was a warm autumn day and his school friends were lying on the grass exhausted after a game of baseball. Stepping up onto the log by the swing, and without his dressing gown, Joel began. "Brothers and sisters, the Lord ...." With admiring eyes, but

[36] Matthew 18:2-4

trembling with fear, his mother watched from the window, as his friends first laughed nervously, then pushed Joel off the log and finally rode off on their bikes. Joel sat weeping.

Those friends never returned, there were no more baseball games for Joel, it was a dark autumn, but every night Joel got back on his bed Bible in hand, Actionman attentively listening. In his loneliness at school Joel began to notice another boy he had not seen before, sitting alone at lunchtime. Stan was shy and somewhat overweight and sat alone to avoid the attention of the school bullies. Somehow Joel and Stan began to spend more time together and to pass the time Joel began to tell Stan some of the stories he made up in his mind. One day he found himself sitting in the bike shed telling Stan the story of Jesus, only he made Jesus into a fat boy who got picked on by the Roman guards. The day came when Stan asked to go to church to hear more stories from Joel's father and to follow Jesus. But the biggest change was for Joel. His storytelling became known in the school and no longer did he spend his lunchtimes alone. Suddenly he was in great demand, "Hey Joel, tell us one of your crazy stories." "No, not that one about the dragon in the shopping mall, the one about the boy with the magic fish who made a picnic for three million people – and that guy Jesus."

Questions Specific to Paper 2

1. What steps do we need to take in our churches to ensure that we give equal worth to children, youth, adults and elsers and avoid the trap of thinking of children as 'potential adults' and elders as 'expired adults'?
2. What does 'child-shaped mission' look like?
3. There is an alternative interpretation of the miracle of the feeding of 5,000. One young boy whose mother gave him a packed lunch so he could go and listen to Jesus, saw a lot of hungry people and a bunch of adults (the disciples) getting in a flap about where and how to by food. He loved Jesus. He wanted to help. He gave up what he had - his lunch. 5,000

adults were so ashamed that they had hidden their lunch and were being offered the boy's lunch that they began to take out their own lunch boxes and do what the boy had taught them - to share. They made a big discovery. Together they had far more than they could eat! The miracle? Not magic with fish and bread but the conversion of selfish adults by the generosity of one child. What are the missional implications of this alternative interpretation of such a well know story?

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Theme 3:

Towards a New Missiology: Renewing our Engagement in God's Mission

Editor's Introduction

Gustavo Crocker is a Latin American missiologist. As such his is the first Majority World voice heard in this Compendium. He brings a different perspective to understanding the place of children and young people within mission. Initially Crocker explores the nature of missiology and the Missio Dei, drawing a distinction between the "missionary dimension" and "missionary intention." He then explores current trends in mission. He uses this "big picture" analysis to create the backdrop against which he develops his argument that children and young people are "The Big Omission" in the Modern Missionary Movement. He argues that "there is biblical and historical evidence that the early church considered children and youth as essential in her life and mission" and it is time for them to be re-included. He asserts that it is time for the Church to become "the Church in mission", and for that we need a new paradigm for understanding mission – and this must include an emphasis on the child in the middle and the indigenous believers. He finishes his paper with an example from Bangladesh, claiming that "The Bangladesh model is a practical demonstration of the new theology of mission that is global, indigenous, holistic, and which places the child back in the middle".

Crocker's argument is timely and builds on the insights from Oxbrow.

PAPER 3

Towards a New Missiology: Renewing Our Engagement in God's Mission

BY GUSTAVO CROCKER

Introduction

Growing up in a small town of Guatemala in the early 1960s, I had the chance to interact with "foreign missions and missionaries." From the perspective of the small child walking the dusty streets of my hometown I still recall the impact that listening to the missionary stories of "Papua New Guinea" or "Swaziland" – unknown places that, I thought, were harder to reach than my land. I always thought that being a missionary was a task of those from the developed world. I had grown up in a country which was referred to as "the mission," a land that was conquered not with a sword but with a gospel … But those were the times of the Christendom.

Missio Dei and the Goals of Mission

The last decade has witnessed unparalleled changes in the ways that Christians engage in what was coined as "the Great Commission." Even though the mission of the church has not changed in its core and purpose, the conditions have evolved to a point that may result in a dramatic slow down of one of the most exciting missionary movements in the history of the church. Those changes are causing us to pause and rethink the extent in which our current missionary endeavours (structure, strategy, support systems, etc.) continue to be relevant for a church that must rediscover its core. Modern missions need to be examined and reviewed for relevance, effectiveness, and biblical coherence. A relevant and effective missionary movement

must be framed by, among other essential elements, a sound theology of mission, or "missiology." Robert Priest Jr., professor of Mission and Anthropology at Trinity Divinity School provides a helpful definition that allows us to engage in framing a missiology for our generation and our context:

Missiology is an interdisciplinary discipline which, through research, writing, and teaching, furthers the acquisition, development, and transmission of theologically-informed, contextually-grounded, and ministry-oriented knowledge and understanding, with the goal of helping and correcting Christians, and Christian institutions, involved in the doing of Christian mission.[1]

This requires an understanding of both the core and the periphery of mission. God's mission, or *Missio Deo*, is the core. It does not change: the mission has always been to announce that Christ has fulfilled His task to redeem the world. Methods and actors are secondary. They are designed to change.

The primary purpose of this paper is, while affirming the unchanging nature of the mission itself, to briefly examine the current trends that shape the way in which the church does mission and then propose a new missiology that would include children and youth as agents of mission as God intended.

1. The Unchanging Mission of the Church

It was a difficult place. Ethnic cleansing had resulted in a war that had displaced thousands of families from their homeland. They did not have a home, a place to work or educate their children or a sense of community. They were refugees in an inhospitable land. Yet, in the midst of their difficulties, they were searching. They needed a source of hope. Then, a young couple of volunteers came to their village. The couple did not have the best cross-cultural training. They did not fit the profile…but they loved the people. This young couple with their children decided to spend time with the youth in the village. They

[1] From http://www.missiologymatters.com/2012/03/07/what-in-the-world-is-missiology (accessed 9 July 2013).

started learning together about the love of Christ, a love that moves us to love others… After several years working with the people of the village, something especial has happened: more than fifty young people have encountered hope in Christ. They are sharing the hope with others and the movement has started…

This story happened in Kosovo, but it may as well be anywhere in the world. The heart of the story is that someone decided to "go and make disciples." This is the unchanging nature of the mission of the church.

2. Missionary *Dimension* and Missionary *Intention*

One of the important elements in missionary theology is the distinction between missionary *dimension* and missionary *intention* (or concentration).[2] The missionary *dimension* refers to the intrinsic nature of the church. "Since the whole life of the Church is the visible means through which the Holy Spirit carries on his mission to the world, the whole of the church's life, thus, partakes of the character of witness."[3] A church without a mission is not a church. A church without a mission is a body without purpose.

The missionary *intention*, on the other hand, refers to the specific activities that the church carries to reach out to the world of those who do not yet know or follow Jesus Christ. It is this second component that justifies the existence of specific missionary interventions and helps us strengthen the argument for "institutionalized missions and missionaries."

The missionary dimension of the church has always had the same purpose. Through history, many theologians have tried to articulate different goals of mission: the salvation of individuals; church growth; church planting; the formation of a Christian society; justice and change of social macrostructures, etc. Independent of the different

[2] L. Newbigin, *One Body, One Gospel, One World: The Christian Mission Today* (New York: International Missionary Council, 1958). See also M. Goheen, "As the Father Has Sent Me, I am Sending You" in *J.E. Lesslie Newbigin's Missionary Ecclesiology* (Uttrecht: Uitgeverij Boekencentrum, 2000).

[3] Goheen, *op cit*, 276.

perspectives that missionary theologians suggest regarding the goals of mission, there are two common elements that these scholars highlight as they study the missionary dimension: a) the glory of God, and b) conversion of the unbelievers.

- The glory of God. As the church engages in missions, her ultimate purpose is that God will be glorified. The way in which the church makes God known is by glorifying Him not by establishing an institutional presence in a given setting. The collective mission of the church is accomplished when the transformational presence of God reaches individuals and communities for the glory of God through the knowledge of Jesus Christ. "The ultimate goal of mission is that Jesus shall see the fruit of his suffering and be satisfied".[4]
- A genuine relationship with God through Jesus Christ. The second goal of mission is the calling of men, women and children to follow Jesus Christ, and to be part of His community. Conversion means more than sharing the news of salvation. It means a transformational process in which people and communities become followers of Christ in word and deed.

The Next Christendom

The present decade is a decade of convergences. Several factors are heading on a collision course in the missionary life of the church. For the first time since the early church there is a separation between the wider society that has economic and political resources and the church that has spiritual dynamism and missionary zeal; for the first time since the 7th century the emergence of Islam is a growing religious force that threatens the West; and for the first time in one hundred years of the Modern Missionary Movement, the purpose, structures, funding, and systems of missions are being revisited in

[4] *Ibid*., 277.

depth across the Christian church. The confluence of these three junctures makes the review critical.

In his study of the growth and development of global Christianity, Philip Jenkins introduced the concept of "the next Christendom".[5] He believes that we are on the verge of a transformational religious shift. As he explains it, Christianity, "the religion of the West", is rapidly expanding south into Africa, Asia, and Latin America, where most of the growth of Christianity is being recorded. Jenkins also predicts that by the year 2050, only about one-fifth of the world's three billion Christians will be non-Hispanic Caucasian. By numbers alone, they will be able to overwhelm the present political secular nation- and city-states and replace them with theocracies, similar to the Islamic Arab nations. He ends with a warning: with the rise of Islam and Christianity in the heavily populated areas of the Southern Hemisphere, we could see a wave of religious struggles, a new age of Christian crusades and Muslim jihads.[6]

If the trends continue as projected, the missiological map of the world in the next ten years will present a different strategic picture. The areas of growth will be those areas with large populations of children and youth.

The Big Omission: The Absence of Children in the Modern Missionary Movement's Great Commission

One important shift in contemporary mission strategy has been God's revelation to the church to bring children and youth back to the original role that they played in the early church. There is biblical and historical evidence that the early church considered children and youth as essential in her life and mission.

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[5] P. Jenkins, *The Next Christendom: The Coming of Global Christianity* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2002).

[6] *Ibid*.

Even though the gospel records and the subsequent epistles of the New Testament, for example, use only men as means to count for the activity of the early church – which has been grossly misrepresented by modern ecclesiology – such an approach to statistical recording did not reflect the actual mandate of the church towards children (and women). James wrote to the early church to remind them that "religion that God accepts is to look after orphans and widows in distress and to keep oneself from being polluted by the world" (James 1:27). Furthermore, "in the Gospels children are depicted in radical ways: at a time when they occupied a low position in society, Jesus receives, blesses, touches and heals them. Also, He depicts them as models for adults of entering the reign of God, vehicles of divine revelation".[7]

The parenting and developmental models that the early church employed were founded on the community principles of God's people as given to them in the Old Testament. These principles were designed to ensure succession and continuity to God's people in the journey: "Only be careful, and watch yourselves closely so that you do not forget the things your eyes have seen or let them fade from your heart as long as you live. Teach them to your children and to their children after them … teach them to your children, talking about them when you sit at home and when you walk along the road, when you lie down and when you get up" (Deuteronomy 4:9; Deuteronomy 11-19). Christ's teachings expanded the importance of children and included them in their sacraments such as baptism.[8]

However, Bunge[9] and Bakke[10] suggest that the issues related to children and youth in the mission of God have been neglected by modern theology and biblical studies until recently. The later part of the 20th century saw an increased emphasis on ministry to children

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[7] M. Bunge, ed., *The Child in Christian Thought* (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans Publishing Co, 2001).

[8] W. Strange, *Children in the Early Church* (Carlisle: Paternoster Press, 1996).

[9] *Op cit*.

[10] O.M. Bakke, *When Children Became People: The Birth of Childhood in Early Christianity*, trans. Brian McNeal (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress Press, 2005).

not only as subjects of God's mission but also as active actors in His mission. Even though the first stages of the Modern Missionary Movement focused primarily on conversion and church development through self-multiplication, self-support, and self-governance, where children were addenda to the new adult converts, modern missionaries quickly realized that children were more open and receptive to the gospel than the adults themselves. The problem of such finding was that the missionary movement was based on quick results and those were not shown with "children as converts" (still a by-product of the Hellenistic mindset of Christendom). An "instant gratification" movement could not afford to wait for children and youth to develop into responsible Christian adults.

These perspectives were rapidly changed by the 20th century understanding that children are as ready to understand and receive the gospel as any adult would be. D.L. Moody is believed to have said, "It is a masterpiece of the devil to make us believe that children cannot understand religion. Would Christ have made a child the standard of faith if He had known that it was not capable of understanding His words?"[11]

The last quarter of the 20th century saw the emergence of a missionary movement that highlighted the importance of children in the mission of God and the mission of the church from a strategic and holistic perspective. Children have slowly become part of the agenda of the work of the church and there are now hundreds of networks that are actively participating in advocacy, mobilization, and training of the church for mission to and with children and youth globally.

[11] Quoted on http://christian-quotes.ochristian.com/D.L.-Moody-Quotes/page-13.shtml and http://www.brainyquote.com/quotes/authors/d/dwight_l_moody.html among other sites.

Putting the Child Back in *Missio Deo*

Children are an essential part of God's mission in today's world. Not only are children a key missiological people group, children are key actors in implementing the Great Commission. By employing the "Joseph principle" (the Child as an agent of God's provision), mission agencies can educate, disciple and mobilize children so that children can become the agents of social transformation for their families and their communities. The "Samuel principle" (the Child as prophet) calls for mission agencies to intentionally evangelize and involve children as bearers of the good news of salvation.

While armies and political systems have manipulated children and youth to become innocent casualties of the wars which those systems support, ministries understand the value that Spirit-filled children and youth have in leading their communities to justice, righteousness and liberation. Because of their energy, boldness, creativity and ingenuity, children have the capacity to mobilize immeasurable resources for the holistic transformation of their communities. Children and youth are some of the most valuable resources in the community.

Children are the epitome of the kingdom incarnated by the Messiah. Christ came as a child and grew into the Rabbi of Nazareth so that people of all ages could experience and carry the redeeming mission of our loving Father. Children should be considered as partners in mission. When filled by the Spirit of God, children can and will discuss with "experienced" ministers the matters of the kingdom. They, too, will respond to us, " Why were you looking for me? Didn't you know that I had to be here dealing with the things of my Father?"

A new missiology should consider the biblical, ecclesiological, theological, social, cultural, and political implications of ministry to and with children and youth in today's world. These missiological considerations need to include (but not be limited to):

- Developing a biblical understanding of God's heart for children.

- Integrating the biblical truths to the various theological and ecclesiological environments in the different contexts of the church as they relate to children and youth.
- Developing ministry models that incorporate children as actors and subjects of the mission while using the biblical and theological frameworks developed around the world.
- Advocating for children and youth as integral part of the body of Christ.
- Teaching the broader Christian community about the role of children and youth in the mission of the church.
- Developing missionary strategies that allocate resources (financial, human, strategic) proportionally to the size of the mission (4/14 window) and the evidence of mission results (80/20 ratio).

The new missionary enterprise must understand that all of those who are engaged in the Great Commission are missionaries indeed. In doing so, mission agencies need to avoid the mistaken arbitrary distinctions developed over time (geography, ethnicity, age, language, etc.) If at all, distinctions may be done in the basis of roles and functions and not on the basis of nationality or language. The child/adult, or young/adult dichotomies must be eliminated and the Church must focus on the fact that we are all God's children and that we are all agents and subjects of God's mission. Paul emphasized this to young Timothy when he appointed him as bishop of Ephesus: Don't let anyone look down to you because of your age…

Case Study: Mission to Bangladesh – A Brief Example of the New Mission Strategy

Influenced by a renewed emphasis on holism, indigenization and strategic impact, the Church of the Nazarene established its missionary work in Bangladesh in 1994. From the beginning, the work of the church was designed to focus on four main intentional areas of mission strategy: 1) Indigenous leadership with global

missionary support; 2) Intentional ministry to children and youth at the heart of the mission; 3) Holistic mission that emphasized preaching, teaching, and healing; and 4) Intentional focus on the poorest and most vulnerable people in the country.

Under the leadership of two capable national leaders, the Church of the Nazarene established two child and community development centres in 1994 (one in the capital and one in the south of the country). Twenty years later, the Church of the Nazarene is the largest church in the nation with more than 3,500 congregations ministering to more than 50,000 adults, 15,000 youth, and 10,000 children in more than 3,000 of the poorest villages of the nation. The Bangladesh model is a practical demonstration of the new theology of mission that is global, indigenous, holistic, and which places the child back in the middle.

Question for Reflection

Gustavo here mentions several global trends that impact current Missiology. What are the implications of these trends for children and youths around the globe? And as we contemplate new models of mission for the 21st Century, inclusive of children and youth, what do these and other trends say to us about our plans and strategies?

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Presentations discussed – "Children as Youth and Partners in Mission"; "A Critical Review of Modern Missions Movement"; "Towards a New Missiology: Renewing our Engagement in God's Mission" (Papers 1, 2 and 3)

The conversations after the opening papers were wide-ranging as participants tried to demonstrate their commitment to the issues at hand. Most of the conversations were relatively well-focused on the subjects that were introduced in the presentations, and the ideas that the speakers shared seemed to resonate well.

Notably, participants strongly endorsed the idea of child-shaped mission, so long as it was consistent with the higher priority of ensuring Christ-shaped mission. Groups agreed that current mission practice is too professionalized and that churches are (often unwittingly) adult-centric. In response, participants suggested that we needed to engage churches with appreciation (not accusation) and help them see the value and strength of encouraging children in mission.

We should help them review the priority churches place on children in terms of their money, time and personal commitment to ensure that the potential of children is more appropriately addressed. This appreciative approach is all the more important since so often this underestimation of the importance of children is often culturally-derived, and therefore must be approached sensitively. This might require the redefinition of mission, church and family in culturally-sensitive and Biblically-informed ways. It would also mean changing the segregate-and-entertain model that so many children's ministry approaches currently employ.

A number of strategies were proposed to address this need. Participants underlined Oxbrow's emphasis on narrative theology as being more child-accessible, though some participants were concerned to maintain a balance with a continued emphasis on propositional theology. It was agreed that training in this area must be an essential component of pastoral training in seminary curricula.

Participants pointed out the need for more research in children's mission engagement to develop more relevant theory than is currently available. We need to know what exists already, and work to enhance that. Likewise, we need to know in what ways children are effective at sharing their faith with other children – and with adults. This may involve better understanding. Participants asked what was appropriate engagement in mission for children at different ages of development, and whether prior experience in doing missional tasks might have an influence on these determinations as well. There is the need for more stories that demonstrate examples of children doing mission, and some participants began to share such stories. This data set of stories could be a "grid for discipleship." We also need to study what kind of approaches need to be discouraged, to ensure that we are avoiding and/or curtailing what is harmful or ethically questionable.

One strategy for encouraging the participation of children in mission might be to identify young leaders who show promise and then intentionally mentoring and equipping them. Any training developed to equip children for mission would need to be designed to make use of existing, common church structures such as Sunday School if they are going to be effective.

Part 2:
The Prompting of the Spirit

INTRODUCTION TO PART 2

How little chance the Holy Ghost has nowadays. The churches and missionary societies have so bound him in red tape that they practically ask Him to sit in a corner while they do the work themselves.[1]

We begin Part 2 with the remarkable devotional reflection by Genevieve James on the founding of the first church in Europe, the continent that was to become the 'home' of the faith for many hundreds of years and from which the great Catholic and Protestant missionary movements were launched into the rest of the world. She offers insights drawn from Paul's missionary experiences in Philippi, especially the central conflict caused by the encounter with a young person: the possessed slave girl. The conflict was driven by several factors (including demonic and economic ones) and James uses them to explore the issues of power, bondage and exploitation -- issues that we may well encounter in our own mission contexts or spheres of influence, especially when they include children and youth as objects and agents of mission.

How do we discern the Spirit's leading in mission today? This is explored in the first of three papers in this section. Richard Howell argues that "the Holy Spirit enables everyone, including children and youth, to be co-equal in the body of Christ and co-workers with God in the world" and that children and youth "are

[1] Attributed to C.T. Studd.

at the centre of missional engagement with rest of the body of Christ." What is needed is radical change as "out-dated concepts (old wine skins) of ministry and mission … must be replaced by an understanding of ministry, based on the enabling of the Holy Spirit, irrespective of age, gender or class (new wine skin)." He argues that "Creating space for children in the church's mission are not only demands on the generosity of the leadership, but also a demand for justice." The paper goes on to explore these ideas in terms of Christian unity and the gifts of the Holy Spirit. There are two responses to this paper, one from an Asian writer exploring an historical Asian perspective, and one from Africa.

The second paper, multi-authored with contributors from Asia, Africa, Russia and Europe, focuses on presuppositions, motives and methods within the "4/14 Window." It starts with a condensed interpretation of the missio Dei, "This chapter presumes three primary considerations: (i) mission flows from the character and purposes of God; (ii) there is no mission apart from the person of Jesus Christ and the work of the Spirit in the church; and (iii) all mission is necessarily contextualized." The chapter explores four motives for mission (relationship with God and others; love; prayer and obedience) and raises the question of mission and ethics. Following a critique of some mission practices, the paper explores Isaiah's vision of the city and seeks to identify ways of applying this ancient vision to modern urban contexts. The paper revisits the concept of a "bottom up" approach (which Howell raises in his chapter), drawing upon the life, death and resurrection of Jesus. It closes with the assertion that "We must take steps to ensure that the values and motives that shape our work reflect the values of God's reign. This may lead us to repentance for the times our egos or confessional bodies have exerted unrighteous influence on our work, or when we have seen the 4/14 generation as a means to an end rather than a worthy and honourable end in and of themselves".

Part 2 closes with Susan Greener's fresh reflections on the story of Samuel. She identifies five principles which are then applied to contemporary mission with and to children. The paper concludes that "The most significant task of each human is discovering one's small, personal story and how it fits into the great narrative of God's mission. … Each child's small story is interwoven into the greater God story in a way that adults may not know or see. … Fully recognizing the dignity and humanity of children who are stamped with God's image requires that a child be more than a member of a missiological target group to bolster conversion statistics or a human resource to be manipulated to achieve adult agendas."

Two Latin American theologians respond, one exploring the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child and further developing the reflections on Samuel. The second raises questions: "Do we have the humility to step aside like Eli, to confess our own mistakes, and to listen to the ways in which God wants to raise this child or these children in the image of his Son?"

Deliverance of a Slave Girl Acts 16:16-38

EDITOR'S INTRODUCTION

Genevieve James' devotion opened the second day of the consultation. She writes from within her own context of South Africa, a country that has seen more than its fair share of economic and structural oppression. As such she brings a perspective on this story – the founding of the first European church – that challenges the often-comfortable assumptions Western Christians bring to the narrative.

She offers insights drawn from Acts 16 where an enslaved girl follows Paul and Silas in the streets of Philippi, prophesying under a demonic power. She is being used by her masters for material gain. Not all prophesy is prompted by the Holy Spirit. In this instance, though what she is saying is true, she is prophesying not out of freedom but out of exploitation. James uses this backdrop and Paul and Silas' subsequent imprisonment and Providential escape, to explore important issues we must consider as we examine the matters of children and youth in mission. James identifies seven implications for our work and leaves us with a few challenging questions for further reflection – and action.

DEVOTIONAL 2

Deliverance of a Slave Girl Acts 16:16-38

BY GENEVIEVE JAMES

The Background

Acts 16:16-38 is a magnificently riveting account of Paul's missionary journeys, the vivid characters, and astonishing and remarkable circumstances he encountered. This text is located in the geographical context of Philippi, regarded as one of the most noteworthy archaeological sites of eastern Macedonia. Philip of Macedon, the father of Alexander the Great, had anticipated the strategic and economic value of the city. After conquering the city he promptly named it after himself.

The story was located in a perilous time in the life of the fledgling Christian movement. Christians were viewed as trouble makers and even dangerous villains. They were considered to dishonour the Roman gods and goddesses. This was an insult, and in some cases, even considered as the breaking of a civic obligation.[1]

The Story

The story begins with Paul's vision where a Macedonian man calls for help. Attributing this call to God, Paul together with Silas begin the eventful journey. At Philippi they encounter Lydia a business women, whose reception to the message of Paul then results in the baptism of

[1] Brian Rapske, *The Book of Acts in its First Century Setting Vol 3: Paul in Roman Custody* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1994). "Roman Emperors Persecute Christians" http://www.nationalgeographic.com/lostgospel/timeline_09.html.

her household. Staying on in Philippi, Paul's mission collides with a slave girl. This dramatic encounter provides the backdrop of the shocking and electrifying events that are to follow:-

[16] Now it happened, as we went to prayer, that a certain slave girl possessed with a spirit of divination met us, who brought her masters much profit by fortune-telling. [17] This girl followed Paul and us, and cried out, saying, "These men are the servants of the Most High God, who proclaim to us the way of salvation." [18] And this she did for many days. But Paul, greatly annoyed, turned and said to the spirit, "I command you in the name of Jesus Christ to come out of her." And he came out that very hour.

1. The Girl (vv: 16-18)

The girl was a slave. She had owners who benefited financially from her "spirit of divination" which enabled her to tell fortunes. According to Luke this was a case of possession by thy spirit of Python. In Greek mythology Python was the serpent which guarded Delphi. The name Python was then used to signify a prophetic demon.[2] Her message "These men are servants of the Most High God, who proclaim to you a way of salvation." was an important truth but served an illicit purpose. The public revelation of Paul and Silas' role and mission would have serious implications in the context of the early Christian movement described earlier. Her witness lacked integrity. What she said, did not link with what she did, and what she thought, this since, she was possessed by the spirit of divination. In the state that she found herself she could not have personally known the salvation she referred to. Her link with the demonic meant that the credibility of her witness was in question and the timing and public nature of her outcry was inconvenient at best, and dangerous, in the worst case scenario.

Paul becomes agitated by the recurring cries of the girl. Allowing the girl's inconsistent witness to continue would amount to endorsing the oppressive spirit within her, the very same spirit that facilitated her captivity. According to Meera Lester,

[2] http://www.sacred-texts.com/bib/cmt/vws/act016.htm.

The text of Acts doesn't mention the slave girl again. Her story is important in the context of the ancients' belief in demonic possession as a way to explain the girl's extraordinary powers. But the power of God working through his holy emissary, Paul, showed a greater power - one that restored the girl to wholeness. Thanks to Paul, she was free of her demonic imprisonment.[3]

2. The Price (vv: 19-24)

Now the story takes on a captivating turn, and the pace begins to pick up. After the glorious moment of the slave girl's deliverance the girl's owners realise that their business asset no longer had the power to generate a lucrative income. They swiftly seized Paul and Silas, bring them before the authorities, and accuse them of upsetting and disturbing the city and promoting unlawful customs as Jews. Crowds joined in the hostility tantamount to a xenophobic attack. Leading the authorities to strip, beat and severely flog the two missionaries. After this they were thrown into inner cells of the prison often reserved for dangerous felons under vigilant watch with their feet secured firmly.

> [25] About midnight Paul and Silas were praying and singing hymns
> to God, and the prisoners were listening to them. [26] Suddenly
> there was an earthquake, so violent that the foundations of the
> prison were shaken; and immediately all the doors were opened
> and everyone's chains were unfastened. [27] When the jailer woke
> up and saw the prison doors wide open, he drew his sword and
> was about to kill himself, since he supposed that the prisoners
> had escaped. [28] But Paul shouted in a loud voice, "Do not harm
> yourself, for we are all here." [29] The jailer called for lights, and
> rushing in, he fell down trembling before Paul and Silas. [30] Then
> he brought them outside and said, "Sirs, what must I do to be
> saved?" [31] They answered, "Believe on the Lord Jesus, and you will
> be saved, you and your household." [32] They spoke the word of the
> Lord to him and to all who were in his house. [33] At the same hour
> of the night he took them and washed their wounds; then he and
> his entire family were baptized without delay. [34] He brought them

[3] http://www.netplaces.com/women-of-the-bible/women-who-prophesied/slave-girl-soothsayer-of-philippi.htm.

up into the house and set food before them; and he and his entire household rejoiced that he had become a believer in God.

3. Jail House Rock (vv: 25-31)

The next part of the story makes for wonderful feel-good sermons with the theme "pray and sing even if you are in trouble and cannot see a way out." I believe that this text is robbed of its richness if taken out of context. We must remember **why** Paul and Silas ended up in prison. Paul and Silas touched the profit margin of the slave girl's owners. We've seen similar resentment to Jesus anger at the temple authorities' economic abuse of the poor and, his driving out of the temple, the money changers and the dove dealers.[4] Paul and Silas too, having touched a financial nerve had to pay the price: public attack and humiliation, brutal flogging enough to cause open wounds and imprisonment like dangerous criminals.

4. Where is the Justice? (vv: 35-38)

After the miraculous liberation from their captivity and the subsequent salvation of the jailor and the baptism of his household the authorities requested that Paul and Silas leave the city. "Go in peace", they were told. Paul would not! Addressing the series of public humiliations and injustice perpetuated against the pair Paul demands justice declaring that his rights as a Roman citizen where not upheld. After the authorities' pleading Paul then left to the house of Lydia.

Some Implications of this Text for Our Work with Children and Youth

There are many aspects of this text that speak to our work *with* and *to* children in our world today. My point of departure for this conclusion is that the slave girl – is either a child or a youth. For that reason I draw the following implications for our work *with* and *to* children:-

[4] See Mathew 21:12-13, Mark 12:40 and Luke 20:47.

1. Mission *with* and *to* children is God's Mission. Like the pivotal vision with the call from Macedonia for help, we too need God's direction to plot the path of our mission journey. It is God's guidance and calling that will establish the church, as it was in the earliest days of the Christian movement. It is God who will direct the sending. God's call and agenda takes precedence over our plans. It is, after all, the *Missio Dei*.
2. The oppression of the slave girl and the economic benefit to her owners remind us of surge in the abuse of children for the evil gain of 21st century drug dealers, labour brokers and sex traffickers. Our work with children in this time in history means that we address evil and violent systems, powers and structures that cause and perpetuate the bondage of children. If we are going to touch the financial nerve that turns children into objects for profit then we can expect to confront the most sinister varieties of injustice. The consequences of our action may mean suffering and persecution.
3. The story of the establishment of the early church was rooted in suffering, obstruction, humiliation, pain and trouble. Is this the story of the church today or is it one of opulence, grandeur and empire and a mere cultural manifestation of our time? While Paul's participation in the deliverance of the slave girl may not have been rooted in a compassion motif. His decision to command the oppressive spirit out of the girl reveals to the reader the girl's value only as a commodity, a beast of burden and an object for the economic gain of her owners. She may never have known her true worth in the eyes of God or her true humanity. As a source of income to her owners she could never have experienced liberty in spirit. If evils against children do not cause you to act out of compassion, act in accordance with God's leading.
4. In the same way that the girl was in bondage we must detect the systems, powers and structures that keep our children in bondage**.** These include economic, legal, political, cultural, social and even religious systems. Today careful scrutiny of

these systems will reveal the massive and unprecedented inhumanities and evils that not only originate in hellish and demonic realms but also human-made systems and hierarchies that oppose life and liberty but foster death and captivity.

5. We are not called for subdued Christian living. We ought to understand justice. Paul refused to go quietly. He understood the rights that should have been afforded to him and claimed those rights. In our work we miss not miss opportunities for justice. We seem to have a preference for mercy, but justice is just as important.
6. Another important dimension of the story is the question of the slave girl's witness. Having been in captivity by the spirit of divination, what she was saying closely resembled truth. Her witness however, lacked integrity since her discourse did not link with her consciousness and her consciousness did not link with her action. Witness integrity is crucial even in the church - we may say the truth but lack credibility as witnesses. In order to determine the true nature of the girl's witness Paul observed the situation before taking action to bring deliverance to the girl.
7. Finally God will ensure that his ultimate purpose is being fulfilled. Paul obeyed the call carried out the mission, Lydia's household was baptised, the girl was liberated from the spirit of divination, the jailor's household baptised and the church was established in Europe.

Reflection

- In your community who is God sending, and where is God sending?
- In what way is the witness to Christ in your community lacking integrity?

- Can you identify different *masters/owners* in your community that gain from oppression exploitation and enslavement of children and young people?
- To what extent does modern-day slavery of children and youth manifest itself in your country?
- In your country what systems and structures work to keep children in bondage?
- What are the possible costs involved in engaging in the fight against injustice against children?
- In your community are you aware of people, organisations/ churches that have stood up against powers and systems that keep children in bondage? Discuss the outcomes?
- Could structural injustice be a form of demonic oppression? How and why?

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Theme 4:

Discerning the Work of The Holy Spirit in Mission Today

Editor's Introduction

Fundamental to Richard Howell's argument is the assumption that "everyone, including children and youth" are "co-equal in the body of Christ and co-workers with God in the world." He supports his assertion with reference to Jesus's teaching and example and by a case study from the Indian context. Howell begins the chapter by identifying the basis for discernment and then uses that framework to explore youth participation with reference to specific themes such as Christian unity and the various gifts of the Holy Spirit. The theme of the equality of Christ's followers runs throughout the chapter – particularly powerful given the evils of the caste system which is such a part of Indian culture – and can be seen in Howell's discussions of the Spirit's gifts, discipleship, power and leadership and what he calls the "bottom up" approach. "The signs of (the Spirit's) work reflect "bottom-up" approach rather than "top-down" approach to leadership and discipleship in the mission of the Church. The community of Christ is to be a place where love reigns without coercion." He finishes with reference to Martin Luther King's famous "I have a dream" speech, noting the significant role of the children and that "the Spirit indwells us, energizes us, and enables us to dream."

Howell brings a welcome knowledge of the Pentecostal and charismatic movements to his exploration.

There are two Responses to Howell's paper. The first one by Gwendolin De Rozario, brings an historical perspective to the role of children in revivals – as well as mentioning a more recent revival in Shillong in India – and asks us to consider what we can learn from these events. In some contrast, Shiferaw W. Michael brings a response from Ethiopia. He highlights the importance of institutions taking structural steps to highlight the importance of children's and young people's participation in the Spirit's work of mission. These two responses hold in tension the sovereign work of the Spirit, like the wind, blowing where He will, and the vital importance of human agency in working with Him.

PAPER 4

Discerning the Work of The Holy Spirit in Mission Today

BY RICHARD HOWELL

Introduction

If you have ever spent time engaged in conversation with children, you can attest to their creative imaginations. Sadly, the sense of awe and wonder twinkling in their eyes is often lost on their journey to adulthood. Children are captivated by the spirit of adventure and willing to embark on risky and perhaps dangerous pursuits. Jesus said to a group of adults long ago and says to us today, "If you want to be great in the Kingdom of heaven, you need to change! Become like children!" This paper presents the reader with a step-by-step attempt at discerning the work of the Holy Spirit in global mission today for the Holy Spirit enables everyone, including children and youth, to be co-equal in the body of Christ and co-workers with God in the world.

Basics of Discernment

"The wind blows wherever it pleases. You hear its sound, but you cannot tell where it comes from or where it is going" (John 3:8). In conversation with Nicodemus, Jesus uses this parabolic saying, to illustrate the real, yet incomprehensible sovereignty of the Spirit who is invisible, mysterious, and only known through His effects. The Spirit's intention is to fill us with joy, thanksgiving, and a song of praise for God as happened with Barnabas in Antioch (cf. Acts 11:22-26). We, like Barnabas, are reliant on the Holy Spirit to discern His on-going work: when we listen and understand within the local context. We need to be open to God's leading and need to safeguard

against traditions turning into oppressive, rigid ideologies. We need to reflect on how to make children disciples and disciple makers, co-equal in the body of Christ and co-workers with God. Our reflection must be based on Scripture and the work of the Spirit in the lives of children and youth. Like the Emmaus disciples, we are on an open-ended journey with Christ, which is full of adventure, anticipation, and a sense of discovery.

A new *kairos* moment has dawned and old ways can no longer be a pattern for our current lives. The challenge before us is to be open to the power and the promise of God's vision of the future. God has granted His church a spirit of wisdom and revelation (cf. Ephesians 1:17-18) so we must engage in a process of envisioning which inspires hope and gives back to the church the capacity for dreaming.

Listening, seeing, understanding, accepting, loving, rejoicing, and obeying are all aspects of discerning the work of the Holy Spirit in global mission. The nature and activity of the Spirit embrace the church and the world, and therefore we understand the Triune God's actions in the mission of the church and in historical events. We can trust the creative and providential power of the Father to direct all things towards the glory of the Son through the enabling of the Holy Spirit in the church and in lives of believers. The Holy Spirit is active in the church helping it to fulfil its purpose of being a blessing to the nations; not living for itself but for the sake of humankind (Genesis 12:1-3; 15; 17; Isaiah 42:6; Matthew 22:32-40.)

A Case Study

Discerning the work of the Holy Spirit demands that we look for signs in the world – the arena of the activity of the Spirit. Certain events from January, 2003 are forever etched in my mind: they occurred primarily in capital cities of various states of India. The key players were hand-picked Christian leaders – young and old, male and female – from mainline, Evangelical and Pentecostal churches and other inter-church agencies. Excitement characterized the crowd, as we all listened to the amazing accounts of how the movement of the Spirit

resulted in transformation of people, churches, cultures, societies and creation. An acute awareness of the Holy Spirit's activity in these communities stirred their hearts.

As we reflected on God's grace at work, a question invariably raised was, "What new thing do you see God doing in your context today?" Initially there was pin-drop silence in the room, and then we heard a lady from the Presbyterian Church begin to narrate her story. She spoke passionately about the Youth Group's incarnational involvement in a nearby village.

The Holy Spirit in these young people's lives vitalized them and filled them with power to live for God. Empowered and guided by the Holy Spirit, they boldly shared the transforming gospel of Jesus Christ. They immersed themselves in the lives of the villagers as they listened to their stories. It was evident that the people had been waiting for someone to come to their aid. The young people were challenged by the poverty of the place, the infertile land, and disease that was slowly killing their animals, the main source of their livelihood. Undeterred by the despair of the people, the barrenness of the situation, and their own inability to help financially, they called upon their heavenly Father to reassert Himself. Praying with confidence, they claimed that God in His love knew their need and those of the entire world even before they uttered a word. They kept going to the village, week after week, and kept sharing the story of villagers with others, while seeking God's face. During prayer they were filled with peace knowing that their Creator was listening.

God answered their prayers. When the land was ploughed, manure added and seeds sown, the land yielded fruit and animals stopped dying! Having been convicted of their sin by the Holy Spirit and been led to Christ, people responded to the gospel with repentance. Soon a group of people started worshipping the living and true God revealed in Jesus Christ.

The Youth Group developed a follow-up plan: one of them was selected to visit this village regularly. They raised money and sacrificially shared from their meagre monthly pocket money. The young people acted in faith and villagers were delivered from bondages of poverty, oppression, and sin. They grew under the

guidance of their mentors, and the lady saw the young people "increase in wisdom and in stature and in favour with God and man" (Luke 2:52).

This story illustrates that the Spirit is transforming every dimension of created life according to Christ's nature and using young and old as co-workers. Too often the young have been devalued in churches and academic writings. This and innumerable other stories from all over the world, reveal the moments of transformation and the structures of God and His Kingdom.

As we begin to discern the work of the Holy Spirit, we realize that children and youth are at the centre of missional engagement with rest of the body of Christ. We need to stop forcing them out of the centre and into the periphery. The outpouring of the Holy Spirit on the Day of Pentecost occurred without discrimination on the basis of age, gender or social standing (Acts 2:16-18).

Formation of the Community of Christ

Along with creation and incarnation, the coming of the Holy Spirit on the day of Pentecost is a definitive act of God. God's sheer generosity and gratuitous love are visibly demonstrated when Joel's prophecy is fulfilled and the Holy Spirit poured out on all flesh; sons and daughters, young men and old men, servants male and female, ushering in a new age of the Spirit. Suddenly, people were exposed to an amazingly new way of living (cf. Acts 2:1-18).

The outpouring of the Spirit enables the formation of the community of Christ with the Holy Spirit indwelling all believers in Christ, just as He promised. This demonstrates the continuity between the Father's mission, Jesus' mission and the on-going mission of the Holy Spirit in the life and witness of the Church (cf. John 20:21-22). The indwelling Holy Spirit posits a new relationship between God and humanity which is intensely alive and creatively dynamic. Jesus compares the oneness of this indwelling to the oneness of His church. He prays to the Father saying, "That they may all be one, just as you, Father, are in me, and I in you, that they also

may be in us, so that the world may believe that you have sent me" (John 17:21). Due to the church's participation in the divine life, the church is first, an ontological reality (what church is) before an instrumental reality (what the church does). The formation of the community of Christ is an expression at the human level of the Triune God's perichoretic life. This shared life of the Spirit is the best determinant of our sense of belonging, enabling us to live by God's grace with one another and with God.

In our understanding of mission it is important that we recognize God as the source of all ministry and mission. Therefore, out-dated concepts (old wine skins) of ministry and mission, which ascribe responsibility for various dimensions of church life to only a few, must be replaced by an understanding of ministry, based on the enabling of the Holy Spirit, irrespective of age, gender or class (new wine skin),. Each member in the body of Christ is a co-equal partner in God's ministry and mission, including children and youth. This co-equality is implicit in the life of the Trinity.

Let us pause to consider if we communicate this truth of co-equality in the religious usage of language? We need to acknowledge that our lens to understand the location and struggles of children and youth are coloured. This happens because of the physical and psychological space in which children are located where their marginalization is often accepted as a matter of fact. However, the indwelling Spirit invites us to listen and discern that children and youth are not only "in the world", silenced to the margins. We are also called to see their identity "in Christ," where they can participate in the life of God. The Spirit restores their identity as co-equal in the body of Christ, co-workers with God and locates them at the centre of God's mission in the world.

When theology is understood from the perspective of its instrumentality, God's mission is cast in terms of its usefulness. This understanding privileges purpose over existence and instrumentality over ontology. Thus children are often sent to the margins due to their perceived performance value. In reality, our performance must issue from our worship. All proclamation of the gospel in word and deed is a call to worship the living and true God revealed in Jesus

Christ (1 Thessalonians 1:9). Pentecost speaks of spontaneity in worshiping together as believers. Spontaneity in worship (1 Corinthians 14:26) is easily embraced and practiced by young, and this has changed how the Triune God is worshipped in many congregations.

1. Community of Equals

Knowing that the community of Christ in its intended form is marked by equality has implications for church leadership. When we think of leadership, we often think of power and when power is conceptualized as "power over" we are implying that relationships characterized by domination and subjugation are desirable. Hierarchy as a system of power is rooted in such thought. In contrast, the church ought to shape its understanding of power guided by the Trinitarian language of interdependence and not domination. Churches should be a place where differences and similarities are celebrated instead of being a place where power is solely vested.

The cross of Jesus reflects God's power at work. According to Barth "power in itself is not merely neutral. Power itself is evil".[1] Therefore, as we study the biblical narrative, we see God's unlimited power is in relation to the doctrine of incarnation and in the self-giving nature of God. We hear Jesus in the Scripture, asking us to denounce self-referential, repressive, imposing, and one-sided power. He asks us to exercise power in collaborative, creative, relational and constructive ways. Jesus also offers a set of warnings (seven woes!) for people who enjoy systemic advantages at the expense of the disadvantaged (Matthew 23:13-39). Creating space for children in the church's mission are not only demands on the generosity of the leadership, but also a demand for justice. Jesus' understanding of power in the kingdom of God is in stark contrast with popular culture and popular practice!

[1] Karl Barth, *Church Dogmatics*, translation eds. G.W. Bromiley and T. F. Torrance (Edinburgh: T&T. Clark, 1957-1975), 2/1: 524.

2. Experiencing the Kingdom as a Little Child

In the Gospel of Mark (9:33-37) we witness Jesus placing a little child in the disciples' midst, saying: "Whoever welcomes one such child in my name welcomes me, and whoever welcomes me does welcome me but the one who sent me." The child noticeably trusted Jesus and was completely dependent upon Jesus. By doing as Jesus asked, the child was modeling the behaviour Jesus expected from His disciples (Mark 9:37).

Traditionally, the accent fell on "the receptiveness of a child" as the key for understanding the analogy between the phrases "as a little child" and "receiving the kingdom of God." However, current scholarly consensus, according to James Bailey,[2] is that Mark 9:33-37 and Mark 10:13-16 must be read with reference to each other and understood in light of their historical frame of reference. In this setting, Jesus was introducing the child as among "the least ones" in the society, who needed to actively to be sought, received, and embraced.[3] When we respect the excluded, we show respect to God; for welcoming a child is akin to welcoming God (Mark 9:37). Pleased by the child's behaviour, Jesus was telling His disciples that "You need to change! You need to become like this child!"

Luke 22:24-27 introduces us to Jesus' conversations about greatness during his last Passover meal. The meal is an anticipation of the eschatological banquet of the kingdom of God which gives Jesus' comments an eschatological perspective. Jesus insists that – in contrast to Gentile leaders who use power and authority to abuse or exclude – among His followers, the greatest become like the youngest, and the leader like the one who serves. Jesus identifies himself with the excluded groups when He said that "I am among you as one who serves" (v 27). In this context, Jesus called attention to two of the most excluded people on the margins in that social context; the child (the youngest) and the slaves. During the conversation, Jesus said: "I

[2] James Bailey, "Experiencing the Kingdom as a Little Child: A Rereading of Mark 10: 13-16," in *Word and World,* Vol. 15, No. 1 (1995): 58-67.

[3] Chad Myers, "The Ideology and Social Strategy of Mark's Community" in *Binding the Strong Man* (New York, Orbis: 1988), 413-448.

confer on you, just as my Father has conferred on me, a kingdom, so that you may eat and drink at my table" (Luke 22:29-30). In contrast to the dominant status quo, where authority is located among those *already* at the table He conferred on the excluded groups a kingdom, with dignity and respect: now they "may eat and drink at my table" (v.30). The Triune God, who created all humanity with dignity and respect, redeems His creation in the person of Jesus Christ: the One who ushers in the reign of God, and invites all to the table without discriminating. On the day of Pentecost these excluded groups of children and slaves – and women – were equal partakers of the power of the Holy Spirit.

Our refusal to see children and youth as co-equal in the body of Christ and as co-equal missional agents of the mission of God is negated and reconstituted by the Holy Spirit; our ego defences are transformed when the self is centred in Christ.

3. Rethinking-Top-Down Approach

Therefore the community of Christ is to call out one another in love, including children and youth, to be what God intends. We find our example of how to act through looking at the Holy Spirit. The signs of His work reflect "bottom-up" approach rather than "top-down" approach to leadership and discipleship in the mission of the Church. The community of Christ is to be a place where love reigns without coercion. Nevertheless, in reality, love reigns to the extent each individual opens their heart to others. The Spirit is always at work in the church facilitating this Trinitarian way of life, orchestrating His manifold gifts and graces in the symphony of hope. Ultimately we are all members of a church on the way toward the full realization of God's life. We must so live to reflect that the community of Christ contains disciples who are equals.

Particularity of Lives And Contexts

God is concerned about our particularity, about every little detail that makes us unique, to the same extent He is concerned about our

oneness. When discerning the Spirit's work, we look within the particularity of specific contexts in which people live, listen, and respond to the gospel. It is essential for us to contextualize our message but once we do our part, it is the work of the Spirit to give it practical application in the unique lives of particular people.

Within the West, the sacred and the secular are often clearly demarcated. However, this is not the case worldwide: some countries continue to rightly acknowledge that all aspects of our life are sacred. For example travelling through Ghana, in Africa one can observe many shops and advertisements stand-out such as 'Jesus is Lord Business Centre and Internet Café.' 'Give Thanks to God Tailoring Shop. 'Riches of Glory Guest House' and the 'Jesus is Lord Fabric Shop.' It is the same throughout much of sub-Saharan Africa, which is now 70% Christian.' The lines between the secular and sacred, and the material and spiritual, are drawn very differently in Asia and Africa than in Western culture; which influenced by enlightenment philosophy/ theology divides the empirical and the spiritual world.

The experience of God's Spirit is specific. Paul explains this in reference to calling when he writes: "Only let each person lead the life that the Lord has assigned to him, and to which God has called him" (1 Corinthians 7:17). God embraces us in our particularity and utilizes all aspects of our life in the service of His Kingdom for the sake of transforming the world. At this point we must consider how is unity in diversity, and diversity in unity actually executed in the community of believers, particularly in relation to children and youth?

Paul differentiates between the gifts and the fruit of the Spirit. He says that the fruit of the Spirit designates the general character and lifestyle of Christian existence as empowered by the Holy Spirit. The gifts of the Spirit are related to specific tasks or functions to which God calls and equips each Christian. The ultimate purpose of the gift of an evangelist (see Ephesians 4:11) is to relate the gospel to non-Christians. It is time that we acknowledge that these gifts do not come with an age limit; age is no bar. The particularity of the gifting of children and youth must be recognized and space must be given to them for effective exercise of their gifts. The gifts given by the Holy

Spirit are not for self-affirmation but for the building up of the community (1 Corinthians 14:26). The gifts find expression in the source of the gifts: the same Spirit ... the same Lord ... the same God (l2:4).

The traditional understanding of mission as vocation is changing and emphasis is on the concept of *charisma,* giftedness, as the corner stone of missiological praxis. Instead of emphasizing that a person has been "called" to do certain work irrespective of their inclinations, prominence is given to engaging in work for which we have been gifted by the Holy Spirit.

Unity of the Spirit

At Pentecost we discern that the Holy Spirit empowers language to be what it is created to be: a tool to facilitate communion between man and God, for interpersonal communication and fellowship, and communication of truth. On this day a substitute to the imposing unity of Babel is created without returning to a pre-Babel state. Before *Babel* humanity spoke *one* language; in Jerusalem the new community speaks *many* languages (vv. 3-7). According to the Pentecostal account, when the Spirit comes, everybody understands each other, not because one language is restored or a new all encompassing language is designed, but because everyone hears their own language spoken. "The Holy Spirit overcomes the "confusion" and the resulting false "scattering" of Babel. However, this is not done by reverting to the unity of cultural uniformity, but by advancing toward the harmony of cultural diversity. The miracle of overcoming broken communication is the fulfilment of a prophecy by Joel".[4]

The National United Christian Forum of India (NUCF) comprising of the Catholic, ecumenical and evangelical churches in 2011 brought together young people in Delhi. Each participant narrated testimonies of their encounter with Jesus Christ. One young

[4] Miroslav Volf, *Exclusion and Embrace* (Nashville TX: Abingdon Press, 1996), 228.

lady shared her encounter with Christ and her call to ministry. She had to give up a well paying job in a mass communication firm and step out from her comfort zone. She began witnessing to others about Jesus Christ. Listening to her, the heart of each participant "was strangely warmed." Her sharing was akin to what one may expect to hear from a young, enthusiastic Pentecostal, except in this case it was a Roman Catholic sharing her journey with Christ, empowered by the Holy Spirit. The gift of speaking in tongues is not limited to Pentecostal and Charismatic denominations alone.

Young people are building bridges by listening, understanding and loving in the process of sharing their faith journey with the Triune God. The fluidity in crossing the boundaries of denominationalism is the work of the Holy Spirit, who unites all believers into the body of Christ, (1 Corinthians 12:13).

How would you describe a person who believes in the Lutheran doctrine of grace, has taken baptism of immersion in a Baptist Church and speaks in unknown tongues? Does such a person have multiple identities? The Holy Spirit is causing cleavages in our rigid theological systems so that fresh winds of the Spirit extend existing boundaries.

The Word Made Flesh – Today

God revealed on the day of Pentecost that all languages are worthy of divine communication (vv. 6-7). Andrew Walls underlines the importance of translatability of the gospel: "When God in Christ became man, Divinity was translated into humanity, as though humanity were a receptor language".[5] The engagement of Christian faith with languages and cultures of the world has the transcendent God at the centre of the universe of cultures, "implying equality among cultures and the necessarily relative status of cultures vis-a-vis the truth of God. No culture is so advanced and so superior that it can

[5] Andrew F. Walls, *The Missionary Movement in Christian History: Studies in the Transmission of Faith* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis, 1996), 27.

claim exclusive access or advantage to the truth of God, and none so marginal and remote that it can be excluded. All have merit; none is indispensable".[6]

However, in an age of speed and complexity of change, there are multiple and competing realities, many of which are mediated by digital means. The Holy Spirit is raising up young people who have experienced the gospel story, understand the times and can communicate in a variety of digital media available. It takes humility for adults to acknowledge that the youth may be better equipped, in some areas, to communicate with other young people and adults. Humility is also required to learn from the young people in the community of Christ. It is time we take notice of the assets God has given us within the church instead of sticking to harmful, traditional practices. What would the Church look like if we imagined that the youth coming to church were looking for a community that would help them meet their deepest needs, construct meaningful identities and experience the living God?

Healings and Miracles

Globally, divine healing and exorcisms are major factors for the growth of the church. From time immemorial, competing appraisals of the significance of healings and miracles have existed. Responding to the accusations from Pharisees, Jesus said: "But if I drive out demons by the Spirit of God, then the kingdom of God has come upon you" (Matthew 12:27). Similar to deeds done in the power of the Spirit, healings are not mere symbols of God's future rule, but anticipatory realizations of God's present rule. They provide tangible testimony to the materiality of salvation.[7] We can also view them as eschatological work of God in history, to bring integrity to the whole

[6] Lamin Sanneh, *Disciples of all Nations* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2008), 25.

[7] Miroslav Volf, *Work in the Spirit* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1991), 104.

human being, including the body, and to the entire injured and groaning reality. Candy Gunther Brown[8] and others write that that divine healing encompasses physical, mental, and social diseases. Thus persons and communities experience healing from physical diseases like cancer, but also experience deliverance and healing from diseases of poverty, unemployment, and racism.

Deliverance from Racism and Casteism

Casteism has exploited and divided humans for thousands of years into the categories of pure and polluted. Race-based narratives of social structures seem to suggest that consequent racial differences produce inherent superiority of a particular race. A glance at the economy reveals a ruthless market economy where accumulation of wealth as power is celebrated, even if competitors are crushed and a trail of causalities follows.

Casteism, racism, and economic classism, are influenced by systems and ideologies which play an overpowering role in shaping and structuring, allowing and disallowing, certain relationships. God's fallen world testifies to a history marked by a gory tale of pursuit and misuse of power and control which dominates and decimates humans. Children suffer in the power games that people play – they are silenced and sent to the margins. Today, the case of over two billion children is more concerning because of the violence perpetuated against them. Once I was witnessing to a poor Dalit that, "You have equal worth and dignity as a high caste person." The response was shocking: "Please do not cause me more pain, leave me in my condition as I am."

People who are beaten-down, stuck in deprivation, and on the margins on account of age, gender, race, caste, or class, often have internalized a false, negative sense of self, including a sense of powerlessness. Sin in this world owes much to powerlessness, pride

[8] Candy Gunther Brown, ed., *Global Pentecostal and Charismatic Healing* (Oxford University Press, 2011).

and lust for power, especially given that inequalities are institutionalized and imposed. The other side of pride, explains Moltmann, is hopelessness, resignation, weariness, and timidity, all of which result in falling away from the living hope that God promises. The sin that most profoundly threatens us is not the evil we perpetrate with power, but rather the good that we do not do with the power we have.[9]

Shaull found a form of Christianity in the Pentecostal movement in Latin America which engaged the primal struggles between order and chaos. He described such Christianity as flourishing at "ground zero" of this struggle. This new paradigm of Christianity he described as a "reconstruction of life in the power of the Spirit. This power to reconstruct life is profoundly manifest in those places where the most basic forms of life in the community – the family, local neighbourhood, social, economic and political structures are becoming unglued, leaving masses of poor people in both rural and peripheral urban areas without stable work, medical care, or opportunities for education".[10]

The Holy Spirit renews our mind and imparts to us the capacity to clearly discern the destructive powers of the dominant culture, and to claim the freedom to act apart from or against those unjust structures. All our mission initiatives for transformation have intrinsic value and significance as they relate to the eschatological new creation.

Speaking in Tongues, Prophecy and Vision

Peter said, "Your young men will see visions" (Acts 2:17). The only limit to our imagination is our vision. The revelations which God gives us through tongues and prophecy permeate our thoughts,

[9] Moltmann, Jurgen, *Theology of Hope*, trans. James W. Leitch (New York: Harper and Row, 1967), 22-23.

[10] Richard Shaull and Waldo Ceaser, *Pentecostalism and the Future of the Christian Churches* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2000), 116.

desires, interests, ideals, imagination, feelings, and body language. Our vision gives rise to our character, our style of life, and our tone of being in the world. Vision is the way we grasp the complexity of life; it involves the meaning and value that we attach to the complexity of life as a whole and to the things of life in particular.

In 1 Corinthians Paul speaks of tongues as "edifying oneself" and says that "my spirit prays, but my mind is unfruitful" (1 Corinthians 14:14). Paul also writes in 14:13: "One who speaks in a tongue should pray for the power to interpret." The gift of tongues provides experiences of praise, joy, longing, or yearning for God. It can also be used for encouragement when words to build the church are included. God has endowed children and youth with the gift of speaking in tongues, interpretation and the gift of prophecy, for the work of mission and for building the Church.

Prophecy denotes a creative or charismatic interpretation of Scripture. The Pentecostal tradition views the Scripture as the living word of the Spirit for the present time. Thus, there is a fusion between Spirit and Word. The Bible presents Christ as "now present in the world and in their lives, manifesting the same divine power, and doing what he did in Galilee. "The ancient tradition of hearing the Word is very much a living tradition in contemporary churches of the global south," observes Jenkins, "giving quite different quality to the reception and the impact of the text".[11]

The Transformational Movements

With the contemporary growth of churches in the Majority World, we have entered a new phase in the growth of the global church. Indigenous cultures have discovered Christianity and Jesus Christ. Communities have embraced Christianity, creating implications for a fresh understanding of the gospel. The fact that people are responding in the midst of militant resurgence of anti-Christian forces suggests a

[11] Philip Jenkins, *The New Faces of Christianity: Believing the Bible in the Global South* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2006), 26.

degree of indigenous compatibility with the gospel. The emphasis now is on local churches that do not import and imitate the lifestyle, law, liturgy, and theology of European churches. It has become essential for churches to be culturally rooted in their particular contexts. It is indeed a new *kairos* moment for the church.

The growth of the Pentecostal and Charismatic congregation is a global phenomenon, such that its adherents are estimated to include about 580 million Christians, or one of four Christians in the world constituting one of the most dramatic stories of modern Christian history. This number equals or exceeds the total membership of all the churches belonging to the World Council of Churches. If the present growth continues, by the middle of the 21st century the world will be home to one billion Pentecostal Christians. And many of these are children and young people.

As we examine the global movement of the Holy Spirit, the effects of the His work cause us to rejoice. It leads us to see the Triune God, to invite children and youth to His table as co-equal with others, and enable them to become co-workers with Him, as disciples and disciple makers.

On August 18, 1963, standing in front of the Lincoln Memorial, Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr. captured people's imaginations then – and now – through the repetition of four carefully chosen words, "I have a dream." He beckons his listeners to enter that dream. He invites all to participate with him in that imaginary world by calling us to "Let freedom ring!" Dr. King said his dream was that…"one day little black boys and black girls will be able to join hands with little white boys and white girls as sisters and brothers".[12]

Notice the role that children played in his dream. Like Jesus, Dr. King set them in the midst – his own four children, and an unnamed and unnumbered group of little black boys and black girls and little white boys and white girls holding hands and recognizing one another as brothers and sisters. On the day of Pentecost, the Holy

[12] Martin Luther King, Jr., *I Have a Dream* (New York: Scholastic, 1986), 219.

Spirit brought young and old, both male and female slaves and "all flesh" together as co-equal in the body of Christ and co-workers in the Triune God's world. The Spirit indwells us, energizes us, and enables us to dream. The historical evidence of the actions of God in the lives of children and youth all over the world is overwhelming. The call of the Holy Spirit is as fresh today as it was then, beckoning us to new levels of commitment to a life of sacrificial self-giving love. What a day it will be when the Kingdom of God comes on earth and the fullness of the dream is realized. Without prophetic imaginations, such dreams don't exist. Let us begin to imagine the energy and momentum for mission in our churches, when children and youth are globally engaged as disciple and disciple makers, by the enabling of the Spirit, supported by the community of Christ.

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RESPONSE 1

Discerning the Work of the Holy Spirit in Global Mission Today

BY GWENDOLIN DE ROZARIO

Children in Revivals

There is enough in history to show that the Lord would just as readily pour His Spirit out on the children and young people as He would on the adults. And by His grace, touch them and or use them mightily to pray His will upon the earth and release His blessings. This section reviews some of these records to establish that when God said "And afterward, I will pour out my Spirit on *all* people…." (Joel 2:28 NIV) or "all flesh" (ESV), He meant exactly that – age is no barrier.

One historical record shows that the unmistakable move of the Holy Spirit was "a mass movement with a nation of eyewitnesses."[1] Beginning around 1707, the children of Silesia, were moved by the Holy Spirit to start gathering to together, in worship and prayer, across several towns, villages and even cities.

> The children, male and female, 4 to 14 years in age, with an unusual devotion for their age, assemble themselves in a certain place daily to pray together with childlike devotion … These poor, hard-pressed children, out of their own desire and without their being given some prescribed method, began to assemble to pray. Begun truly without any direction from a single adult, not only were they not given help but were even having to act against the commands of the civil and religious authorities as well as their parents … They hold orderly prayer meetings, singing, reading the Bible, they fall on their knees, and at some places it is reported

[1] Eric Jonas Swensson, *Kinderbeten – The Origin, Unfolding, and Interpretations of the Silesian Children's Prayer Revival.*

> they fall on their faces praying and repenting. It had begun sparsely but in many places it grew to 3,000-4000 people. Ordinarily they sing seven songs, and a prayer comes between each one; they have a psalm of repentance, and they read a chapter from the Bible; in the end the children lift hands together upwards and sing another hymn The bystanders could not regard it without being moved to tears hearing the prayers. They have among their prayers also one which is to ask the dear God for peace in the land and to give their churches back to them. No one knows how the children would have gotten such a longing without the parents' knowledge.[2]

This move of the Holy Spirit sparked off a "regional renewal movement"[3] in the area of Teschen, south of Poland. "Great crowds inside and outside the church passed the time in prayers, confessions, and ardent hymn singing. Revival soon spread to the surrounding towns and villages. Teschen was to central Europe in the 18th century what Edwards' Northampton was to America."[4]

> "The story does not end there. Some Protestants in the neighbouring region of Moravia were inspired by the revival at Teschen. They grew weary of religious and economic persecution and fled to east Saxony in German territory. There they found safe harbour on the estate of the pious nobleman Count Nicolaus von Zinzendorf, who established a village for them on his property. They christened it Herrnhut, "the Lord's Watch," since they were determined to watch for the Lord even as they understood themselves to be under his watch and care. A fresh revival broke out among these refugees in 1727 (beginning again with the children), and Zinzendorf moulded this movement into the Renewed Moravian Brethren. At a meeting of some of these

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[2] From "Fernere Nachricht," an anonymous report of 1708. Quoted by Eric Jonas Swensson in http://pietist.blogspot.com/2009/09/tale-of-hope-and-prayer.html. Note: Records of this move of the Holy Spirit on the children can be found in *Praise out of the Mouth of Babe, or A Particular Account of Some Extraordinary Pious Motions and Devout Exercises, Observ'd of Late in Many Children in Silesia* (London: 1708).

[3] Swensson, 2009.

[4] *Ibid*.

> same Moravian Brethren in Aldersgate Street, London, in 1738, the future founder of Methodism John Wesley felt his heart "strangely warmed." [5]

John Wesley himself recorded how the Holy Spirit would move the children in intercession.

> Hearing in the evening that they were got to prayer by themselves in the school, I went down…Two or three had gone in first; then more and more, till above thirty were gathered together. Such a sight I never saw before nor since...
>
> The rest were all on their knees, pouring out their souls before God, in a manner not easy to be described. Sometimes one, sometimes more, prayed aloud; sometimes a cry went up from them all; … I suppose such a visitation of children has not been known in England these hundred years. In so marvelous a manner, "out of the mouth of babes and sucklings" God has "perfected praise!"[6]

Not only were the children drawn to prayer by the Holy Spirit but also to repentance and conversion. "Is not this a new thing in the earth? God begins his work in children. Thus it has been in Cornwall, Manchester and Epworth. Thus the flame spread to those of riper years."[7]

Records showed that the Holy Spirit continued to move *upon* and *through* the children, whether as a groups or individuals. He does so in various ways and in different intensity. Closer to today, we continue to read about reports of such a move of the Holy Spirit. One example is Shillong, in the north east state of Meghalaya in India. "Lyngdoh a priest of the All Saint Church himself said that he does not understand why is the anointing mostly in the children and not in elder people or church leaders perhaps God has a special purpose for

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[5] *Ibid*.

[6] John Wesley, *The Works of the Reverend John Wesley*, A.M., Vol. 7 (New York: J. Emory and B. Wadoh, 1831), 394.

[7] Abel Stevens, *The History of the Religious Movement of the Eighteenth Century Called Methodism Part T*wo, (Kessinger Publishing, 2004), 154.

all this." [8] Indeed as Dr Richard Howell highlighted in his paper, "the wind blows wherever it pleases…."John 3:8.

What We Can Learn from these 'Revival' Reports?

1. Children are just as capable of responding to the Holy Spirit's leading and revelations

These 'moves' of the Spirit on children are often spontaneous with little adult supervision. The children are reported to have a very real awareness of sin. Worship, prayer and intercession are a core part of their response to the move of the Spirit. In terms of longer term effects of these experiences, there are usually reports of a change in character and a greater hunger for God and desire to obey Him.

Thus in any of our mission work amongst children we should remember that the Holy Spirit has and will continue to move *on* children. We should be praying for more of such moves. We should also remember that the Spirit will move *through* the children: involving them in our mission work is critical to harness their full potential in God.

2. Adults who lead children might actually be the obstacles

Another lesson is the realisation that as adults who lead children we might actually be the obstacles, preventing our children from being able to respond to the move of the Holy Spirit. We may be too focused on running our programmes or trying to direct the children. We would do better to stay alert and discern the leading of the Holy Spirit ourselves and be willing to step aside as it were when led to. Whether in the mission field or back in 'Sunday School', this is easier said than done. For the 'task oriented' leader, getting through the programme is a must.

[8] http://shillongrevival.wordpress.com/2006/08/

What is the Spirit Saying to the Church Today?

I believe it can be summed up in the word: 'release.' We need to release the children to hear what our Lord is saying to them through the Holy Spirit and play their part in God's mission. We need to release them in true praise and worship. We need to release them to pray and intercede as the Spirit guides them. We need to release them to 'go' as the Lord leads.

Recommended Reading

Baker, H.A. *Visions Beyond the Veil.* Whitaker House, 2006.

Lane, Vann, *Children of Revival, Letting the Little Ones Lead*. Destiny Image Publishers, 1998.

Toledo, Jennifer. *Children and the Supernatural*, Charisma House, 2012.

Walters, David. *Children Aflame: Accounts of the Historic Wesleyan and Modern Revivals With Children.* Good News Ministries, 2003.

Online Video Resources

http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=H5Aq70IGwqY&feature=youtu.be

http://youtu.be/hyrtMMHjtiw

RESPONSE 2

The Ethiopian Experience in Holistic Ministry to and with Children

BY SHIFERAW W. MICHAEL

Introduction

Christianity has been in Ethiopia for many centuries. Ethiopia got its first Orthodox Church bishop from the Egyptian Orthodox Church around 303 AD. Much of the history of Ethiopian Christianity is in one form or another traceable to the Ethiopian Orthodox Church. All evangelical churches in Ethiopia have learned and benefited much from the teachings and practices of this Church regarding children.

During in the last 35 years we have started to see a significant change of attitudes in theologians, lay leaders, pastors and evangelists in the work for and with children among evangelical churches in Ethiopia.

Decisions and Policies Made by Evangelical Churches

Ethiopian evangelical churches passed through severe persecution between 1974 and 1991, a period of 17 years. Several hundreds of believers were killed, thousands put in jail and many fled the country to different parts of the world. Very few evangelical churches remained open. Many church leaders believe that persecution is probably the main reason behind the relative unity Ethiopian evangelical churches have been enjoying among themselves since then. There is a very conducive environment to address all churches and Para churches in the same venue and at the same time with any issue of national scope.

As a result Ethiopian evangelical churches have put in place polices and made decisions with respect to ministry to and with children. The following agreements brought about attitude and practical change regarding the place of children in God's work.

1. The Covenant on Ministry to and with Children, March 2001

The Covenant is a historic document and the most significant work so far on the work with children and the place of children in the church. The Covenant outlines the responsibilities of the church and Para-churches at the national, regional and local church levels on ministry to and with children. It calls for collaboration between churches and Para churches and is the benchmark of ministry to and with children. The following paragraphs are taken from the preamble of the Covenant:

> The weakness in the handling and caring for children has contributed to millions of children being victims of many and various man-made and natural disasters, diseases, poverty and various "deter able" or "preventable" and dangerous conditions. They are forced to live without hope in despicable conditions…

Taking into consideration the matters indicated in the above proceeding paragraphs and similar other facts, we the leaders of evangelical churches of Ethiopia humbly ask our great God to forgive us for failing to do what we could and what we ought to have done for children;

In addition, we now decide to leave behind our mistakes and weaknesses and commit ourselves to care for, raise and lead children in accordance with the Word of God.

2. Agreement to create a new generation of Ethiopians

A further development happened in April 2004 with three important decisions being made:

a. to raise a new generation of Ethiopians as God's instruments

   The participants believed it was imperative that things have to change in the country as could not continue in the way it had for centuries. For this to happen, it was necessary that a new

generation of Ethiopians be created who will be God's instrument to bring about healing and holistic transformation in the country.

b. to equip and mobilize the local church for raising the new generation

c. to form an organization to equip, empower and challenge the local church

The ***Child Development Training and Research Center (CDTRC)*** was formed to lead the churches' effort in the mobilization of the local church and children. The CDTRC's dual mission is to help children and youth thrive by offering holistic child development training programs to those working directly with or on behalf of children and to promote child wellbeing in Ethiopia and other African countries by educating leaders in both church and society about the current needs of children and their central role in Africa's future.

3. The Child Protection Policy of Evangelicals (May 2009)

Another landmark of profound importance is the adoption of a national document on child protection, entitled Child Protection Policy of Evangelicals . One of the most significant provisions of this document is Article 33 which challenges the church to teach its members on keeping children safe at home and in the community.

4. National baseline survey on holistic children's ministry (2012)

The national baseline survey on the profile of Evangelical churches on holistic children's ministry was launched by the CDTRC in 2011 and was completed by January 2012. The target population of the survey included Sunday school teachers, Sunday school attendant children, parents of children attending Sunday school and local church leaders. The overall objective is to provide the evangelical churches of Ethiopia and other stakeholders, with authentic and comprehensive information regarding the profile of children's ministry. The results of this will serve as a basis for further developing appropriate and viable intervention strategies to address the identified problems on the one hand, and as benchmark for measuring the achievements of the

interventions to catapult the work of the church in children's ministry on the other. This is the first study of its kind ever made in the country on the subject.

5. Orthodox, Catholic and Evangelical Churches Joint Forum

A joint forum of all Trinitarian churches was established in Ethiopia in 2011 through the effort of the Ethiopian Bible. This is an exciting and recent development in relations between churches in the country. It gives an opportunity for institutions like the CDTRC to encourage and challenge the Ethiopian Orthodox Church (about 43% of the nation) to make children's ministry an important aspect of its ministry. A significant advocacy for children's ministry has already begun in this forum. The possible opening up of the Ethiopian Orthodox Church for a mission-oriented response to holistic ministry to and with children will bring about harvest that goes beyond the imagination of any of us who are in children's work in Ethiopia today.

6. Converting congregations into "child friendly congregations"

The second largest denomination in Ethiopia has now taken a move to convert initially twenty five of its congregations (local churches) into "children friendly" congregations with the expectation and intention that these will be used as models to help their other congregations become "child friendly" in due course.

7. Planned national program to celebrate champions for children

Ethiopian evangelicals are now organizing a special occasion to celebrate individuals, organizations and movements that have done service to children affected by poverty, disease, natural and manmade disasters or have lost their parents or one reason or another.

These decisions and policy measures have enhanced the work of the church for and with children and brought about visible results. Now, many denominations have established departments for children's ministry and allocate a budget for children's work. Many local churches send their children Sunday schools teachers to training institutions like the CDTRC.

Success Factors in the Mobilization of the Church for Children's Ministry in Ethiopia

I will share some of the reasons why I think there has been relative success in raising the profile of children ministry churches in the country.

1. Divine providence and guidance

Starting in 1993 the Lord brought together dedicated and determined people to leadership and influential positions, to do all they could in laying down a good foundation children ministry among evangelical churches. The Holy Spirit spoke vividly to a key church leader on how he wanted the ministry of Compassion was to be started. He was told by the Holy Spirit that "God did not want ***children's ministry to be started in church compounds but in the heart of church leaders***".

The Holy Spirit gave wisdom and unity to people who were in the forefront of children's ministry about how to win the hearts and minds of church leaders for ministry to children. They were led to organize churches in clusters for purpose of sharing with them the vision of ministry to children and follow up of implementation on agreed matters.

2. Children and Church Growth

There is amazing growth among the local churches that have embraced the role of children in God's agenda and work. Almost all local churches that equipped and empowered children for ministry have registered significant growth in their church membership. Moreover, the preparation and adoption of the policies on ministry to children described above have significant contribution to the ministry to children among churches. Many denominations participated in the drafting of these instruments creating a sense of ownership. The process of adoption has been highly educative to the participants.

Presentation Discussed – "Discerning the Work of the Holy Spirit in Global Mission Today" (Paper 4)

Participants deeply appreciated the Trinitarian understanding of the church as a basis for informing us where children belong. Specifically, they discussed the ontological nature of the Trinity as representing the equal value of children and adults in the church. This was contrasted with the functional hierarchy in the Trinity representing the hierarchical structures necessary to maintain order and protect children from the risks and responsibilities of adulthood. This concern for the necessary order of churches was echoed by some participants that noted the absence of a statement of adult/child equivalence in Galatians 3:28. It was asserted that if we are to find the proper place for children in the church we must move beyond the Trinity and discuss the equal human dignity that children possess, as well as the ways that our understanding of sin might need to temper our enthusiasm somewhat.

Participants also noted a number of church structure issues related to children, both literally and figuratively: there was a view that new wine requires new wine skins. Consistent with this, it was lamented that many church buildings tend to locate their children's ministry rooms at the furthest margins of the church, and expressed concern that such distance from the sanctuary sends the wrong message to children about where they belong. Instead, churches should champion intergenerational churches, which are more organic than organizational, and encourage all generations to actively participate. Participants also called for child-friendly churches – those that intentionally appreciate, involve, and empower children in ways that are equal to adults. However, they also recognized the need to affirm the dignity of children as persons. It was noted the cultural sensitivity that must be employed. Nakah's reference to the idea of "acquired personhood" in many African contexts is a challenge that must be confronted, and there were very few good examples of churches being intentional in doing this. Mission education needs to start early in a child's life and all members of the family must be

involved in it. This especially underlines the importance of involving and respecting parents.

A number of participants focused on the Holy Spirit-focused emphasis within of the presentation. It was regretted that more depth was not given about how to better discern the work of the Holy Spirit in children although some participants said that the paper encouraged them to be more open and attentive to that work. It is important to develop curricula that equips adults working with children to encourage the creativity and sensitivity of children to the Holy Spirit.

Theme 5:

The Missiological Presuppositions, Motives, Structures and Methods Specific to the 4/14 Window

Editor's Introduction

Siga Arles led the creative process of authoring this paper. He worked with an international team, writing from different theological traditions and geographical contexts. Each author contributed different parts of the chapter and these were then edited together into this chapter. All the authors use the concept of missio Dei as foundational in their thinking, but within this broad framework the authors chose to critique three models of mission ("mission and church growth … when children are used to bolster church statistics"; "the 'teacher complex' of the church" and "the churches transformational efforts in the world pertaining to children"). The paper draws upon Isaiah 65:17-25, Isaiah's vision for the city, highlighting specific areas in which Christians are called to work in their mission with and to children: in discovering the city's joys, healthcare and longevity, housing, economic development and advocacy. The paper concludes with reflecting upon mission ethics, drawing upon Jesus' personal example and on Paul's letter to the Philippian believers. The authors "affirm it is right to draw particular attention to the 4/14 generation, calling on the Churches to pay particular attention to and invest resources in this rising generation …. that children are a gift from God and have their unique contribution to make to the task of world

evangelisation" and that "the 4/14 movement must ensure that children are not instrumentalised or weighted down with responsibilities beyond their years."

This chapter raises issues of ethics and motivation, picking up the theme of power raised by Howell in the previous chapter. Reflecting upon our practice in mission requires that we are willing to hear and respond to the Holy Spirit's guidance. This is most especially the case when we are convicted that our motivations and practice do not reflect the grace and love of God.

PAPER 5

The Missiological Presuppositions, Motives, Structures and Methods Specific to the 4/14 Window

BY SIGA ARLES, JOHN BAXTER-BROWN, GENEVIEVE JAMES, GLICERIO (JOJO) MANZANO, JR., NATIVITY PETALLAR, AUGUSTIN SOKOLOVSKI

Missiological Presuppositions

To speak of mission is to speak of God and the world, of the sending by the Father of Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit for the salvation of the whole Creation. Our mission is not our own mission, but the mission of our Lord Jesus Christ, entrusted to us. Every Christian is called to fulfil this mission and invited to live that fulfilment from the very depth of her calling. In his re-commissioning of the disciples as portrayed in Matthew 28:18-20, Jesus gave us the commandment to make disciples, baptising believers in the name of the Father, Son and Holy Spirit. This invocation helps us understand that the life of those three persons - who live in and for each other - is the first expression of mission. Genuine Christian mission is concerned with God's reign for others, without egoistic interest and a specific denominational or confessional purpose.

This chapter presumes three primary considerations: (i) mission flows from the character and purposes of God; (ii) there is no mission apart from the person of Jesus Christ and the work of the Spirit in the church; and (iii) all mission is necessarily contextualized.

A third of the world population consists of children. Many of these live in urban contexts. VIVA Report 2008[1] documents that "One

[1] *The VIVA Report 2008: The State of the World's Christian Work with*

in every five people in the world today is a suffering child." In that same report, a stunning 37% of the world's children, more than 674 million, live in absolute poverty. In many Asian countries, children are forced to sexual servitude and unsafe labour conditions among others.

As will become evident from the rest of this paper, these realities frame much of the context facing the 4-14 movement.

Motives

The motivations for mission are varied and mixed. Although mission is ultimately God's action in the world, he chooses to use human agents. Being human it is inevitable that missiological motives will carry both some honourable dimensions but also some aspects and motivations that we need to reflect upon carefully. We need to continually check our motives against biblical teaching, repenting where necessary and thanking God when our motives match the ethical standards we find in the teachings of Jesus.

Motivations can be both personal and institutional. The following section offers an analysis of such motives at the conceptual and practical levels of how the church serves children.

1. Mission as Relationship with God and Others

God is by God's very nature a missionary God. The Godhead of Father, Son and Holy Spirit exist in mutual relationship between themselves, but also in relationship to the entire created order of things both seen and unseen. This relationship, between the Godhead and with creation, is part of the very nature of God. Mission must always reflect this theological truth and is therefore relational. It cannot be otherwise. Thus the primary motive for mission is one of desiring relationship with God and with Creation, in particular with women and men and children who bear the image of God as created

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Children. Published by VIVA, www.viva.org.

beings. The nature of God's internal and external relationships is the mirror into which we are called to look to discern if we carry God's image in and through what we do and who we are.

It is through relationship with God that we seek relationship with others, and part of that relationship is to invite others also to develop a personal, dynamic relationship with God. The depth of our missionary commitment is a reflection of the depth of our Christian commitment: if we have a dynamic relationship with God, we simply cannot but be drawn into missionary endeavours. If our relationship with God is weak or even non-existent, then we will have a correspondingly weak commitment to evangelisation. This is because a core characteristic of God's nature is love: love exists not in its own right and not for itself, but only truly exists in dynamic relationship to others. If we say we love God, then we will have a correspondingly deep love for others manifested in mission. If that commitment is lacking, then we need to ask ourselves how truly deep and personal is our own relationship with God.

One of the lessons adults have often been slow to understand is the way the love of God is reflected in the faith and trust of children. It is not accidental that Jesus points his squabbling disciples to a child in order to show them what a loving relationship looks like. It is the very simplicity of the child that calls into question motives of grandeur and power that threaten to tear apart the relationships of the disciples. As we look to our relationships and the motives we have, the Church must always keep love – the deep yet simple trust of a child and God's relationship with that child – at the centre.

2. Mission as Love

A secondary motive follows from the first: love overflows and one expression of this is simply the desire to share with others the good things we have received from God. It follows that the primary motive for mission is love: love for God and love for others. If we have not love, we are simply making noise. If we have love, we are making music. The psalmist exhorts us to 'taste and see that the Lord is good!' He is talking from his own experience of the Lord's goodness and as a result of this he can say that God is good. Moreover, he can exhort

other people to taste for themselves. Everybody who has tasted God's goodness is concerned with the mission and everybody has a part to act in.

A recent statement by the World Evangelical Alliance Theology Commission, drawing on the text of Mark ch. 5, stated that "As we celebrate the evangelistic example of Jesus himself and seek to learn from it, we remember again that all who claim to be followers of Jesus must proclaim both his authority – Jesus is Lord! - and the breadth of his grace and reach. This is the fullness of mission, this is holistic evangelisation and we must prioritise it as Jesus did".[2] The statement continues by quoting from Ad Gentes 1: "The pilgrim Church is missionary by her very nature, since it is from the mission of the Son and the mission of the Holy Spirit that she draws her origin, in accordance with the decree of God the Father." Mark tells the story of Jairus, a leader in a local synagogue, who came to Jesus "fell at his feet and begged him repeatedly" (Mark 5:22-23) to heal his dying daughter. There is a strong emotional connotation with the phrase 'begged him repeatedly' (parakalei): there is urgency, desire, pleading. The phrase recalls the love, the desperate longing, of a father for his dying daughter to be made well. Jesus is the child's, and therefore the father's, last hope for life. However, as Jesus leaves with Jairus, he is waylaid by a woman who is also in dire need of healing, and whilst Jesus talks with her, the daughter dies. As Anne Richards comments, "It seems that the woman has effectively ended the life of the child and claimed the healing miracle for herself".[3]However, she goes on to note that "once Jairus had asked for help, nothing stops Jesus from getting through to his daughter, despite interruptions, a crowd pressing on him from every side, a usurpation of his healing power by another, and the news that the child is beyond help anyway. *Nothing* … Jesus finds in her something of complete value, worthy of saving

[2] http://www.worldea.org/images/wimg/files/Evangelism%20-%20The%20Hallmark%20of%20Evangelical%20Faith.pdf (accessed July 2013).

[3] Anne Richards, *Children in the Bible: A Fresh Approach* (London: SPCK, 2013), 102.

and healing, loved by God, … loved by her father to whom Jesus responds".[4]

The narrative is compelling for it offers a glimpse not only of Jairus' motivation – that of any loving father seeking what is best for their child – but of Jesus' own compassion and determination. Mark 5 emphasises Jesus' authority but also "shows that the Gospel extends to all of creation: it is for men and women caught up in evil, for people who are suffering from illness and disease, and for children and their parents. The breadth of the gospel is for those excluded from the community (the demon-possessed man), for those within who are also outcasts (the woman), and also for those in positions of power and influence (Jairus). No one is exempt from the need of God's free and saving grace. Transformation is for all".[5]

3. Mission as Prayer

Prayer is an essential element of mission: no human effort can be fruitful without prayer. Mission is a life in prayer because prayer nurtures love for God and for others. We pray for mission, so that its motives, purposes and fruits correspond to the Gospel. This is the way in which we must live the mission, not as slaves of God or slaves of the world but as brothers and sisters of the Son, freely choosing to live in submission to God the Father in the power of the Spirit as taught and shown in Jesus the Son.

Children and young people should be both the objects of our prayers – we make petitions to God for them – and prayer partners with us. The Church teaches and instructs both children and adults into the life of prayer and it is in the Spirit that we are made one in the body of Christ.

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[4] *Ibid*., 103.

[5] http://www.worldea.org/images/wimg/files/Evangelism%20-%20The%20Hallmark%20of%20Evangelical%20Faith.pdf (accessed July 2013).

4.Mission as Obedience

The so-called "Great Commission" of Matthew 28:18-20 is often interpreted as a command 'to go.' However, the imperative verb in these verses is 'make disciples'; all other verbs (go, teach, baptize) are participles. The other post-resurrection re-commissioning texts lack any sense of command (Mark 16:15; Luke 25:45-49; John 20:21; Acts 1:8). This emphasis upon obedience as a motive for mission can be traced back to the seminal work of William Carey, *An Enquiry into the Obligations of Christians to use Means for the Conversion of the Heathens*[6] (1792). In his context, with widespread apathy towards mission and evangelism, such an emphasis can be understood despite it lacking biblical authority. Rather, to quote Bosch[7], the biblical witness points to mission as "simply an expression of the inner law of their lives … an essential result of Pentecost." It is true that Paul felt a sense of duty to share the Gospel, but closer reading of the text reveals this to be a "debt of *gratitude* not *duty*".[8] Bosch goes on to affirm with Newbigin that "'You shall be my witnesses,' is not a command to be obeyed, but a promise to be trusted."

Obedience is not wrong *per se*, though it is not the most noble or the highest motivation. Just as a parent raising a small child hopes that in time that child will "obey" simply because she loves the parent, so God desires our mission to be our way of responding in love to the God who first loved us.

As we think about the ways in which mission is taught in the Church, it is imperative that children and young people come to see such obedience in light of such trust. This not only will give them a sense of participation in the life of God, but will shed light on how they view the motives of those who work with them. That is, if we give

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[6] William Carey, *An Enquiry into the Obligations of Christians to use Means for the Conversion of the Heathens*, (originally published 1792), Ebook available from http://www.wmcarey.edu/carey/enquiry/anenquiry.pdf.

[7] David Bosch, "The Structure of Mission: An Exposition of Matthew 28:16-20" in *The Study of Evangelism: Exploring a Missional Practice of the Church*, eds. Paul W. Chilcote and Laceye C. Warner (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2008), 75.

[8] *Ibid.*, 76 emphasis in original.

the impression that we are working with children or young people simply out of obedience, there is the danger of such children not seeing the inherent value that they play in God's kingdom or the way they are loved just because of who they are, not out of an obligation to love. But if they see that our work with them flows from the love of God to us, they are invited into that mission, into sharing in such work out of grateful trust, not obligation.

5. Mission and Ethics

Jesus promised his first disciples "power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you" (Acts 1:8). The power and grace of the Holy Spirit is indispensable in Christian life and mission. Yet this Spirit-sourced power is not the only power dynamics that exist in mission. Paul mentions people who 'proclaim Christ out of selfish ambition' (Philippians 1:17) and others who seek to cause him further suffering. In these cases, mission is being conducted for reasons of gaining power for one's-self or over other people. In the history of 'Christian' mission there have been awful examples of the abuse of power, of forced conversions, of linking life-giving emergency aid to conversion, of the subjugation of peoples in the name of Christ. Today there continues the risk of mission motivated by a thirst for power. For the 4-14 movement the risk is that children can be instrumentalised and manipulated to serve the interests of the movement rather than to grow in their faith and become God's agents in growing His Kingdom.

In the Church there is a growing awareness of the need for consistent and ethical practice within evangelisation. For example, recently an historic document was published by the World Evangelical Alliance, the Pontifical Council for Interreligious Dialogue and the World Council of Churches, *Christian Witness in a Multi-Religious World: Recommendations for Conduct*.[9] The document explores the biblical and ethical principles upon which

[9] It can be downloaded from http://www.worldevangelicals.org/resources/categories/index.htm?cat=67 among other places. Jointly published in Geneva, June 2011.

Christian witness should be based. It recommends that they should be studied by Christians and adapted to be "applicable to their particular contexts." There is some work being done to apply the document to mission with teenagers and an opportunity exists to develop a version of the document suitable for the 4-14 generation.

A Critique of Three Methodologies in Relation to Children

Firstly we consider the close link between mission and church growth and how this has become hazardous especially when children are used to bolster church statistics. We then move on to briefly consider the "teacher complex" of the church in its dealing with children. Finally we explore the churches transformational efforts in the world pertaining to children.

1. Mission and Church Growth – "Attract the children and parents will come"

The church is not different from other cultural manifestations of society since it displays the same propensity to empire, to grow and internationalize. The mission of God sometimes is unfortunately seen as the mission to increase church attendance numbers rather than make disciples of Jesus Christ. The fixation on the statistical gains of the church is regularly compared with corporate marketing strategy as the battle for the market share, in this case, the religious market share, rages on. The temptation to empire-building is strong as many churches realise that the way to reach adults (who are their primary market) is to secure the fondness and allegiance of children. For this reason a host of churches, some even calling themselves missional churches, offer state of the art children's entertainment, albeit with a spiritual twist. Despite noble motives for the salvation and spiritual formation of children, there is a risk that ministry to children fall short of an effective and authentic witness to Christ. Children seem to learn more about belonging to the fellowship of Christians than about fellowship with Christ. This form of mission to children can then become tantamount to club membership. What is also dangerous

when the lines between mission and church growth start to blur is that children bear witness to the power struggles, splits, divisions and the super egos of church leadership.

In the light of this situation in relation to a missional foundation for the 4/14 window, a possible task is to explore the following questions: how can we avoid a toxic approach to church growth where children become mere statistics in the race to win the market share? Is church growth the ultimate aim of our mission? If the church is God's alternative community, how are middle-class churches counter-cultural in a world where the desires of the individual, customer or consumer take precedence over all? If children can be lured into the church through Disney-styled entertainment salted with a bible verse or two, then will the perceived desires of middle-class children continue to shape the church's mission to children?

2. Mission to Children – Adults as the custodians of the knowledge of God

If we apply the principles of cognitive justice to mission then we will realize, contrary to popular belief, that a child is not a spiritual tabula rasa on which we can effortlessly begin to engrave our faith perceptions, biblical interpretations and spirituality. Koyama[10] warned of the "teacher complex" inherent in Christianity and cautioned of "one way street Christianity." The same can be said of our ministry to children. The knowledge of God is seen as the exclusive accomplishment of adults. Mission with children is contingent on the generosity of adults who claim to be the custodians of the whole gospel. Yet as human beings, our understanding of the whole gospel, as in the case of our understanding of reality, is rooted in, and arises from, intellectual and faith traditions and culture. It can be difficult to acknowledge that children are in communication with

[10] Kosuke Koyama, "Christianity Suffers from 'Teacher Complex' " in *Mission Trends* No 2*,* eds. Gerald Anderson and Thomas Stransky (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1975), 70-75.

God and God is in communication with children with or without the teaching of adults.

The 4/14 movement has rightly called on the global mission enterprise to recognise children as active, fully capable, agents of mission not only passive recipients of mission. Adults are necessary to guide, and mentor but it should never be considered that a child can not have the direct leading of the Holy Spirit.

3. Children, Mission and Social Transformation

If missiology is an attempt to critically reflect on a "religious community as an agent of change"[11] then the church's efforts in the world must be critically considered in the light of its presence amidst children. The proliferation of children's NGOs highlights the failure of governments to bring about justice. NGOs that deal with children's rights and justice have been at the forefront in the battle to safe guard the dignity of children. However the desperate and appalling state of children in the world is not only an indicator of government failure, but also reveals a critical weakness in the practice and presence of the church in the world. The church has had a chequered and controversial history in its handling of children. Part of the challenge to the church is that it has often focused on its mission to adults. It is only in recent times that women's theologies have gained the freedom of expression and status as a legitimate theological endeavour. It is clear then how patriarchal the theological and missiological enterprise has been even two millennia since Jesus placed the child in the midst.

Further to this in many cases women and children have been conveniently heaped together in one group called "the marginalised." Thorne[12] calls for the conceptual autonomy of children. For too long women have been heaped together with children as a monolithic marginalised group. The conceptual autonomy of children in the field of missiology is critically urgent. We must remember that this is

[11] J.N.J. Kritzinger, "Studying religious communities as agents of change: An agenda for missiology" in *Missionalia* 23(3), 1995: 366-396.

[12] B. Thorne, "Revisioning women and social change: Where are all the children gone?" in *Gender and Society* 1 (1) 1087: 104.

largely a youthful world with the most populated countries having the most youthful demographics.

4. Developing Methodologies

There are several steps that are important to follow in developing or adapting methodologies for mission to and with the 4/14 generation. **Prayer** and **vision casting** are of prime importance. But **the perspective of the child** is of equal import. For too long the Church has had a tendency to treat children as objects – beneficiaries of charity or mission targets – rather than as co-subjects of mission. There is no "child/ adult" dichotomy within God's economy. Rather, as shown elsewhere within this book, children are quite capable of contributing to God's mission as actors.

It is necessary to explore the historical, socio-economic, and governmental backgrounds and agendas – and to appreciate how they impact children, their families and communities – if we are to fully understand the contexts in which we evangelise, and before we apply missiological principles. As Musk[13] asserts, "methods must be custom-made to fit their subject matter" – in this instance the 4/14 age group and how to engage with them in missions.

Given the complexity of the contexts in which children and young people grow, it is unwise to assume that a project that works well in Melbourne can be readily replicated in Manilla, or transplanted from Lima to London. There is not just one method that can meet the challenge: there needs to be a combination of methodologies. Paul adopted different approaches "that I might by any means save some" (1 Corinthians 9:22). Musk[14] emphasized that "it is inconceivable in this day and age to claim absolute knowledge for a single methodology when so much is available." One task for the 4/14 movement is therefore to create a series of case studies of good

[13] Terry C. Musk, "Perspectival Methodologies: A Complementary Understanding of the History of Religion and Missiology" in *Mission to New Religious Movements* 2004.

[14] *Ibid*.

practice from across the globe that can act as both an inspiration and a benchmark for mission to and with children and young people.

The 4/14 publication, *Strategies for Reaching and Mobilizing Children and Youth of the 4/14 Window*,[15] states that "each Christian organization shall: (1) Have clear strategies for the equipping and mobilization of children in the 4/14 window and their families for holistic transformation and that the same is done throughout its regional and national offices; (2) Coordinate its work with organizations' that have a similar calling at international, regional and national levels to bring about more effective and efficient results in the equipping and mobilization of children and their families; and (3) Directly or through its branches, work closely with regional and national church organizations and local churches for the equipping and mobilization of children and their families for holistic transformation."

Isaiah's Vision for the City

Long before both the 4/14 Movement and the advent of NGOs, Isaiah had a vision for the new Jerusalem (Isaiah 65:17-25). This vision can provide a biblical basis for developing this missiology further. He gives valuable indicators of a conducive environment for the development and nurturing of children.

> *17 For I am about to create new heavens and a new earth; the former things shall not be remembered or come to mind.*
> *18 But be glad and rejoice for ever in what I am creating; for I am about to create Jerusalem as a joy, and its people as a delight.*
> *19 I will rejoice in Jerusalem, and delight in my people; no more shall the sound of weeping be heard in it, or the cry of distress.*
> *20 No more shall there be in it an infant that lives but a few days, or an old person who does not live out a lifetime; for one who dies at a*

[15] Available from http://4to14window.com/covenant-on-4-14-window-draft. The quote is from "Role of Christian Organizations… 5 Strategies for reaching and mobilizing children and youth of the 4/14 Window."

hundred years will be considered a youth, and one who falls short of a hundred will be considered accursed.
[21] They shall build houses and inhabit them; they shall plant vineyards and eat their fruit.
[22] They shall not build and another inhabit; they shall not plant and another eat; for like the days of a tree shall the days of my people be, and my chosen shall long enjoy the work of their hands.
[23] They shall not labour in vain, or bear children for calamity; for they shall be offspring blessed by the Lord and their descendants as well.
[24] Before they call I will answer, while they are yet speaking I will hear.
[25] The wolf and the lamb shall feed together, the lion shall eat straw like the ox; but the serpent – its food shall be dust! They shall not hurt or destroy on all my holy mountain, says the Lord.

We include this text in order to draw attention to the prophetic role of the church in the creation of an environment of justice where children can experience joy, health and longevity, provision and well being, peace and grow up in ecologically safe environments. Above all children can develop a relationship with God such that before they call He will answer. Naturally the church cannot assume the roles and responsibilities of the government; however it can strongly advocate for service provision, public utilities and most importantly justice and fairness for the poor and the marginalized. Wherever possible the church can actively participate in the renewal and transformation of the physical and social space of the environments children find themselves in. In the discussion to follow we explore five key issues from Isaiah's vision in terms of its impact on children.

1. Discovering the City's Joys

If God is in the city there is still sufficient reason to be hopeful and joyful. The task of the church is to permeate the urban environment with the Christian joyfulness and positivity. Despite the obvious negativity that shrouds the city, the church is called to "discover the joys" of the city. What greater joy can a city possess than its children? In the international church it is rare to find celebrations of children, of what God is doing with and through children and if these

celebrations occur the voices of children themselves are muted. If we are to delight in the city of the 21st century then we are to delight in the children of the city.

2. Health Care and Longevity

Isaiah 65:20, 22 includes reference to the prolongation of human life. Premature death was interpreted as a sign of divine displeasure and on the contrary a long life was counted as a blessing and a sign of approval from God.[16] God's agenda for the city includes restoration of health and life, essential elements of Isaiah's vision. Infant mortality is still high in most developing world cities despite the great technological advancements in the world. In Durban on the east coast of South Africa there are many cemeteries that no longer have the space to bury the dead due to the high mortality rate caused by AIDS. Child headed households are on the rise. The causes and stimulants of ill health should be addressed together with the inadequacy of the health system in the city.

3. Housing

Isaiah (65. 21-22) points attention to one of humankind's basic necessities: shelter. Housing is an essential issue in the city, as daily thousands of people flock to the cities in search of better prospects. On their arrival they are met with the harsh reality that the streets of the city are not paved with Gold. Housing provides dignity and contributes a sense of belonging, stability and security to life. The favelas that hang precariously on the cliffs of Rio de Janeiro or the squatter-settlements that weave their way in and around South African cities are certainly not what Isaiah had in mind. Linthicum succinctly states that the church should work for "safe" fairly distributed housing for all, "whether one is powerful or a 'nobody' in the city, whether one is rich or is poor".[17]

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[16] Buttrick George Arthur, George Keith and Butterick Crim, *The Interpreters Bible Dictionary* (Nashville, TX: Abingdon Press), 155.

[17] Robert C. Linthicum, *City of God, City of Satan: A Biblical Theology of the Urban City* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1991).

4. Economic Development

Isaiah in chapter 65:21-23 describes material prosperity, security and enjoyment of the fruit of labour. The church in the city should advocate a just workable economy. Concerning this Linthicum adds that "promotion of economic justice, control of the distribution of an economy, particular attention to the hurting of any urban society, and using the law of love as the highest code by which a city structures itself all become principles upon which economic development must be based".[18]

The church should also be the voice against unjust and unscrupulous financial decisions and activities undertaken by the private and public sectors. Certain corporate giants and multinational companies are notorious for their taste in cheap labour. These businesses lure large numbers of children to the city where they employ them at an obscenely low wage. Despite the global outcry and even sporadic boycotts against these companies they continue to economically abuse children. Small businesses too have blood on their ambitious hands, since illegal sweatshops are commonplace in cities across the world, where conditions are not even suitable for animals and payment is sometimes not forth-coming. The church has to be a voice in the face of these injustices and can not be the body of Christ if it turns its back on these and other forms of malpractice in the city. According to Andrew Davey Jesus taught about "the economy of God" which is concerned with the "reordering of relationships and resources through a just and gracious liberality." Davey[19] adds that the apostle Paul believed that economy was the "Christ-centred activity of God."

5. Advocacy

While it is reasonable to recognize the positive contribution of the authorities in the city it is not sensible to overlook the inadequacies of

[18] Ibid., 169.

[19] Andrew Davey, *Urban Christianity and Global Order: Theological Resources for an Urban Future* (Massachusetts: Hendrickson Publishers, 2002), 111.

public utilities and non-delivery of services, especially when they hurt children. The church's lack of socio-political analysis will prevent sound and sustained social interventions in the city. This is not implying that the church should take on the role and functions of the government but that the church should embrace its prophetic role in keeping the government aware of the consequences of their actions and in-actions.

In an article titled "Mission as Ethos/Ethos as mission", Robinson[20] carefully points out that the visible presence and observable actions of Christians and faith communities are stronger, more powerful representations of what they stand for, than what they say and believe. Robinson warns that the church "should pay serious attention to the intimate link between its mission and its ethos, that is, between its obligation to witness and its conduct of daily life".[21] If our mission to and with children is to be authentic it is time that the church must link what it says with what it thinks with its action.

Conclusion

We assert that the basis for any missiology for the 4/14 movement must be built within the framework of the *missio Dei*. We are but servants in God's own mission and are consequently called to develop a Jesus-centred and biblically-based missiology. As such we are bound by the values of the Kingdom of God as exemplified in the life, teaching and ministry of Jesus himself. He clearly valued children and saw in them attitudes that He wished His followers to emulate. However, His ministry had a breadth and depth that included everyone: the outcast and infirm, women and men, old and young, married, widowed and single, the poor and the powerful. In our age, with the sheer scale of need among children and young people, we affirm it is right to draw particular attention to the 4/14 generation,

[20] Robinson, "Mission as Ethos/Ethos as Mission" in *Missionalia* 1990: 156-167.

[21] *Ibid*., 156.

calling on the Churches to pay particular attention to and invest resources in this rising generation. Yet, this cannot be to the exclusion of any other group. We affirm that children are a gift from God and have their unique contribution to make to the task of world evangelisation, but our work must focus upon empowering them to be and become followers of Jesus. The power dynamics of the 4/14 movement must ensure that children are not instrumentalised or weighted down with responsibilities beyond their years. Rather we are called to facilitate their growth – spiritual, physical, social, psychological – in wholesome ways that equip them to be life-long followers of Jesus. We affirm that the 4/14 generation can be agents of mission and can influence others to make a commitment for Christ. They are much more than just recipients or objects of missions.

It is vital that we as Christ's disciples take time to reflect on our motives in mission. We must take steps to ensure that the values and motives that shape our work reflect the values of God's reign. This may lead us to repentance for the times our egos or confessional bodies have exerted unrighteous influence on our work, or when we have seen the 4/14 generation as a means to an end rather than a worthy and honourable end in and of themselves. It is imperative that we consider issues of justice, rights and equality theologically from the perspective of children and young people.

The great hymn Paul uses within his letter to the church in Philippi (Philippians 2:5-11) can act as an object lesson for the 4/14 movement.

> *5 Your attitude should be the same as that of Christ Jesus:*
> *6 Who, being in very nature God, did not consider equality with God something to be grasped, 7 but made himself nothing, taking the very nature of a servant, being made in human likeness.*
> *8 And being found in appearance as a man, he humbled himself and became obedient to death – even death on a cross!*
> *9 Therefore God exalted him to the highest place and gave him the name that is above every name,*
> *10 that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, in heaven and on earth and under the earth,*
> *11 and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father.*

Jesus laid aside claims to power to humble Himself and follow a path of obedience: we must have a similar mindset. Let us determine to cultivate a "bottom up" approach that actively seeks to hear the voice of the 4/14 generation and be shaped by it, but within the godly limits of the *missio Dei*. This bottom up approach also requires us to acknowledge that there is no 'one size fits all' solution to work with the 4/14 age group as each context may require different approaches. Therefore we need to build a series of case studies from across God's good earth, and learn from them. Such examples can provide the basis upon which to create new ministries aimed at the 4/14 generation, their families and communities, as well as to refresh and renew existing work. This bottom up mentality underlines the importance of not imposing top down solutions upon the contexts faced by the millions of workers – paid and voluntary – around the world who work with the 4/14 generation. Rather, we are to learn and so inspire, equip, empower for the benefit of each child and for the glory of God.

> "In the last days, God says, I will pour out my Spirit on all people. Your sons and daughters will prophesy, your young men will see visions, your old men will dream dreams" (Acts 2:17).

Suggested Questions

1. How effective had we been in our mission to the children thus far? Evaluate the status of children ministry around the world.
2. What new measures / infrastructures / methods are we to undertake "to cover the earth with the knowledge of the glory of our God"?
3. What ways of solidarity and synergy should be planned by our 4/14 Global Initiative?

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Presentation discussed – "The Missiological Presuppositions, Motives, Structures and Methods Specific to the 4/14 Window" (Paper 5)

Participants engaged rigorously with the structure and content of the presentations, as well as the questions that the team presented for Paper 5. Many participants engaged extensively in the task of evaluating the effectiveness of mission to children so far. It was agreed that the necessary tools or empirical evidence for this were not readily available and the general sense of the participants was that the many groups that are doing very good work with children tend to be isolated instances of excellence. Usually the church tends to be relatively inactive towards mission with children. Reasons for this include a lack of funding and the way pastors are trained. Too often a lack of senior pastor positions causes would-be church leaders to take positions as youth pastors as a "stepping stone" position.

On the whole participants appreciated the structure of Paper 5. Some isolated the need for further discussion on presuppositions suggesting that this was the component most in need of revision if the church is going to genuinely engage in mission with children. Many felt that too often mission groups see mission with children as a second-rate activity or as a means to an end. The instrumentality of work with children came up repeatedly in discussion around motives for ministry with children. It is clear that participants believe that mission with children must be done out of a genuine desire to see children develop and deepen their relationship with Christ, and must not be exploited as a mechanism for increasing church size or coercing parents to attend. Experience has shown that a narrow focus on church growth is too liable to be driven by adult-centric concerns and is not in children's best interests.

Participants also discussed the models and methods most appropriate to work with children. There was a strong desire to see the development of assessment tools to help churches and organizations evaluate their own work with children. When asked to make their own suggestions for new methods and models the

responses ran from a call for more intentional use of technology (cyber mission) to the value of empowering Sunday school teachers as mini-pastors and encouraging them to do home visits. It is important to listen carefully and creatively to the children themselves to see what part they might serve in creating these new methods. Participants once again reinforced the need to incorporate parents into any missional strategies and to pay close attention to ethical concerns. For example, we must avoid the "puppet model" of working with children (a common critique of ministries that work with children in Latin America). It is important to keep in mind the social transformation of society but this may need to start with the transformation of the church.

Participants observed the importance of continuing to discuss these ideas together. They felt that it was important for the 4/14 window movement to continue helping them gather and discuss these issues and provide opportunities for prayer, fellowship and mutual accountability as we pursue these new approaches as a community.

Theme 6:

Raising Samuel

EDITOR'S INTRODUCTION

Susan Greener takes the well known story of the birth and early life of Samuel, the prophet-cum-kingmaker of ancient Israel. From exploring the narrative she raises five principles which, she claims, should guide us in our work with children and young people:

1. Children are to be holistically nurtured throughout childhood;
2. Children are to be active participants in worship and service to God;
3. Children can be called by God and hear his voice;
4. God uses whom he will, including those on the margins of life; and
5. The supreme story of history and life is God's and we are to envision and empower children as participants in that greater Story".

Greener offers us insights both drawn from the biblical narrative and other sources. A strong theme throughout is that children are fully human (or as a colleague and friend of mine puts it, "children are human beings not human becomings"). The Christian community must "fully recognise that the dignity and humanity of children who are stamped with God's image requires that a child be more than a member of a missiological target group to bolster conversion statistics or a human resource to be manipulated to achieve adult agendas." A

second powerful theme is that of child participation in the mission of God and the life of the church. From these themes other strands are woven, touching on key issues: the role of the Holy Spirit, parents, the Christian community, vocation, human development among others.

Greener's paper has two responses, both from Latin Americans. Erique Pinedo gives an overview of the recent developments in the UN Convention of the Rights of the Child, followed by two reflections: the first on child participation in the church; the second on mentoring from the Scriptures. Rosalee Velloso Ewell offers a short response asking, "If our work with and for children and youth is about embodying Christ and witnessing to Jesus in a troubled and violent world, is it the Jesus of the gospels that we bear with us? Do we have the humility to step aside like Eli, to confess our own mistakes, and to listen to the ways in which God wants to raise this child or these children in the image of his Son?"

PAPER 6

Raising Samuel: Releasing Children to Discover God's Purpose

BY SUSAN GREENER

Introduction

A mother bound by the One Child Policy hopes for a son. In disappointment she aborts the girl child she carries so that she may try again for a boy-child to bring her status in the community and security in her old age. A father in another part of the world celebrates the birth of a son, who he has already determined will take over the family business. A couple in the West uses every technological advance available to allow the woman to conceive her own biological child because it gives her a sense of accomplishment. A mother who cannot carry a child pays a surrogate to carry her and her husband's biological baby so that the child they receive is truly 'theirs.' And in a poorer part of the world, a family celebrates as the mother bears her sixth baby, grateful for extra hands to help with household chores and farming responsibilities.

It would be difficult to make the case that children are not valued by societies. Depending on the culture or the historical time period, children may fulfill differing needs. Children may serve material needs or confer status to a family or meet emotional needs for companionship – or even a sense of fulfillment or affirmation of parental skill or provision. And, children may fulfill a strategic purpose for evangelism and the future of the church. After all, children are more open to the gospel and there are so many of them in the world, particularly in areas where the gospel needs to be shared. Yet, I do not believe that valuing children as a strategic means to church growth and as missionary targets fully embraces a biblical, ethical or respectful value of children in the Kingdom or the Church.

We must look to scripture for touchstone stories that may illuminate a proper and godly posture toward children and their place in God's greater narrative. The raising of Samuel is such a story.

In the first chapter of Samuel 1, we encounter a childless woman, despairing and miserable. Hannah is tormented by her husband's other wife who has born him many children and does not hesitate to remind Hannah of her inadequacy as a wife until Hannah is crying and unable to eat. Year after year she goes with Elkanah, her husband, and the extended family to the temple, visibly distressed even though her husband expresses his love for her. She may wish to have a child to gain status in her household, please her husband and get Peninnah to stop antagonizing her. We do not know all of her reasons why she values a son. But we do know that she voices her prayer through weeping and anguished cries, saying "Lord Almighty, if you will only look on your servant's misery and remember me, and not forget your servant but give her a son, then I will give him to the Lord for all the days of his life" (1 Samuel 1:11, NIV). She is so distraught that Eli thinks her drunk.

"Not so, my lord," Hannah replied, "I am a woman who is deeply troubled. I have not been drinking wine or beer; I was pouring out my soul to the Lord. Do not take your servant for a wicked woman; I have been praying here out of my great anguish and grief."

Eli answered, "Go in peace, and may the God of Israel grant you what you have asked of him."

She said, "May your servant find favor in your eyes." Then she went her way and ate something, and her face was no longer downcast. (1 Samuel 1:15-18, NIV).

Her prayer is answered and she fulfills her vow to God, returning her very young son to that very same temple so that he may spend his whole life (1 Samuel 1:28) in worship to the Lord – as an agent of transformation and mission for Israel.

The first three chapters of Samuel 1 tell the story of Hannah's anguish, the gift of a son, and Samuel's early years at home and in the temple. After dedicating Samuel to the Lord and leaving him with Eli, Hannah offers a canticle of praise to God as the sovereign deliverer

who lifts up the lowly, such as herself, a formerly barren woman. Samuel ministers in the temple and grows in all facets of human development through his childhood and is called by God as a child. The story is a rich one of imperfect people used by God as actors in a much greater redemption story that is especially relevant for releasing children to discover God's purpose.

I wish to explore this narrative further to discover how God works in the life of Samuel; how Samuel discovers God's purposes for his own life; and how adults rightly value and nurture him as an agent of transformation. We glean five key principles through Samuel's story:

1. Children are to be holistically nurtured throughout childhood;
2. Children are to be active participants in worship and service to God;
3. Children can be called by God and hear his voice;
4. God uses whom he will, including those on the margins of life; and
5. The supreme story of history and life is God's and we are to envision and empower children as participants in that greater Story.

Children Are to Be Holistically Nurtured Throughout Childhood

For those of us who work in Christian NGOs promoting holistic ministry with children, Luke 2:52 is a fundamental supporting scripture verse. It reads, "And Jesus grew in ***wisdom*** and ***stature***, and in *favor with God and man*" (emphasis mine, NIV). This brief sentence covers all of the areas of human development: intellectual, physical, spiritual, and psycho-social. We know very little about Jesus's childhood, yet from this verse we can infer that his development was well-rounded and that he grew in all ways, just as any healthy child should grow.

Holistic ministry is grounded in the foundational truth of the incarnation as proclaimed in the ancient creeds of the church. Most theological statements tend to concentrate on the incarnation of Jesus as a human, but are less likely to explore the implications of Jesus' development over time [and through childhood]. Jesus not only came in human form, but in the same manner and timing of all of humanity. He, too, was conceived (albeit uniquely), born as an infant, grew throughout childhood and adolescence into adulthood. The incarnation is far reaching, even to the redemption of all of creation, including the whole of human development through the lifespan.[1]

As stated by Ireanaeus, "He was made an infant for infants, sanctifying infancy; a child among children, sanctifying childhood . . . a young man among young men, becoming an example to them, and sanctifying them to the Lord".[2]

The Luke passage is not the only one to draw attention to the growth of the whole child. 1 Samuel 2:26 parallels this description of Jesus's childhood[3]: "And the boy Samuel continued to grow in stature and in favor with the Lord and with people" (NIV). Healthy growth requires awareness and nurture of all aspects of the child's development. And the passage is placed in juxtaposition to the wickedness of Eli's sons, the young priests of Shiloh.

Research confirms that programs that combine interventions to address children's needs holistically are more effective than programs that address an isolated area of development.[4] Such care needs to begin early, ideally prenatally, and continue with consistency and emotional warmth for many years. Samuel *continued* to grow,

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[1] S.H. Greener, "Children in the Church: Our Ministry Application Based on Biblical Principles and Sound Social Science." Missiology Lectures on Children and the Mission of God (Pasadena, CA: Fuller Theological Seminary, November 8-9, 2006), 1.

[2] H. Bettenson, ed., *The Early Christian Fathers: A selection from the writings of the Fathers from St. Clement of Rome to St. Athanasius* (Oxford, UK: Oxford University Press, 1978), 80.

[3] J.A. Fitzmyer, *The Gospel According to Luke (I-IX)* (Garden City, NY: Doubleday & Company Inc, 1981), 446.

[4] Greener, *op cit.*

emphasizing the process and continuation of development throughout childhood.

Although parents, programs, and specific ministries can be mindful of holistic ministry, we learn from Samuel's story that the outcome of nurture is the work of the Holy Spirit and not dependent on adult perfection or biological relationship. In gratitude Hannah gives her young son over to the temple to be raised by a father with significant shortcomings who had failed miserably in the rearing of his own biological sons. Yet God uses this imperfect man to care for young Samuel. As stated in 1 Samuel 3:19, "the Lord was with Samuel as he grew up, and he let none of Samuel's words fall to the ground" (NIV). Brueggemann[5] notes that "Samuel's growth has been nurtured by Eli. It has been governed from the beginning, however, by Yahweh. … Eli himself is inept but not evil." Yet God used Eli to journey alongside Samuel as a nurturer, model, teacher, and support.

Thus, a tension arises in holistic ministry with children. Adults are to be mindful of children as whole and fully-human persons and have a responsibility to ensure quality and holistic childcare. If ministry efforts are targeted on only one or two areas of development (most typically, the spiritual and/or physical areas), some caring adult must maintain responsibility and advocacy for complementary care so that children's growth and development are holistically addressed (e.g., in the intellectual and psycho-social areas as well). This may require not only investing in biological parents but casting vision for the Church to see all of her children as a community responsibility. We do not need to be perfect and when successful, we are not to take inordinate pride in the outcomes of holistic childcare; rather, we must recognize that positive outcomes are the work of the Holy Spirit. The holistic nurture of children is not done solely for the sake of healthy development but to allow children to be in a place of discovery of God's purposes for their lives. And part of that purpose is to worship and serve God (Psalm 8, Matthew 21:15-16).

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[5] W. Brueggemann, *First and Second Samuel Interpretation: A Bible Commentary for Teaching and Preaching.* (Louisville, KY: John Knox Press, 1990), 22-23.

Children Are to Actively Participate in Service and Worship to God

Once weaned, Samuel was taken to the temple at Shiloh by his parents to be apprenticed as a priest by Eli, likely when he was little more than 3 years of age (the approximate age of weaning and when a boy's name was entered into the genealogical records, 2 Chronicles 31:16). Other than his parents' desire to return him to God in gratitude for the gift that Samuel was to them, there is no indication that young Samuel had any particular gifts for the priest hood.

Yet, in 1 Samuel, chapter two, we are told that "the boy ministered before the Lord under Eli the priest" (v. 11), that he [Samuel] "was ministering before the Lord – a boy wearing a linen ephod" (v. 18) and that "the boy Samuel grew up in the presence of the Lord" (v. 21). 1 Samuel 3:3 repeats that "the boy Samuel ministered before the Lord under Eli." The author is making clear to the reader that Samuel is not a passive receptacle of adult input, but an active participant in worship and service to God under the supervision of Eli the priest.

I do wish to say this carefully, but feel it is important to ask questions about children's participation in worship in our churches. In many traditions, the greatest segregating demographic characteristic in the church is age. Children are in their own Sunday school, their own worship service, their own youth groups and may have little to no intergenerational interaction except as a cute, sentimental presence for a Christmas program or to sing a choral selection for a special occasion. For example, when a church congregation grows too large for worship space, often the first way to adapt to this reality is to remove the children from the sanctuary to give adequate space to adults.

A few questions are offered for reflection on our own churches and ministries. How are children's gifts of praise and worship recognized and nurtured? Are girl children, as well as boy children, viewed as bearers of God's image in such a way that they can be seen as full recipients of gifts from God and participants in the life of the church? Are children considered to be full participants in the church

or passive receptacles of adult ministry efforts? Do generations within the church have opportunity to engage and learn with and from each other? Is it surprising that recent U.S. research indicates that a number of teens and young adults leave the church because they have not been fully integrated into the intergenerational body of believers?[6]

It is challenging to see how children can be agents of transformation and mission if they are sequestered in certain parts of the church building and from much of Church life. I assert that releasing children to discover God's purpose and allowing them to grow as transformational agents of God's mission requires that their gifts and callings be nurtured and affirmed as they are encouraged to fully participate in worship and service to God within the Church, just as Samuel did. Children's spirituality is dependent upon their "relationships with a human community of significance and care, with non-human creation and with sources of transcendence and/or the sacred".[7] Fostering deep spiritual development requires full and deep integration into the intergenerational family of God.

Children Can Be Called by God and Hear His Voice

Now Samuel did not yet know the Lord: The word of the Lord had not yet been revealed to him. A third time the Lord called, "Samuel!" And Samuel got up and went to Eli and said, "Here I am; you called me." Then Eli realized that the Lord was calling the boy (1 Samuel 3:7-8, NIV).

This part of the story is perhaps the most familiar to us. Samuel has been asleep and believes that he has heard Eli call for him in the darkness. Three times he rises to attend to what he believes to be Eli's voice and by the third time, Eli, perhaps exasperated with the

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[6] D. Kinnaman, *You Lost Me: Why Young Christians Are Leaving Church...and Rethinking Faith* (Baker Books, 2011).

[7] Joyce A. Mercer, "Capitalizing on children's spirituality: Parental anxiety, children as consumers, and the marketing of spirituality" in *International Journal of Children's Spirituality*, Vol.11 No.1 April 2006: 23-33.

interruptions of his rest, realizes that Samuel has indeed heard a voice – not Eli's, but God's call. Although Samuel is young Eli does not doubt that God can speak to the boy and gently instructs Samuel to return to his bed and if he hears God's call again to respond, "Speak Lord, for your servant is listening" (1 Samuel 3:9).

As one biblical scholar asserts, "This story is about vocation or calling".[8] Samuel journeys forward into the calling God has for his life by hearing God's voice, truly listening, and responding. Yet, he needs a nurturing adult at this time to help him discern God's voice. Without Eli's caring counsel, Samuel would likely remain only confused by a voice in the night that may be no more than a waking dream.

It is crucial to recognize and affirm the interdependence of Eli and Samuel, one that should be reflected among generations in the household of God. "Samuel is available for this communication from God and perfectly responsive (v. 10). Moreover he is fully supported by Eli, who is now dependent upon him (v 18). . . . Patient, caring Eli instructs Samuel in his response to God (vv. 9-10) . . . . Young Samuel is completely dependent on knowing Eli".[9] Samuel and Eli need each other for God's voice to be heard. Eli requires great humility to allow Samuel to be the bearer of God's word. Not only is a child that bearer, not one of Eli's own biological sons, but one adopted into his household. Eli must live in a new reality that acknowledges that God can speak through this boy and the words that Samuel has to give may not be good news for Eli or his descendants.

Like Eli, wise adults believe that God can speak to children and are willing to heed children's voices, even when their words create discomfort. "'What was it he [God] said to you?'" Eli asked. 'Do not hide it from me. May God deal with you, be it ever so severely, if you hide from me anything he told you.' So Samuel told him everything, hiding nothing from him. Then Eli said, 'He is the Lord; let him do what is good in his eyes'" (I Sam 3:17 –18).

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[8] Francesca A. Murphy, *1 Samuel* (Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos Press, 2010), 27.

[9] Brueggemann, *op cit.,* 25.

Eli believed that what Samuel heard was from God and that it was a confirmation of the earlier prophecy of the downfall of the house of Eli. I wonder how often children do have something to share that needs to be heard, yet it is minimized, ignored or seen as too naïve for consideration. In a guileless way, children and youth can see injustice and pain and often call out the obvious, the sinfulness, and the hypocrisy of the world when adult hearts have become hardened or overwhelmed by great need and the sheer complexity of problems.

In a recent interview with a veteran pastor who was raised in a tradition that does not give much credence to dreams and visions, I was told of his call to ministry at the age of 8. In the middle of the night, he saw a child-sized angel standing by his bed. It did not speak, but held an open bible in its outstretched hands with a burning candle standing upon the book, illuminating the pages. The pastor said that he knew that somehow his calling was to bring light to God's word and that his life would be a light for God's people. He said, "Even as a child, I knew the difference between having a dream and being awake and I was awake, not dreaming." That calling was affirmed over the years by adults in his life, but not because he told them of his vision, which he saw as too sacred to share with anyone at that time, some 45 years ago. Even now, he has only told that story to a select few and has found it easier to tell to African colleagues, who do not find a child experiencing a call from God in the form of a vision to be too difficult to believe.

Again, some questions for reflection are needed. Do we believe that children can hear from God? Are we available to nurture their hearts and help them discern when God is calling to them? Do we really want to listen to what they are hearing from the Lord? Are we willing to listen if the words mean relinquishing control of ministries that we have come to see as "ours"? The posture of humility, recognizing that the greater story is one of God's redemption and not about personal success, requires the attitude of stewardship of ministries, missions, and children's lives, holding lightly to what is God's so that the greater story is primary.

God Uses Whom He Will, Including Those on the Margins of Life

The story of Samuel encourages the reader to embrace the notion that all children are to be regarded as gifts from God. We know Samuel's story because of who he became – the leader of a nation. Yet, when she prays for a child, Hannah does not know that her son will be anyone of importance: the anointer of Saul and David as kings, the first of the prophets (Acts 3:24) and the last of the judges (Acts 13:20). Nor does she know that she will ever bear other children. Yet she freely gave her gift-child back to God to be nurtured by Eli.

Her gratitude for the gift of Samuel is expressed in her song of thanksgiving (1 Samuel 2:2-11), which mirrors Mary's canticle of praise after the angel tells her she will bear the Messiah. Hannah's prayer is not focused on the baby or herself, but on the attributes of her powerful God: deliverer, all-knowing, holy one, provider, and one who sets the foundations of the earth. Her song reminds the reader that it is God who raises up and brings low as he wills: "It is not by strength that one prevails; those who oppose the Lord will be broken. The Most High will thunder from heaven; the Lord will judge the ends of the earth" (1 Samuel 2:9b-10b, NIV). The song of praise celebrates that only God can feed the hungry, give children to the barren, make alive, exalt the lowly, raise the poor from the dust, and lift the needy from the ash heap (vs. 5-8).

Hannah is celebrating that God can use a barren woman, one of little value in Old Testament culture, a woman on the margin of society. Although her husband, Elkanah, is of the tribe of Levi (the priestly line), he has no future with a barren wife[10] (Brueggemann, 1990) and Hannah is reminded of her situation constantly by the mocking of Peninnah, Elkanah's other wife. Her song is a witness to Yahweh, who can transform "barrenness to birth, vexation to praise, isolation to worship.[11]

[10] Brueggemann, *op cit*.
[11] *Ibid*., 12.

Hannah's song is an exhortation that it is only the Lord's favour that empowers anyone. If we look only to the powerful, the rich, and the connected, we are proud and arrogant (1 Samuel 2:3). The implication is that all people, including children, have potential to be actors in God's covenant story and that a proper attitude toward them focuses ultimately on this sacred role as the one giving value.

Societies have long held to differing views of children and childhood, which are reflected in Christian theology and in the social sciences. "One of the more colorful taxonomies is in the area of childhood anthropology, where Lancy[12] alliterates concepts of children as 'cherubs, chattel, and changelings', noting how societies often simultaneously see children as innocents, little devils, and commodities that either contribute to or drain financial resources of families".[13]

Theologian Marcia Bunge has long argued for complex views and theologies of childhood, allowing children to be multifaceted, fully human beings. Bunge[14] asserts that views of children need to be held in tension: as gifts of God and sources of joy; as sinful creatures and moral agents; as developing beings who need instruction and guidance; as fully human and made in the image of God; as models of faith and sources of revelation; and as orphans, neighbours, and strangers in need of justice and compassion.[15]

The landmark cross-cultural surveys on the value of children completed in 1984 and 2007[16] indicate that there are three main

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[12] D. Lancy, *The Anthropology of Childhood: Cherubs, Chattel, Changelings* (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 2008).

[13] S. H. Greener, (June 2012), *Whose Childhood? Global Experiences of Children-at-Risk and Spiritual Formation*. Children's Spirituality Conference: Christian Perspectives. Concordia University, Chicago – forthcoming.

[14] M. Bunge, "The dignity and complexity of children: constructing Christian theologies of childhood" in *Nurturing Child and Adolescent Spirituality: Perspectives from the World's Religious Traditions*, eds. K.M. Yust, A.N. Johnson, S.E. Sasso and E.C. Roehlkepartain (Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield Publishers, Inc, 2006).

[15] Greener, 2013 - forthcoming

[16] J.W. Berry, Y.H. Poortinga, S.M. Breugelmans and A. Chasiotis, *Cross-Cultural Psychology: Research and Applications* (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge

reasons that parents choose to have children with prioritization of these reasons varying somewhat by culture. The first reason is economic or utilitarian, which focuses on the material benefits of having children, whether that is contribution to the household economy and completion of chores or ensuring financial security in old age. The second reason is psychological or emotional, indicating that parents have children for joy, fun, companionship, pride, and to give parents a sense of accomplishment. The third reason is social or normative, meaning that parents gain social acceptance and social status by having children. Although none of these reasons is inherently negative, the focus of the child's value is as a means of gratification of parental desires and adult needs.

Many of us are parents and may see our biological children as categorically different than other children who may be the beneficiaries of our ministry efforts. Few of us would be willing to relinquish our child to be raised by another. And I am in no way suggesting that it is preferable that a parent give his or her child to others to be raised. For participants in this conference, myself included, there is typically great investment in our own children and we often expect stellar academic performance and entry into the right colleges and prestigious careers so that we may have pride in their accomplishments, which confirms our performance as parents. Some concerning trends for middle class families around the world include:

Greater investment of financial resources, time, and emotional energy in children by many parents… with more monitoring and 'over-supervision' of children… [and] increased pressure on adolescents' school performance. Fewer siblings and cousins mean fewer opportunities to acquire spiritual concepts and skills through these relationships, including empathy and spiritual nurturance. In addition, family mobility, dissolution, and reconstitution may impair spiritual socialization.[17]

University Press, 2011).

[17] S. Verma & M. Sta. Maria, "The changing global context of adolescent spirituality" in *The Handbook of Spiritual Development in Childhood and Adolescence*, eds. E.C. Roehlkepartain, P.E. King, L. Wagener and P.L. Benson

Our investment does not necessarily result in the outcomes we desire. Spiritual connectedness and discovery of calling in God's greater story may be lost in the competition with other parental agendas. It is all too easy for adults to be swept up by societal and cultural pressures and for priorities to be lost. The question God asks of Eli could be asked of any of us: "'Why do you honor your sons more than me?'" (1 Samuel 2:29).

In contrast, we have Hannah, the biological mother, acknowledging that the story of her life and that of her gift-son are ultimately God's story and we have Eli who has no biological connection to the boy. Although biological parents have a greater responsibility for their children (1 Timothy 3:5; Ephesians 6:4), a singular attitude toward children as primarily gifts of God and players in God's redemption story has a biblical foundation. New Testament themes of adoption into the household of faith and unity through doing the will of God indicate that non-biological connections are now primary indicators of belonging.[18] All believers are now part of one's family and merit the same value and treatment as a biological child. As Chukwu asserts, "The new family of God (Church) embraces the whole human race without any iota of discrimination on the basis of race, sex, gender, culture, language or class",[19] and might I add that age is not a factor that enhances or diminishes one's value within the family of God. Given this new family relationship, the adults in the family of God must be cautious to make decisions that do not harm our spiritual children by favoring our biological daughters and sons. Further, they must make decisions that honor spiritual children as an integral part of God's community

Valuing children as gifts from God and vessels of divine purpose cultivates a relationship where the caregiver is the temporary custodian or steward of the life of a young person who is discovering

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(Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage Publications, 2006), 127.

[18] U. Schnelle, *Theology of the New Testament* (Baker Academic, 2009).

[19] D.O. Chukwu, *The Extended Family in Africa as a Model for the Church: Toward an Ecclesio-Missioncentric Theology of Inculturation for the Evangelization of the Igbos in Nigeria* (Proquest Publishing, 2008), 186.

God's purpose for his or her life. The word 'steward' must be carefully defined, so as to minimize perceptions of adults as managers of children and children as possessions or human capital. It may be helpful to borrow from the theology of environmental stewardship to ensure that God is paramount in our understanding. "The main point of the term, in Christian usage, is the steward's responsibility to God".[20] Christian stewards recognize that they, too, are created beings and that God has continual involvement with creation. Thus, "humans should care for creation within the context of God's own caring for it, not in place of God's caring for creation".[21] A faithful steward functions in community with fellow creatures and God, and must act in harmony with God's justice, compassion, and mercy.

The attitudes of both Hannah and Eli toward Samuel are instructive of proper posture as stewards of the life of a child, recognizing that the sovereign God gives adults the opportunity to participate in children's lives as a gift and blessing, not as a right. Children are not possessions, consuming units or programming targets to enhance adult egos. Adults, who act as stewards, recognize that children are gifts from God and full members of God's community. As in the parable of the faithful servant, a steward of children is mindful that God, the true owner, could return at any time and it is the joyful duty of the steward to be worthy of the responsibility entrusted to her (Matthew 24:42-51; Mark 13:32-37; and Luke 12:35-48).

What might it look like if adults saw their nurturing role with children as one of stewardship? And as a mandate not only for biological children but any child that God brings into their sphere of influence, affirming that all children can be adopted into the household of God as full heirs of the eternal promise? Nurturing a child then becomes an opportunity because we do not know who could be a Samuel (or Miriam or Mary, the Mother of Jesus). The

[20] R. Bauckham, "Stewardship in question" in *Bible and Ecology: Rediscovering the Community of Creation* (Waco, TX: Baylor University Press, 2010), 1-36, 1.

[21] *Ibid*., 8.

surprise of God's choosing whomever He will to lift up and to be called by the power of the Holy Spirit, frees us to look beyond our own biological connections, our own networks, ethnicity, social class, church body or any other boundary to recognize that the possibility of calling and transformational participation in Kingdom work lies in every child.

Stewardship implies not only valuing children as transformational participants, but also recognizing their vulnerability and protecting them from undue risk, harm, pressure or coercion. Adults already control many aspects of participation: resources, agenda, topics under discussion, process, and often selection of who gets to participate.[22] For this reason, non-governmental organizations have developed guidelines for protection for participating children that are expressed in the form of rights that may be worth reflection:

Children have rights to be listened to, to freely express their views on all matters that affect them, to freedom of expression, thought and association, and of access to information; Participation should promote the best interests of children and enhance their personal development; All children have equal rights to participation, without discrimination; All children have the right to be protected from manipulation, violence, abuse and exploitation.[23]

The Church may frame these concerns in different language – that of love, care, concern and advocacy – yet the goals remain similar: inviting children and youth, including those on the margins of society, to participate in matters that concern them. For Christian children, the goals are expanded to theological and missiological concerns, recognizing that God includes children as full members of the family of God and invites them to participate in the life of the Church and the Missio Dei.

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[22] Inter-Agency Working Group on Children's Participation (IAWGCP) *Minimum Standards for Consulting with Children* (Bangkok, Thailand: Inter-Agency Working Group on Children's Participation (IAWGCP), ECPAT International, Knowing Children, Plan International, Save the Children Alliance, UNICEF EAPRO and World Vision, 2007), http://plan-international.org/files/global/publications/participation/ministandards.pdf.

[23] *Ibid.* 12

The Supreme Story of History and Life is God's and We Are to Envision and Empower Children as Participants in that Greater Story

The story of Samuel involves many players and all are "creatures of God's sovereignty and agents of God's intended future".[24] The greater story is one of redemption and those who are called by God play a part, big or small, in that narrative. In humility, we must remember that "Yahweh is the one who has the *power to transform* and the *willingness to intervene* (emphasis is Bruggemann's) on behalf of the powerless. Both qualities are required. Power to transform without willingness to intervene ends in haughty transcendence. Willingness to intervene without power to transform ends in a pitiful sentimentality".[25] If adults believe that either we or the organizations that we create or our churches have the power to transform, we are guilty of pride. If we intervene in children's lives, especially those at risk, without introducing them to God's power, we offer little but pity. It is in introducing them to God's Story and helping them discern their calling in that story, that we allow them to shift from *objects of pity* to *people of promise* (emphasis is mine) who play a role in kingdom transformation.

The biblical narrative repeatedly and consistently involves children as agents of transformation and mission. In a thorough review by White[26], numerous key child characters are present throughout the biblical redemption story. To name just a few: Joseph (a teenaged dreamer), Benjamin (an agent of reconciliation), Miriam (the clever girl who saved her baby brother from death and engineered her mother to be his caregiver), Moses (adopted into a place of power and then able to use those gifts and connections to free Israel), David (boy slayer of a giant), Namaan's servant girl (a bold

[24] Brueggemann, *op cit*, 10.

[25] *Ibid*., 17.

[26] K.J. White, "A Little Child Will Lead Them: Rediscovering Children at the Heart of God's Mission" (2012), http://www.childtheology.org/new/docuploads/A%20little%20child%20will%20lead%20them.pdf (accessed December 2012).

messenger to a general), Josiah (the boy king), Jeremiah (chosen by God as a child) and of course, Jesus. In the story of Samuel, we are reminded that a child can be the designated agent of mission for a nation. The people hear and understand that "Yahweh is already at work providing for new, godly leadership for his people".[27] Overlooking the possibility of children and youth having a role in the redemption story is not only short-sighted; it does not reflect the biblical pattern of God using children to achieve his purposes. As in the case of Samuel, when adults fail, God can and will speak to and through a child.

Contemporary Applications

The story of Samuel in many ways mirrors the principles and cautions of youth participation initiatives. Children are vulnerable and need stewards in their lives who protect them. Yet vulnerability lies in tension with children as gifts.

Secular non-governmental organizations have actively sought child and youth participation, consulting them on issues that affect their well-being and rights. It is good and right to allow children and youth to speak into solutions for global problems that have been created by prior generations. Decisions made for immediate gratification and profit rarely consider the long-term effects and the burden that is passed to the young. Although progress has been made in addressing some global problems, such as infant mortality and access to primary education, much remains to be done. The global community recognizes that "building the capacity of and creating sustained partnerships with young people are crucial strategies to achieving the Millennium Development goals that have not been fully realized by the international community".[28]

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[27] Dale R. Davis, *Looking on the Heart, Volume 1: Expositions of 1 Samuel 1-14* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 1994), 31.

[28] *Youth and the Millennium Development Goals: Challenges and Opportunities for Implementation* (United Nations, 2005)

However, such participation strategies require much more than a token presence at high profile events. Battaini-Dragoni,[29] in sharing lessons learned from the European experience at the 2010 World Youth Conference, reminds us that investing in youth is a long-term process and that they need to be equipped through social and non-formal learning opportunities.[30] They must be involvement from the beginning in setting policies rather than expecting them to support what adults have already decided. At times the temptation can be to ask the opinion of youth without adequate equipping and context and then to be disappointed with the response, resulting in a dismissal of the ideas of the young as ineffectual. It is true that adults have more education and experience, yet they risk becoming cynical or trapped in outmoded thought patterns, professional jargon and solution gridlock. Although children and youth lack the education and experience, they may bring a renewed zeal and idealism, and a fresh look at longstanding problems.

The Church could be ahead of secular non-governmental organizations in the area of child participation. With the rich biblical tradition of child participation, Jesus' exhortations to see children as Kingdom models, and recent scholarly work in child theology, the Church has strong foundations for including children in mission. Most importantly, their presence affirms that the larger story is God's and that we are not to limit who He may use to speak; rather, we are to create opportunities to cultivate spirituality and leadership from the cradle.

Conclusion

The most significant task of each human is discovering one's small, personal story and how it fits into the great narrative of God's

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http://tig.phpwebhosting.com/themes/mdg/YouthMDG.pdf, xv.

[29] B. Battaini-Dragoni, "Panel on Social Justice and Security," World Youth Conference, Leon Guanajuato, Mexico (August 23-27, 2010).

[30] *Ibid*., 4.

mission. Not all stories are noteworthy like Samuel's story, but then only Samuel was called to Samuel's story. Each child's small story is interwoven into the greater God story in a way that adults may not know or see.

In human essence and as agents of transformation, children are not that different from grown-ups. Yet, the difference of being older creates a responsibility for adults toward and with children for their holistic nurture, preparation, empowerment and protection. And that responsibility requires that children be present, active, included and truly heard.

For this reason, I am reluctant to suggest specific ways for children and youth to engage in God's mission. That conversation requires children and youth to be present from the beginning, and we need them to help extrapolate from research findings and to join with us in engaging with Scripture.

Releasing children to discover God's purpose is a millstone responsibility. Fully recognizing the dignity and humanity of children who are stamped with God's image requires that a child be more than a member of a missiological target group to bolster conversion statistics or a human resource to be manipulated to achieve adult agendas.

May we look forward to intergenerational conversations on mission and transformation with delight and anticipation. And may we find the strength and courage to name and nourish children's gifts, steward their stories with compassion, and be willing and able to see their place and hear their voice in the Missio Dei.

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RESPONSE 1

Children and Youth as Agents of Transformation and Mission: Child Participation

BY ENRIQUE PINEDO

Reflections on the Convention of the Rights of the Child

More than two decades have gone by since the ratification of the Convention on the Rights of the Child and "Child Participation" is one of the less developed Rights and is the most controversial in practice.

Alejandro Cussiánovich, a leading children's participation activist in Latin America asks:

> Why is grown-up society so delayed in recognizing boys and girls as actors, as social, economic, ethical, political and cultural subjects? Or why does the adult world resist recognizing children as co-participants of all that affects them? There is no answer to these questions without probing the representations, ideas, and conceptual categories that underlie the manner of relations between older and emerging generations.[1]

Throughout history there have been diverse concepts of childhood, and it is difficult for the adult world to recognize boys and girls as actors and subjects of transformation. In his book, *History of Childhood, a History Without Words*, Egle Becchi, in trying to understand this diversity and complexity, asks:

> What does it mean to write the history of childhood? … The more we go back in time, the more we find that the footprints we

[1] Alejandro Cussiánovich, *Ensayos sobre la Infancia: Sujeto de Derechos y Protagonista (Essays on Children: Rights Subject and Protagonist)* (Lima, Perú: IFEJANT, 2006), 7.

encounter are fleeting, not because the child has maintained their own role, but simply because the concept of childhood is diverse.[2]

In the twentieth century, with the Declaration of the Rights of the Child of 1959, society took an important step in the definition of childhood by conceptualizing a child as vulnerable and in need of special protection. Three decades later, the Convention on the Rights of the Child (in 1989) proposes another important definition for children as subjects of rights.

Camilo Bacáres, in his book, *Towards the Hermeneutics of the Convention on the Rights of the Child*, states about the childhood rights of participation:

> "The rights grouped in this block are where one can see historical changes for childhood; given that, for the first time in Western history, children are legally recognized as subjects of enunciation and self identity. Furthermore, children receive these approved first rights by consensus and belated: the rights of the first generation, configured in the eighteenth century. Rights that are agreed upon as necessary for peace and justice in addition to the social, economic and cultural rights the majority of States of the world agreed upon in the Universal Declaration of Human Rights of 1948 for all human beings." [3]

These childhood rights of participation are truly historical, they arrived a little late, but in the end, they affirm the child as a human being; making clear that participation is a fundamental right of citizenship.

This new paradigm has not been easy to assimilate by the adult world (including the Church). Although there have been some advances, the truth is that the implementation of the right of participation continues to be a challenge for society.

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[2] Mentioned by Alejandro Cussiánovich in *Paradigmas de la culturas de infancia como formas de poder (Paradigms of childhood cultures as forms of power)* (Lima, Perú: IFEJANT, 2010), 10 . [Bechi Egle, Storia dell'infanzia, storia senza parole?, 1996]

[3] Camilo Bacáres, *Una Aproximación Hermenéutica a la Convención sobre los Derechos del Niño (A Hermeneutic Approach to the Convention on the Rights of the Child)* (Lima, Perú: IFEJANT, 2012), 5.

Dr. Green says at the end of her paper:

> In foundational thinking, the Church could be ahead of secular non-governmental organizations in the area of child participation. With the rich biblical tradition of child participation in important narratives, Jesus' exhortations to see children as models of his Kingdom and recent scholarly work in child theology, the Church has strong foundations for including children in mission.

This statement is correct. While the majority of nations don't include boys, girls, or adolescents as actors in their history, God intentionally includes boys, girls, and adolescents in his divine history:

1. God intentionally includes boys, girls, and adolescents in his divine history

> … "The history of the majority of nations around the world only makes reference to boys, girls, and adolescents as a large and general social group, but often not as individual persons, identified by their proper name. On the other hand, throughout the history of God's people – the nation of Israel – we can see many boys, girls, and adolescents mentioned by name and at the same time presented as actors and protagonists of that history." [4]

2. Boys, girls and adolescents are persons and individuals with dignity, created in God's image

Another foundational principle for the Church is that the children's dignity does not come from the Convention on the Rights of the Child, but from God.

Girls and boys are people created in God's image; therefore, they are individuals of worth and dignity. As any human being, their

[4] Enrique Pinedo, *Niñez, Adolescencia y Misión Integral: Nuevos desafíos a la educación teológica en America Latina (Children, Adolescents and Integral Mission: New challenges to theological education in Latin America)* (Buenos Aires: Kairos Foundation, 2012), 24.

dignity comes from God's sovereign act, as their Creator (Genesis 1:26-28). Both, their rights and worth have not been acquired nor conceived by any human power or convention, but they come from God and are inherent to them by creation.[5]

3. Children are protagonists of history and active agents in Gd's mission

Dr. Green described five key principles to help us understand the subject (*see the paper above*). In the first four principles, Dr. Green shows how Eli, with all his imperfections, was important for Samuel's holistic development, to show him to serve God at the temple and minister in front of God. He helped Samuel identify his spiritual gifts and how to recognize God's voice. I would like to highlight two more principles from Samuel's story here:

a. Children can deliver messages in God's name and adults can be apt to listen.

   God gives Samuel His word making Samuel a participant in the history of missions. Not only is Samuel's voice heard and space made for him to participate, but God also takes a message to an adult through a child. This topic is very important, given that being listened to is not the same as being heard. Adults should be willing to hear children' voices, recognizing them as persons with the rights to listen and be heard. God uses a child prophet to give a message to his servant Eli and this adult was willing to listen.

b. Children and adults need to have an interdependence or co-participation approach in God's mission.

   Dr. Green noted "It is crucial to recognize and affirm the interdependence of Eli and Samuel, an interdependence that should be reflected among generations in the household of God."

[5] Segura, Pinedo, Figueroa, *Los Niños y las Niñas en los Propósitos de Dios: Aportes para un marco bíblico en Niñez*, *(Boys and Girls in God's Purpose: Input to a Bible- Theological Framework on Childhood)* (Buenos Aires: Movimiento Latinoamericano Juntos con la Niñez y la Juventud, 2004), 3.

Reflections from Scripture on Co-participation

It is necessary to a new childhood culture and a new adulthood culture. The Scriptures are our guide for changing our concepts regarding childhood and their participation in God's work. Here are some other Biblical principles in the field of co-participation that I'd like to suggest.

1. Co-Participation: The Mentoring Factor

Adults have the duty to mentor children according to their age and development so that they can participate in an informed manner, knowing how to formulate an opinion, use their voice, identify their spiritual gifts and use them in God's and their neighbors' service. Eli mentored and instructed Samuel so he could recognize God's voice, how to serve in God's presence and speak in God's name.

2. Co-Participation: The Opportunity Factor

In order for children's participation to be possible adults should use the authority that has been bestowed upon them to generate such opportunities. Eli also gave young Samuel the opportunity to serve in God's temple ministering before the Lord wearing a linen ephod.

The story of an adolescent David can also help us with this co-participation concept. In the David vs. Goliath story, "one could criticize Saul regarding several aspects of his life, but in this particular case it should be recognized, because as a leader, Saul gave an adolescent the great opportunity to make history in God's Mission."[6] Promoting participation does not seek to break with adult authority but rather to establish new ways in which to exercise it.

[6] Enrique Pinedo, *Niñez, Adolescencia y Misión Integral: Nuevos desafíos a la educación teológica en America Latina" (Children, Adolescents and Integral Mission: New challenges to theological education in Latin America)* (Buenos Aires: Kairos Foundation, 2012), 28.

3. Co-Participation: The Sling Factor

When David confronted Goliath, "he refused to use tools of war that the adults use (Saul's armor), but crystallized his victory with a sling, a tool he was familiar with, that was proper to his age and as pastor of sheep."[7] A latent danger is asking children to participate by adopting attitudes, actions and discourses that are not their own and correspond to the adult world. David knew his sling well and was comfortable with it; it was the best way that he could serve and honor God in this context.

In Latin America's past, some Christian (and secular) NGO's promoted participation initiatives where "participation" was synonymous with political actions. They participated by marching in the streets, holding posters advocating for some just cause, even giving elaborate speeches as 'mini-politicians.' One of these NGO's decided to ask the children if this was how they would like to express themselves. The response was "no." They would much rather express themselves with music, street art, technology and other create ways, appropriate for their age.

4. Co-Participation: "When Your Children Ask You" Factor

Adults should affirm that children's Christian formation at home and at church must allow for and encourage their participation as active collaborators in God's purpose for the world, and to develop their full potential as human beings. In the Old Testament God established some ceremonies and reminders that took place in the family and at the communal level.

The same question: "When your children ask you" was asked intentionally as part of Easter Celebration (Exodus 12:26-27), in the celebration of the consecration of firstborns (Exodus 13:14-15), and the remembrance of the twice stones of the Jordan crossing (Joshua 4:6-7).

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[7] Enrique Pinedo, "Voice of the Youth & Child Participation: A "United with Children and Youth's Movement" journey", Micah Network Conference, Switzerland, October 2012.

> "In this way, new generations were included creatively in the liturgy and took an active role in it, in a way that is appropriate for their age. They did what boys and girls do best: ask questions in order to satisfy their innate curiosity, thirsty for answers." [8]

This factor has to be an intentional objective that adults need to pursue: to look for ways for children to be creatively involved in the family devotions, ministry and life of the church.

[8] *Ibid*., 19.

RESPONSE 2

Children as Agents of Transformation

BY C. ROSALEE VELLOSO EWELL

"And Samuel continued to grow…" What can we learn from this narrative about holistic child care and the ministry of children?

What did Samuel grow into? When we talk about the full humanity of children and young people, what do we mean? What is 'fullness' in this sense?

In our churches and in the wider world today, there is the danger of seeing children's humanity as merely a mini version of adults; it is the danger of thinking of children as 'agents of transformation' as a lesser or smaller version of our own agency. However, agency and empowerment for mission in Christian mission and theology have to be about Jesus. If we lose Jesus, we have lost the whole point of the story.

What is brilliant about Eli's response and behaviour in this narrative is his wisdom and his humility to step aside and to let Samuel grow in the way God wants him to grow, keeping in mind that this might not necessarily be the way Eli would have chosen for Samuel to grow and develop into the priesthood.

In 1 Corinthians 13:12 Paul says "we see through a glass dimly"… "but we do see Jesus" states the author to the Hebrews (Hebrews 2:9). "We see through a glass dimly" – this is humility and knowing that we do not have God's view of things, that we do not have all the answers or the plans or necessarily the best strategies. We do not have all the power, but "we do see Jesus" – this is humanity in its fullness and in all its power.

It is important to keep these two perspectives in check – humility and humanity – because when we talk about the humanity of children or of adults, we have to talk about Jesus. Jesus – not ourselves or our idealized version of a church leader – is the standard of humanity.

Hebrews makes explicit the upside-down character of our humanity: we do not know what it means to be human apart from Jesus. So as we try to live as a missionary people it matters a great deal what Jesus we are embodying. As agents of transformation and mission, as agents of reconciliation, whether children or adults, we must follow Jesus.

In our mentoring and leadership programmes, what Jesus are we teaching? In Latin America there are many faces, many types of Jesus – from the baby Che Guevara to the cute little baby in Mother Mary's arms. If our work with and for children and youth is about embodying Christ and witnessing to Jesus in a troubled and violent world, is it the Jesus of the gospels that we bear with us? Do we have the humility to step aside like Eli, to confess our own mistakes, and to listen to the ways in which God wants to raise this child or these children in the image of his Son?

The story of Samuel and Eli remind us that we are not the ones who decide who is an agent of transformation. Yet we are called upon to listen, to be alert to God's voice and to his command. To do this listening we need one another. It takes the Christian community together to challenge and build one another up, to check for blind-spots and areas where our work with and for children might fall short of God's desire for us and for them. God might be calling someone we do not like. God called Samuel, and Eli was finally able to recognize that. Are we?

- What are the opportunities for better integration of children into the mission of your church/organization and how might you take advantage of these opportunities? What are some of the challenges and how might you respond to those challenges?
- How are children integrated into worship, service and the mission of the church? How are children's voices heard in the development of mission? Is there opportunity for meaningful participation in the life, mission and body of the church? How could children be better incorporated into the planning and implementation of mission?
- What does leadership development look like for children in your worship community? How early does it begin? Is there a way to begin leadership development at an earlier life stage or to do leadership development more effectively?
- How are children's gifts of praise and worship recognized and nurtured? How are girl children, as well as boy children, viewed as bearers of God's image in such a way that they can be seen as full recipients of gifts from God and participants in the life of the church?
- How do generations within the church have opportunity to engage and learn with and from each other? If this is not currently taking place, what steps might your church or organization take to facilitate relationship and community amongst generations?
- If we believe that children can hear from God, how are we available to nurture their hearts and help them discern when God is calling to them?
- How can we provide opportunities to actively listen to what they are hearing from the Lord? Do we have a plan for transition of leadership, if listening to children means relinquishing control of ministries that we have come to see as "ours"?

- What might it look like if adults saw their nurturing role with children as one of stewardship and release of children to transformational mission? Imagine a scenario where stewardship is seriously considered as a mandate not only for biological children but for any child that God brings into their sphere of influence, affirming that all children can be adopted into the household of God as full heirs of the eternal promise. How would all children be viewed as part of the household of God and empowered in your church or organization?
- How might children and youth be equipped for ***meaningful participation*** in planning and decisions in your church or organization? If this is happening already, what lessons could be shared with the broader church and mission community?

Presentation discussed – "Raising Samuel: Releasing Children to Discover God's Purpose" (Paper 6)

Participants greatly appreciated the biblical and theological work that was presented in this paper. One theme that the participants particularly appreciated was Eli's openness to God's choice of speaking directly to the child Samuel and to mentor him appropriately in listening to God in an appropriate way for a child. This was an important reminder of how adults must be humble with the spirituality of children, especially when young people operating under God's direction could be perceived as a threat to adult power. Hannah's role in the development of young Samuel was valued – both her choice to commit the boy to service in the temple (which is, of course, still a common practice in parts of the world) and her continued support of him as represented by her gift of clothes.

Participants agreed that more work needs to be done to shift parents' and caregivers' thinking about their relationships with children away from ownership and towards stewardship. This metaphor helps caregivers to respect the role of parents while still taking appropriate responsibility to nurture the children they serve. Thinking in terms of stewardship also helps parents and caregivers to be more ready to release children once they are ready. Another metaphor that was used frequently in discussion was mentoring, implying a more direct guidance of older to younger, and helping to emphasize the agency of children over and against the more property-driven ideas that stewardship might suggest.

The theme that provoked the greatest response was Greener's distinction between Eli's struggles as a parent and his success in raising Samuel. Participants tended to respond to this insight in quite different ways. Some agreed with Greener's positive perspective on this story, showing how God can redeem even a parent with a poor track record for his purposes. But other struggled as they reflected on the disconnect often observed between a pastor or Christian caregiver's family life and the success of their ministries. It prompted some participants to reflect on their own lives, and wonder whether

there was more they could be doing to mentor their own children. This is a key theme for further consideration – how can a Christian do both well?

Part 3:
The Position of Jesus

Introduction to Part 3

"Follow Me, and I will make you fishers of men." Jesus

Part 3 begins with a devotional study based on Mark 10:13-16. Las Newman does not offer some romantic reading of the text. Rather he opens this study with reference to the harrowing way in which children have been murdered in his home country of Jamaica. He asks what can we learn from the life and ministry of Jesus that will inform and transform the church's ministry and mission towards children and youth in the middle of the 21st century? He takes the six actions of Jesus from the text and then draws four conclusions for the contemporary Church.

There follows three chapters all of which start developing potential policy frameworks for the future of mission with and to children and young people for the next few decades. Perry Shaw and Corneliu Constantineanu lead by examining the importance of 'hospitable space' as a concept that can shape how we work and what work we do. Vinay Samuel's chapter explores the value of 'releasing' children into the missio Dei. Finally Dave Scott explores what he terms 'the adult/ child dyad', concluding that We are at a critical moment in the history of the Church, when our understanding of the value and potential of children is increasingly trending towards one that more fully honours the dignity God has bestowed upon them.

One of the characteristics of Jesus' ministry is that it was practical. He was – is! – the activist par excellence. In whatever context he found himself, he always responded to the needs of

the people he met, as well as focused upon what his Father wanted to do through him. He held his life of prayer in perfect balance with his life of action. One significant part of his strategy was to train the apostles to continue his ministry on earth, and this included teaching them to become teachers and trainers themselves. This pattern of becoming a follower and a 'fisher of men' has been maintained throughout the centuries and continues today. It is appropriate, therefore, for the last section of this book to consciously focus upon Jesus, to learn from him and to find fresh impetus and inspiration for the ongoing mission to explore the changing worlds of children and young people and to seek out the new life Jesus has to offer them, and – through them – us.

Jesus, Children, Church and Mission

Editor's Introduction

The world in which we live and minister is harsh: as Las Newman notes, "children are bought and sold, exploited and trafficked, destroyed and ultimately discarded like waste products." Wisely he does not try and give reasons for these horrors but rather focusses on what our responses should be using the story of Jesus placing a child in the midst of the disciples. He highlights the six actions of Jesus (he noticed what was happening around him; he expressed anger at adults who blocked children's access to him; he welcomed children and created space for them; he warned against misrepresenting children's significance; he took the children in his arms; he blessed the children). From this he draws out four implications for the contemporary church: Jesus was on the side of children; the Church must unblock access of children to Jesus; the Church must ensure appropriate ways to bless children; and, Christian mission must be radically counter-cultural. Newman raises key missiological issues but they are not issues only for the missiologists – or children and youth specialists: rather these issues are for the whole Church to grapple with. "Christian mission", Newman rightly asserts, "cannot uphold cultures of exclusion or exploitation of children and youth".

DEVOTIONAL 3

Jesus, Children, Church and Mission

BY LAS G. NEWMAN

Introduction

On the first day of February this year the people of Jamaican woke up on a bright, sunny morning, to another screaming newspaper headlines in the major newspapers. The headline in the Daily Gleaner shouted at you. ***'BARBARIC - FOUR-YEAR-OLD RAJAY BECOMES SECOND CHILD MURDERED IN LESS THAN 24 HOURS.'***

This was yet another child murder in Jamaica, 1600 of them in the last 12 years.

Shortly after 7.00 am on Thursday morning, January 31, four-year-old Rushaun Burford was on his on his way to school in Kingston with his 43-year-old grandmother when a lone gunman with whom the grandmother had a dispute over water pipes, arrived on the scene, opened his gun and fired. Rushaun was shot in the face and died on the spot while his grandmother was hit in the right thigh. As people in the community gathered to commiserate on the tragedy that had taken place, the newspaper said: "Children cried, teachers cried, seasoned policemen cried, neighbours cried and even journalists struggled to hold back the tears as they looked at the body of little Rushaun, better known as 'Rajay.' *"A nuh my child, one woman said, but me feel it……We need Jesus in this country!"* shouted one woman as tears streamed down her face.

"This is the worst that I have ever seen," said the Member of Parliament for the area, Education Minister Ronald Thwaites. Revd Thwaites said *"I covered my face to hide the tears after looking at the body. I'm devastated and I wonder what kind of animal could have done this."*

Two days before, on Tuesday morning, at around 11.00am, the body of a teenaged girl, Shariefa Saddler, an 8th grader, was found on the street in the city, wrapped in a blanket. Shariefa was 14 years of age. Reports are that she left home at around 6.00am to take the bus to school. While waiting on the bus she was abducted and later persons in her community saw a man driving a sliver motor car, placing an item wrapped in a sheet on the road. They became suspicious and called the police. The police confirmed that it was the body of the 14 year old from the community.

Later, an autopsy revealed that Shariefa was sexually assaulted, strangled with her school tie, and her body dumped on the street like garbage in the middle of the day. These two alarming cases add to the growing numbers of murdered and missing children in Jamaica and throughout the Caribbean.

As Jamaicans we find ourselves asking, alongside the Education Minister and the Member of Jamaica's Parliament, *"what kind of animal could have done this?"* What kind of society do we live in where children and young people, 1600 in 12 years, are abused, gunned down, slaughtered, and discarded like junk for the garbage bin? What kind of environment have we allowed to develop in the Caribbean where children are bought and sold, exploited and trafficked, destroyed and ultimately discarded like waste products? Where is the outrage of the church and the moral majority in Jamaica and the countries of the Caribbean? What is, or more importantly, what should be the policy framework that governs the mind and mission of the church in the Caribbean in regards to our children and youth? What is the Caribbean church doing about children and youth that comprise more than 50% of the population?

In this situation where there is a deep crisis facing children in the Caribbean, as elsewhere, we do well to reflect on the issue from the point of view of Jesus's attitude and actions towards children during his earthly ministry. And we ask, are there any pointers to guide the followers of Jesus today, in this 21st century, in regards to their own attitude and actions towards children and youth? In other words, what can we learn from the life and ministry of Jesus that will inform and transform the church's ministry and mission towards children

and youth in the middle of the 21st century? From a missiological perspective, the key question is, in what ways should children and youth be recognized as "Strategic Partners in Mission?"

Mark's 10:13-16

There are several wonderful, informative, and instructive stories recorded in the four Gospels that provided excellent material for enlightenment, inspiration, and direction in answer to the questions we have posed.

I take the account in Mark's Gospel 10:13-16 of an incident that took place one day in the life of Jesus' ministry. It was a fascinating encounter between three sets of actors, (a) one was a crowd of people (mothers and children and presumably some curious fathers and men of the community; (b) Jesus's entourage of disciples (a group of twelve Jewish men of varying family upbringing and socialization) who were following Jesus in his daily ministry, and (c) and third was Jesus himself who was clearly self-conscious of his missional role on earth as prophet, priest, and king, conscious of his cultural background and upbringing, and conscious of the needs of children and their parents in the crowd. He was intensely aware of his unique mission and took charge of the scene that unfolded around him. In fact, he had his disciples in training to help them with their own self-understanding of his uniqueness and the mission he was inaugurating which they would be responsible for propagating and expanding in the future.

This story is recorded by all the Gospel writers Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John. Mark, in his account, tells us that at this point in the daily ministry of Jesus:

> [13] People were bringing little children to Jesus for him to place his hands on them, but the disciples rebuked them. [14] When Jesus saw this, he was indignant. He said to them, "Let the little children come to me, and do not hinder them, for the kingdom of God belongs to such as these. [15] Truly I tell you, anyone who will not receive the kingdom of God like a little child will never enter

it." [16] And he took the children in his arms, placed his hands on them and blessed them.

In Mark's description of this encounter, six actions of Jesus are highlighted. Could these actions be pointers to the church's ministry and mission to children and the engagement of children in God's Mission in the world? What are these actions?

1. Jesus noticed what was happening in front of him and around him… ***When Jesus saw this…***

What did he see? He saw the eagerness of the parents for divine blessing of their children. He saw the eagerness of the children to come to him. He saw bright prospects in the faces of the little children. He saw the image of the Father – the *imago dei* – in those children. He saw the attitude and behaviour of his own disciples towards the parents of those children and the crowd that had gathered. The disciples told them off and rebuked them for bringing their children to Jesus and demanding that he should place his hands on them. Jesus had no time for little children, they seemed to imply. He was busy with adult issues. He should not be disturbed by requests for attention to children's issues.

Is this not the same with church leadership today? Pastor, elders, and deacons are busy with big issues of the church. They have no time for children. Children are not given priority attention. In fact, the structure and management of church may be obstacles in the way of children gaining access to Jesus. But Jesus noticed what was happening. He saw the situation and recognized it for what it was.

2. Jesus expressed anger at adults who blocked children's access to him... ***He was indignant***

What an amazing scene! The ordinary people of the village and surrounding areas began to recognize the power and influence of Jesus – the Christ – and so the women and men picked up their children and scrambled in the throng to bring them to Jesus. They recognized that there was something divine in the hands of Jesus and they wanted him to place his hands on them. There are adults who understand that. They want the best for their children and would do

anything within their power to ensure that their children are pushed forward, are given the right foundation for child development, and support for growing up.

However, there are those even inside the church who still have the old Victorian attitudes towards children where children are treated as second class, subordinated creatures who should neither be seen nor heard. They are like the disciples whose reaction to the crowd was to block access to Jesus, and to scold the people about wasting their time. Mark points out that when Jesus saw this he was 'indignant.' He was fuming at best or angry at worst. Either way, he did not like the fact that the children were being prohibited from receiving his touch and his blessing. His perspective was so different from that of his followers, the very men who would later constitute the church. By its attitude and action toward children the church can be barrier to children receiving the blessing of Jesus. Too often adults by their actions and attitudes deny children access to Jesus and to the blessing they need from him.

3. Jesus welcomed children and created space for them... Let the little children come to me, and do not hinder them

Jesus spoke up. While the disciples were rebuking the crowd, Jesus was rebuking them. And in his rebuke, he elevated the status of children and created space for them right in his personal presence. In contrast to the actions of those who blocked the children's access to Jesus, Jesus welcomed them. He placed value on them. He affirmed them as full humans, made in the image and likeness of God.

How sad it is, that in the marketplace of life today the world commodifies children, placing monetary and material value on them as products to be marketed, exploited, traded, or used to service the greed and indulgence of adults. I am amazed at how much money is spent by the advertising industry on advertising products aimed at children. According to a Federal Trade Commission report on food marketing to children released in 2006, the US advertising industry spent approximately $1.6 billion marketing their products – mainly soda, fast food and cereal – to children. They recognize the commercial power and appeal of the children and youth sector and

devote significant percentages of their advertising budget expenditure towards them.

As Dan Brewster and the people in Compassion ask, how much of our church's budget is expended on children and youth? How much do we spend to recruit, train, and develop children into the men and women God created them and redeemed them to be? Jesus said "*Let the little children come to me, and do not hinder them*." He welcomed them in a very gentle, affirmative way, creating a safe space for them who are to be counted among the most marginalized and most vulnerable in the population.

Are the children in church being excluded or exploited by the adults around? How does the church show that it welcomes children and demonstrates a radically different valuation and affirmation of who they are, in contrast to what obtains in the world? How does the church make space for children in their midst, as families and people of the community bring their children to church for divine blessing?

In Matthew's Gospel, Jesus warned, "If anyone causes one of these little ones—those who believe in me—to stumble, it would be better for them to have a large millstone hung around their neck and to be drowned in the depths of the sea." (Matthew. 18:6).

4. Jesus warned against misreading the significance children... *anyone who will not receive the kingdom of God like a little child will never enter it*

How do we understand the importance of childhood and childhood? Jesus illustrated the nature of the Kingdom of God by drawing an analogy to a little child. *'Truly, I tell you, anyone who will not receive the kingdom of God like a little child will never enter it.'* The Kingdom of God which he inaugurated is to be received like a little child receiving a birthday present, or a box of goodies for a special occasion. Children love to receive gifts with eager anticipation. With humility and dependence. With joy and gratitude. That is how we are to receive the Kingdom.

Children are significant to and included in the Kingdom of God: *'The Kingdom belongs to such as these.'* If they are significant to the Kingdom, they are significant to the church. As members and agents

of the Kingdom then, children are witnesses to the grace, mercy, and peace that Jesus gives. They understand compassion and affection and shalom. They understand God as the almighty ruler, gracious father, and merciful reconciler. As such, they can be effective and powerful agents of the transmission of God's grace, mercy, and peace to others and be strategic partners in mission. Their partnership in mission can be strategic in the sense that they possess the ability to make a unique contribution to the communication of the Gospel to young and old alike.

Children are significant to the community of faith as well as to the local community. They are reminders of the inter-generational workings of the Kingdom, how the Kingdom of God interlocks and intersects and grows from one generation to another.

Matthew tells the story that on the occasion when entered the Temple courts in Jerusalem and saw what was going on, he drove out all the adults who were buying and selling and turning the Temple area into a bazaar. He overturned the tables of the money changers and the benches of those selling doves. The blind and the lame came to him at the temple and he healed them. Some children had caught sight of what Jesus was doing and they were excited by the wonderful demonstration of his supernatural power and exhibition of authority. They began to shout, "Hosanna to the Son of David." Again, the religious leaders, chief priests and teachers of the law were very upset at the behaviour of the children. They turned to Jesus and asked him, "*Do you hear what these children are saying?*" Jesus responded by quoting from Psalm 8:2. "*Yes," replied Jesus, "have you never read, 'out of the mouth of infants and nursing babies you have prepared praise for yourself'?"* (Matthew 21:12-16).

5. Jesus physically embraced children... 'Took Them In His Arms And Placed His Hands On Them.'

Jesus took the children in his arms and placed his hands on them. When children are deprived of adequate human touch and closeness they can become emotionally unstable and even suffer mental illness. It is sad reality of our times that in an age of the significant malpractice of paedophilia, we have to become by law politically

correct and circumspect in the way we physically relate to children. In this the 21st century, the church of Jesus Christ must hang its head in shame and embarrassment at the way in which children in the care of the church have been abused and exploited by paedophile priests, deacons, and elders, some of whom have been elevated to the High office of Bishops and Presbyters. This has been the greatest scandal of the church in the 20th century and continues into the 21st century. Children are consequently starved of affection and bereft of the physical touch of caring adults, even in the church. No human being can survive without experiencing the importance of human touch.

How in the 21st century do we restore trust and credibility in the church's outreach and embrace of children? We must ensure that children are protected from irresponsible behaviour of adults. However, the church cannot withdraw or hold back from responsible, compassionate physical embrace of children. We must, as Jesus did, embrace children in our arms. We must, as Jesus did, be able to place our hands on them in a positive, responsible, and life affirming way. That's what Mother Theresa exemplified in her ministry to the poor. She exemplified the difference responsible, healing human touch can make, especially among the poor and marginalised in society.

6. Jesus blessed the children… *He blessed them.*

One of the key issues in the Caribbean for a long time has been how to bless our children. Two of our colleagues in Jamaica, Dr. Barry Davidson and Dr. Faith Linton, have recently co-authored a book on parenting in the Caribbean, *'Answers to Questions Parents Ask'*.[1] In this book, they drew attention to the fact that the parenting culture of the Caribbean tends to pronounce a curse on our children rather than a blessing. "We do not know how to bless our children", they point out. They argue that, 'unfortunately, many children hear far more negative words than positive ones and they often live with the

[1] Linton, Faith/ Davidson, Barry: 2012. *Answers to Questions Parents Ask.* Family Life Ministries: Kingston, Jamaica, 183-196
www.familylifeministriesjamaica.com

negative consequences for the rest of their lives – unless someone intervenes and brings them the blessing they long for'.[2]

They highlight Terry and Melissa Bone's book, '*The Power of Blessing*',[3] and the story in Genesis 48:8-20 of Jacob blessing the children of Joseph by placing his hands on them and pronouncing a blessing. They emphasise the ways in which we can bless our children, including through meaningful touch, through a spoken message, by attaching high value, by picturing a special future, and by active commitment. When parents deliberately speak words of blessing over their children, they point out, they empower them to succeed and to thrive in every area of life.

We bless our children by affirming them, not by blocking them. We bless our children by including them, not by excluding or exploiting them. We bless our children by recognizing the missional power and significance of children. We bless our children by recognizing their estimable value to the Kingdom of God, to the church, and to society.

Implications and Conclusion

We have undertaken a task of great importance, focussing on one of the key missiological questions of the 21st century. We have reflected on the question, 'in what ways can children and youth be strategic partners in mission'; what are the implications for the church and mission in the 21st century? In the 1st century, Jesus showed the way. In these six actions I believe Jesus demonstrated how we may begin to involve children and youth in missional action for the Kingdom of God. If we practice them, we would certainly help raise up a new generation of partners in God's mission, witnessing to God's wonderful grace and the power of His Kingdom that transforms the church and the world.

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[2] *Ibid*., 187.

[3] Terry and Melissa Bone, *The Power of Blessing* (Crossroads Christian Communications: 2004).

1. Jesus was on the side of children

Whatever else can be said, this account in Mark's Gospel emphatically points to this fact. Jesus's words and actions are consistent and point to this conclusion. The global agenda of Compassion International, the 4-14 Window, the Child Theology movement – and the many other networks that are engaged in bringing the attention of children to the church and the world – is therefore right, timely, and much needed. You are on the right side of biblical theology and world history.

2. The church must unblock access of children to Jesus

The church must seek to remove all obstacles to children and youth involvement in church and mission. As it has done in the last two centuries, the church must renew its commitment to Sunday and Sabbath schools in this century by redirecting resources to support and strengthen programmes for children and youth in the church. This includes training and equipping staff and providing adequate physical space.

3. The church must ensure appropriate ways to bless children

Children need and crave the blessing of adults. It is very important to them. In its ministry to children the church must establish clearly defined ways in ways parents and adults bless children. Some best practices are worth noting. In addition to the occasion of birthdays, there are other opportunities such as anniversary of baptism, confirmation and other rites of passage, school examinations and other school achievements, age-appropriate leadership responsibility, and leadership development. As a community of faith, the church must support and reinforce overt acts of spiritual blessing of children and youth, especially at the critical moments in their physical and spiritual journey.

4. Christian mission must be radically counter-cultural

Christian mission, by its very nature, challenges the status quo and offers an alternative vision of the present and future. It cannot uphold cultures of exclusion or exploitation of children and youth. The

dynamic of the Judeo-Christian faith is that it moves forward, advancing towards the day when *'the earth shall be filled with the knowledge of the glory of God as the waters cover the sea.'* (Habakkuk 2:14).

Theme 7:

Space and Community, Engagement and Empowerment: Missiological Equipping for a New Mission Era

Editor's Introduction

Perry Shaw and Corneliu Constantineanu examine "possible ways in which space within [the Christian] community can be provided to children and youth such that they can be better understood, engaged, and empowered in using their gifts in service of the mission of God." They bring a sharp missional focus to their chapter and use the biblical concept of "hospitable space" as the foundation for their argument. They note that "In most contexts the space provided for children and young people is extremely limited and generally defined by others" and the church is (usually) no exception to this. The mandate is for all believers to participate in the missio Dei, including children and young people. Yet the focus too often tends to be on religious leaders which leads to "a blindness to the strategic nature of the 4/14 window – children and young people who are particularly open to the gospel and often passionate for the gospel, and who comprise a large percentage of the population." This is compounded by "generational difference" and "the global connectedness that is part of the essential experience of today's children and young people."

Churches need to respond to the changing culture and yet are often slow to do so, if at all. The authors apply their argument

to theological institutions and to local churches. As Jack Eggar and Mark P. Gonzales noted in their response, "Shaw and Constantineanu's unfolding paradigm is a wonderful starting point to re-focus church and institutional efforts to empower and equip the next generation as the Christ-following leaders of tomorrow."[1]

There are several responses following the paper. Amanda Sanchez highlights issues surrounding the family and emphasises the crucial role of the father as a role model for the children especially in terms of church attendance and the mother in terms of "nurture, care and intimacy." It is "no less vital or valuable" than the father's role. She closes with a mention of higher education.

Manfred W. Kohl's response, "Children and Ministry" – an Integral Part of Theological Education, raises seven questions to consider especially within the context of theological education and ministerial formation.

Victor Nakah offers a Response from the African Perspective. He explores African culture, especially the dynamic that exists between the individual and the community. He gives a penetrating insight into the contextual issues that Shaw and Constantineanu raise, paying particular attention to the notion of "acquired personhood." This has devastating consequences for children and young people because "They haven't attained personhood and therefore they are not human as yet. .... They are therefore ignored, undermined, demeaned and taken advantage of because they don't share the same human value as those who have attained personhood." What is needed is a renewed appreciation of "the intrinsic value of human beings" because "they are godlike beings made in God's likeness, and possessing unique capacities which distinguish them from the

[1] Jack Eggar and Mark P. Gonzales gave a paper at the conference, "Response from the Perspective of Church Ministry." It is not reproduced in this volume.

animal creation. … It is this, which accounts for the unique worth of all humanity including children and youth".

PAPER 7

Space and Community, Engagement and Empowerment: Missiological Equipping for a New Mission Era

BY PERRY W.H. SHAW AND CORNELIU CONSTANTINEANU

Introduction

The essential calling of the people of God is to participate in their Lord's great mission of the restoration of the fallen created order. The Christian community of faith has always been most fruitful in the accomplishment of this missional mandate when space is provided for all of God's people to use their gifts in engagement with the world in which they have been placed. This all-inclusive vision for the church, a vision which seeks the engagement and empowerment of all of God's people, irrespective of race, gender, and age, was clearly affirmed in The Manila Manifesto of the second International Congress on World Evangelization:

> The church is intended by God to be a sign of his kingdom, that is, an indication of what human community looks like when it comes under his rule of righteousness and peace. As with individuals, so with churches, the gospel has to be embodied if it is to be communicated effectively. It is through our love for one another that the invisible God reveals himself today, especially when our fellowship is expressed in small groups, and when it transcends the barriers of race, rank, sex and age which divide other communities. … *We repent of our share in discouraging the ministry of laity, especially of women and young people. We determine in the future to encourage all Christ's followers to take their place, rightfully and naturally, as his witnesses. For true evangelism comes from the overflow of a heart in love with Christ. That is why it belongs to all his people without exception.* (Lausanne Movement, 1989)

The current essay reflects on possible ways in which space within community can be provided to children and youth such that they can be better understood, engaged, and empowered in using their gifts in service of the mission of God. The provision of hospitable space is a tangible expression of reconciliation, as well as being a practical necessity for emerging generations. However, space in community is unlikely to emerge in seminary, church, and family without proactive intentionality. It is our hope that this paper will represent a resource for those engaged in biblical and theological reflection on the place and role of children and youth in the church and in the mission of God.

The Biblical Imperative of Hospitable Space

The provision of hospitable space is a theological act through which we are able to reflect the character of God – a God who from the beginning created bounded and ordered space in which the voice of all is encouraged. The act of separating light from darkness (Genesis 1:4-5) and the waters above from the waters below (Genesis 1:6-7) reflected God's divine value for both order and space. With the creation of Adam God saw the need for a bounded and ordered space in the garden, a space within which the first task given was for Adam to use his voice in naming the animals (Genesis 2:19-20), a task for which he needed a partner as together they completed the task of naming as steward-rulers (Genesis 2:20-22). When we create ordered and bounded space in which others might express their voices we fulfil our identity as created in the image of God.

With the fall the perfect space of this good and ordered world became corrupted and cursed. The whole redemptive story from Genesis to Revelation is a story of the restoration of broken relationship with God and the return to a community space in which our voices can again be used to glorify our Creator. It is in our reconciled community life that our acknowledgement of God's rule is proclaimed most clearly. This is the central message of the gospel: in Christ we can experience restoration of relationship with God, and

through this restored relationship and empowered by the Holy Spirit we are able to become agents of genuine healing for a broken and fallen Creation. While these convictions are widely acknowledged it is not so widely recognized that the provision of hospitable space is a central element in the experience of biblical reconciliation.[1] In the provision of hospitable space we become genuinely ministers of reconciliation – the face of God in the broken world in which we live.

While a growing number of specialized books and articles have recognized the prominent role of hospitable space in biblical societies, Western theological reflection continues to emphasize theological instruction over theological act, and rarely can one find a single entry under "hospitality," "guest," or "meal" in any Western general theological text – an omission that impoverishes our understanding of the biblical message of reconciliation. In high context communication cultures such as the Middle East[2] much more is at stake: the creation of hospitable space is itself a theological drama, through which the mighty act of Divine reconciliation is known by the participants not simply in word but through personal experience.

Biblical examples of the interface between the reconciling work of God and the provision of hospitable space are legion: the covenant with Abraham is sealed with a meal (Genesis 15); the Exodus begins with the Passover (Exodus 12); as the Israelites enter the desert they are established as a people through the sharing of a meal in the Divine presence (Exodus 24:9-11). At times the reconciling work of God was extended to the enemies of the People of Israel, and repeatedly it is a shared meal that becomes the seal of reconciliation, as when Isaac makes a feast for Abimelech (Genesis 26:26-31), or Elisha mediates peace between the Arameans and the Israelites (2 Kings 6:8-23). In every case, whether with God or with the enemy, the provision of hospitable space was not a peripheral act to the narrative but a dramatic expression in action of the covenant relationship spoken in

[1] Perry W.H. Shaw, "A welcome guest: Ministerial training as an act of hospitality" in *Christian Education Journal*, Series 3 Vol. 7:1, 2011a: 8-26.

[2] Edward T. Hall, *Beyond Culture* (New York: Anchor Books, 1976).

word:[3] as food is shared the value of the individual within the broader community is affirmed through the common hospitable space.

The interface between reconciliation and affirmation through shared hospitable space becomes even clearer in the person and work of Jesus. The description of Jesus as "a glutton and a drunkard, a friend of tax collectors and sinners" (Matthew 11:19) was (at least to a certain extent) justified by his uncompromising willingness to eat and drink with the outcasts of society (Mark 2:15ff; Luke 7:36-50; 15:1-2; 19:1-10). Repeatedly Jesus used the very act of sharing bread with "sinners" as a primary teaching methodology for instructing about the centrality of reconciliation to the Kingdom of God: the sharing of communal space around a meal was a means by which Jesus affirmed each person's intrinsic value as a part of the community of faith, offering genuine freedom through the relational experience of love.

Particularly striking was Jesus' welcome and provision of hospitable space to women and children, accepting and affirming two of the most disregarded segments of his contemporary society. Jesus' model of lifting up the weak and despised demonstrated in action the message he declared in word, and provided a model to his disciples then and now. It is in the provision of hospitable space that we are able to reflect the character of God, and together with those we serve become ministers of reconciliation.

The apostle Paul equally provides strong testimony to the fact that reconciliation with God is intrinsically connected with, and cannot be separated from, reconciliation with "the other." The Pauline emphasis on the intertwining of divine and interpersonal reconciliation speaks powerfully to the contemporary church with its tendency to reduce reconciliation to its vertical, spiritual aspects with no connection to its social dimension. For Paul, reconciliation is a multifaceted reality that encompasses reconciliation with God and reconciliation between human beings, forming together an inseparable reality.[4]

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[3] *Op cit.*

[4] Corneliu Constantineanu, *The Social Significance of Reconciliation in Paul's*

The Pauline imperative for hospitable space is clear in Romans 15:7: "*Welcome one another*, therefore, *just as* Christ has welcomed you for the glory of God." Christ's work of reconciliation is the ground and model for what the church must now do: *just as* Christ welcomed and reconciled the believers so they also should welcome and be reconciled one with another. The conjunction "*just as*" indicates some sort of comparison, thus highlighting not only the fact of Christ's welcome but also *the manner* in which he did it. God's reconciliation was an act of pure grace in which Christ manifested his love towards people while they were weak, sinners, even enemies of God. *In the same manner* believers should manifest their love one towards the other, to show the same grace to others that they have been shown by God.

God's reconciling initiative, shown in the very act of Christ's death on the cross, is not only the pronouncement of God's reconciling the world, but also the ground and model for reconciliation among people. Paul provides an unshakable foundation for both the possibility and the actuality of social reconciliation. Paul's ultimate vision of the reconciliation of all things in Christ gives assurance and hope, and an irresistible impetus to the believer's ministry of reconciliation in all its forms and manifestations. To live according to the logic of the gospel and in the light of Christ means to be community oriented – a community where everyone (including every child and youth) is engaged in the ministry of nurturing and embodying practices of reconciliation, a community which strives after the consummate ideal of life together in harmony and solidarity, peace, love, and regard for others. In that children and young people are essential members of this community of faith, the creation of hospitable space for them is not optional but a biblical imperative.

Theology: Narrative readings in Romans (London/New York: T&T Clark/Continuum, 2010).

The Nature of Hospitable Space

Genuine hospitable space has a number of foundational characteristics:

1. Hospitable space is both bounded and open

Palmer observes that "space without boundaries is not space, it is a chaotic void".[5] For a space genuinely to be a space it must have a level of openness, but must also have clear limitations. This is the value of healthy community: where the individual is valued in community, the community provides the individual with an opportunity for free expression, but the community also provides guidance and limitations. Both the voice of the individual and the voice of the community are valued and affirmed. It is space in community that provides the best context for engagement and empowerment.

2. Hospitable space addresses fear through the promotion of trust and courage

For many people the expression of their own voice is a fearful enterprise.[6] The desire to be "right" leads to fear that what is said or done will reveal ignorance, prejudices, or failure, and it often seems safer to remain passive and silent than to discover one's gifts and use them. Addressing the fear of personal expression is a particular challenge in much of the non-Western world, where the cultural tradition of respect for elders discourages children and young people from expressing their own opinion, and hence developing confidence in their own voices. Where there are dictatorial governments the ideological realities further exacerbate the difficulties of engagement and empowerment. Healthy faith communities have a unique role in providing a safe context in which understandable fears are

[5] Parker J. Palmer, *To Know As We Are Known: Education as a spiritual journey* (San Francisco, CA: Harper, 1993), 69.

[6] Parker J. Palmer, *The Courage to Teach: Exploring the inner landscape of a teacher's life* (San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass, 1998), 36.

acknowledged and addressed through an environment of encouragement and trust.

3. Hospitable space recognizes the value of reciprocity

Nouwen has observed, "When hostility is converted into hospitality then fearful strangers can become guests revealing to their hosts the promise they are carrying with them. Then, in fact, the distinction between host and guest proves to be artificial and evaporates in the recognition of the new found unity".[7] It is not coincidental that the Greek verb for showing hospitality "*xenizein*" also means "to experience surprise." In providing space to others we often discover new perspectives on our own lives and understandings.[8] Our private space is enlarged and enriched, made more open and free, even illuminated.[9]

Hospitable Space and the Empowerment of Children and Young People

In most contexts the space provided for children and young people is extremely limited and generally defined by others. In the church this generally means that children and young people are expected to participate in organized programmes which are planned, established, and run by adults. Children are viewed as consumers rather than creators with space to take initiative in leadership and the formulation of ministry action. A growing body of research would challenge the wisdom of these limitations.

Fernando has commented that "a crisis that is not followed by a process becomes an abscess".[10] Such has been found when there is a

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[7] Henri J.M. Nouwen, *Reaching Out: The three movements of the spiritual life* (New York: Doubleday, 1975). 47.

[8] Marjorie J. Thompson, *Soul Feast: An invitation to the Christian spiritual life* (Louisville: Westminster John Knox, 1995), 128.

[9] Parker J. Palmer, *The Company of Strangers: Christians and the renewal of America's public life* (New York: Crossroad, 1981), 69.

[10] Ajith Fernando, *Spiritual Living in a Secular World: Applying the book of*

focus on child conversion without encouraging a process of maturation and ministry. The extensive research conducted by the Search Institute[11] has suggested that many of the key developmental assets for children and young people, necessary for them to enter adulthood with confidence and maturity, are related to empowerment. As young people have opportunities to contribute to others, they generally rise to the challenge, and increasingly become recognized as valued members of their communities.

Powell, Griffin, and Crawford's[12] investigation of the factors that make for "sticky faith" in the college years found that the more teenagers serve and build relationships with younger children, the more likely it is that their faith will stick: "The students we surveyed who had served in middle school or children's ministry while they were in high school seemed to have stickier faith in college" (p. 75). Likewise, Back's[13] study of late adolescents found that meaningful involvement, through which young people have the opportunity to discover and use their gifts and talents in some form of leadership, is a key factor in developing lasting faith: "[Youth] want to be needed, not just entertained. They seek out churches where they can do something significant" (p. 33).

Over ten years ago Tom Sine observed:

> Those of us who are parents, grandparents, pastors, educators, and youth workers have a special responsibility to equip the young for life in a demanding future. But most of us are unwittingly preparing the young to live in the world in which we grew up instead of the world of the third millennium. As a direct consequence of this lack of foresight, I believe many of our

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Daniel today (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1993), 107.

[11] Search Institute (1990/2012) "Developmental assets", online at http://www.search-institute.org/developmental-assets (accessed 4 October 2012).

[12] Kara E. Powell, Brad M. Griffin and Cheryl A. Crawford, *Sticky Faith, Youth Worker Edition: Practical ideas to nurture long-term faith in teenagers* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 2011).

[13] Wesley Back, "Stopping the dropouts: Guiding adolescents toward a lasting faith following high school graduation" in *Christian Education Journal*, Series 2, 5 (1), 2008: 28-46.

> approaches to parenting, youth ministries, and education are the wrong stuff. I believe we are often doing the opposite of what we should be doing to equip our young people to live, thrive, and serve God in a new millennium. Tomorrow's global society is likely to be a more complex, demanding environment than the one in which we grew up. To live, thrive, and serve God in that world, I am convinced our young people will need to have high initiative. They will need to be self-starters and problem-solvers.
>
> … Now, stop and think about how many well-intended parents are raising their kids today. Many, out of love, are waiting hand and foot on their young and raising them in a highly indulgent environment. The worst thing we can do for young people is to rob them of initiative. …How do we typically conduct youth ministry in our middle-class congregations. Hire a guy with a car to run activity-driven programmes to entertain the young people and keep them busy, distracted, and out of trouble. Doing for the young again. High school students are perfectly capable of planning and running their own programmes.[14]

It is crucial that we provide a safe environment for children and young people in our churches within which they can share their understanding of God's salvific work. It is only then that, in the light of Scripture and in this open space, we provide proper learning and correction even while we encourage them to reflect on their own role as participants and agents in God's mission. Through the provision of opportunities for children and young people to take responsibility they are empowered to discover and exercise their gifts, and in an atmosphere of trust they are able to take initiative and gain confidence in their service, and in their role and place in God's mission. As has frequently been observed, a person is grown up not when they can take care of themselves, but when they can take care of others. Providing space for children and young people to discover and use their gifts is both a theological affirmation of the message of Divine reconciliation, as well as a practical necessity if we wish to see

[14] Tom Sine, *Mustard Seed versus McWorld: Reinventing life and faith for the future* (Grand Rapids: Baker, 1999), 41.

the church vital and effective in the complex world of the twenty-first century.

The Missional-Ecclesial Vision, Empowerment, and Engagement for All

The Scriptures make clear that the ultimate goal of all we are and do as individuals and as a church is to participate in the *Missio Dei*, and more specifically to work and serve for the extension of the Kingdom of God and the proclamation of Christ as Lord throughout the earth. Throughout the biblical narrative a strong emphasis is placed on the people of God in the declaration of God's mighty acts (1 Peter 2:9), and hence the need for every church and every training context to keep in mind a foundational missional-ecclesial vision.

In reality the church across the globe struggles to fulfil this mandate. Both internal and external challenges to the church blur its vision and stifle its effectiveness. The church is in desperate need of faithful men and women who can guide the people of God to confront and overcome the challenges they face and courageously and clearly fulfil their missional mandate. Unfortunately, despite the widespread doctrinal affirmation of the "priesthood of all believers," the empowerment and engagement of all the people of God is rarely practiced. While some progress has certainly been seen over the past 50 years, in general the pervasive clergy-laity distinction has worked to limit the effective ministry of the whole community of faith, as both from above and below the expectation remains that ministry is the responsibility of "ordained ministers." The cultural predominance of high-power-distance[15] leadership structures in much of the world simply exacerbates the situation, limiting the space in which believers can use their gifts in mutual service towards the fulfilment of the church's missional mandate.

[15] Geert Hofstede, *Cultures and Organizations: Software of the mind* (London: McGraw-Hill, 1991), 28.

As with first century Palestine so in much of the world today the tendency of the people of God to focus on the role of religious leaders and a conscious or subconscious dismissal of the weak has led to a blindness to the strategic nature of the 4/14 window – children and young people who are particularly open to the gospel and often passionate for the gospel, and who comprise a large percentage of the population. Most churches are geared for the 10-20% of the population who are aged 50+ and take little consideration of the 30-60% of the population who are under 20. The challenge is magnified by the extent to which youth embrace the rapidly changing world in which we live. Generational difference is becoming increasingly stark, as traditional cultural patterns are more easily challenged through the global connectedness that is part of the essential experience of today's children and young people.

Few churches are willing or able to pay the price of responding to the rapidly changing conditions in which we find ourselves in the twenty-first century. On the contrary many believers look to the church as a safe place of stability and continuity, often resisting change through confusing the eternal truths of Scriptures with constancy of form. In this way the incarnational imperative of sacrificial response to changing societal needs is easily lost. Theological institutions, mission agencies, and local churches need to rethink their self-understanding and develop strategies whereby the whole people of God are empowered to engage the context in light of the text so that the work of God can go forward.

Theological Institutions, Space, and Generational Engagement

Most of our theological institutions have uncritically adopted a model of education that was developed in an historical context that bears little resemblance to the world that the contemporary church is finding itself engaging. The four classic "disciplines" or "silos" of theological education (biblical, historical, systematics, ministerial studies) emerged in a context where the relationship between the church and the wider society was largely in a "Christendom"

paradigm – that is the assumption was that the church could and should have a level of power and influence in society. It is for this reason that missional elements in content and methodology are barely evident in the classic approach to theological education and the emphasis has been on the study of texts from the past. The "Christendom" paradigm has never been relevant in the non-Western world, and is no longer relevant in most of the West. Hence the urging from people such as Robert Banks[16] and Linda Cannell[17] for a missional foundation to theological education. As Cannell puts it:

> A structure formalized in the medieval period, modified to suit the theological shifts of the Reformation, influenced by the scientific methodology of the Enlightenment, shaped by the German research university, deeply affected by modernity, and assumed to define true theological education today is likely not adequate for the challenges of contemporary culture and the education of Christians who have been shaped by that culture.[18]

Curricular reform is one of the most pressing needs facing theological education in the twenty-first century, but such change does not come easily. As Woodrow Wilson[19] summarized his own experience as President of Princeton University, "It is easier to change the location of a cemetery than to change the school curriculum."

The starting point of curriculum planning is knowing why exactly we exist, and what are we trying to accomplish anyway. In this regard the Bologna Process for European higher education has coined the phrases "Fitness of Purpose" and "Fitness for Purpose".[20] Any effective educational programme must first establish an appropriate self-

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[16] Robert Banks, *Reenvisioning Theological Education: Exploring a missional alternative to current models* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1999).

[17] Linda Cannell, *Theological Education Matters: Leadership education for the church* (Newburgh: EDCOT, 2006).

[18] *Op cit.* 306.

[19] Quoted in Andrew Seaton, "Reforming the hidden curriculum: The Key Abilities Model and four curricular forms" in *Curriculum Perspectives* 22 (1), 2002: 9-15.

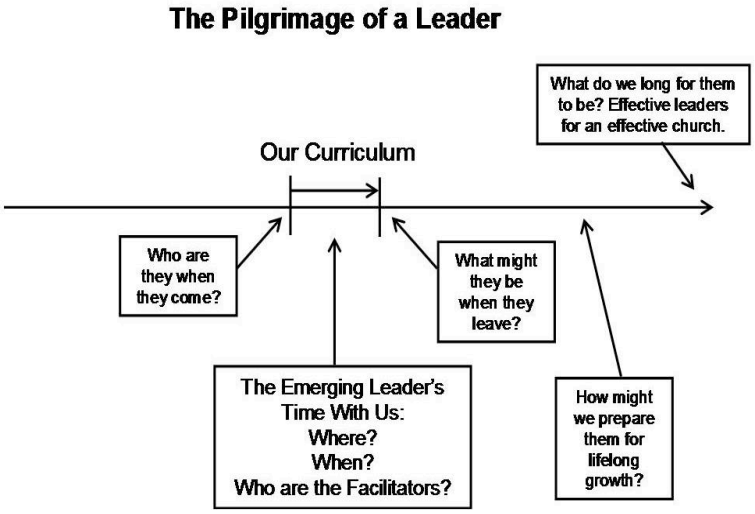
[20] ENQA, *Standards and Guidelines for Quality Assurance in the European Higher Education Area* 3rd ed. (Helsinki: European Association for Quality Assurance in Higher Education, 2009).

understanding of why it exists, in other words a fit purpose. Once this is in place the institution and its curriculum should then be shaped to best fulfil that purpose. For theological education we must seek a theological answer to the question of purpose: good theology should drive our pedagogy. Why do theological schools and programme of ministerial training exist? What are we trying to do anyway? A missional-ecclesial foundation for theological education suggests that our schools exist in order *to prepare men and women who are capable of guiding the church to be effective in fulfilling the mission of having Christ acknowledged as Lord throughout the earth*.[21] Note that the preparation of men and women is not the ultimate goal, but a significant means towards the accomplishment of the greater goal of having Christ acknowledged as Lord.

While our role as programmers of study is important in preparing faithful men and women for Christian service, in point of fact our time with students is extremely limited, and we do well to acknowledge our limitations. Few of our programmes of study have access to emerging leaders for more than a handful of years, but the Divine work of leadership formation continues throughout life. The whole process can be represented diagrammatically as follows:[22]

[21] Perry W.H. Shaw (2011b), "Asking the right questions in curriculum development" in *The Theological Educator* (on-line journal of the European Evangelical Accrediting Association), Vol 4.2 (October 2011), online at http://thetheologicaleducator.net/2011/10/14/asking-the-right-questions-in-curriculum-development/#more-422 (posted 14 October 2011).

[22] Shaw, 2011b, *op cit.*



There is a tendency in many schools to attempt to deliver in three years everything that an emerging leader will need for the remainder of his or her life. The end result is a dense curriculum that focuses on content, with little attention to the need to train students in lifelong learning. A more effective approach to curriculum for missional-ecclesial theological education will be highly selective in the content delivered, providing significant opportunity for the development of skills in dynamic critical thinking and lifelong self-education. The information revolution of the past few decades makes such a restructuring all the more imperative.

Given a missional-ecclesial foundation of theological education, and a recognition that students' time with us is limited, a series of significant curricular questions emerges naturally (Shaw 2011b).[23] The first three of these questions provide a rationale for providing space in theological education for the engagement and empowerment of children and young people.

[23] *Ibid*.

1. What is the ideal church in our context?

If the reason for our existence is the missional mandate of the church, then the first question we need to ask is what an ideal church might look like, a church that serves the *Missio Dei* faithfully and effectively in the local context where our students are likely to serve. Given the large proportion of the global population which is under the age of 25, and the disproportionate number of people who embrace the Gospel during the 4/14 window, missional churches will be those that take seriously the engagement and empowerment of children and young people. A genuinely missional-ecclesial theological education will have the dynamic world of children and young people at the forefront of its attention.

2. What are the contextual challenges?

What are some of the challenges that confront the church, that hinder it as an effective agency for the proclamation of Christ? New challenges are emerging daily, and often it is the children and young people of Christian faith communities that are most aware of these challenges.

3. What might a responsive theological institution look like?

In light of questions 1 and 2 (above) it is clear that effective leaders are those who understand children and young people, know how to provide space for their voices, and are effective in engaging and empowering children, youth, and adults in addressing the rapidly changing challenges of the contemporary world.

In their rigid adherence to the classic model, most of our theological institutions are becoming increasingly anachronistic. Our curricula are packed with the study of texts, leaving little space for engagement and empowerment. This situation is unlikely to change so long as curricular decision-making remains in the hands of faculty, people who are often more comfortable in the academy than they are in the local church. As those who have succeeded in the system teachers and administrators are often the least open to question the system to which they have devoted so much of their lives. Meaningful curricular reform will need greater stakeholder involvement; in

particular an effective curriculum for theological education will provide space that listens to the voices of children and young people so that the contemporary challenges confronting the church in the fulfilment of its missional mandate are recognized and then addressed.

As the foundational questions are addressed it will become clear that it is not enough simply to add on more courses or to develop tracks or specializations in children and young people ministry – seen in many schools as peripheral to our "real" task of academic theology. For theological institutions to be effective as servants of the church's missional mandate a process of reflection, reorientation, and creative reconceptualization is needed, in which less content is taught, and theological education is seen more in terms of training students in the process of addressing changing challenges through biblical and theological lenses. Such curricular change will necessitate the incorporation of elements that are rarely even considered in traditional schools, such as technology, social networking, environmental concerns, global conflict, the growing challenges to traditional social patterns and the postmodern shape of pluralism and "tolerance" with its abhorrence of the advocacy for a single metanarrative.

The missional-ecclesial vision has already gripped several schools, such as Columbia International University, Tyndale University College and Seminary (Toronto), Arab Baptist Theological Seminary (Beirut), South Asia Institute of Advanced Christian Studies (Bangalore), Southeastern Baptist Seminary and Denver Seminary. In most of these cases change has come through paradigm shift and a move away from a "discipline" approach to an integrated approach that sees the classic fields of study as lenses for looking at contemporary challenges and issues. The need is for others to follow and extend their example.

Hospitable Space and the Local Church

If theological colleges and mission and parachurch organizations are going to be effective in the twenty-first century there needs to be a recognition of the biblically mandated role of the local church, and close cooperation that both challenges and supports local churches in the accomplishment of their missional mandate. Helping local churches to avoid institutionalization and develop faithful biblical responses to societal change will be one of the greatest contributions these organizations can make. Engaging and empowering children and young people are an essential element in this process.

Drawing on numerous biblical periscopes in which Jesus used children as the model of "kingdom community" (Matthew 18:1-7, Mark 9:33-37, and Luke 9:46-48; Matthew 19:13-15, Mark 10:13-16, and Luke 18:15-17), Harkness[24] asserts that, for Jesus, children are bearers and mediators of the essential spirit of the kingdom of God. As such a major means by which adults become aware of the living values of the Kingdom will be through meaningful interaction with those who are most prone to reflect those values – namely, children. Embedded in the life and teaching of Jesus is the imperative of providing hospitable space in which children and young people discover and use their gifts.

Despite the common rhetoric, generosity of time and space and genuine hospitality towards children are not necessarily common features of contemporary cultures. Nor was it common in Jesus' time. And yet, against the cultural norms of his time, Christ's action of placing a child in the centre of a theological conversation provides a striking message then and now: in the measure of the Kingdom children are of intrinsic importance and consequently need to be heard with all seriousness. The logic of the Kingdom of God is radically different from the logic of our dominant culture, and we are called to reassess and restructure the way we understand and relate to our children and young people. An important starting point is to re-

[24] Allan G. Harkness, "Intergenerationality: Biblical and theological foundations" in *Christian Education Journal Series* 3: 9 (1), 2012: 121-134.

educate the people of God in their understanding of children through a patient but emphatic presentation of Jesus' life model and Kingdom instruction with respect to children and young people. But while verbal instruction is valuable, even more powerful learning will come through experience: when we provide the space for children and young people to share their own life experience of God's grace the church can discover the rich gifts they bear, and the important place and role that children and young people have in God's missional purposes.

Healthy faith communities understand the relationship between adults and children as "parakletic" rather than purely didactic and directive. As those (hopefully) further along the path of faith pilgrimage adults come alongside and join children on their unique spiritual journeys.[25] In as much as we recognize and understand the unique way in which the Holy Spirit is working with each child we can point the way forward and encourage children and young people in their own distinctive faith development and expression.

Among all the practices that have been found to strengthen, engage, and empower children and young people into adulthood, the experience of intergenerational worship and community life has been found to be one of the most powerful. Powell, Griffin, and Crawford[26] discovered that involvement in all-church (intergenerational) worship during high school is more consistently linked with mature faith in both high school and college than any other form of church participation:

The closest our research has come to that definitive silver bullet is this sticky finding: high school and college students who experience more intergenerational worship tend to have higher faith maturity.

Intergenerational ministry is increasingly being recognized as a key element in a church's missional effectiveness. For example one

[25] Catherine Stonehouse, *Joining Children on the Spiritual Journey: Nurturing a life of faith* (Grand Rapids: Baker, 1998).

[26] *Op cit.* 75.

recent study by Martinson, Black, & Roberto[27] found that congregations in which young people are welcomed and expected to participate and lead in church-wide ministries, including worship, education, fellowship, outreach, and decision-making, led to the young people bringing their friends and the congregation having a greater impact on the surrounding community. Based on his extensive research into the theological, educational, and social science foundations of intergenerational ministry, Harkness[28] likewise concludes that "… if faith communities are to increase effectiveness in fulfilling their mandate to equip people for life and relevant mission, no longer can the widely used homogeneous-age group methodology go unquestioned. An intergenerational component must be conceived as normative."

The reciprocity that is at the heart of hospitable space is found richly in intergenerational faith communities where children and young people are engaged and empowered in the use of their gifts and voices. As they will inevitably benefit from their experience of the love and trust of adults, so also adults are often surprised by what they learn for their own faith journeys from the insights of children and young people.[29] This surprised sense of discovery is well-expressed in the words of one adult who has experienced the faith gifts of children and young people: "My task, I'm finding, is no longer to impart spirituality to my children. Rather, I share this journey with them. I, too, have much to learn".[30]

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[27] Roland Martinson, Wesley Black and John Roberto, *The spirit and culture of youth ministry* (St Paul: EYM, 2010).

[28] Allan G. Harkness, "Intergenerational and homogeneous-age education: Mutually exclusive strategies for faith communities" in *Religious Education* 95, 2000: 51-63, 63.

[29] M. Perry, "A way of life: Embodying the "intergenerational" vision" in *PMC: the Practice of Ministry in Canada* 11(1), 1994: 22-23.

[30] Quoted in Harkness, *op cit.,* 2012.

Bounded Space in the Family

The most influential context in children's lives is the home. The family is the child's first experience of the world, and continues to play a dominant role in the lives of children until adulthood. Although the school also plays an influential role, the family remains the hub of life experience for most children and young people. The enormous influence of home and family stands in stark contrast to the minimal number of hours that children spend in church and other formal Christian activities. Empowered and trained believers must engage families for the missional-ecclesial vision of the people of God to be accomplished.

A variety of studies[31] have pointed to the strong correlation that exists between parental child-rearing practices and children's images of God. Effective Christian ministry will support and train parents in how best to reflect God's character to their children. While many aspects of God's character might find expression in parental relationships with children, perhaps the two most significant are the intertwining of God's love and his holiness. When believers understand and bask in the richness of these characteristics, their lives become a distinct and attractive witness to others. Homes characterized by clear and enforced boundaries, balanced with

[31] Simone A. De Roos, "Young children's God concepts: Influences of attachment and religious socialization in a family and school context" in *Religious Education* 101 (1), 2006: 84-103; Simone A. De Roos, Jurjen Iedema, and Siebren Miedema, "Influence of maternal denomination, God concepts, and child-rearing practices on young children's God concepts" in *Journal for the Scientific Study of Religion* 43 (4), 2004: 519–535; Jane R. Dickie, Amy K. Eshleman, Dawn M. Merasco, Amy Shepard, Michael Vander Wilt and Melissa Johnson, "Parent-child relationships and children's images of God" in *Journal for the Scientific Study of Religion* 36 (1), 1997: 25-43; Bradley R. Hertel and Michael J. Donahue, "Parental influences on God images among children: Testing Durkheim's Metaphoric Parallelism" in *Journal for the Scientific Study of Religion* 34 (2), 1995: 186-199; R. T. Lawrence, "Measuring the image of God: The God Image Inventory and the God Image Scales" in *Journal of Psychology and Theology,* 25, 1997: 214-226; Alicia Limke and Patrick B. Mayfield, "Attachment to God: Differentiating the contributions of fathers and mothers using the experiences in parental relationships scale. *Journal of Psychology and Theology* 39 (2), 2011: 122-129.

unconditional love and space for exploration, are most likely to create an environment that models God's holiness and love. Families that reflect God's love and holiness through the provision of age-appropriate hospitable bounded space will be best situated to develop children who embrace the gospel, share the gospel, and live the gospel.

Key elements of the Search Institute's[32] "40 developmental assets" are the need young people have for both support and boundaries. Young people need to experience support, care, and love from their families, neighbours, and many others, but they also need to know what is expected of them, and whether activities and behaviours are "in bounds" and "out of bounds." A variety of studies[33] have found that this sort of "authoritative parenting"[34] best promotes healthy life adjustment. Where children's voices are encouraged, and they are expected to behave intellectually and socially at levels consistent with age and abilities, within a firm but warm environment of high child-parent attachment, children tend to be more emotionally secure, self-confident, independent, self-assertive, friendly with peers, cooperative with parents, happy, achievement-motivated, and socially and academically successful. In contrast, both purely strict and punitive ("authoritarian") and undemanding ("indulgent") parental patterns have been found to result in poor social adjustment.

When children are engaged and empowered within the family, both children and parents experience the reciprocal joy of learning

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[32] *Op cit*.

[33] David Fontana, *Psychology for Teachers* (New York: Macmillan Press, 1995), 7; Robert S. Feldman, *Development Across the Lifespan* (Upper Saddle River: Prentice Hall, 1997), 266-268; Peter L. Van Katwyk, "Towards a balanced whole: The well-functioning family" in *The Journal of Pastoral Care* 55 (3), 2001: 239-246.

[34] Diana Baumrind, "Current patterns of parental authority" in *Developmental Psychology*, 4 (1, Pt. 2), 1971: 1-103; Diana Baumrind, "Parental disciplinary patterns and social competence in children" in *Youth and Society*, 9, 1978: 238-276; E.E. Maccoby and J.A. Martin, "Socialization in the context of the family: Parent-child interaction" in *Handbook of Child Psychology, Volume IV: Socialization, Personality, and Social Development* 4th edition, eds. Paul Mussen and E. Mavis Hetherington, (New York: Wiley, 1983), 1-101.

and growth that is one of the key features of genuine hospitable space. One interesting study[35] has pointed to the value of "bidirectional" religious communication in the home, in which children and parents are mutually active and both behave in ways that may ultimately influence the other. Children value their own voice in the family. Contexts in which parents both guide children in the faith and listen to the children's own expressions of faith are more likely to lead to long-term faith ownership and commitment.

The normal pattern of family dynamics is that parents will repeat the parenting approaches they experienced as children, often with damaging results. Christian parents need support and training so as best to model the character of God to their children. The provision of appropriate space through which children are engaged and empowered will be an essential element of living out holiness and love. Seminaries play a key role in training church leaders, and churches play a key role in providing supportive opportunities for parents. As both parents and children discover their voices of faith, the whole people of God will be in a better place to live out the gospel both in word and deed.

Conclusion

An essential means by which the mission of God will be accomplished is the provision of hospitable space through which all the people of God are engaged and empowered to bring their gifts into service of the whole community. Particularly in the rapidly changing world of the twenty-first century the missional contribution of children and young people will become an increasing imperative. For this to happen theological institutions must go back to foundational questions and enter a process of reconceptualization, local churches must address their tendency to institutionalization through engaging

[35] Chris J. Boyatzis and Denise L. Janicki, "Parent-child communication about religion: Survey and diary data on unilateral transmission and bidirectional reciprocity styles" in *Review of Religious Research*, 44 (3), 2003: 252-270.

the voices of emerging generations, and families must be trained and empowered to become the living embodiment of God's character.

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Response from the Perspective of the Family

BY AMANDA J. SANCHEZ

Shaw and Contanineanu argue that the family provides the most influential context in a child's life. From an infant's earliest days all the way through adulthood, the family occupies a central position that is unrivalled by any other institution or relationship. Clearly, when it comes to these broader issues of space, community, engagement, and empowerment the family serves as the hub from which all other relational and contextual spokes extend.

The implications of this perspective require a thoughtful response. In particular, the idea of missiological equipping elucidates deeper questions about the philosophical and practical outworking of how we engage and empower children within the context of the family and how we do so in a way that is Biblically-faithful, culturally-appropriate, and relevant within the contemporary milieu of children in the 21st Century.

I would like to briefly address these concerns.

Scripture includes admonitions for children to honour and obey those in authority over them. This recurring theme is not without promise or purpose, as children are commanded to obey their parents because "this pleases the Lord," "this is right," so "that you may live long in the land," and so "that it may go well with you." The charge to obedience is clear, but as Shaw and Contanineau show, the missional imperative to empower and engage the younger generation also redounds. Their participation is vital to the mission that God is accomplishing in the world today. So what might this look like in light of the Biblical command to submission? There is no clearer,

more compelling picture of this complementary outworking of both obedience and empowerment than the Trinity. According to Ware:[1]

The equality that exists in the Trinity is reflected in the equality by which God has made every human being. Since each member of your family is made in the image of God, each should be treated in ways that are fitting to who they are. … Parents and church ministries together must cultivate an atmosphere where children learn to speak to one another and act toward each other in ways that find approval in God's sight.

Ware provides a foundation for the basis of empowerment within family relationships: intrinsic equality based on the *imago dei* without detracting from the command to submission. As in the Trinity and human marriage, differentiated roles do not equal differential worth. Thus, the basis of children's empowerment flows from a proper understanding of their intrinsic value before God. This places an imperative upon parents to recognize that their child's voice and engagement is vital.

With this perspective, the question then becomes, How do families engage and empower their children to be witnesses to Christ while remaining faithful to the Biblical injunction (and in some cases, cultural expectations as well) for submission and respect? One way of approximating an answer is to examine what rests at the root of the word empower. According to Moen[2], Ephesians 6:10 provides a striking example of what lies behind this word empower. The Apostle Paul writes, "Finally, be strong in the Lord and in the strength of His might," and he uses the term endunamoo for "be strong." This is sometimes translated as empower. However, the real application of

[1] Bruce Ware, "The Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit: The Trinity as Theological Foundation for Family Ministry" (October 10, 2012), from http://www.sbts.edu/family/blog/the-father-the-son-and-the-holy-spirit-the-trinity-as-theological-foundation-for-family-ministry/ (originally appeared in the *Journal of Discipleship and Family Ministry*, Vol. 1, Issue 2, accessed December 2012).

[2] Skip Moen, (May 12, 2009), Three Together. Hebrew Word Study, from http://skipmoen.com/tag/empowerment/ (accessed December 2012).

this term is found in the words that closely follow: "strength" and "might."

Paul uses the Greek word *ischus* for "strength", meaning the ability to perform, and the Greek word *kratos* for "might," meaning power that is ready for action. Moen points out that *kratos* doesn't necessarily mean that action happens, but that power is available and ready for when it is needed. And therein lies the key for empowering children: every parent's goal should be to empower their children with *ischus* and *kratos*, the ability to perform and a readiness to apply their strength when required. This does not negate submission, because "to be equipped by the Lord has little to do with being delegated authority and responsibility"; rather, empowerment is much more about being "a means by which the inherent power of God is manifested through me for His purposes".[3]

Empowerment within the context of the family is a process in which parents teach their children what it means to be connected to the ultimate Source of power, Jesus Christ, and live their lives through the strength He provides and in obedience to Him and the authorities over them. Empowerment is connecting the child to God and not prematurely placing them in formal roles for which they are still maturing.

This leaves us, however, with the most fundamental issue of all: parents cannot impart what they don't already possess. Perhaps the best hope then is to begin building the foundation at the level of the parent. I propose three strategies for churches to consider as they equip the parents to equip and empower their children for missiological engagement.

[3] *Ibid.*

The Role of the Father

"In a very real sense, as the husbands and fathers go, so goes the family and, as households in a congregation go, so goes the congregation".[4] According to the findings of Swiss research:

> If a father does not go to church, no matter how faithful his wife's devotions, only one child in 50 will become a regular worshipper. If a father does go regularly, regardless of the practice of the mother, between two-thirds and three-quarters of their children will become churchgoers (regular and irregular). If a father goes but irregularly to church, regardless of his wife's devotion, between half and two-thirds of their offspring will find themselves coming to church regularly or occasionally.[5]

Fathers have the critical role in the formation of their children's relationship to the church, therefore it is imperative that fathers are a focal point within the family discipleship ministries of local churches. Fathers themselves must first possess a passion for the mission of God, which includes an understanding of the Heavenly Father's heart in calling children to Himself. Fathers need to set the example for their children by engaging in this mission; they must directly teach and equip their children to be part of this mission in ways that are consonant with the Spirit's work inside them and the gifts He has bestowed. If fathers are not fulfilling their discipleship and equipping role in the family, the course of the entire family and subsequently, congregation, is put at risk.

This three-fold pattern resonates with what Paul writes in 2 Timothy 2:1-2 (ESV):

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[4] Bruce Ware, "The Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit: The Trinity as Theological Foundation for Family Ministry" (October 10, 2012) in *Family Ministry Today* from http://www.sbts.edu/family/blog/the-father-the-son-and-the-holy-spirit-the-trinity-as-theological-foundation-for-family-ministry/ (originally appeared in the *Journal of Discipleship and Family Ministry*, Vol. 1, Issue 2, accessed December 2012).

[5] Robbie Low, "The Truth about Men and Church" (June 2003), originally in *Touchstone* from http://www.touchstonemag.com/archives/article.php?id=16-05-024-v (accessed January 2013).

> You then, my child, be strengthened by the grace that is in Christ Jesus, and what you have heard from me in the presence of many witnesses entrust to faithful men who will be able to teach others also.

Paul's words are instructive for fathers and churches in that they provide a clear outline for how missiological empowerment can look within families today:

- *Strengthened by the grace that is in Christ Jesus*: fathers must have a relationship with Christ, and participate in the *missio Dei* themselves.
- *What you have heard from me*: fathers should model the Christian life
- Entrust to faithful men who will be able to teach others also: fathers should pass the baton on to children.

Churches can play a pivotal role in helping to equip fathers in these important areas.

The Role of the Mother

The role of the mother in the formation of children cannot be overstated. Mothers occupy a position that is no less vital or valuable than the father's role. This equality is based on the *imago dei* inherent in the created order, but just as God has given order to His creation, so too has He assigned unique roles to the mother and father in the shaping of their children's spiritual life. As Low[6] heartily affirms, mothers occupy a primary position in the realms of nurture, care, and intimacy. It is fundamental that church ministries encourage and equip mothers to be the nurturers, caretakers, and confidantes that their children need. This should also extend into the role of wives' relationships with their husbands, particularly in terms of how they are gently encouraging and supporting their husbands to provide spiritual leadership.

[6] *Ibid.*

Higher Education

We cannot bypass the parents, teachers, and mentors who will help equip children for their Kingdom destiny. One of the most strategic places to start is by capturing the minds and hearts of such people during their tertiary education years. The Church can become a centre of learning and service for these young adults by providing discipleship-driven higher education within the context of the local church. This requires a strategic effort to holistically disciple them to become mature, Christ-centred adults who will provide the missiological space, and the ethos of empowerment, that will ultimately equip children to become participants in the *missio Dei*.

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RESPONSE 2

"Children and Ministry" – An Integral Part of Theological Education

BY MANFRED W. KOHL

Often called the "queen" of higher learning, theology was from the beginning the centre of university education. Over the years, however, it has been replaced in significance by philosophy, medicine, law, art, science, and technology in university settings. In reaction to these developments, theological departments, the church, and denominations started their own institutions, the so-called "theological seminaries."

These theological seminaries, however, continued with the original four classical disciplines of theology in their research, teaching, and writing; namely, 1) **Biblical Theology Studies**, requiring the original languages, Hebrew, Greek, and Latin; 2) **Historical Theology Studies**, from the early church to the present; 3) **Systematic Theology Studies**; 4) **Ministerial or Practical Theology** Studies. These four areas of study were carried out for centuries in universities, as they still are in theological seminaries and bible institutes.

With the emergence of mission agencies, whether serving overseas or at home, the need for mission studies became evident. Less than two centuries ago, mission studies slowly took hold in theological institutions. In the last century churches began to have a mission programme, directed by a mission committee, and some large churches even have a full time pastor for missions. Today, every theological institution, whether within a university or in a theological seminary, has a department of missions and professors of missions, and they offer various degree programmes in missions up to an including a Ph.D. in missions. It would be helpful for someone to provide a historical study of how this happened, specifically how

missions became a major programme at every theological institution and therefore a vital aspect of every church and parachurch organization throughout the world.

Exactly the same development can be recorded with regard to ethics and counselling. A few generations ago these subjects did not exist as separate disciplines. Today every theological institution has clearly defined divisions of ethics and counselling, with faculty specifically trained in these areas.

How can we bring the topic of "Children and Ministry" into the mainstream of theological education? This has to become an independent department just as mission, ethics, or counselling have.

Much progress can already be seen. Our conference, like other conferences before, as well as numerous publications, a well-prepared and readily available curriculum, a Masters programme and the Ph.D. programme offered at some institutions in Asia indicate clearly that indeed a good beginning has been made.

Some practical issues and questions for discussion:

1. The often used slogan "As the seminary goes, so goes the church" should be supplemented by another, "As the church goes, so goes the seminary." The pressure must come from the church and its people. We must demand professionally trained "experts" to deal with "Children and Ministry." How can we accomplish this most effectively?
2. A clear distinction needs to be made between "Children and Ministry" and Christian education. What should be the emphasis of each? How can the well-established Christian education programmes in churches support the efforts of this new division?
3. The breakthrough in establishing any new programme depends on funding. How can we influence foundations and scholarship agencies to provide funding for this new specific programme (research, writing, Masters and PhD studies)? Who could do such lobbying work among funders?
4. If a person studies three to five years for his or her Ph.D. in "Children and Ministry," that person will be committed to

teaching it after the doctoral programme has been completed. How can we help several universities or theological seminaries on each continent to offer a specific Ph.D. programme in "Children and Ministry"? Convincing a theological faculty to change its curriculum is a difficult task. Perry Shaw quotes in his paper the words of Woodrow Wilson, "It is easier to change the location of a cemetery than to change the school's curriculum." Specific efforts are necessary also to influence accreditation agencies.

5. The media (and not only the Christian media) must be influenced to write more about "Children and Ministry." In the area of child abuse prevention several agencies have now been established, with the specific task of training thousands of professionals throughout North America to deal with child abuse. Their task is to speak at every university and college, trying to convince the administration and faculty to deal with this issue in their curriculum. Could we be part of the National Child Protection Training Centres?
6. What would be the best name for this topic of "Children and Ministry"? We must find a very effective name that covers all the various aspects. The three disciplines mentioned above -- Mission, Ethics, and Counseling – are now household terms. We should indeed spend some time coining a simple term that will be used from now on without variation.
7. We should try to go back to basics. Jesus' ministry to children must be emphasized more in all that we do and proclaim, as well as in all that we publish. Some of the theological opinion leaders, well known pastors and evangelists, foundation and parachurch leaders, etc. -- all should be asked to jump on the bandwagon. Who is able, having the time and resources, to start such a public relations effort immediately?

These are some very practical issues for discussion and for decision.

Note: The topic of "Peacemaking/Reconciliation" should follow the same pattern. Both "Children and Ministry" and "Peacemaking/

Reconciliation" were at the centre of Jesus' ministry. They must also become the centre of our ministry. Let's make it happen.

RESPONSE 3

Response from the African Perspective

BY VICTOR NAKAH

"There is no such thing as a "self-made" man. We are made up of thousands of others. Everyone who has ever done a kind deed for us, or spoken one word of encouragement to us, has entered into the make-up of our character and our thoughts, as well as our success." (George Matthew Adams – Philosopher)

Introduction

There has been a great deal of misconception about the idea of community and the social status of the person in African thought. One of the consequences of this misconception is that the relation of the person to the community has been misconstrued. This is best seen in the social status given to children and youth in community.

Of the many African cultural values that have come to be admired by others, the African sense of community stands out as the most admirable. Perhaps the reason is that it is in community that all the other values make sense. A popular African proverb that expresses this says:

> "Go the way that many people go; if you go alone, you will have reason to lament."

Community is a characteristic that defines Africans both in being and mode of life. The African idea of security and its value depends on personal identification with and within the community. Therefore, the authentic African is known and identified in, by, and through his community.

The African church (the Christian community of faith) has embraced most African values, but especially 'the sense of

community' both as a distinctive and a relevant expression of the gospel. Correctly understood, this has the potential to unite the community of faith as witnessed in the book of Acts. Unfortunately, if misunderstood and misinterpreted, as is often the case, what is meant to be a blessing could become a curse. The challenges that confront the African church and mission, especially with regards to children and youth are partly to do with misconceptions about community and personhood. The consequence has been the apparent disregard of children and youth as equal members of the community of faith. These misconceptions are obvious in the on-going debate about community, family, and personhood.

The Idea of Community and Personhood

A survey of African scholars who have written on this subject reveal that most of them, with the possible exception of Ghanaian philosopher Kwame Gyekye[1], regard African concepts of the individual and self to be almost totally dependent on and subordinate to social entities and cultural processes. Kenyan theologian, professor John S. Mbiti[2], for example, believes that the individual has little latitude for self-determination outside the context of the traditional African family and community. He writes:

"Whatever happens to the individual happens to the whole group, and whatever happens to the whole group happens to the individual. The individual can only say: 'I am because we are; and since we are, therefore I am.' This is a cardinal point in the understanding of the African view of man".[3]

[1] Kwame Gyekye, *The Unexamined Life: Philosophy and the African Experience* (Accra: Ghana Universities Press, 1988).

[2] John Mbiti, *African Religions and Philosophies* (New York: Doubleday and Company, 1969), 141.

[3] *Op cit.* (1969: 109).

For the Ghanaian philosopher Kwame Gyekye[4] the individual, although originating from and inextricably bound to his family and community, nevertheless possesses a clear concept of himself as a distinct person of volition. It is from this combined sense of personhood and communal membership that the family and community expect individuals to take personally enhancing and socially responsible decisions and actions. Although he accepts that the dominant entity of African social order is the community, Gyekye believes "it would be more correct to describe that order as amphibious, for it manifests features of both communality and individuality."

Here, Gyekye, takes an egalitarian view on the subject, choosing rather to avoid the excesses of the two exaggerated systems, while allowing a meaningful, albeit uneasy, interaction between the individual and the community. This introduces an understanding of community that brings together the idea of interdependence of "Person and Community" as well as "Person in community." Whilst it is true that the African social order is communal through and through, the idea of individuality is not necessarily ignored or denigrated. However, the thinking that seems to carry the day in Africa thought and has in fact contributed to the problems we have with regards to children and youth is the view that promotes the supremacy of community over and against the individual person.

In contrast to Gyekye's mutually enhancing understanding of community and personhood, Nyasani[5] possesses a far less egalitarian view of the individual in African society. According to Nyasani, the African individual hardly knows how to act outside the context of his community's prescriptions and proscriptions. For Nyasani, the existence of the individual in African society is "quasi-dissolution into the reality of others for the sake of the individual's existence".[6] For him, "everything boils down to the 'me' in the 'we' or rather to the

[4] *Op cit*., 31-32.

[5] J.M. Nyasani, *The African Psyche* (Nairobi: University of Nairobi and Theological Printing Press Ltd, 1997).

[6] *Ibid*., 60.

survival of the self through the enhancement and consolidation of the 'we' as a generic whole. Thus, in Africa, the individual will go to all lengths to ascertain the condition of the corporate 'we' and to play his part, if necessary, to restore the balance of wholeness".[7]

The Notion of Acquired Personhood in African Culture

Linked to the perception that community is supreme over the individual is the whole notion of acquired personhood, the idea that in African culture personhood is conferred by the community. In order to make a point, I will point out a few significant contrasts between this African conception of the person and various other conceptions found in Western thought.

According to Menkiti[8] the first contrast worth noting is that whereas most Western views of man abstract this or that feature of the lone individual and then proceed to make it the defining or essential characteristic which entities aspiring to the description "man" must have, the African view of man denies that persons can be defined by focusing on this or that physical or psychological characteristic of the lone individual. Rather, man is defined by reference to the environing community. As John Mbiti[9] notes, the African view of the person can be summed up in this statement: "I am because we are, and since we are, therefore I am."

The second point of contrast between the two views of man, according to Menkiti is what he calls, the *processual* nature of being in African thought, the fact that persons become persons only after a process of incorporation. Without incorporation into this or that community, individuals are considered to be mere danglers to whom the description 'person' does not fully apply. For personhood is

[7] *Ibid*., 81-82.

[8] Ifeanyi A. Menkiti, "Person and Community in African Traditional Thought" in *African Philosophy: An Introduction*., ed. Richard A. Wright (Lanham Maryland, 1984), 171-175.

[9] *Op cit.,* 141.

something that has to be achieved, and is not given simply because one is born of human seed.

In the light of the above observation it is clear that western conceptions of man could be described as minimal, whoever has a soul, or rationality, or will, or memory, is seen as entitled to the description 'person.' However, the African view has a maximal definition of the person. Personhood is something at which individuals could fail, at which they could be competent or ineffective, better or worse. Hence, the African emphasis on rituals of incorporation and the overarching necessity of learning the social rules by which the community lives so that what was initially biologically given can come to attain social self-hood.

That full personhood is not perceived as simply given at the very beginning of one's life, but is attained after one is well along in society indicates that the older and individual gets the more a person he becomes. What we have here is both a claim that a qualitative difference exists between old and young, and a claim that some sort of ontological progression exists between infancy and ripening old age.[10]

The African Family and Community

Nyasani identifies the traditional African family as a setting wherein the vertical power structure of the society is introduced and sustained as predominant over the freedom of individuals. For Nyasani there is a "fundamental difference between the traditional African child and a child in the Western culture. The child in Africa was muzzled right from the outset and was thereby drilled into submission to authority from above".[11]

Within the communal context, Nyasani argues that Africans exhibit an,

[10] *Op cit.,* 174.
[11] *Op cit.,* 129.

> Endemic and congenital trait of what could be described as natural benign docility generally brought about by years of blind social submission and unquestioning compliance to the mystique of higher authority that reigns surreptitiously yet effectively in all black African societies in varying degrees. This benign natural docility is generally regarded as positive, legitimate and virtuous strictly within the context of a traditional social regime.[12]

Community norms, he says,

> Are merely received but never subjected to the scrutiny of reason to establish their viability and practicability in the society. Maybe, it is because of this lack of personal involvement and personal scrutiny that has tended to work to the disadvantage of the Africans especially where they are faced with a critical situation of reckoning about their own destiny and even dignity.[13]

From the supposed primacy of the reality of both the community and family, it is evident that, community defines the person as a person and that personhood is acquired. Unfortunately it is this understanding that seem to influence African thinking about community and personhood both in general culture and the church. Generally, Africans have always had problems with how to include women and children in community. Embracing the primacy of community over the individual and allowing community to confer personhood simply makes an already bad situation worse.

The late John Stott[14] once made an accurate and sobering observation with regards to man and woman and God. He said, "In many cultures women have habitually been despised and demeaned by men. They have often been treated as mere playthings and sex objects, as unpaid cooks, housekeepers and child-minders, and as brainless simpletons incapable of engaging in rational discussion. Their gifts have been unappreciated, their personality smothered, their freedom curtailed, and their service in some areas exploited, in

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[12] *Op cit.,* 113.

[13] *Ibid*., 63-69.

[14] John Stott, *New Issues Facing Christians Today* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1996), 285-286.

others refused." Unfortunately this observation is true not only in African cultures but also in the church. The situation of children is no different and perhaps worse.

The church in Africa struggles to include children and youth, as part of the community of faith and for that reason the all-inclusive vision for the church still remains a pipe dream for them. We however need to ask why, especially when all the ingredients for the realization of this vision are there, ingredients like a high sense communality, hospitality, respect for the elderly and sacred space. For example, African hospitality is known to transform aliens into kings and queens when they visit the African continent? When a poor family receives a guest they will sacrifice their last chicken and give over the only bed they have to make him comfortable. But why are children and youth left out and often made to feel like second-class citizens in families and the community of faith that is equally theirs to belong and participate?

If Africans and the community of faith are that much *communocratic*, how do we explain the fact that children who should be significant in community are meant to be seen and not heard? In other words they should not speak in the presence of adults making it almost impossible for them to experience community like everybody else? How do we explain why children are always victims of war, famine, poverty, and conflict? In Africa's long-running civil wars in the past three years, more than 100,000 children have been abducted, tortured, and sexually abused before being recruited to fight in wars they have no idea how they started and for what reason. The Democratic Republic of Congo has more than 30,000 child soldiers fighting in militias and acting as bodyguards for government army commanders. Girls are also kidnapped and gang-raped by soldiers using them as entertainment and rewards for bravery.[15]

[15] Meera Selva, *Africa's Children of War* (November 18, 2004) from http://countercurrents.org/hr-selva181104.htm (accessed January 2013).

Conclusion

So, where does this leave children and youth? They haven't attained personhood and therefore they are not human as yet. The general community and the community of faith are both 'adults only club' and children and youth don't qualify membership. They are therefore ignored, undermined, demeaned and taken advantage of because they don't share the same human value as those who have attained personhood.

If the African church is to intentionally create community space for children and youth she will have to confront this misconstrued view of community and personhood. What is needed in the words of the late John Stott[16] is a fuller doctrine of human beings. All our ministry to and with children and youth depends on our evaluation of them. The higher our view of their worth, the more we shall want to serve them by including them as full fledged members of the community of faith.

The basis for serving our fellow human beings (children and youth) says Stott, is not because of what they may become in the speculative future development of the race, but because of what they already are by divine creation. The intrinsic value of human beings by creation is affirmed from the first chapter of the Bible onwards, they are godlike beings made in God's likeness, and possessing unique capacities which distinguish them from the animal creation. True, human beings are fallen, and the divine image is defaced, but despite all contrary appearances it has not been destroyed (Genesis 9:6; James 3:9). It is this, which accounts for the unique worth of all humanity including children and youth.

[16] *Op cit*., 23.

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- In Oriental societies you honor people by entering their space and providing them with the opportunity to show you hospitality. Much of the discussion in Perry and Corneliu's paper focused on providing space within which children and youth come into faith community space in order to be engaged and empowered. However, genuine mission should surely also entail the church entering the space "owned" by the children and youth themselves, what has been described as "outside-in" ministry. What might be some of the barriers to the missional engagement of children and youth in their own space and communities, and what might be some ways in which these barriers might be overcome?
- In much of the world the societal expectation is that the younger should defer to the older out of respect, and this pattern is repeatedly affirmed in the Scriptures. Isn't the advocacy of the engagement and empowerment of children and youth at odds with the biblical teaching of children honoring and obeying parents, and the general directive to respect leaders? Particularly in light of the missional mandate of the church, how might these two biblical teachings be reconciled?
- In much of the world the education system from kindergarten to university revolves around rote learning, in which success comes from regurgitating the voice of the teacher. In such a context children and youth increasingly lose confidence in their own voices, and even the ability to know what their voices might be. What are some specific practical steps that the Christian faith community could take to help those raised in this sort of educational environment to discover and express their voices?
- What are some of the potential risks involved in the process whereby children and youth become creators rather than consumers, and older leaders empower younger leaders?

How might these risks be addressed honestly and constructively?

- One of the criticisms of intergenerational ministry is that the unique developmental needs of different ages cannot be met in a "one-size-fits-all" approach, and the tendency is for those who design the ministry to focus on the developmental needs of their own interest group. Surely there is also a place for age-specific ministry, particularly within a missional context, where "outsiders" are being invited to participate in children or youth ministry? How might a balance between intergenerational and age-specific concerns be facilitated in the context of a local church?

Presentation discussed – "Space and Community, Engagement and Empowerment: Missiological Equipping for a New Mission Era" (Paper 7)

This topic focused more specifically on practices that churches can employ in order to engage children as participants in mission. It centered on the common idea of creating hospitable space: adults in any church context must see the essential importance of creating space for children to participate in mission, and then encourage children to do so. The paper resonated strongly with participants, although some noted the need for further theological grounding on this theme. The discussions that ensued were especially vibrant.

The participants were asked to discuss some of the barriers to creating hospitable space for the empowerment of children. The most frequently-cited concern was the strong awareness of cultural resistance (for example, the rigid societal expectations and limitations of the caste system). Simply put, many cultures do not value any children as participants and are structured to ensure that children are not permitted participative space. Second to these cultural barriers are individual adults who resist the participation of children because they feel that doing so places their authority and control at risk.

The solutions proposed mostly involved the intentional practice of intergenerational worship (a theme that was repeated several times at the conference). This sees the worship and ministry of the church in terms of a family dinner where there is a place set for every member of the family. Breaking out of age-specific segregation will be an essential aspect of any solution but not every aspect of the church's worship can be intergenerational at all times.

Similarly, some participants noted that adults need reminding that the basis for good ministry is relational and, therefore, effective ministry can only be achieved once appropriate relationships of mutual respect are established. Children need to be seen as more than consumers of spiritual insights from adults, but as creators as well. These relationships would need to be culturally nuanced (for example, respect for elders means something very different in an

Asian culture where filial piety is a high priority), but such relationships must be seen as the responsibility of caring adults in every Christian community.

Participants discussed what some of these spaces of mutual respect and interdependency of children and adults in mission might look like. One thread was the importance of understanding children as children, and ensuring that whatever space was created enabled them to be just that. This will include helping adults – and especially parents – better understand the world from a child's point of view, thereby encouraging adult humility and helping them to see children's "creative" behavior as something other than merely "disobedience." In some cases, children's boundary-testing behavior might simply be a developmentally-appropriate way for them to participate. Another thread was the importance of moving beyond age- and developmental stage-based expectations of children's participation to more flexible expectations that are based on individual children's personalities and capacities.

Once these spaces have been established adults need to avoid intruding or invading: they must wait to be invited in. Such patience is a powerful gesture of respect in many cultures. Children still need to be mentored and encouraged, but harsh critique and strict controls are counter-productive. Children could also be employed to interpret one another's work for adults. One model for this patient engagement is based on the image of Jesus in Revelation, standing at the door and knocking.

These spaces might employ curricula that are more intentionally active and holistic in orientation. This could include, for example, reflective activities that allow adults and children to serve alongside each other where true partnership can be worked out in the context of ministry. They would also includes elements of curriculum that move beyond verbal and written activities, using creative arts as ways for younger children to express themselves non-verbally.

A number of participants emphasised that it is vital that parents be empowered to be leaders in these spaces, and be seen as the primary shapers of the spiritual and missional potential of their children. This would work against a common stereotype that sees the

Church's work with children as a "drop-off" activity in which the church becomes the surrogate "faith" parent in a child's life.

Most participants noted that the idea of "space" rightly implies that there need to be boundaries placed around these spaces. Adults and children must develop sensitive understandings of how this participation can best take place, as well as when children's participation may not be appropriate. Therefore there was some discussion about the distinctions between wanting to give power, but not authority, over to children. This is an area that could be explored further.

Discussions took new technology into account. Virtual space can be seen as a means of creating other kinds of hospitable space but care must be given to the intrusion of virtual space on geophysical space: neither children nor adults should be distracted by the pull of technology (i.e. always-on smartphones and the like).

Manfred Kohl's observations sparked significant discussion. Conference participants echoed the need for seminary curricula to be changed to prioritize the role of children as participants in mission. Similarly churches need to support these changes through providing scholarships for those who would study and advance research in this area. Accrediting bodies need to be so influenced that they prioritize the importance of this new discipline. Important lessons might be learned about how this could be done by observing the successes of the Holistic Child Development movement that stemmed from the work of Compassion International. In this way, passionate and effective trainers could be identified and online courses might be developed to expand the availability of relevant training.

If these changes are to happen there will need to be a number of national or denominational initiatives. We will need to work to encourage Christians of all denominations and organizational backgrounds to participate. Media attention would be needed to encourage these changes. Perhaps each national coalition should identify a contemporary issue affecting children which could serve as a platform for highlighting the importance of children in mission.

Finally, when asked to propose a new name for this area of study the groups were quite divided. Some suggestions were as follows:

- child growth and development
- holistic child development
- intergenerational studies
- child theology

The biggest challenge is finding a name that could translate easily into multiple languages and yet still carry the intended meaning of the new discipline.

Theme 8:

Children and Youth as Agents of Transformation and Mission

Editor's Introduction

Vinay Samuel builds his paper on the basis that Jesus came to inaugurate the Kingdom of God and he seeks to show "the biblical and theological basis for the claim that children and youth are agents of the mission of the Kingdom of God." The Kingdom has arrived in Jesus – the King – but it is, for the time being, both "yet and not yet." Samuel argues that the child is placed at the centre of the Kingdom and offers four ways in which this is so. Therefore he asserts that the child is an agent of the Kingdom and gives five perspectives on this. In passing he notes that "At the heart of the biblical understanding of human personhood is not the rights of a person but the sacredness and mystery of persons." Samuel touches on power and empowerment: "Empowerment language privileges the possession of power. The child in my view does not need empowerment for mission but release. … empowerment language continues to be significant in Christian mission. I believe we need to further explore a child's experience and understanding of empowerment. It is difficult to be just bearers of God's power in mission without acting as owners or exclusive possessors. Much of the scandal and dysfunction in Christian mission can be traced to problems in the area of power.

He concludes that “the child is not an object but a subject on the Kingdom of God … The child not only has capacity but agency and the Gospel account of the child … is the child’s agency in both defining, clarifying and advancing God’s Kingdom.

Vinay Samuel was unable to attend the conference. The conference chair, Dr Dan Brewster therefore read out a summarised version this paper. This version is the original. There are no responses.

PAPER 8

Children and Youth as Agents of Transformation and Mission

BY VINAY SAMUEL

Introduction

Our conviction that children and youth can be agents of God's Mission and transformational action in God's world is based on the teaching of Jesus concerning the place of children in the Kingdom of God.

Judith Gundry-Volf in her excellent study "To such belongs the Reign of God – Jesus and Children"[1] concludes, "The Gospels teach the reign of God as a children's world where children are the measure, rather than do not measure up to adults, where the small are great and the great must become small, that is, the Gospel teaching calls the adult world radically into question".[2]

In this paper I will seek to establish the biblical and theological basis for the claim that children and youth are agents of the mission of the Kingdom of God and identify their particular contribution to the mission of God's kingdom.

The Kingdom of God

Dr N.T. Wright titles his inaugural lecture at St Mary's College, University of St Andrew's (26 Oct 2011) as "Imagining the Kingdom:

[1] Judith Gundry-Volf, "To such as these belongs the Reign of God: Jesus and Children" in *Theology Today,* 56 January 2000: 469-480.

[2] *Ibid*., 480.

Mission and Theology in early Christianity." His main contention is that the Gospels as the story of Jesus are the story of how Israel's God became King of the whole world. He shows how Matthew and Mark draw heavily on Daniel 7 where God confronts and overthrows the kingdoms of the world. He asserts that the royal announcement of the Kingdom of God was at the heart of Paul's evangelistic and church planting activity against the backdrop of the royal authority and rule of the Roman Emperor.

In relation to the teaching of the Kingdom of God in the Gospel, we can identify two clear dimensions. The Kingdom is the fulfilment of the promise of God to rule the world. This has arrived in the person and work of Jesus and so is a continuation of God's rule of Israel. The Kingdom is also the entry into human order of an entirely different – even an inverted – order of reality with values and understandings that are radically different, like the child at the centre, rather than the periphery, of society.

The Kingdom of God in the Gospels is integrally tied to the Great Commission of God to his people (Matthew 28:18-20) and to the Great Commandment to love one another (John 13:14). The Kingdom begins a new creation (Ephesians 2:11-22) reconciling the world to God, hostile human communities to each other, and begins with a community of mutual love and a mission to proclaim the kingdom and invite all people to be part of it.

The transcendental order that the Kingdom brings is made possible in human society by the death and resurrection of Jesus and by the pouring out of His Holy Spirit. The Kingdom order of life, its way of organizing relationships, its way of valuing life and activity, its way of explaining and organizing reality is the order that the resurrection of Christ confirms and makes possible. The affirmation of Jesus' sacrifice on the cross by God raising him up from the dead gives confidence to the church to engage in a transforming mission to enable the order of the kingdom to become the order of our society and communities.

The Gospels also identify aspects of the connection of the two orders of reality, the Kingdom which arrives in Jesus and the world. It is 'yet and not yet.' The future is in the present but does not displace

it. The possibilities of the future can be experienced in some measure in the present. They can be grasped and worked at. The kingdom in the present operates primarily at the periphery rather than the centre of the world. It uses people, provisions, structures and systems that have their home in the periphery and so brings transformation from there, overwhelming, displacing and transforming the centres created inhabited and ruled by the forces of the world. The Kingdom of God in the present accepts the penultimate aspects of its presence while it moves history to the ultimate. Jesus teaches that some ultimate judgments must be withheld and penultimate judgments made about the identity of those who may ultimately never be part of God's kingdom. This was not pragmatism. The ultimate is still the standard of judgment. The penultimate nature of the Kingdom is the recognition of the nature of the process of moving the present to God's ordained future as shaped by humility and grace.

Pauline teaching does not use the term "Kingdom" but reflects its foundation in the Kingdom teaching in the key themes that Paul develops. The work of Christ as bringing the new creation, fulfilling the messianic promise (Isaiah 65:17-25; John 13:34; Luke 5:39; 1 Corinthians 11:25; 2 Corinthians 5:17f; Galatians 6:15; Ephesians 4:24; Colossians 3:10), reconciling all things to God, to establish his rule (Colossians 1:20) and transforming persons and creation (2 Corinthians 5:17) all reflect the nature of the Kingdom of God in the world.

The Child and the Kingdom

Jesus' teaching about God's kingdom places the child at the centre of the Kingdom (Matthew 10:13-16; 19:13-15; Luke 18:15-17). Biblical scholars like Judith Gundry-Volf, Dawn DeVries, Robin Maas, Jurgen Moltmann, Margaret MacDonald, and Peter Spitaler agree that Jesus continues in the Old Testament tradition that sees children as God's gifts and signs of his promise and blessing. Further, Jesus presents a child as first, the model of entry into the Kingdom of God and second a model of greatness in the Kingdom.

1. Model of Entry into the Kingdom

In Matthew, Jesus teaches that the kingdom belongs to the poor (Matthew 5:3-12). It is clear that children share with the poor the state of being socially marginalized, even excluded from God's favour. At best they occupy a peripheral position in human kingdoms. Jesus reverses this view and makes the Kingdom belong to children and the poor. Further, the child is described as the model for entry into the Kingdom. The stress is not the entry of the child into the Kingdom but the reception of God's reign by the child. Judith Gundry-Volf[3] discusses Eggers' work that suggests that neither obedience nor obligation to the Law is a requirement for entry into the Kingdom. Neither is required of the child, who will receive the Kingdom as God's gift, a favour he joyfully accepts.

2. The Child and Greatness

In Matthew 18:1-5 Jesus teaches that the humility that the child personifies is the quality of greatness in God's kingdom. Childhood itself is seen by Jesus as a state of humility. It is not what the child does but what the child is. The adult must revert to childhood status or childlikeness as a disposition, a quality of mind. The status of childhood is a status of utter dependence on the other. To trust the other, receive the other's favours without question and joyfully is the disposition of the child.

This is contrasted in Jesus' teaching by the preoccupation with high status by those who seek greatness, even in God's Kingdom. Such pre-occupation with one's status creates barriers for the child and others of low or no status and invites God's severe judgment (Matthew 18:6). One's ability to serve the children and the lowly for the sake of the Kingdom is undermined by a desire for status and enhanced by an attitude of childlike humility.

[3] *Op cit.*, 473.

3. The Child as the Sign of the Kingdom

The identification of the presence of Jesus with the presence of the welcomed child in the midst of God's people affirms that the child is the sign of God's reign. When two or three gather in Jesus' name he is present. He is present when a child is welcomed and placed at the centre in the life of the community of God's people.

The church has a continuing tradition of the Christ Child. Irenaeus wrote that Jesus became a child to sanctify childhood. Jesus went through all ages of life to sanctify them. In Jesus the Child we understand our relationship with our Father in Heaven. Childhood is therefore not a stage to grow out of but a status to keep at the centre of our journey with God. The human child becomes, in the teaching of Christ, the sign of Christ's real presence – a sacrament of the Kingdom of God. The child in his finitude can represent the infinitude of God as he stands before God and just receives from him.

In Isaiah 7:14 the virgin bearing a child is a messianic promise and a sign of hope. The virgin's child is a sign of the future that God promises and fulfils. Even at the consummation of the new creation the child is central (Isaiah 4:6-9). So every human child also, when welcomed and treasured reveals the presence of the Christ child and the mission of the Christ child (Luke 2:34-38).

4. Child and Spiritual Threat

In Matthew 18:5-6 Jesus teaches that a child can be subject to spiritual danger. The child who intuitively, freely and joyfully receives God's reign can have obstacles placed in her path, preventing her from receiving God's reign. The sin that human society creates and nurtures places children in mortal peril. Christ will protect his little ones but will also deal most harshly with those who cause children to sin.

The Child as Agent of the Kingdom

1. Personhood and the Child

Human persons are agents through their presence, their testimony/witness and their action on behalf of themselves or others. Human personhood is complex and mysterious and cannot be reduced to concepts and propositions. Mystery always surrounds personhood. The mysteriousness of human personhood is particularly evident in the mystery that surrounds a child. We may use 'potential' quite often to describe a child but 'mystery' reflects our feelings and sense better. Mystery calls for reverence. So in Jesus' teaching where the child reflects the reality, the wonder and the mystery of the Kingdom, Jesus is reverencing the child.[4]

The child's world is a relational world. A child is always in a relationship, understands and lives out life as a set of relationships not just actions. The child as a part of the Kingdom advances the Kingdom as a set of relationships with the Lord of the Kingdom. Kingdom advancement is not primarily a strategy or a system but a personal agency, building on and developing relationships. This requires that the personhood of the agent is central. This helps to understand why Jesus privileged a child as the model and representative of the Kingdom.

At the heart of the biblical understanding of human personhood is not the rights of a person but the sacredness and mystery of persons. The child's intuitive recognition of the sacred and openness to the sacred makes her the obvious representative and agent of the Kingdom. The immediate acceptance by the child of an invitation to pray to God reflects the openness to the sacred in all cultures. Again, a child often steps out in faith when someone he trusts gives the invitation. Stepping out in faith is easier and more natural to a child. She does not need the security of knowledge with every "i" dotted and

[4] http://www.theosthinktank.co.uk/comment/2012/10/02/audio-dr-rowan-williams-at-theos-annual-lecture-2012. The text can be found at: http://rowanwilliams.archbishopofcanterbury.org/articles.php/2636/

every "t" crossed and the security of material possessions to step into a world of faith. The child's dependence on the other that he trusts with little sight or evidence is what makes the child in Jesus' teaching the model of how to enter into God's Kingdom.

2. The Child and God's Rule

Jesus' teaching of the Kingdom questions, relativizes and even replaces the powers that dominate nations and societies. The Kingdoms of this world will become the kingdom of our Lord and King. In his monumental work, "Religion in Human Evolution, from the Paleolithic to the Axial Age", Robert Bellah[5] charts the emergence of what are termed "Axial Religions." These are religions like the Old Testament Religion, Buddhism, Hinduism and Confucianism that develop ethical frameworks that balance the power of the state or its embodiment the King.

In announcing the arrival of God's Kingdom, Jesus announces the direct rule of God on earth but places a vulnerable and powerless child at the centre of such rule. The Kingdom of God in and through Jesus sees the child as the agent of God's reign and power in the world. The principle of value reversal is presented here, the first is the last and the last first, the master is the servant and the servant is really the master, and the child represents the mystery and agency of power in God's kingdom. It would not be an extreme statement to assert that we can better understand the nature of power in God's kingdom through the eyes, experience and agency of the child. The King of the Kingdom marches in chains to his death, seemingly powerless in the presence of Imperial human power. He embraces vulnerability and powerlessness. He allows himself to suffer like a child meekly taking his punishment. How can a child not represent this King?

3. Welcoming the Kingdom and the Child

In Jesus' teaching "whoever welcomes a little child in my name welcomes me" (Matthew 18:5), the child is also the welcomer of the

[5] Robert Bellah, *Religion in Human Evolution, from the Paleolithic to the Axial Age* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2011).

Kingdom. The child's humility, his utter dependence on God's favour, the child's immediate acceptance of the Kingdom as the eternal that is now and is present due to the presence of the King, the openness of the child to others with the material need to trust others to provide, all affirm the child's station at the entrance to the Kingdom of God as its welcomer.

The child's agency in God's Kingdom is compatible with the vision of wholeness in the teaching of Jesus. Dawn DeVries, commentating on Schleiermacher, wrote, "The insights of childhood are not illusions that must be replaced with the cold hard facts of adult reality".[6] Jesus taught that God "has hidden these things from the wise and learned, and revealed them to little children" (Matthew 11:25). The child's vision of the Kingdom can receive and grasp its nature as at once in heaven and on earth, here now and yet to come, a foretaste and a fulfilment in the future. The child accepts the Kingdom's own experience of the future.

4. The Child and the Holy Spirit

The prophecy of Joel (2:28) that the Spirit will be poured on "all people" asserts that the previously excluded groups – women excluded by gender, youth and children excluded by age – are now included in the gift of the Holy Spirit. The Old Testament has several passages where children lead in praise to God suggesting their praise comes from God. The speech of praise is the gift of the Holy Spirit. Adults are often tempted to construct even God's speech for the world. Children are content to receive it and voice it. This is the gift of the Spirit.

The Joel prophecy speaks of the gift of dreams, seen in prophecy as a legitimate form of revelation. Children and youth are not excluded from this gift of direct revelation. A missiological thrust of announcing to the nation and calling them to God is evident in the prophecy. A new speech and truth is granted through the pouring out of the Sprit as part of the promise of God of a new relationship and

[6] Dawn DeVries, "Toward a Theology of Childhood" in *Interpretation* 55.2 (April 2001):162-67, 165.

covenant with God in the new creation. It links with the prophecy in Jeremiah 31:33 where an immediate knowledge of God is given to those in the new covenant, a knowledge not mediated by the Torah but by the Spirit. Sons and daughters, old men and young men, those usually excluded, those considered weak, powerless and hopeless, the underprivileged people, get anointed with the Spirit and become witnesses to and agents of God's transforming mission. Joel predicted the future and Peter saw that the future had arrived at the first Pentecost.

The praise of God is the witness to God's faithfulness and promise and is a missional activity. The inclusion of the child as part of the covenant community is evident in the Old Testament. What is highlighted in Joel's prophecy is that children are included in the covenant acts of witness of God's covenantal faithfulness to the world. They are endowed with the Holy Spirit to be such witnesses and perform primarily by their praises. The praise of God recognizes who God is and also recounts how God acts. The Spirit's enabling of the child to praise God is enabling the child in her mission. In Matthew 21:14-16 God prepares praise for himself out of the mouths of infants and babies. This is asserted against the background of the blindness and refusal of the chief priests and scribes to recognize who Jesus is. The Holy Spirit enables the child to praise Jesus as the Spirit also enables him to recognize Jesus and identify him as Lord.

5. The Particular Mission Witness of Children and Youth

In the teaching of Jesus, a child defines humility that is part of God's kingdom (Mark 9:33-37). The humility that is necessary to receive the gifts of God of salvation and entry into his Kingdom requires a sense of total dependence on the grace of God. The child finds this is a natural inclination; the adult needs to unlearn much and relearn such dependency.

A. Wonder and the Miraculous

The humility of the child is intensely linked with the child's sense of wonder. This sense of wonder enables the child to focus on the person of Christ rather than his actions. In my experience of sharing with

children the Gospel stories of the miracles of Jesus, I am amazed that the child does not get pre-occupied with the details of the miraculous but the person of Jesus who can do such wonderful things. The child's faith is deepened by the miracle. The adult looks for confirmation of his faith through the miraculous.

B. Text and Truth

There is a particularity in the way a child owns and interprets the biblical narrative and text. Adult focus on propositional truth means we cannot see a child presenting truth propositionally. We see a child's narration of a biblical truth as primarily personal and experiential and so possibly not stable or reliable. This is one reason why there appears to be resistance to seeing a child as an agent of God's mission as some recent discussion among evangelical mission activists and scholars suggests.

The child's exploration of the biblical text is a necessary resource to the community of God's people in modelling an approach that joins humility with wonder. It would be naïve to assume that the contemporary managerial, market based and consumption oriented culture does not influence our handling of the biblical text and particularly for mission. The child's approach to scripture may well serve as a corrective and even healing of the way biblical text is used in mission.

C. Mission and Power

Mission and power is a major theme and significant reflection and study has been done in the area. In my own work, this area has figured prominently in the recent past. Adults are as concerned about the ownership of power as its use in mission. Empowerment language privileges the possession of power. The child in my view does not need empowerment for mission but release. Whether it is mission as proclamation or mission as transformation, empowerment language continues to be significant in Christian mission. I believe we need to further explore a child's experience and understanding of empowerment. It is difficult to be just bearers of God's power in mission without acting as owners or exclusive possessors. Much of the

scandal and dysfunction in Christian mission can be traced to problems in the area of power.

The child as model of greatness in the teaching of Jesus places a very different narrative at the centre of our understanding of power. The child as the one who naturally serves, who is unimpressed by status or standing, is the model of greatness and so the model of power in the Kingdom.

We are called to learn from the child how to be a bearer of the power God gifts us for servant hood and mission.

D. The Presence of Christ

Another contribution of the child's agency of the Kingdom is the recovery of understanding of the Kingdom of God as the Presence of Christ. Jesus teaches that the child herself represents his presence in our midst where children are experiencing the transforming mission of the Kingdom. Where children are servants of such mission we can assume the presence of Christ without doubting. Children are the definitive signs of Christ's presence in our midst. This should shape the way we design and execute our transformational mission.

Conclusion

While we value the potential of children for spiritual life and maturity, we must also recognize that in the teaching of Jesus the child is not an object but a subject on the Kingdom of God with all the qualities of a person. The child not only has capacity but agency and the Gospel account of the child in the context of the Kingdom is the child's agency in both defining, clarifying and advancing God's Kingdom.

Theme 9:

Redeemed Adult/Child Dyad and the *Missio Dei*: Speaking Back to Missiology

Editor's Introduction

This chapter was originally given as a response to Crocker's paper. The editors took the decision to place it at the end of this compendium as a chapter in its own right. Dave Scott raises some important issues which are worthy of further reflection.

He begins by exploring the use of language, noting the inadequacy of our theological discourse about children and young people: "Fully replacing a theological understanding of children that is characterized by domination and dependency with one that recognizes their true potential may require theological deconstruction and rebuilding on a scale far grander than any of us realize today. … [Missiology] is built around certain limited understandings of the nature of children and the relationships between adults and children, may need to undergo some significant revision as we continue our work."

Scott uses the term 'dyad' to refer to the relations between our consideration of "what part of the Church is at the 'centre' and who is the 'other'." Dyads, therefore, provide a way of analysing power structures and observing change in our thinking and practice. Scott gives some historical examples from Christian mission beginning with Peter's visit to Cornelius in Acts 10 through to the issue of the adult/child dyad. As missiologists and child advocates, we need to struggle "with the Biblical

evidence and historical theology in light of contemporary concerns and developing concepts of agency, equality and empowerment in order to better understand God's intentions … [so] that followers of Christ be involved in their communities and societies to revise and redeem those practices and structures that either intentionally or unintentionally discriminate against the disempowered party, and to work towards more biblically-informed relationships among all Christians." Scott goes on to examine issues of empowerment and participation and a redeemed adult/child dyad.

Scott closes by applying his argument to the contemporary context in terms of the missio Dei and intercultural partnerships. He concludes that "We are at a critical moment in the history of the Church, when our understanding of the value and potential of children is increasingly trending towards one that more fully honours the dignity God has bestowed upon them. Therefore, it is incumbent upon us to step into the larger conversations about mission that often are taking place without us, and advocate not just for the role of children, but for how reframing our understanding of them ought to affect us more broadly".

PAPER 9

The Redeemed Adult/Child Dyad and the *Missio Dei*: Speaking Back to Missiology

BY DAVE H. SCOTT

Introduction

If you have ever been to the United States, it may surprise you to know that since 1893 the US has operated on the metric standard. As an American myself, I find this difficult to believe. My elementary education in the 1970s and 80s – which required cross-training in both the American yards, pounds and quarts and the metric meters, grams and litres – simply did not match the experience of my everyday life, which left metric measurement as a task for the classroom. Sure, I bought soft drinks in one-liter bottles, but in virtually every other area of my life – the miles I drive in my car, the cups of flour it takes to bake a cake, the extra pounds I'm looking to burn off with my exercise – my experience simply does not match the law. Legally, I know that this is because the US Federal government has allowed the conversion process for the last 120 years to be voluntary, and Americans are stubborn people. They will not change even if they are forced to.

But there are some very practical issues around this, too. Changing common units of measure would have enormous consequences. It is far more than stripping the "inch" units off of the rulers in classrooms across the country, and moving from "letter" to "A4" paper. The decision that was made by then US Secretary of State John Quincy Adams in 1821 to establish the inch-pound system as the official national standard was both a recognition of how common and standardized this system of weights and measures had already become, and also a statement about the independence of the American way. As such, changing today would mean converting the

national awareness of the acceptable cost of a gallon of gas to a litre of gas (although no one is making me say "petrol" – that is simply a bridge too far). But perhaps even more foundationally, it would suddenly make many contemporary intangible concepts archaic. Aphorisms like, "walk a mile in someone else's shoes," and, "you give them an inch, they take a mile," would suddenly become quaint.[1]

In many ways, it is a task much like this one that we are in the midst of this week. Reconceptualizing children in mission is critical to missiology not just so that the Church can more appropriately prioritize work with children, or enhance the effectiveness of her work with them. Re-evaluating the Christian understanding of the dignity and value of children in mission and their role in it has far-reaching consequences because, just like replacing the inch with the centimetre, missiologists have been applying an anaemic understanding of children to their understandings of mission for centuries. Fully replacing a theological understanding of children that is characterized by domination and dependency with one that recognizes their true potential may require theological deconstruction and rebuilding on a scale far grander than any of us realize today. This is why it is so essential that we do our work well this week, and continue to ask about the on-going implications of those ideas.

In order to illustrate this point, I will begin first by sharing some lessons to be learned from cognitive anthropology about human brain processes in order to demonstrate just how embedded a single idea can be throughout the entirety of a worldview. Then, I will argue that the re-evaluation of relationships and the re-estimation of the value of persons – such as what we are doing this week – is entirely in line with missiological thought throughout the history of Christianity. Following this I will offer some basic concepts that are central to the redemption of what I call the "adult/child dyad" and then I will show how applying this redeemed dyad to several key missiological themes can help to revise, clarify, and enrich missiological discourse and have

[1] William Harris, "Why isn't the U.S. on the Metric System?" from HowStuffWorks.com http://science.howstuffworks.com/why-us-not-on-metric-system.htm (Last modified Oct 4, 2011, accessed Feb 2, 2013).

relevance even to mission that would not otherwise directly be concerned with children.

The Ubiquity of a Metaphor in Human Thought: Lessons from Schema Theory

According to cognitive anthropology, schemas are the basic building blocks of human thought. Technically, schemas are, "learned, internalized patterns of thought-feeling that mediate both the interpretation of on-going experience and the reconstruction of memories".[2] Schemas are the discrete units of understanding that our brains use in order to process knowledge. Furthermore, there is a priority of different schemas. As a number of theorists have shown, the most basic schemas are those that describe early, tangible experiences. For example, each of us learned the schemas for "warmth," "hunger," "pain," "up," and "mother" as infants. We were experts on each of these ideas well before we were able to articulate the words, whatever our first languages might have been. The words simply gave further organization to these universal experiences.

However, not all concepts are as tangible as these. Indeed, most schemas are heavily processed combinations of existing schemas, which in turn borrow from others, until one works back to those basic ideas that draw the most concretely from our lived experiences. So, when I "clean up" my office, I am drawing on the English term "up," but largely in the metaphorical sense of up meaning good or improved. Similarly, the sense of "clean" I am referring to is actually derived from the absence of dirt, even though I am probably not scrubbing the floors and windows. Instead, knowing my office, all I am really doing is piling the catastrophic collection of random scraps of paper into neat piles, and perhaps putting books back on shelves. In any case, this intended meaning is easily understood, since other

[2] Claudia Strauss, "Models and Motives" in *Human Motives and Cultural Models*, eds. Roy G. D'Andrade and Claudia Strauss (Cambridge University Press, 1992).

English speakers are likely to intuitively know that I am not claiming to be scrubbing my ceiling, despite the literal meanings of the terms "clean" and "up." This is especially important since the human understanding of the directional term "up" is foundational and learned very early in life in the most tangible of ways. We learn "up" to be good because we know that it is good to be held. Many American children learn the word early on, simply because it is the most efficient way to move from the relative isolation of the floor to the warm embrace and safety of a parent's arms. But it is that understanding of "up" that we take and use in so many different contexts – going up the stairs, reading up on a topic, clamming up, the upshot, upside down etc. While some of these uses are more metaphorical than others, they all bear some vestige of our earliest, tangible experiences of the concept, while being modified by later experiences and understandings into a conceptual gestalt, or schema.[3]

It is precisely this pattern of schema recycling that creates such a challenge in theology, since theology is unavoidably about the articulation of abstract concepts. It is the endless attempt to put divine transcendence into words; quite literally "God-talk." As I often observe, even though Jesus encouraged us to pray to God as our Father, in order to understand the significance of this invitation we must hold it in tension with the reality that God is not, in fact, our human father. This admission does not take away from the deeper spiritual significance that, whereas we know that biologically each of us is the product of a mother and a father (regardless of the relationship we had with those people), we are all ultimately, and more rightly, the result of the love of our Heavenly Father. By the same token, if our experience of human Fatherhood is deeply flawed, we will have difficulty grasping the extensive and significant meaning that Jesus intended for us to draw from that identification. Those who

[3] Gilles Fauconnier and Mark Turner, *The Way We Think: Conceptual Blending and the Mind's Hidden Complexities* (New York, NY: Basic Books, 2002); George Lakoff and Mark Johnson, *Metaphors We Live By* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1980); Claudia Strauss and Naomi Quinn, *A Cognitive Theory of Cultural Meaning* (Publications of the Society for Psychological Anthropology, Cambridge University Press, 1997).

have struggled lifelong with the absence or abandonment of our human fathers typically and understandably have trouble reconciling that experience with the deeply loving understanding of a heavenly Father that Jesus intended.

This is unavoidable, and inherent to the human development of theology. The construction of the ineffable transcendence of God through the combining of concrete metaphors, or schemas, means that changing or revising one of those fundamental schemas can result in enormous and unexpected ramifications throughout our entire theological system, depending on the ways in which that schema has been re-used. So, too, should we expect that missiology which is built around certain limited understandings of the nature of children and the relationships between adults and children, may need to undergo some significant revision as we continue our work from here.

Children as Agents of Mission: A Natural Development of Missiology

As daunting as such an enterprise of theological reconstruction might appear to be, the truth is that this is a perfectly normal place in which a missiologist should expect to find him or herself. One of the key emphases of missiological concern has always been on how those who see themselves as being in the Church perceive those who they see as being outside of it (i.e. the "other"). This has been further refined through the ages to focus on the differences between those who are at the centre of the Church (or who perceive themselves to be so) vis-à-vis those who are not. The only issue that changes from era to era and place to place is what part of the Church is at the "centre" and who is the "other." For the purposes of this article, I will refer to that relational equation as a "dyad." One way of understanding missiology throughout the ages is as a discipline that employs theology, history and social sciences in an integrative, praxiological way to transform and redeem dyads at the boundaries between church and non-church.

Therefore, it should not surprise us at all that missiology is now considering the role of children in mission.

Over most of the history of Christian mission, the dyads of greatest concern in western missiological discourse have been cultural (the west/non-west dyad) or religious (the Christian/non-Christian dyad). However, since the middle of the twentieth century greater effort in missiological conversations everywhere has been committed to using many of the same tools to re-evaluate all manner of power relationships inside and outside the church. In every case, the conclusion of this re-evaluation has consistently been to move towards increased equality or, in those cases when equality was not yet seen as possible, mutuality.

Perhaps the earliest instance of this was when Peter received the invitation to visit Cornelius in Acts 10. At that time, the missional issue was whether this new Gospel of Christ was relevant to Gentiles, or to Jewish believers alone? In this case the relationship in question was a Jewish Christian/Gentile dyad. The rest of the New Testament bore witness to the expansiveness of God's missionary vision, as the early church was confronted with the need to embrace all parts of their society, Jew and Gentile alike.

A few centuries later, as European Christendom gained in numbers and influence, missional questions shifted to wondering how the "heathen" outside of the Holy Roman Empire were intended to fit in God's economy (the Christendom/world dyad). By end of the fifteenth century Jesuit missionaries had begun venturing out to spread the Gospel in Asia and the conquistadors began setting out to the new world. This was a new form of mission that was global in scope, rather than just focused within the geographical borders and immediate neighbours of the existing church. Looking back on the motives for this new form of mission is a confusing and often discouraging task. However, the fact that mission of this kind was attempted at all demonstrates a shift in the appraisal of the Christendom/world dyad. The world was worthy of mission, and the European church saw value (even if it was sometimes self-serving) in sharing the Gospel.

However, this type of mission necessitated raising further questions about the relative value of the people that had converted to Christianity, especially given that this was occasionally accomplished only through force. Were these new Christians and the churches that were founded to support them of equal value to those in Christendom, or were they somehow inferior? This was a slightly different dyad under consideration – the Christendom Christian/non-western convert dyad. Dilemmas such as the rites controversy in China were in some senses emblematic of this challenge, as well as the long-standing practice of extraction and re-enculturation that tended to dominate local mission practice. A common component of all of these issues was the nature of the west/non-west dyad: how did the church in the west perceive Christians in the non-west?

By 1910 this issue had still not been satisfactorily resolved, such that participation in the Edinburgh missionary conference included only 17 non-western representatives, all of whom were from Asia. Furthermore, the perspectives of other cultures that were offered at that conference were reported almost exclusively through the voices and observations of western missionaries who were working in those places.[4] The implicit message of this choice is that although Protestants in the west had a global vision for the church, they did not yet recognize the legitimacy of the churches that had been planted to speak or participate for themselves. However, of the three Asian representatives who were invited to address the assembly, V. S. Azariah's comments were perhaps the most noteworthy when he stated, "The problem of race relations is one of the most serious problems confronting the church today…the relationship between the European missionaries and the India workers is far from what it ought to be, and a certain aloofness, a lack of mutual understanding and openness, a great lack of frank intercourse and friendliness exists throughout the country".[5]

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[4] Brian Stanley, *The World Missionary Conference, Edinburgh 1910* (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans Pub. Co, 2009).

[5] Quoted in Scott W. Sunquist, *Understanding Christian Mission: Participation in Suffering and Glory* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2013).

It was not until the second half of the twentieth century that the west/non-west dyad began to be seen as a place for churches in the non-west to receive the respect and opportunities for engagement that they deserved. Just as the European colonial powers liberated their colonies, the newly-formed World Council of Churches began regularly holding global gatherings outside of Europe and North America, and many important non-western church leaders were given the opportunity to speak into these conferences. Furthermore, the 1970s saw the development and legitimization of contextual theologies as a part of global Christian discourse.[6]

Along with this, western missionary endeavours have increasingly shifted to a paradigm of partnership with churches elsewhere, rather than the more independent and isolationist approaches to mission they had learned. While the missionary patterns of today still struggle with challenges regarding how to effectively partner across cultures when certain aspects (such as funding) are out of balance between the two entities, western partners are far more likely to have great expectations on the potential of non-western churches than ever before.[7]

One way of seeing this history is as a progressive realization by the church in the west of the legitimacy and importance of the participation of the church in the non-west. As I have mapped out above, this process started with recognizing the need for other cultures and peoples to know the Gospel. From here, once the modern missions movement had begun there was an increased recognition on that not only were these other "daughter" churches legitimate, but after two centuries of development and progressive independence they had a unique contribution to make to global mission. Once this happened, their requests to actively participate were finally heard in the west – first as quiet spectators, but increasingly as peers. This was a very different perspective on the

[6] Francis Anekwe Oborji, *Concepts of Mission: The Evolution of Contemporary Missiology* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2006).

[7] James F. Engel and William A. Dyrness, *Changing the Mind of Missions: Where Have We Gone Wrong?* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2000).

west/non-west dyad than could have been conceived by William Carey in his era.

In the second half of the twentieth century, while some of these other developments were still in process, theologians of all kinds were also hard at work reconsidering a number of other important dyads within the Church. Each of these represented an opportunity to re-evaluate relationships between those in the church with the most power in contrast to those with little to no power. These included considering the established church/oppressed dyad through the development of Liberation Theology and the male/female dyad as explored in feminist theology.

In each of these cases, the Church has painstakingly struggled with the Biblical evidence and historical theology in light of contemporary concerns and developing concepts of agency, equality and empowerment in order to better understand God's intentions. Yet, in each case the resulting conclusions have required that followers of Christ be involved in their communities and societies to revise and redeem those practices and structures that either intentionally or unintentionally discriminate against the disempowered party, and to work towards more biblically-informed relationships among all Christians. Furthermore, the task of doing mission forces these on-going re-evaluations. It seems clear that God designed the missional task in this way, and responsible Christians cannot avoid it. Our theology, and our missiology, must change over time as the realities in our world change and as the Church attempts to remain a relevant witness to the Gospel of Christ.

Lessons from Placing a Child at the Center of Missiology

However, as we consider the role of children in mission it would seem we have a justifiably "special" case. Whereas in each of these other situations the entity in view has been an adult who is expected to take responsibility for themselves, this is an expectation we dare not place on children. Instead, it is the responsibility of parents and other adults to protect and care for them. As a result, the Church has been very

hesitant to the vulnerable situations that recognizing children as full participants in mission might expose them. But as child advocates we know that, left unattended, in practice the adult/child dyad too often devolves into a destructive relationship of absolute domination and dependency. Furthermore, whether we recognize their agency or not, children are agents of mission. A Ghanaian proverb suggests that no one needs to teach a child about God. I would suggest that, in much the same way, if it is indeed true that as evangelists our task is to be witnesses, then the heart of a child that has been shaped by their encounter with the person of Jesus is one of the most profound witnesses that can be found.

As a result, one of the central themes for this conference has been to present an argument for the ways in which this "special case" thinking has been overplayed, and how many new avenues for effective mission are opened up once adults engage children as agents of Kingdom transformation, rather as simply objects of adult concern. I will not go into great detail regarding how this can be done. Rather, I will highlight only a selection of ideas from the child participation literature which I expect we will have addressed and redeemed for missional purposes.

1. Children are Living Representations of the Kingdom

First, the basis for child participation must start by recognizing the unique temporal paradox that childhood represents. Children are both now and not yet, living representations of the Kingdom. They are developing beings, with capacities that are changing and increasing all the time. By giving them opportunities to participate we allow them to move faster towards fulfilling their potential and release more and more of the dependency that early childhood inevitably represents.[8]

At the same time, children have unique contributions to make now. As I often remind my friends and students, there are things that

[8] McConnell, Douglas, Jennifer Orona, and Paul Stockley, eds., *Understanding God's Heart for Children: Toward a Biblical Framework* (Colorado Springs, CO: Authentic; 2007). Published in partnership with World Vision.

children can do for the church as children that adults are simply incapable of doing. If we wait to engage children as agents of mission until they have grown up, we will have missed out on all of those unique contributions. And the more effort we put into discovering what those contributions might be, the better off the mission of the Church will be for eternity.

But because they are developing beings, we must also be extremely cautious about managing our expectations of what they can achieve. Adults should never place on children more weight than they are developmentally able to bear. However, the record of the church is that we tend to be too cautious in this direction for our own good. On the other hand, when children do make important contributions, we need to be humble and open enough to recognize them as such and, if necessary, adjust our plans in light of those contributions.

The not-yet-adult status of children requires that, at least in the initial stages, adults must retain responsibility for what takes place. Therefore, it is essential to the participatory process to create safe spaces for children, ensuring that the environment for child participation allows freedom to make mistakes, to be creative, and assures children that when mistakes are made, someone else will be there to help them. However, a different dimension of creating safety inevitably involves ensuring that their involvement is entirely voluntary. No child should be forced to participate against their will, and children need to feel free to end their participation at any time.

However, over time children need to begin sharing responsibility for what takes place. Tearfund asserts that there are three essential spokes in the wheel of child participation, which are all supported by a core of respect for children. However, once that respect for children has been established—by listening to children, asking for their opinions, and responding to them appropriately—this makes it possible for children to be given opportunities, responsibility and appropriate support. Therefore, as children are given the information and encouragement they need to participate, and as they are given opportunities to do so in meaningful ways, they also need to share, at

least in a mediated way, in the outcomes of their choices.[9] This is most graphically represented in Hart's Ladder of Participation, which helps to place different types of child participation on a continuum, from situations where no children are genuinely participating, to those cases where children are essentially working on their own, and only involve adults at their discretion.[10] As children are given more opportunities to participate and gain greater experience (or, as the facilitator learns how to better work with them), greater opportunities for participation can be offered.

The end result of all of these insights ought to be the cultivation of an expectant but tempered optimism. This should not be based on blind faith, but rather in the successful experiences that will be built with children as we continue to risk and encourage them in their abilities to make vital contributions to mission.

Furthermore, engaging children as participants ought to afford the opportunity to redeem the adult/child dyad in meaningful ways. To be an adult in a redeemed adult/child dyad should not be associated with paternalism, domination, or absolute control. Rather, the adult should see their side of the dyad as being one of compassionate responsibility; an opportunity for mentoring and empowering of youth; a chance to serve others and share their expertise; and an exercise in humility. Ultimately, being an adult should be seen as the opportunity to understand the Christ-like use of power and authority.

2. A Redeemed Adult/Child Dyad

Similarly, being a child in a redeemed adult/child dyad should not be characterized by utter dependency and powerlessness. Rather, the redeemed dyad should help the child see themselves as being given the freedom and opportunity to be creative; to learn and contribute;

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[9] Paul Stephenson, Steve Gourley, Glenn Miles and Rachel Blackman, *Child Participation,* Vol. 7. Roots resources. (Teddington, Middlesex, UK: Tearfund, 2004).

[10] Roger A. Hart, *Children's Participation: From Tokenism to Citizenship* (Florence, Italy: UNICEF International Child Development Centre, 1992).

to fulfil their potential in a safe environment; to experience loving concern; to be protected; and to have the opportunity to decline the offer to participate in the first place. Ultimately, being a child should offer the chance to redeem the dignity of submission and obedience while affirming the integrity of personhood.

Applying the Insights

In the following section I will demonstrate how placing the insights we have gained from the redeemed adult/child dyad in juxtaposition with key missiological concepts can help to better inform both. In so doing, I hope to honour the hard work of understanding the role of children in mission we are doing this week while also further nuancing our own conclusions.

1. The Missio Dei and the Adult/Child Dyad

The missio Dei concept emerged from the work of Karl Barth, who was reacting against the dominant perspective that mission was primarily about the actions of the church in the world. His argument was that all mission emerged, first of all, from the character of the Trinitarian God: God is missionary by nature. This nature is reflected in the Creation and repeated in the pursuit , of God for all people throughout Biblical history. Some have explored this idea further by identifying the missional relationship between the members of the Godhead. The Father sent the Son and Jesus sent the Holy Spirit. Therefore, the mission we engage in is not a mission of the Church, but rather a mission that moves from a Trinitarian God to the world he created and sustains by his power.

Of course, this doctrine has also been used to redefine mission in entirely secular terms. Proponents of this view saw the mission of God as being so expansive that the missional work of the church was effectively excluded. The theologian most associated with this

perspective was J.C. Hoekendijk[11], who harboured a deep distrust of the Church. As a result, some contemporary theologians struggle with the aptness of the missio Dei for contemporary mission. Nevertheless, as Bosch notes, the ability to centre the task of mission provides a strength that no other concept in theology of mission has been able to match or exceed.[12] Therefore, it is difficult to imagine not including it as a central concept for mission in the years to come.

What has not been explored, however, is the significance of a redeemed adult/child dyad when considering this important missiological doctrine. If God is our Father, and He invites us, as his children, to participate in His mission, it seems more than appropriate to then apply what we understand of the redeemed adult/child dyad to this theological formulation. Of course, this would be an abhorrent concept if we failed to first address the mistaken notions of paternalism and helpless dependency. Indeed, from a certain perspective this would seem to be the understanding of the relationship between God and His church that would give rise to the kind of church-negating theology of mission that Hoekendijk championed – a Church that is weak, helpless and virtually useless.

However, the vision of children as potential agents of mission has tremendous potential. For example, by applying our understanding of the temporal paradox of childhood, we are reminded that God invites all of us to participate in His mission at whatever stage of our development we may be. There is a place for every one of Christ's followers to witness to the truth of the Gospel, and to accurately reflect what we know of his person and what the Holy Spirit has done in our lives. However, participation in God's mission is designed to encourage our maturation towards the perfection he intends for us, and a full flowering of our witness. He calls us to continue to deepen our relationship with him in order to become more adept at representing Christ's Gospel with integrity.

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[11] See, for example, Johannes Christiaan Hoekendijk, *The Church Inside Out* (Philadelphia: Westminster Press, 1966).

[12] David J Bosch, *Transforming Mission: Paradigm Shifts in Theology of Mission* (Maryknoll: Orbis, 1991).

Our understanding of child participation may also help us understand the relative responsibility we share for accomplishing God's missional purposes more tangibly. What if God has made a safe space for our missional efforts, just as we must do when we invite children to participate? How different would our mission strategizing be if we genuinely trusted that God was in control, and that the accomplishment of His mission did not rest entirely on our shoulders? But even more, what if we did mission with the recognition that God is with us and that he does not give us more than we can handle? As my friend Patrick McDonald often says, God does not give us three shoes and tell us to put one on each foot.

How freeing is it to think of our missional work not as an urgently serious task, but rather our willing service to a God that wants us to make a unique, creative contribution? What about our mistakes and the mistakes of others? Is our heavenly Father big enough to use them for his purposes? It is hard work for us, there is no doubt about that, just as good child participation represents genuine work for children. But how much more comforting is it to realize that the Holy Spirit is with us, empowering our efforts, giving us opportunities, and allowing us to genuinely share responsibility for what we do?

The remarkable thing about applying the redeemed adult/child dyad to the missio Dei is how naturally the metaphor fits. It almost feels like this is how we were always supposed to understand serving God through mission. It should also provoke us to wonder whether our understanding of the missio Dei might be able to inform our understanding of child participation more fully.

2. Intercultural Partnerships and the Adult/Child Dyad

One of the primary models for mission practice employed today is cross-cultural mission partnerships. In this model relationships are developed between churches in Africa, Asia and Latin America with churches in the west (and predominantly in the United States) in order to gain funding and relevant expertise as it is needed.

Stanley Kruis, in his recent dissertation on the topic, offers an overview of the missiological literature on the topic both by decade

and in terms of the differences between ecumenical and evangelical thinking. He shows that while different themes were identified at different times, and while conciliar churches tended to address the key questions considerably sooner than evangelical churches, the principal challenges with using the partnership model consistently boil down to two key themes: paternalism and dependency.[13]

Paternalism is the complaint of the non-western partner, as they experience western churches using their accountability structures to dominate and control the way funds are used. Conversely, churches in the west lament the dependency of their poorer partners, expressing their desire to see the work they are contributing to become more self-sustaining. In fact, these complaints are nothing new. They are identical to the concerns raised to Henry Venn in 1855 when he asked a visiting Sierra Leonian businessman why the Christians in Sierra Leone did not adequately support their own churches. The response he received was, "Mr. Venn, when you stop treating us like children, we will stop acting like children".[14]

Two important observations must be made about this vignette. First, according to Shenk this moment represented a tipping point for Venn, motivating him to propose (along with his American colleague Rufus Anderson) the now-famous three-self church concept.[15] In that model of mission, missionaries should strive to establish churches that are essentially autonomous: self-supporting, self-governing and self-propagating. In so doing, he would be able to address the nagging problems of paternalism and dependency.

Many scholars have asserted, particularly in the twentieth century, that this was an overcorrection, and has led to a multitude of other problems. Smalley[16] helped to observe that asserting autonomy

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[13] Stanley D. Kruis, *Ecclesiological Assumptions and International Mission Partnerships: A Philippine Case Study* (Pasadena, CA: Fuller Theological Seminary, School of Theology, 2009).

[14] Wilbert R. Shenk, *God's New Economy: Interdependence and Mission* (Elkhart, IN: Mission Focus, 1988), 17.

[15] *Ibid*.

[16] William Smalley, "Cultural Implications of an Indigenous Church" in *Practical Anthropology* 5 (2), 1958: 51-65

as the apparent goal of the three-self program was far from supportive of a contextualized church. Rather, insisting on the independence of a local church was simply the further imposition of western cultural hegemony. Beyerhaus and Lefever took this critique a step further, calling the three-self church model of mission sub-biblical.

In contrast, the partnership model, as proposed at Whitby in 1947 and developed by a host of missional thinkers, is quite different. Rather than making autonomy the goal of mission, the international partnership model emphasizes the interdependence and unity of the church across cultural divides through sharing resources. Beyerhaus and Lefever[17] proposed a theology of mission partnership based on "Christonomy." Shenk describes this theology as, "the body is to be always in submission to Christ as head and in a relationship of interdependence within the body".[18] More recently the standard-bearers for international partnership in mission have been led by advocates such as K.P. Yohannan, Luis Bush and others. The emphasis in these writings rightly champions the practicality and effectiveness of indigenous mission and the essential nature of western funding to support it. The problem is that too often these paradigms of mission turn the west, and particularly the United States, into the international ATM of the global mission project. To most western audiences this seems like quite a narrow understanding of the interdependence of the Body of Christ.

Second, given the topic of our conference it is impossible not to see the marred adult/child dyad the businessman used to make his point. In this man's eyes (and apparently in Venn's) children were to be dominated and doted upon – not respected and involved. It is tempting to think that, had a redeemed adult/child dyad been available, rather than the marred understanding of childhood Venn held, the resulting model might have had a less-destructive impact on the missions movement. Thinking metaphorically, the three-self church model, far from encouraging a child towards empowerment

[17] Peter Beyerhaus and Henry Charles Lefever, *The Responsible Church and the Foreign Mission* (Grand Rapids, MI: W.B. Eerdmans, 1964).

[18] Shenk, *op cit*. 18.

and full contribution, tends to advocate gradual abandonment of adult responsibility in favour of the autonomy of children. Yet this is remarkably unlike the model of parenting that God provides. With this frame of reference in mind, John Gatu's moratorium assertion in 1971 and the stir it created seems remarkably reasonable.[19] This is especially notable since it is often forgotten that Gatu did not actually suggest a permanent moratorium on western missions. Rather, his original request was for, "a period of not less than five years for each side to rethink and formulate what is going to be their future relationship… The churches of the Third World must be allowed to find their own identity, and the continuation of the present missionary movement is a hindrance to this selfhood of the church".[20]

In order to see our way through this morass, it is important that we recognize one important contemporary distinction. While it may have been reasonable in Venn's day to imagine that western missionary agencies were the adults in their particular adult/child dyads, today that is clearly no longer the case. Rather, while there are inevitable asymmetries in every partnership, one of the grave mistakes too often made is for the west to assume that they are the adult. Rather, given the relative strength and size of the church in the south we cannot uncritically apply the lessons we have learned from child participation in this domain.

If we accept the idea that we are children participating in God's mission, then it stands to reason no Christian or group of Christians can assert ultimate dominance over any other group. Rather, all of us who participate in God's mission are siblings who are trying to work out this global task together. Of course, some churches may be older than other churches, but those relative ages may not, in fact, resolve along national lines. There are many Latin American, African and Asian churches that far predate the establishment of my own local church plant. And in any case, I would assert that age is not as important as relative expertise. If we are willing to apply our

[19] Gerald H. Anderson, "Moratorium on Missionaries" in *Christian Century 91* (2), 1974: 43-45.

[20] *Ibid*.

understanding of the distribution of spiritual gifts within the body of Christ as the superstructure for true interdependent partnerships, we must realize that there are resources on both sides of a partnership that can genuinely be contributed to each other, no matter what the birth order might be.

So, rather than seeing relationships either in terms of the goal of radical egalitarianism or absolute dominance, we need to see the inevitable asymmetries as more changeable. Responsibility in these relationships must be shared and decisions regarding who takes leadership must be made on a moment-to-moment basis. Each partner needs to keep evaluating which entity is best-suited to the missional tasks at hand and then must be willing to either submit or take leadership as needed. This kind of responsiveness has been proposed by Koeshall as something she terms "dynamic asymmetry".[21] Furthermore, once determinations of leadership are made, this kind of shared responsibility can make more ready allowance for ensuring that each member of the family is able to contribute in meaningful ways. However, in any case, if both parties seriously take on the challenge of involving and engaging the participation of the other, they should be able to address these kinds of dilemmas with new eyes.

Conclusion

Participating in the Mission of God is a massive task. In this article I have attempted to show that the ways those who are at the centre perceive those who are at or beyond the margins of the Church have always had enormous impact on the nature of mission, and our understanding of what God intends to characterize the adult/child dyad is, in turn, a key component of our understanding of mission. Therefore, reconsidering and redeeming these perceptions are

[21] Anita Koeshall, *Toward a Theory of Dynamic Asymmetry and Redeemed Power: A Case Study of Reflexive Agents in German Pentecostal Churches* (Pasadena, CA: Fuller Theological Seminary, School of Intercultural Studies, 2008).

integral to doing missiology and mission itself. Furthermore, as these fundamental perceptions change, so does our understanding of the task of mission more broadly. We are at a critical moment in the history of the Church, when our understanding of the value and potential of children is increasingly trending towards one that more fully honours the dignity God has bestowed upon them. Therefore, it is incumbent upon us to step into the larger conversations about mission that often are taking place without us, and advocate not just for the role of children, but for how reframing our understanding of them ought to affect us more broadly.

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After Word

It is usual to end a book like this with a section entitled *Conclusions* or *Recommendations*. However, the conference was not an end in itself but part of an on-going process of calling the Church to hear God's thoughts about the place of children and young people in his mission. That process must continue and so rather than reaching conclusions, the conference explored issues, critiqued methods and assumptions and, perhaps most importantly – though careful listening to God's Word and to each other – the conference identified significant matters for the global Church. One way to isolate and reflect on them is to emphasise *the central importance of children to Jesus*, *the broad shape of a new missiology that incorporates children* and *strategic issues that need further action and reflection*.

The Central Importance of Children to Jesus

Time and again, through bible studies, plenaries, small group discussion and keynote speeches, this theme emerged. Newman's devotional study of Mark 10 specifically focussed on this theme, noting how Jesus took children and blessed them. But it is much more than that: the child her- or himself is a model of the Kingdom of God, held up to correct and rebuke the disciples. Children are not simply the objects of blessing but equal subjects of the Kingdom. As such, and Greener and Vinay Samuel emphasise, and as others note, as equal subjects they are – or should be – equal participants in God's Kingdom. They can hear God speak to them just as well as an old priest or a young teenage Mary. The prophecy of Joel, quoted by Peter in his sermon on the Day of Pentecost, was referred to throughout the conference. Though there are some differing opinions on this, it seems to affirm the agency of children alongside other groups of people. They too are given gifts by the Spirit to enable them to serve

within God's Kingdom. Yet their participation can be blocked or exploited by (sometimes – but not always – well-intentioned) powerful adults.

The Kingdom of God challenges concepts of power. Jesus, by placing a child at the centre of the Kingdom, shows that how we – as adults – understand and use power is a significant marker of how well we understand the fundamental nature of Jesus' 'now and not yet' rule. As noted in the Introduction, there is an "upsidedownness" within God's Kingdom where the first shall be last and the last first. There are allusions throughout the Compendium to power and children. For example, the critique of some missionary practices mentioned in Arles' paper is a comment on the use of power and children within mission praxis and indeed within mission agencies. We need to be careful of our own motives, reflecting deeply on how we as parents, teachers, policy makers, carers *etc*. view the "little ones" we are called to steward, responsible to God for how we do so.

The Broad Shape of a New Missiology

The conference called for greater reflection on developing a new missiology for our time. A number of presenters believe that this current time is critical: "a new kairos moment" according to Howell. Oxbrow and Crocker both presented critiques of the modern missionary movement, both calling for renewed reflection. During the conference various suggestions were made as to what a new missiology might look like, especially as it relates to children and youth. The Document Team captured some of these:

- This missiology will be thoroughly biblical and theologically robust. It will see a Trinitarian conception of the missio Dei as foundational. It will seek restoration of the created order through the salvific work of the incarnate Christ.
- This missiology should be research-based, taking into account both salvation history and the work of the Church in pursuing mission, recognizing that our understanding of children has often fallen short of God's intent.

- This missiology will come with a strong ecclesiology which emphasizes the agency of the church, and sees children, within the responsibility of their parents or caregivers, as vital participants. It will see the church as the body of Christ, the people of God, and the family of God.
- This missiology will see mission starting with the family in relationship as an echo of Trinitarian mutual submission, and prioritizes intergenerational engagement. Parents and other caregivers will be equipped to invite, nurture and support their children as co-labourers while also recognizing and protecting their vulnerability. Safe spaces will be created that will allow children to exercise and develop their mission-oriented gifts and capacities. This new missionary paradigm will see children neither as objects or idolized, burdened beyond their abilities or neglected and ignored.
- This missiology will focus on an incarnational approach that lives the gospel, focused on making disciples and not just evangelizing. It will go back to Jesus and consider what he would do with children in a context. It will be holistic and comprehensive, employing a paradigm of service and have an emphasis on justice, peace and equity.
- This missiology needs to focus on converting leaders to have God's heart for children and should actively seek to transition missiological leadership to the next generation.

In addition:

- This missiology will have a strong narrative flavour, realising that children, along with adults, need to develop ways of joining their own personal and communal stories with the story of Jesus; "a missiology which is rich in the story telling of children, the analytical and propositional work of adults and the reflective, mystical, thoughtfulness of our elders" to quote Oxbrow.
- This missiology will rely on God's power, given through the Holy Spirit, and will understand and apply all appropriate forms of power according to the values of the Kingdom. This

will include valuing and embracing those who are thought to be marginalised – indigenous people, women, children, the old, the sick, the powerless – not as objects of mission but as participants in the *missio Dei*.

Strategic Issues

The small group discussions were a valuable aspect of the conference process. Through them people were given a voice to respond to presentations, positively and negatively. Participants had the opportunity to raise specific issues and the following paragraph reflects these discussions, as well as the input from the speakers.

The role of adults – parents, carers, teachers, and indeed all adults who have any dealings with children and young people – is vital. They need to be encouraged and equipped to release the next generation as active and equal participants in mission *now*. There are resources available but the fundamental need is not one of resources but one of vision: we need to cast the vision at all levels within the Church and pray that the Church is willing to hear God's call and respond.

The training and equipping of church leaders is therefore of particular significance. Seminaries and training institutions need to grow curricula that take these issues seriously and a new theological disciplines must be created (Holistic child development? Child theology? Intergenerational studies? Youth and children's ministry?)

The use of space – physical as well as metaphorical space – is crucial. This includes practices such as hospitality but also the deliberate use of inter-generational activities, including worship. Appropriate boundaries are necessary; these must be culturally and age appropriate.

There is a need to build a better understanding of 'good practice' of mission work with children and young people. This is necessary for a number of reasons, but there are two main ones. Firstly we need to better understand the work at the grass roots to inform the new missiology – there has to be a strong 'bottom up' dimension as it is developed. Secondly, current good practice models are required to be used in the training of children, their carers, teachers and church

leaders. To create a data set of models will require some systematic and rigorous research but the dividends may be truly transformative.

If you have ears to hear …

Jesus often left people to work out the meaning of his teaching. There was always a challenge – sometimes even a threat – to the status quo. This is one reason why he remains one of the most exhilarating (and to some, annoying!) teachers that have ever lived. His teaching is full of such challenges, but also full of encouragement and promise. Most often he leaves the response to those who heard him speak. He often still does so, trusting that the Holy Spirit will take his words and apply them – and trusting that you and I will have the ears to hear and hearts to respond appropriately. The editor's prayer for this Compendium is that you, the reader, will hear through these pages the encouragement and challenges that we faced as we heard these papers and discussed them; that God's Holy Spirit will have been prompting you not only to greater understanding but also to *action*. For following Jesus remains to this day the call not just to belief but acting out the reign of God, to taking constructive steps in our behaviour to transform this wonderful but broken world, to help in the task of ushering in God's Kingdom. And our prayer is that you will take such steps to ensure that children and young people, who make up the biggest 'people group' on our planet, will join you in following Jesus and in working in the *missio Dei*.

For the sake of the children.

For God's sake.

Scripture Index

1 Corinthians 1 39, 110, 114, 115, 119, 189, 269
1 Corinthians 10:11 39
1 Corinthians 11:25 269
1 Corinthians 12:13 115
1 Corinthians 13:12 189
1 Corinthians 14:13, 14 119
1 Corinthians 14:26 110, 114
1 Corinthians 7:17 113
1 Corinthians 9:22 147
1 Peter 1:20 39
1 Peter 2:9 222
1 Samuel 1 42, 162, 177, 180
1 Samuel 1:11 162
1 Samuel 1:15-18 162
1 Samuel 1:22 42
1 Samuel 1:28 162
1 Samuel 2 164, 170, 171, 173
1 Samuel 2:2-11 170
1 Samuel 2:26 164
1 Samuel 2:29 173
1 Samuel 3:19 165
1 Samuel 3:3 166
1 Samuel 3:7-8 167
1 Samuel 3:9 168
1 Samuel 4:21 42
1 Thessalonians 1:9 110
1 Timothy 3:5 173
1 Timothy 4:1 39
2 Chronicles 31:16 166
2 Corinthians 5:17f 269
2 Kings 6:8-23 215
2 Timothy 2:1-2 242
2 Timothy 3:1 39
Acts 1:8 43, 142, 143

Acts 10 279, 286
Acts 11:22-26 105
Acts 13:20 170
Acts 16:16-38 93, 95
Acts 2 27, 29, 37, 38, 40, 42, 43, 154
Acts 2:1-18 108
Acts 2:16-18 108
Acts 2:17 27, 29, 37, 38, 42, 43, 118, 154
Acts 2:17-19 27, 37
Acts 3:24 170
Colossians 1:20 269
Colossians 3:10 269
Daniel 7 268
Deuteronomy 11-19 80
Deuteronomy 4:9 80
Deuteronomy 9 21
Ephesians 1:17-18 106
Ephesians 2:11-22 268
Ephesians 4:11 113
Ephesians 4:24 269
Ephesians 6:10 240
Ephesians 6:4 173
Exodus 12 187, 215
Exodus 12:26-27 187
Exodus 13:14-15 187
Exodus 2:6 42
Exodus 24:9-11 215
Exodus 30:14 42
Galatians 6:15 269
Genesis 1:26-28 185
Genesis 1:6-7 214
Genesis 15 215
Genesis 2:19-20 214
Genesis 2:20-22 214
Genesis 26:26-31 215
Genesis 48:8-20 207
Genesis 9:6 256
Genesis 12:1-3; 15 106

Habakkuk 2:14 209
Hebrews 2 20, 21, 189
Hebrews 2:9 189
Isaiah 4:6-9 271
Isaiah 42:6 106
Isaiah 61:1-2 42
Isaiah 65:17-25 135, 148, 269
Isaiah 7:14 271
Isaiah 8:4 42
James 1:27 80
James 3:9 256
James 5:3 39
Jeremiah 1:6 42
Jeremiah 31:33 275
Joel 2:18-32 47, 62
Joel 2:28-32 38
John 13:14 268
John 13:34 269
John 17:21 109
John 20:21 108, 142
John 20:21-22 108
John 3:8 105, 126
John 6:39 39
Joshua 4:6-7 187
Luke 12:35-48 174
Luke 15:1-2 216
Luke 18:15-17 229, 269
Luke 19:1-10 216
Luke 2:34-38 271
Luke 2:52 108, 163
Luke 22:24-27 111
Luke 22:29-30 112
Luke 25:45-49 142
Luke 4:18-19 42
Luke 5:39 269
Luke 7:36-50 216
Luke 9:46-48 229
Mark 10:13-16 111, 195, 229

Mark 13:32-37 174
Mark 16:15 142
Mark 2:15ff 216
Mark 5 140, 141
Mark 5:22-23 140
Mark 9:33-37 111, 229, 275
Matthew 10:13-16 269
Matthew 11:19 216
Matthew 11:25 274
Matthew 12:27 116
Matthew 18:1-5 270
Matthew 18:1-7 229
Matthew 18:2-4 63, 64, 69
Matthew 18:6 270
Matthew 19:13-15 229
Matthew 21:12-16 205
Matthew 21:14-16 275
Matthew 21:15-16 16, 165
Matthew 22:32-40 106
Matthew 23:13-39 110
Matthew 24:42-51 174
Matthew 28:16-20 142, 155
Matthew 28:18-20 137, 142, 268
Matthew 5:3-12 270
Numbers 1:3 42
Philippians 1:17 143
Philippians 2:5-11 153
Psalm 2 22
Psalm 8 11, 13, 15, 18, 19, 22, 24, 165, 205
Psalm 82 22
Romans 12 19
Romans 15:7 217

Appendices

About the Sponsoring Organisations

IN ALPHABETICAL ORDER

Asia Theological Association (ATA) is composed of theological educational institutions, committed to evangelical faith and scholarship, which are networking together, to serve the Church in equipping the people of God for the mission of the Lord Jesus Christ. ATA was established in 1970 as a direct outcome of the need expressed at several Asia wide conferences and consultations. Since then, it has grown into a movement committed to serving its members in the development of evangelical biblical theology by strengthening interaction, enhancing scholarship, promoting academic excellence, fostering spiritual and ministerial formation, and mobilizing resources to fulfill God's global mission within diverse Asian cultures.

The Church of God in Latin America, with headquarters in Cleveland, Tennessee is a Pentecostal Christian denomination. With over six million members in over 170 countries, it is one of the largest Pentecostal denominations in the world. Under the leadership of David Ramirez, and in partnership with Compassion International, their theological institutions have been at the forefront of developing programs of study in Holistic Child Development.

The Church of the Nazarene is an evangelical Christian denomination. It is the largest Wesleyan-holiness denomination in the world. The denomination has been at the global forefront of focusing ministry on the 'next generation.'

Compassion International is one of the world's leading Christian child development organizations. In response to the Great Commission, the ministry exists as an advocate for children, to release

them from their spiritual, economic, social and physical poverty and enable them to become responsible and fulfilled Christian adults.

Fuller Theological Seminary is one of the largest multi-denominational seminaries in the world, providing professional and graduate-level education in schools of theology, psychology, and intercultural studies. Since its founding by radio evangelist Charles E. Fuller in 1947, Fuller has equipped students to be leaders with a mind for scholarship and heart for the gospel. Fuller is a global leader in theological education, standing on the front lines of evangelical thought while remaining committed to ministry and mission grounded in scholarship.

The **Transform World Connections** movement his movement was a result of the 'World Inquiry,' a three-year global research project looking for 'expressions of the mission of God.' Their primary focus now is on the 4/14 Window.

The Global Alliance for Advancing Holistic Child Development, also known as the HCD Global Alliance, is a voluntary group of seminaries, Bible schools, and other Christian academic institutions working together with researchers, trainers, practitioners, and other Christian leaders to create a global movement of academic programs in holistic child development (HCD).

World Evangelical Alliance (WEA) is a global ministry working with local churches around the world to join in common concern to live and proclaim the Good News of Jesus in their communities. WEA is a network of churches in 128 nations that have each formed an evangelical alliance and over 100 international organizations joining together to give a worldwide identity, voice and platform to more than 420 million evangelical Christians. Seeking holiness, justice and renewal at every level of society - individual, family, community and culture, God is glorified and the nations of the earth are forever transformed.

About the Participants

Gender Representation

- 86 Males
- 34 Females

Country Representation

AFRICA (9)

- Burkina Faso
- Chad
- Ethiopia
- Ghana
- Kenya
- South Africa
- Uganda
- Zambia
- Zimbabwe

EUROPE (7)

- Armenia
- Bulgaria
- Romania
- Russia
- Switzerland
- Ukraine
- United Kingdom

NORTH AMERICA (2)

- Canada
- United States of America

LATIN AMERICA & THE CARIBBEAN (9)

- Bolivia
- Brazil
- Chile
- Ecuador
- Guatemala
- Honduras
- Jamaica
- Mexico
- Peru

ASIA & THE PACIFIC (11)

- China
- India
- Indonesia
- Korea
- Malaysia
- Mongolia
- Myanmar
- Philippines
- Singapore
- Sri Lanka
- Thailand

Organisations/Institutions Represented

CHRISTIAN ACADEMIC/RESEARCH INSTITUTION

1. Arab Baptist Theological Seminary, Lebanon
2. Asia Pacific Theological Seminary, Philippines
3. Asia-Pacific Nazarene Theological Seminary, Philippines
4. Bethel Mission School, India
5. Biblical Seminary of the Philippines, Philippines
6. Caribbean Graduate School of Theology, Jamaica
7. Caribbean Nazarene College, Trinidad and Tobago
8. Centre for Contemporary Christianity, India
9. Child Development Center, Ethiopia
10. Colombo Theological Seminary, Sri Lanka
11. Eastern Theological College, Jorhat, India
12. Eurasian Theological Seminary, Russia
13. Fuller Theological Seminary, USA
14. Institute for Ecumenical Studies University of Fribourg, Switzerland
15. Institutul Teologic Penticostal, Bucharest, Romania
16. Jubilee Institute, India
17. Malaysia Baptist Theological Seminary, Malaysia
18. Mount Carmel School, India
19. Myanmar Evangelical Graduate School of Theology, Myanmar
20. Petra Institute, South Africa
21. South African Theological Seminary, South Africa
22. Ukrainian Evangelical Theological Seminary, Ukraine
23. University of South Africa (UNISA), South Africa
24. Wheaton College Graduate School, USA

CHRISTIAN ALLIANCES/NETWORKS/FELLOWSHIPS

1. Accrediting Council for Theological Education in Africa (ACTEA), Zambia
2. Alliance of Evangelical Churches and Missions of Chad (EEMET), Chad
3. Asia Evangelical Alliance, India
4. Confraternity of Evangelical Churches of Latin America (CONELA), Mexico
5. Cooperative Baptist Fellowship, Ukraine
6. European Evangelical Alliance, Belgium
7. Faith2Share, United Kingdom
8. Global Network of Mission Structures, Korea
9. International Fellowship of Evangelical Mission Theologians (INFEMIT)

10. Karnataka Missions Network, India
11. Korea World Missions Association, Korea
12. Lausanne
13. Rede Maos Dadas (Hand in Hand Network), Brazil
14. The Alliance for Ukraine without Orphans, Ukraine
15. The Global Alliance for Advancing Holistic Child Development
16. The Great Commission Coalition, USA
17. World Evangelical Alliance, United Kingdom

CHRISTIAN ORGANIZATIONS/MINISTRIES

1. Almighty Bible Holdings, Korea
2. ARISE! – Evangelical Fellowship of Singapore, Singapore
3. Awana Indonesia, Indonesia
4. Awana Korea, Korea
5. Awana, USA
6. Biblica, USA
7. Christian Broadcasting Network (CBN) Indonesia, Indonesia
8. Child Evangelism Fellowship, Korea
9. Compassion International Alumni Association, Philippines
10. Compassion International, Burkina Faso
11. Compassion International, Indonesia
12. Compassion International, Kenya
13. Compassion International, Korea
14. Compassion International, Latin America & The Caribbean
15. Compassion International, Philippines
16. Compassion International, Thailand
17. Compassion International, USA
18. Hosanna Foundation, Hong Kong SAR, China
19. International Exchange Service Foundation, Korea
20. International House of Prayer, Kansas City, USA
21. Kidzana Ministries, USA
22. Loving Concern International, Korea
23. Mission Evangelistic Association, India
24. Nazarene Compassionate Ministries, Armenia
25. Novus Foundation, Bolivia
26. OneHope, Chile
27. Overseas Council International, Canada
28. Overseas Council International, Zimbabwe
29. Pioneers, USA
30. Singapore Centre for Global Missions, Singapore
31. Transform Culture International, Korea
32. Transform World Connections, Singapore
33. Transform World Connections, USA
34. Transform World Family Challenge, Malaysia

35. U.S. Center for World Mission, USA
36. Viva, Uganda
37. World Vision Ecuador, Ecuador
38. Youth With A Mission, Myanmar

CHURCH/DENOMINATIONAL BODY

1. Bangkok Korean Union Church, Korea
2. Bayariin Medee Christian Church, Mongolia
3. Bulgarian Orthodox Church, Bulgaria
4. Church of God, USA
5. Church of the Nazarene, Germany
6. CITAM Kenya, Kenya
7. Free Methodist Church, Philippines
8. Gateway Grace Fellowship, USA
9. Hallelujah Community Church, Korea
10. Iglesia Presbiteriana de Chile, Chile
11. Promise Ministries International, USA
12. Westside Community Church, Trinidad and Tobago

About the Contributors

BY LAST NAME

Siga Arles is a graduate of Asbury Theological Seminary and University of Aberdeen. As a Langham Scholar, he teaches Missiology and mentors postgraduates for leadership. He founded and directs the Centre for Contemporary Christianity at Bangalore, through which he conducts renewal seminars, publishes missiological-contextual, theological-pastoral and other books, and offers extension research study opportunities for working people in the areas of Missiology and Holistic Child Development (HCD). He has been an active leader in the 4/14 Global Initiative and the Transform World Movement, and had pioneered HCD teaching in India with the Global Alliance for Advancing HCD.

Dan Brewster is the International Director for Academic Programs in Holistic Child Development (HCD) for Compassion International. Dan has worked with Compassion for 29 years. He has been in the past Compassion's Africa Area Director, and the Advocacy Director for Asia. He has a doctorate in Missiology from Fuller Seminary, and likes writing and teaching in areas of Christian holistic child development. He and his wife Alice have lived in Penang, Malaysia for the past 15 years. He was the Chairman of the Steering Committee for the *Now and Next* Theological Conference on Children, and the Program Chair for this Missiology conference

Bambang Budijanto is Vice President for the Asia Region at Compassion International. He currently serves as Director of the Mission Commission and Vice Chairman of the Asia Evangelical Alliance. He is chairman of the 4/14 Window Global Initiative Steering Committee, a board member of Micah Network, and a member of the editorial board for the Transformational Journal/UK. Bambang also chairs the boards of Pesat Foundation, the Consortium for Graduate Programs in Christian Studies (CCS/KPPK), and the Institute for Community and Development Studies (ICDS). Bambang received his PhD from the Oxford Centre for Mission Studies and the University of Wales.

Luis Bush is a Christian servant catalyst on God's mission of transformation. He serves as a servant catalyst in the 4/14 Window Movement and as international facilitator of Transform World Connections based in Singapore. He is also the person who introduced Joshua Project and the 10/40 window term. He has a PhD in Intercultural Studies from Fuller School of World Mission in 2003, and is active in many ways to get the body of Christ to transform the world.

John Baxter-Brown is a consultant specialising in evangelism, mission, Christian unity and youth and children's ministry. Throughout his 27 years of ministry, he has focused on these four areas but his passion is world evangelization. He has worked most recently with World Vision International, the World Evangelical Alliance and the World Council of Churches and has spoken in a number of seminaries and conferences around the world. His current work includes a book project with the World Council of Churches on the theological history of evangelism and mission 1910-2010, and one on contemporary theological understandings of evangelism. John was born in India, has lived in Scotland, France and Switzerland, but has spent most of his life in England where he now lives with his wife and 2 teenage daughters.

Ricardo "Toyditz" Cosico is the Asia Advocacy Director of Compassion International. He has been doing teaching and training consultancy with churches and local and international NGOs in Asia. His dream is for the churches in Asia to be S.U.P.E.R. (Strengthened, United, People-focused, Equipped and Relevant) Churches and that local Christian NGOs will enable the churches to fulfill its role in integral mission. Toyditz is also an Elder of Bread from Heaven Community Church, and preaches once in a while when not traveling. He is happily (very much!) married to Manette and they have 2 sons, Caleb (21) and Daniel (17).

Gustavo Crocker is the General Superintendent of the Church of the Nazarene. Formerly he was the Regional Director for the Eurasia Region of the Church of the Nazarene. His previous experience includes service with World Relief Corporation, Compassion International, and Nazarene Compassionate Ministries. A licensed

architect, Gustavo has a PhD in Organizational Leadership in Business (Regent University), and has taught Catalytic Church Planting, Transformational Leadership, Missiology, International Development, International Business, and Social Development in various universities in Latin America and the United States. As an organizational development specialist, he has focused on strategic planning and capacity development for faith-based organizations. Gustavo is married to Rachel. They have 2 daughters, Raquel and Elizabeth.

Over the last 12 years, **Isobel Booth-Clibborn** has been based and working to develop networks linking Christians working with vulnerable children in a number of cities in Africa. The current focus is on 5 key city networks linking together churches and organisations who work with more than 43,000 children. Based in Kampala, Isobel travels across Eastern and Southern Africa to support Viva's networks. She is a mission partner of the Church Mission Society, seconded to develop Viva's work in Africa. She has taught in UK, Zimbabwe and Kenya and worked on children's ministry with Anglican dioceses UK and Uganda.

Samuel Cha is a graduate of Hankuk University of Foreign Studies, Hapdong Theological Seminary, and Torch Trinity Graduate School of Theology. As an associate pastor of of Hallelujah Community Church (HCC), he has served in various ministries, including Children's English Worship, Adults' EE, Kids' EE, Parish, and Education Director ministries, while translating 15 Christian books into Korean language, including Transforming Children into Spiritual Champions by George Barna. As an active champion for children ministry, he has been leading the Kids' EE ministry in Korea since he started it at HCC in 2005.

Corneliu Constantineanu is President and Associate Professor of NT Studies at Institutul Teologic Penticostal (Bucharest, Romania). He has served as academic dean of Evangelical Theological Seminary (Osijek, Croatia), and also executive director of the Areopagus Centre for Christian Studies & Contemporary Culture (Timisoara, Romania). In addition to his specialization and publications in the areas of Pauline theology and reconciliation, Corneliu has a special interest in

pursuing a holistic understanding of the gospel as public truth, thus trying to integrate Christian faith with cultural, social and political realities of everyday life. He is member of the INFEMIT Networking Team. Corneliu is married to Ioana and they have 2 daughters, Anamaria and Carmen.

Gwendolin de Rozario-Seah has been in children's ministry for the last 20 years. In 2002, she started ARISE!, Singapore's first national children's praise and worship event. There, she saw how the Holy Spirit led a child to pray for the people and reports of healing followed every time. By 2012, the vision expanded – children across the world were gathered on the same day (April 14) to worship and pray. Since 2002, Gwen has worked with like-minded partners to train and release children in prayer, intercession and mission. She is married to Rev. Steven Seah. They have 3 teenage children, Sarah, Rachel and Benedict.

After completing her MBBS from Gandhi Medical College, Bhopal, Dr. **Lalita Edwards** worked with the Red Cross Society, at NM Wadia Hospital, and World Vision as director of their maternal and child welfare project in rural Navapur. In 1995, she joined the Association for Christian Thoughtfulness pioneering home-based care for HIV patients and sex education programmes for schools in Mumbai. In 2002, she started the Santvana Home in Pune for AIDS orphans which caters for 21 children. Lalita presently works with high risk groups of female, male and transgender persons. She has 3 daughters and 5 grandchildren.

Jack Eggar has served as President/CEO of Awana since 1999. Under his direction, Awana has expanded from 9,000 churches worldwide to 27,445 churches in 103 countries today, where well over 2 million children and youth meet weekly to learn more about Jesus Christ and his word. Awana has also extended God's love to children at risk through orphanages, Christian schools, slums, refugee camps, prisons and a leper colony in India. Jack's vast and varied experience includes business, higher education, pastoral ministry in the US, missionary work in Korea and Fiji, church planting, writing, and consulting.

Mark P. Gonzales is pastor of Gateway Grace Fellowship, a radio broadcaster, founding president of Christian Home Educators of SW Florida, a pastoral consultant for Awana, International, and author of The Story of God and Man – a 192 page full color children's picture book presenting a transdenominational version of the Shorter Catechism of 1648 in rhyming verse and set to music. He has a DMin in Missions and Evangelism, an MDiv, and a BA in Political Science. He and Lindy live in Ft. Myers, Florida and have 3 grown sons serving the Lord.

Susan Greener, PhD, is Associate Professor of Intercultural Studies and Mission at Wheaton College Graduate School. Previously, she served for 6 years as Dean of Students and Adjunct Professor for Trinity Evangelical Divinity School. She has worked with children-at-risk for over 22 years in universities and Christian NGOs, including Mission of Mercy and Compassion International. She holds degrees in Human and Community Development from the University of Illinois at Urbana. Susan has trained children's workers from over 30 countries and authored educational materials, journal articles, and book chapters on children-at-risk and global child development topics.

Freda Howell received her BA (First-class Hons.) in Psychology from the University of Manitoba and MA in Counselling from Providence University College & Theological Seminary (Otterburne, Canada). While studying she interned at Turning Point Youth and Family Counselling Centre, a division of Youth for Christ (Winnipeg, Canada). She also worked as an emergency youth care practitioner at the Youth Resource Centre/ Shelter, Macdonald Youth Services in Winnipeg. Currently she works as a counsellor at Mount Carmel School assisting children with a wide range of concerns. She is also actively involved with her church's youth ministry in New Delhi, India.

Since encountering Christ at age of 12 in Punjab, India, **Richard Howell** has been witnessing to the transforming power of God. Richard has MTh (Regent College, Canada) and PhD (Netherland). He was the Principal of the Allahabad Bible Seminary from 1990-1996. Currently, he is the general secretary of the Evangelical

Fellowship of India (EFI) and of Asia Evangelical Alliance. He is also member of the Global Christian Forum. Richard has written and edited 5 books and numerous articles on various subjects. He also edits the monthly magazine AIM published by EFI Publication Trust. He is married to Sunita. They have 3 daughters, Melanie, Freda and Sabrina.

Genevieve Lerina James is an urban missiologist by training, currently serving at the University of South Africa in the capacity of executive assistant to the Pro Vice Chancellor. She established and directs a national community learning programme called Chance 2 Advance where economically marginalised communities across South Africa can benefit from free education and skills training programmes and awareness drives. She has served as a resource person for several social justice and development organisations on issues ranging from higher education, gender, migrancy, and children's justice. She designed a special tool to create awareness about child rape for children between the ages of 3-10.

Lawrence J. C. Ko is the National Director of Singapore Centre for Global Missions. He served as a pastor for seven years in a local church and in management of Christian organisations including YMCA, ORTV and TWR-Asia. He is currently also an associate trainer with the Singapore's Civil Service College. He is founder-director of Asian Journeys Ltd, a social enterprise involved in Asian social concerns and community service among heartland youths and urban poor. He has led youths in environmental projects in Asia. Lawrence serves on the Asian Lausanne Committee Executive Committee, Singapore Lausanne Exco and the Asia Evangelical Alliance Mission Committee.

Manfred W. Kohl is Vice President of International Development with Overseas Council International for Theological Education and Mission (OCI). He has done extensive traveling and speaking, both with OCI and formerly with World Vision International. He has conducted seminars and conferences on time management, fund raising/stewardship, and pastoral and theological issues for national Christian leaders around the world. He is on the teaching staff of the Institute of Excellence for Theological Education. Manfred has

presented papers at numerous theological conferences and has had articles on stewardship and fund raising published in major journals. He has also written and edited several books in German, English and Portuguese.

Thai Lam serves on the leadership team of the International House of Prayer where he leads Luke18 KC, the college ministry of IHOP-KC. Thai previously pioneered and led campus ministries at UC Berkeley (San Jose State, Stanford) and UCLA, and served on the national leadership team of Every Nation Campus Ministries. He has also planted and served as associate pastor of BayPointe Church (San Jose, California). Thai did Religious Studies at UC Berkeley and Cross-Cultural Missions at Fuller Theological Seminary. He and his wife Angela have 2 boys, Noah Zadok (3) and Cohen Asher (1), and a baby girl on the way!

Shiferaw Michael is Founder and Director of the Child Development Training & Research Center (CDTRC) in Ethiopia. Before responding to God's call in ministry to children, Shiferaw has worked in the civil service, started and led a law firm, and taught law at Haile Selassie University. He also started and led Compassion International in Ethiopia and Tanzania, later serving as Child Advocacy Director for Compassion in Africa. Shiferaw has a background in law (Columbia University) and organizational leadership (Eastern University, Pennsylvania). He is married to Seble, and they have 3 adult children and 3 grandchildren.

Victor Nakah is the Senior Vice President for Spiritual Ministry with CURE International. Formerly he was President of the Theological College of Zimbabwe (TCZ) for 10 years. He received his BA in theology from the Theological College of Zimbabwe and his Honours and MTh degrees from the University of South Africa (UNISA). His PhD degree in Theology is from the University of Stellenbosch in Cape Town, South Africa. Victor serves as the Africa Regional Director for Overseas Council. Victor is both a minister and theologian and therefore takes the relationship of church and seminary very seriously.He is married to Nosizo and they have 3 daughters, Nothabo, Rumbidzaishe and Chipo. They live in Bulawayo, Zimbabwe.

Las G. Newman, PhD (Wales) is President of the Caribbean Graduate School of Theology (CGST) in Kingston, Jamaica. Among his many ministry engagements he currently serves as the Honorary International Deputy Director (Caribbean) for the Lausanne Movement for World Evangelization and chairs the Caribbean Regional Council of the Langham Partnership International. Las is a graduate of Tyndale University College, Toronto, University of Waterloo, and the Oxford Centre for Mission Studies, UK. He holds a PhD in Mission Studies from the Oxford Centre for Mission Studies/University of Wales.

Mark Oxbrow is International Director of Faith2Share, a network of 40 mission agencies from five continents committed to discipleship, collaboration and emerging mission movements. Together they deploy around 6,000 missionaries in over 100 countries. Mark is an Anglican minister who previously worked for Unilever PLC, in mental health, parish ministry and in the leadership of Church Mission Society, one of the oldest Anglican missions. Mark serves with the Lausanne Movement facilitating Orthodox-Evangelical relations in mission; on the board of several other missions; on the ministry team of his local church in Oxford, UK; and writes regularly on mission topics.

Nativity A. Petallar is Program Director of Holistic Child Development at the Asia-Pacific Nazarene Theological Seminary (APNTS). She is also the associate coordinator for the Alternative Learning System at APNTS which provides basic education to out-of-school youth. Natz is a communications graduate at APNTS and took her ThD at the Asia Baptist Graduate Theological Seminary (Baguio City, Philippines). She is happily married to Mark Petallar and they have a 5-year old daughter, Zoe Lara Gil.

Enrique Pinedo is Child Advocacy Regional Director for Compassion International in Latin America and the Caribbean. He also holds various positions, including general secretary for the Latin American "Together with Children and Youth" Movement, coordinator for the Latin American HCD Academic Program in Biblical Seminaries and Theological Institutions, co-facilitator of the 4/14 "Holistic Children Ministries trough Local Churches" Global Track, and global

coordinator of the Children Thematic Forum at Micah Network. An ordained minister, Enrique is a member of the Latin American Theological Fellowship and holds a Master's degree in Missiology from the Las Americas Evangelical University (Costa Rica). He is married to Miriam, and they have 4 children.

Vinay Samuel, an ordained Anglican priest, is Executive Director of the Oxford Centre for Religion and Public Life, as well as Founder and Director Emeritus of the Oxford Centre for Mission Studies. He studied in India and Cambridge University (UK), and has written extensively in the area of the mission of the Church. As a theologian who stresses the dignity of the oppressed, he has been a practitioner of development and has published widely. He also developed and led the International Fellowship of Evangelical Mission Theologians (INFEMIT), and helped established theological institutions and research centers in Asia and Africa. Vinay is married to Colleen. They have 4 children and 5 grandchildren.

Amanda J. Sanchez serves as Director of Development for a global initiative called Church-based and Community-centered Higher Education (CaCHE). The CaCHE vision is to equip the Church worldwide to provide an accessible, discipleship-driven higher education to young people within the context of their own communities, especially within communities that have the least access to higher education. CaCHE was inspired by the visionary passion of Vishal Mangalwadi (The Book That Made Your World) and is currently coordinated by Dr Bob Moffitt (Harvest Foundation). A homeschool graduate, Amanda received her BA from Pepperdine University (California), MEd from Vanderbilt University (Tennessee), and PhD from University of Minnesota.

Dave H. Scott is Associate Director of the Center for Missiological Research and Assistant Professor of Intercultural Studies and Children at Risk at Fuller Seminary in Pasadena, California. Dave is married to Charity and they have 3 children: Emma (13), Nathan (11) and Annais (8). He previously served with Viva from 1998-2006, in Oxford, England; Cape Town, South Africa; and in the US. Both as part of his role in Viva and since that time Dave has been developing training for Christians working with children at risk, and has played a

key role in developing the children at risk emphasis at Fuller Seminary.

Perry Shaw is Professor of Christian Education at the Arab Baptist Theological Seminary in Beirut, Lebanon. Originally from Australia, he and his family have been living in the Middle East since 1990, serving in a variety of church and seminary-related ministries. Perry has many years of experience in classroom teaching and educational leadership, and is active as a curriculum and faculty development consultant to theological colleges and ministry training programmes. Perry and his American wife Karen have 2 children, Christopher (20) and Phoebe (15), who love their father's body-heat and the family trips he organises.

Joe Simfukwe is an ordained Baptist minister from Zambia in his 20th year on the faculty of the Theological College of Central Africa (Ndola, Zambia) which he joined after graduate studies and pastoral ministry in Australia. He is currently director of the Accrediting Council for Theological Education in Africa (ACTEA), and Exco member of the International Council for Evangelical Theological Education (ICETE). Prior to his present role in theological education, Joe served as the first Zambian pastor of Lusaka Baptist Church for 10 and half years. He is married to Alice and they have 2 sons, 3 daughters, and 3 grandchildren.

Augustin Sokolovski is a deacon of the Russian Orthodox Christian, and teaches systematic and ecumenical theology at the University of Fribourg (Switzerland) and Kiev Theological Academy (Ukraine). He received his PhD from the University of Fribourg. Augustin is fluent in many languages including Russian, German, French, Spanish, Italian, Dutch, Polish, and Portuguese.

Sunny Tan is currently Academic Dean of the Malaysia Baptist Theological Seminary (MBTS). He has served as pastor of a Baptist Church in Penang, Malaysia for about 10 years before joining the faculty of MBTS in 1994. He studied at MBTS (Penang), Regent College (Vancouver), and the Asia Baptist Graduate School of Theology (Philippines). He is a director of the Child Theology Movement, and also director of the Theology Program of the AGST

Alliance (a graduate school linked to the Asia Theological Association). Sunny is married to Rosalind and they have 2 adult children, Sarah and Asher.

C. Rosalee Velloso Ewell is a Brazilian theologian, born and raised in São Paulo. She earned a PhD from Duke University (Durham, USA) and until 2008 was Professor of Biblical Theology & Ethics at the South American Theological Seminary (Londrina, Brazil). Her current work includes serving as New Testament editor for a one-volume Bible commentary for Latin America and another book project with the World Council of Churches on the theological history of evangelism and mission 1910-2010. Rosalee is the Executive Director of the Theological Commission of the World Evangelical Alliance and has been involved in interfaith dialogue and peace and reconciliation initiatives. Rosalee is married to Samuel Ewell. They have 3 children.

Keith J. White, PhD, and his wife, Ruth, live at Mill Grove, a Christian residential community that has been caring for children and young people in the East End of London UK since 1899. He is founder and chair of the Child Theology Movement, a trustee of the UK Christian Child Care Forum, and member of the UK government's Care Standards Tribunal. He has chaired national professional child care organisations in the UK, and written or edited a number of books including The Bible (Narrative and Illustrated). Keith teaches holistic child development at Malaysia Baptist Theological Seminary, is associate lecturer at Spurgeons College, and faculty member of the Asian Graduate School of Theology.

Carmen Menchit Wong serves as Compassion International's Director of Child Advocacy, and also in the leadership of global movements for children such as the 4/14 Window Global Movement and the Global Children's Forum. For the last 30 years, she has served various roles in grassroots development, program management, children's ministry in churches, youth mentoring, global partnership development and strategic leadership. She has served Compassion International in the Philippines for 16 years, and in 5 of those, she was the country director. In June 2012, Menchit was officially appointed

by Lausanne as Senior Associate for Children at Risk. Menchit is married to Rico Wong and they have 3 sons.

Alison Worrall is based and works from a small fishing village, Maracaípe, in the state of Pernambuco, Brazil. She is the representative and facilitator in the north-east of Brazil for Rede Mãos Dadas (Hand in Hand Network), a network of 36 partner organizations serving 1.5 million children and adolescents. Academically qualified as a photographer, she uses this ability in network communications, art therapy initiatives with children and young people and in defending the marine and mangrove environment where she lives. Ali, as she's known, is a member of the International Mission Agency Latin Link, with whom she´s been serving from the UK to Brazil for 23 years.

Appendix: "Where have we come from, where we are and where are we going?"

BY LUIS BUSH

In his address called, "Where have we come from, where we are and where are we going?", Luis Bush noted some of the significant streams influencing the 4/14 Movement and which led up to the conference. Among them were:

1992 At the Evangelical Fellowship of Mission Agencies Executive Retreat in the US, Bryant Myers, noted that 85% of people who come to Christ in America, do so between the ages of 4 and 14. Discussions followed in Compassion resulting in coining the term "4/14 Window."

1996 Dan Brewster wrote the article, "The 4/14 Window: Child Ministries and Mission Strategies." That article became a chapter in the book by Phyllis Kilbourn entitled *Children in Crisis: A New Commitment* (Monrovia, CA: MARC. 1996).

1997 In January 1997 a consultation was held at Oxford (championed by Patrick McDonald who launched the Viva Network) which resulted in the influential "Oxford Statement on Children at Risk."

1997 Patrick MacDonald and Dan Brewster led a 4/14 Window workshop at the WEA meetings in Abbotsford, BC, Canada. They partnered again to lead a 4/14 Window track at GCOWE 97 in South Africa.

2001 Shiferaw Michael let the Ethiopian church in reflections resulting in the Covenant on Ministry to Children (March 2001), and Shiferaw's establishment of the Child Development Training Center (CDTRC) (April 2004).

2004 AWANA, led by Jack Eggar, began their 4/14 Window Forums.

2005 Transform World Connection in Indonesia launched their Next Generation focus in a stadium event with 80,000 young people.

2006 Child Theology Movement, led by Keith White, launched in Penang, Malaysia where the Holistic Child Development Institute is directed by Rosalind Lim-Tan.

2007 The Global Alliance launched to promote Academic Programs in Holistic Child Development (HCD) in seminaries and theological institutions.

2011 The *Now and Nex*t Child Theology Conference in Nairobi, Kenya, led by Dan Brewster and Keith White brought together theologians and practitioners in the first global consultation on the theological significance of the child. The *Now and Next* Compendium provides background, context and perspective for on-going theological and missiological reflection on children and youth, and their role as both objects and agents of mission today.

Children and youth are not only the most receptive of 'people groups' to the Gospel, but they may also be the most effective as *agents* for mission. Evidence suggests that they will increasingly become the primary energy for mission in the 21st Century. The 4/14 Missiology Conference held in Seoul, Korea in February 2013 brought mission leaders and theologians from all over the world together to reflect biblically on the place and role of children and young people as 'Strong Partners in Mission.'

This Compendium of papers presented in the 4/14 Window Missiology Conference sheds light on the significant role children and youth can and do have in evangelism and mission. It suggests ways in which mission leaders may intentionally and strategically invest in reaching, rooting, and releasing children and youth to reach out to their communities and nations.

The Church is facing "a new kairos moment." She has the opportunity to embrace a renewed missionary vision, based firmly in the Scriptures but drawing upon the enthusiasm and vitality of children and young people. This is the core message of this book, with the contributors drawing upon the combined wisdom of Scripture, the experience of children and young people, their own lived experience, church history and the social sciences.



Dan Brewster



John Baxter-Brown